GILLES DELEUZE

Edited by Eugene W. Holland // Daniel W. Smith // Charles J. Stivale

IMAGE AND TEXT



Gilles Deleuze:
Image and Text

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Contents

Notes on the Contributors vii

Introduction Image, Text, Thought 1
Eugene W. Holland

Part I Text/Literature

1 The Landscape of Sensation 9
Ronald Bogue

2 Bim Bam Bom Bem: 'Beckett's Peephole' as Audio-visual Rhizome 27
Colin Gardner

3 Where Has Gertrud(e) Gone?: Gertrude Stein's Cinematic Journey from Movement-Image to Time-Image 41
Sarah Posman

4 (Giving) Savings Accounts? 63
Karen Houle

Part II Image/Art

5 Sensation: The Earth, a People, Art 81
Elizabeth Grosz

6 Matisse with Dewey with Deleuze 104
Éric Alliez and Jean-Claude Bonne

7 Mad Love 124
Nadine Boljkovac

8 Affective Imagery: Screen Militarism 143
Felicity Colman

9 Hyperconnectivity through Deleuze: Indices of Affect 160
Jondi Keane

10 Deleuze, Guattari and Contemporary Art 176
Stephen Zepke

11 Why is Deleuze an Artist-Philosopher? 198
Julie Kuhlken

Part III Philosophy

12 Gilles Deleuze and the Problem of Freedom 221
Constantin V. Boundas

13 On Finding Oneself Spinozist: Refuge, Beatitude and the Any-Space-Whatever 247
Hélène Frichot

Index 265

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(Paris: Vrin, 1995); *La Pensée-Matisse* (with J.-Cl. Bonne) (Paris: Le Passage, 2005); *L'Œil-Cerveau. Nouvelles Histoires de la peinture moderne* (in collaboration with Jean-Clet Martin) (Paris: Vrin, 2007); and several edited volumes. He is the general editor of the *Œuvres de Gabriel Tarde* (Paris: Les Empêcheurs de penser en rond/Seuil [13 volumes published]) and is a founding member of the editorial board of the journal *Multitudes*.

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Introduction

Image, Text, Thought

Eugene W. Holland

Over the past two decades, readers of the works of Gilles Deleuze have had several opportunities to participate in international conferences held at Trent University and organized by Constantin V. Boundas. In that tradition, we undertook to organize a conference on the theme of 'Gilles Deleuze: Texts and Images'. The conference took place, under the able auspices of Paul Allen Miller, on the campus of the University of South Carolina between 5–8 April, 2007, sponsored by the Program in Comparative Literature, the English Department and the College of Arts and Sciences. The conference theme was understood inclusively rather than exclusively: it would embrace broad and comparative interpretations and commentaries from Deleuzian perspectives on subjects such as literature, philosophy, painting and film, as well as exegeses of Deleuze's body of work engaging with ontological and epistemological concepts and problems. The present volume offers, then, a selection of essays from more than 60 papers presented, including those of the invited plenary speakers, Éric Alliez, Ronald Bogue, Constantin V. Boundas and Elizabeth Grosz.

Along with thought itself, and far more than most philosophers, Deleuze was intensely interested in the *medium* of thought – interested both in individual styles of thought and in the various genres in which thought is conducted. For thought is by no means limited to philosophy alone: it also takes place – can also take place, in the right hands and under the right circumstances – in science, mathematics, literature, painting and cinema, to mention some of the genres or media of thought to which Deleuze most often refers. In the essays that follow,

then, the texts in question will be literary as well as philosophical, the images cinematic as well as painterly and architectural. And in each case – Deleuze being in this respect a dyed-in-the-wool modernist – thought will experiment in a given medium specifically in order to take that medium beyond its limits, as Ronald Bogue concludes in the opening essay: plastic arts render invisible forces visible in painting or sculpture, music captures silent forces in sound, literature registers 'visions and auditions that are not of language, but which language alone makes possible', as Deleuze suggests in *Essays Critical and Clinical* (1997, p. lv). And yet, as most of the essays included here suggest, whether implicitly or explicitly, Deleuze-the-modernist could also be considered postmodern at least in this respect: he did not pursue the endeavour to surpass such limits merely for its own sake, but for the sake of a New Earth and a People to Come.

In this volume, we have grouped essays according to genre categories – literature, art, philosophy – but as we and the contributors understand Deleuze's work, these categories intersect in an ongoing circulation of conceptual exchange. Hence, rather than solely emphasizing the arrangement of the Table of Contents, we wish to introduce this volume by highlighting some of the transverse connections linking the essays via issues of representation, temporality, affect, sensation and counter-actualization.

In the opening essay, Ronald Bogue carefully traces what he calls the 'conceptual motif' of faciliality through Deleuze's entire corpus. In this way, he is able to show not only how thought variously inhabits and exceeds the limits of art, music, cinema and literature, but also why the vocation of literature for Deleuze must be to reverse the priority of language over experience, of the sayable over the seeable (as Foucault would put it), of text over image, so as to open us to becomings and spaces of transformation, in an opening that is simultaneously aesthetic and political. Beckett's television plays, as Bogue notes, are among Deleuze's favoured examples of literature's struggle to exceed the limits of language, particularly in the way Beckett strives to silence the 'voices and . . . stories' (*Essays Critical and Clinical*, p. 157) that haunt language and literature.

Several essays pursue this reflection in a complementary vein: Colin Gardner thoroughly explicates Beckett's plays in relation to Deleuze and Guattari's book on Kafka and especially Deleuze's books on cinema; and he shows, in this way, just how Beckett's defeat of language leads beyond narrative and representation to something akin to the cinematic time-image. Moreover, Sarah Posman's essay shows how, in writing the opera 'Four Saints in Three Acts' (1927), Gertrude Stein attempted to subvert linear-narrative time in favour of a Bergsonian time-image that prefigures the evolution of cinema analysed by Deleuze. In another essay focusing on a literary text, Karen Houle echoes Bogue's invocation of Foucault on literature's challenge to the limits of language in relation to the complexity of Marilynne Robinson's novel *Housekeeping* (1980). Houle examines Robinson's attempt to give voice to the unsayable and push literature beyond representation while also demonstrating the difficulty (verging on impossibility) of pushing literary response itself, including her own, beyond judgement.

The essays by Nadine Boljkovac and Felicity Colman examine the ability of cinema and video to go beyond representation by extracting affect from both subjective interiority and narrative. But whereas for Boljkovac, Chris Marker's 'La Jetée' frees affect in order to induce a becoming-other that moves beyond tragedy and loss to a love beyond death, Colman sees Gulf War trophy videos and other tele-screen war imagery as mobilizing affect to create malignant, politically paralyzed virtual communities saturated by a vicarious militarism. Jondi Keane and Julie Kuhlken in turn consider the passage beyond representation in relation to conceptualizations of the practices of art, architecture and thought. For Keane, attempts by Agamben, Verbrugge and Arakawa and Gins to reconceptualize art, architecture and language in necessary relation to their outside and the body can usefully be understood in light of Deleuzian concepts, particularly embodied affect and becoming. For Kuhlken, Deleuze's modifying appropriation of the image of the 'body without organs' from Artaud enables him to break out of representation in the process of changing from a 'philosopher's philosopher' to an 'artist-philosopher' so as to actively engage with the world rather than merely interpret it.

A truly remarkable thing about Deleuze's treatment of art is the way he situates it in relation to nature and as one of the most creative parts of nature: 'Art does not wait for human beings to begin', he insists (with Guattari) in *A Thousand Plateaus* (1987, p. 320) (on art as an expression of nature in Deleuze, see Eugene W. Holland, 'Jazz Improvisation: Music of the People-to-Come' in *Deleuze, Guattari and the Production of the New*). It is thus crucial to resituate any discussion of the relations Deleuze proposes between art and thought, sensation and concept in the broader context of nature – of life and the evolution of life on this earth. Elizabeth Grosz shows that for Deleuze, art in all its forms, natural as well as human, is an expression of excess rather than lack; as a component of sexual rather than natural selection, and hence involving intra-species attraction rather than inter-species competition, art is an expression of life and the expansive reproduction of life rather than of death and destruction. The sensations transmitted in art operate in-between subject and object by embodying new qualities and intensive forces, thus transforming organs in view of potential futures and people to come. In this essentially transformative role, Grosz suggests (echoing von Clausewitz), art is in effect the continuation of politics by other means. As Éric Alliez and Jean-Claude Bonne show in their essay, Matisse too was intent on resituating art in a broader context, pushing the limits of painting into a becoming-other beyond the canvas in connection with architecture and the decoration of lived public space. Painting for Matisse would thus eschew both representing the form of things and exploring the medium of painting itself, and turn instead to expressing the vital forces of colour. Alliez and Bonne show that for Matisse as for Dewey, reconnecting art as decoration with architecture puts painting back into contact with the public experience of art and architecture in the very process of intensifying it, so that decorative-architectural art becomes in a Deweyan sense the continuation of democracy by other means. In another essay in the same section, Stephen Zepke demonstrates the obverse: Deleuze's critique of phenomenology and analytic philosophy also targets their aesthetic counterparts, minimalism and conceptual art,

in favour of an art of sensation whose becoming-inhuman has important political implications. Minimalism and conceptual art merely reinforce the political orthodoxy of consensus and information–communication, thereby forfeiting or stifling the political-transformative potential of sensation.

Given the emphasis in nearly all of the essays on the transgressive and transformative potential of literature and art, text and image, Constantin Boundas's essay demonstrating that Deleuze is fundamentally a philosopher of freedom provides a fitting lead-in to the concluding section of the volume. By carefully situating Deleuze in relation to the Stoics, Leibniz, Bergson and Nietzsche, Boundas shows how he develops the necessarily paradoxical problematic of freedom through the concepts of the virtual and counter-actualization. Freedom, Boundas explains, is a key predicate of the virtual as it exists outside of actual time, while counter-actualization engages both past and future, both memory and project, to realize freedom 'at the intersection of necessity and chance'. Another essay provides the perfect image for Boundas's text: Hélène Frichot examines and elaborates on the diagram of the fold from Deleuze's study of Foucault, and in this way, she illustrates how the fold of subjectification operates on the plane of immanence in relation to Spinoza's three kinds of knowledge. She also echoes both Alliez's and Bonne's insights about Matisse's Deweyan ambitions in connecting painting with architecture and Deleuze's ambition to connect a philosophy of freedom with its outsides (expressed in many of the other essays). For Frichot envisions a 'formidable new individual' emerging at a crucial intersection, that of our architectural and environmental surroundings construed as a plane of immanence, on the one hand, and our bodies as loci of sensation critically enfolded with memory and pregnant with futurity, on the other.

The meeting from which we have developed this volume was an uncommon and truly enriching encounter, and thanks to the extraordinary hospitality and facilities at the University of South Carolina, the participants from all over the globe found ample opportunities to discuss together many concepts within and beyond the conference's themes. With this volume, we have

wanted to extend some aspects of this discussion to other readers and students of the works of Gilles Deleuze. It is our hope that these essays contribute to understanding and further developing our politico-ethico-aesthetic existence through their exploration of the expression and transmission of sensation and affects beyond representation in texts and images alike.

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Part I

Text/Literature

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Chapter 1

The Landscape of Sensation

Ronald Bogue

What is the relationship between texts and images in Deleuze's conception of the arts? One means of initiating a response to this question is to examine the figure of the 'landscape', which has a certain prominence in *A Thousand Plateaus*, appears briefly in *Cinema 1*, and then resumes a position of some importance in *What Is Philosophy?* and *Essays Critical and Clinical*. To call the landscape a full-blown 'concept', in the terms set out in *What Is Philosophy?*, is perhaps excessive. Rather, it seems more accurate to describe the landscape as a 'conceptual motif', a recurring element that participates in the functioning of several key concepts – faciality, the reflection-image, sensation, percepts, affects, fabulation. Although the motif is introduced initially in *A Thousand Plateaus* as part of a discussion of the face-landscape complex and painting, when Deleuze elaborates on the theme later in that book and in subsequent texts, the landscape proves to be germane to his treatment of several other arts as well – notably, architecture, sculpture, cinema, music and literature. It is in his discussion of the landscape and literature that this conceptual motif becomes especially interesting, for here we see clearly the tensions between speaking and seeing, between texts and images, tensions that suggest a decidedly nonlinguistic dimension to Deleuze's conception of literature.

According to the *Robert dictionnaire historique* the word *paysage* first appears in French in 1549, initially as 'a term of painting designating the representation of a generally rural site, then the painting itself'. The word's history roughly parallels that of its English counterpart, *landscape*, a rendition of the Dutch *landschap* imported in 1602 to designate a painting of natural inland

scenery. Interestingly, the first reference in English to the natural world itself as a 'landscape' does not appear until 1642 (here in the simple sense of 'a bird's-eye view'), which suggests that art precedes nature in this instance and that painters taught people to see aesthetic landscapes in the world. It is not surprising, then, that in Plateau Seven of *A Thousand Plateaus*, 'Year Zero: Faciality', Deleuze and Guattari associate the *paysage* with painting, nor that they approach it as a culturally constructed object. In Deleuze and Guattari's analysis, the landscape functions in coordination with the face as part of a process that 'facializes' reality. When individuals speak, they make facial expressions – smiles, grimaces, sneers, frowns – that 'define zones of frequency or probability' (Deleuze and Guattari, 1987, p. 168) whereby speech-acts are sorted, regulated and normalized in accordance with dominant systems of signification. At the same time, facial expressions 'form loci of resonance that select the sensed or mental reality and make it conform in advance to a dominant reality' (Deleuze and Guattari, 1987, p. 168), that reality enforcing the positions of the interlocutors as subjects. Far from being a natural entity, the face is a constructed object, which operates in conjunction with two regimes of signs: the signifying, despotic regime, in which every signifier refers to another signifier in an endless play of signification controlled by a central, despotic power; and the postsignifying, passional regime, in which a point of obsessional fixation determines a dominant reality and constructs a subject. The dual processes of signification and subjectivation, then, govern the mixed semiotic of the despotic and passional regimes of signs, and the face channels those processes through signification-related 'zones of frequency' and subjectivation-oriented 'loci of resonance'.

The face functions in tandem with the mixed semiotic of the despotic and passional regimes to enforce networks of signification and subjectivation, and since the goal of that mixed semiotic is to subsume everything within its order, faciality extends from the face per se to other body parts, to neighbouring objects and to the surrounding milieu. Fetishization (foot fetish, hair fetish, shoe fetish) is a symptom of the facialization of the body and its associated objects, one that proceeds not via

resemblance (the foot resembling a face) but via a coordination of forces of discipline passing through faces and the body. That passage of forces may then radiate to include an entire landscape. Indeed, Deleuze and Guattari claim, 'All faces envelop an unknown, unexplored landscape; all landscapes are populated by a loved or dreamed-of face, develop a face to come or already past' (Deleuze and Guattari, 1987, pp. 172–3). This interplay of forces through landscapes and faces shapes both architecture and painting: 'Architecture positions its ensembles – houses, towns or cities, monuments or factories – to function like faces in the landscape they transform. Painting takes up the same movement but also reverses it, positioning a landscape as a face, treating one like the other' (Deleuze and Guattari, 1987, p. 172).

The face of faciality is created through a process of decoding and overcoding. The head as polysemic body part is first decoded, and then it is overcoded as functional extension of the despotic-passional regimes of signs. In turn, the facialization of the body entails a decoding of the body as site of multiple semiotic circuits and a subsequent overcoding of that site as the corporeal surface of a single system of signs. The facialization of the landscape merely amplifies this process of decoding and overcoding. It is important to note, however, that the overcoding of facialization is not a textualization of the visual. To speak is not to see. Although the face works in conjunction with language to enforce the disciplinary networks of the despotic-passional regimes of signs, the face is distinct from the verbal signs it channels, modulates and regulates. The face, the facialized body and the facialized landscape may be associated with various discourses and vocabularies, but they have their own mode of organization. They constitute a general schema of visibility, a kind of vectorial gridding of the visual as a component co-functioning with language in the maintenance of a field of forces. In this regard, the facialized world resembles the domain of 'visibilities' that Deleuze sees as a central feature of Foucault's work. Foucault's 'visibilities' take form within what Deleuze calls a 'regime of light', a structure of scintillations, shadows, glares and reflections, a given regime of light serving

as the condition of possibility that determines what can be seen and what cannot. Each historically specific regime of light is in a dynamic relationship with a discursive formation, but visibilities are not reducible to statements. Rather, visibilities and statements intervene in one another, interconnect while remaining heterogeneous and incommensurable. The face-landscape complex of faciality may then be seen as a specific regime of light, one coordinated with the mixed linguistic semiotic of the despotic and passional regimes of signs.

In *A Thousand Plateaus* Deleuze and Guattari assert that 'the "problem" within which painting is inscribed is that of the *face-landscape*', whereas the problem of music 'is entirely different: it is the problem of the *refrain*' (Deleuze and Guattari, 1987, p. 301). Despite this strict separation of the two arts, however, in their analysis of the refrain Deleuze and Guattari discover a musical aspect of the landscape. Refrains may be loosely defined as the rhythmic patterns through which organisms and their surroundings co-produce and maintain diverse ecological systems. Differences in the structuring patterns of various creature-habitat complexes, such as those that delimit milieu organisms from territorial animals, arise from the relative degrees to which refrains are deterritorialized in one context and reterritorialized in another. Music's task is to deterritorialize natural refrains in general and reterritorialize them within sonic compositions. Deleuze and Guattari find indications of this relationship between nature and music in the juxtaposition of Jacob von Uexküll's ecological writings and Olivier Messiaen's musical compositions. Von Uexküll treats nature as a grand symphony of interconnected activities and processes, each organism and its surroundings interrelated as point to counterpoint in a giant Baroque fugue. Messiaen for his part appropriates birdsong and natural sounds as compositional elements in much of his music.

In their account of the degrees to which refrains become deterritorialized in natural systems, Deleuze and Guattari state that at a certain stage in the emergence of territoriality (in the ethological sense of the term), refrains take on an autonomy of their own, at which point 'territorial motifs form *rhythmic*

faces or characters, and . . . territorial counterpoints form *melodic landscapes*' (1987, p. 318). The term 'rhythmic characters' [*personnages rhythmiques*] comes from Messiaen, who explains that his conception of rhythm is dramatic, rhythms interacting with one another like characters in a play, one active, another passive, yet a third serving as a witness to the active–passive couple. Although Messiaen does not articulate the complementary concept of 'melodic landscapes' per se, he does indicate that in his birdsong-oriented compositions he situates the various bird motifs within an appropriate sonic landscape. For example, in the *Catalogue d'oiseaux* (1958), a massive series of pieces for solo piano, he features the song of a single bird in each piece, but he includes as well motifs from other birds and sounds corresponding to a given setting. He also prefaces each piece with a brief prose description of the natural scene he is rendering. 'Le merle bleu' (The Blue Rock Thrush, Book I, p. 3), for instance, presents a seascape in June near Banyuls-sur-Mer, with waves and cliffs providing the background against which the blue rock thrush, theckla lark, swifts and herring gulls issue their cries and songs. The first twenty measures of the score bear the following sequence of motif labels: cliffs, swifts, cliffs, swifts, water, swifts, water, blue rock thrush, water, swifts, water, theckla lark, water. This interweaving of birdsongs and seascape sounds continues throughout the piece, its composite texture suggesting how in both nature and music, to cite Deleuze and Guattari once again, 'territorial motifs form *rhythmic faces or characters*, and . . . territorial counterpoints form *melodic landscapes*' (1987, p. 318).

Faciality's visual concepts of face and landscape, then, have aural counterparts in the concepts of the rhythmic character and melodic landscape, yet Deleuze and Guattari insist in *A Thousand Plateaus* that painting's central problem is that of the face-landscape. Hence, when in 1981 Deleuze speaks at length about painting in *Francis Bacon*, one might expect further discussion of the face-landscape pair, but instead the face is treated only as a minor consideration and the landscape is not mentioned at all. In 1983, however, the landscape does appear briefly as part of Deleuze's exposition of the action-image and reflection-image

in *Cinema 1*.[1] To contrast the Large Form and Small Form species of the action-image, Deleuze differentiates a 'respiration-space' from a 'skeleton-space' [*espace-ossature*] (Deleuze, 1986, p. 168). He derives the terms from Henri Maldiney's analysis of Chinese painting theory, which focuses on Hsieh Ho's sixth-century recommendation that the painter first 'reflect the vital breath; that is, create movement', and then 'seek the skeleton; that is, know how to use the brush' (Maldiney, p. 167). (*Ossature* is Maldiney's French rendering of 'skeleton', the word *ossature* meaning both 'the disposition of the skeleton's bones' and 'any framework of elements structuring a whole'.) The unity of the cosmos arises from the vital breath (*chi* in Chinese) of the primordial void that permeates all things in a systolic and diastolic respiration, and the painter's task is to manifest this vital breath's movement as it 'appears' and 'comes into presence'. But the painter must also render individual details with discrete brush strokes, thereby demarcating the structuring the *ossature* of the world and revealing the 'disappearing' of things, like the dragon whose tail disappears behind a cloud. Ultimately, the movement of the vital breath subsumes the *ossature* of the world within a single, unifying cosmic process, but Deleuze sees in this '*notion of the landscape*' (Deleuze, 1986, p. 187) two tendencies worth distinguishing, even if they are finally inseparable. The respiration-space is one in which the landscape is an all-encompassing milieu within which individual actions emerge and take their relative position. The landscape of the skeleton-space, by contrast, is one that is constructed piece by piece, from action to action – not, however, in a random fashion, but following a vector that reveals a 'line of the universe', a cosmic zigzag of vital energy. On the basis of this distinction Deleuze categorizes various film plots, contrasting for example the respiration-space of John Ford's westerns, in which a dominant landscape summons forth the characters' actions as responses to their surrounding situation, with the skeleton-space of Anthony Mann's westerns, in which heterogeneous spaces are interconnected via the explosive actions of the protagonists as their movement-images fashion a 'line of the universe'. Deleuze likewise contrasts Kurosawa's respiration-space and Mizoguchi's skeleton-space, each of these

directors pushing the action-image to its limit and thereby creating a reflection-image in which mental relations permeate physical relations.

What this cinematic treatment of the landscape adds to the previous landscapes of painting and music is a narrative dimension of sorts. If painting's deterritorialization of the face-landscape is primarily spatial, and music's deterritorialization of rhythmic characters and melodic landscapes is primarily temporal, cinema's respiration-space and skeleton-space are spatiotemporal, images-in-movement that are tied to narratives, at least in the classic cinema. We must note, however, that for Deleuze conventional narratives are a secondary product of movement-images, which generate stories through the unfolding of trajectories regulated by the sensory-motor schema. Films are not visual translations of discursive narratives, but non-discursive images that are incommensurable with the verbal terms that may be used to describe them.

In *What Is Philosophy?* the landscape is associated with the 'percept', which, along with the 'affect', is one of the two constituents of 'sensation', sensation itself delineating the domain proper to the arts. Deleuze and Guattari derive their sense of the landscape from Henri Maldiney, whose account of the operation of form and rhythm in visual art is based on a phenomenological reading of Cézanne's comments on painting. (We might note that Maldiney sees in Hsieh Ho's observations about Chinese painting simply another version of the insights articulated by Cézanne.) Maldiney's guide to his understanding of Cézanne's art is Erwin Straus, who in *The Primary World of the Senses* (1935) argues that we must differentiate the world of perception, in which subject and object are clearly distinguished and situated within commonsense spatiotemporal coordinates, from the world of sensation, a primary, preverbal world we share with animals, in which subject and object are indistinguishable and space-time moves with us in a perpetual Here-Now. In Straus's terms, the space of perception is a space of *geography*, whereas sensation's space is that of the *landscape*. Maldiney argues that this Strausian primary space of sensation is what Cézanne is describing when he remarks that as he begins to paint, he is one

with the world that surrounds him: 'We are an iridescent chaos. I come before my motif, I lose myself there. . . . We germinate' (Cited in Maldiney, p. 150). At this moment, says Cézanne, man is 'absent, but entirely within the landscape' (Cited in Maldiney, p. 185).

Clearly, a version of the Strausian opposition of the geography of perception and the landscape of sensation is at play in Deleuze and Guattari's statements that 'the aim of art is to wrest the percept from perceptions of objects and the states of a perceiving subject' (Deleuze and Guattari, 1994, p. 167), and that 'the percept is the landscape before man, in the absence of man' (1994, p. 169). This Strausian landscape, it would seem, is quite different from the landscape of *A Thousand Plateaus*, and indeed, the earlier landscape was a facialized landscape – that is, a landscape territorialized by forces of facialization. But as Deleuze and Guattari insist repeatedly, immanent within any stratified power structure are forces of deterritorialization, and this new landscape is a deterritorializing domain of hecceities and becomings. Understandably, then, in *What Is Philosophy?* the landscape is most frequently paired not with faces but with becomings, 'Becoming animal, plant, molecular, becoming zero' (Deleuze and Guattari, 1994, p. 169), becomings constituting the realm of affects, in which humans become nonhuman. Sensation, then, consists of affects and percepts, and in the words of Deleuze and Guattari's aphoristic summation, '*Affects are precisely these nonhuman becomings of man*, just as percepts – including the town – are *nonhuman landscapes of nature*' (1994, p. 169). This coupling of becomings and landscapes may be seen as a version of the dyad of rhythmic characters and melodic landscapes, in that both pairs delineate actors within an environment, the actors in one pair being humans engaged in becomings, and in the other pair, rhythms interacting with one another. And in fact, Deleuze and Guattari make use of the *rhythmic character-melodic landscape* pair at several points in *What Is Philosophy?* We must observe, however, that in *What Is Philosophy?* the primary sense of the landscape is not melodic but visual. 'The landscape *sees*' (1994, p. 169), say Deleuze and Guattari. And when they invoke percepts and affects, they most often speak of percepts

as 'visions' and the artist as creator of landscapes as a 'seer' [*un voyant*]. Just a few examples: 'Everything is vision, becoming' (1994, p. 169); 'The artist is a seer, a becomer' (1994, p. 171); 'the artist is the presenter of affects, inventor of affects, creator of affects, in relation with the percepts or visions that the artist gives us' (1994, p. 174; translation modified). Aesthetic figures 'are sensations: percepts and affects, landscapes and faces, visions and becomings' (1994, p. 177). (Note that this last citation provides the only pairing of landscapes and faces in *What Is Philosophy?*)

This pairing of percept-landscapes and affect-becomings, however, is further complicated as Deleuze and Guattari refine their speculation on the 'incarnation' of sensation in the arts. 'We spoke too quickly when we said that sensation embodies [*incarne*]' (Deleuze and Guattari, 1994, p. 178), they remark. Percepts and affects do not unite in a single phenomenological 'flesh of the world'. Rather, the embodiment of becomings presupposes 'not so much bone or skeletal structure [*ossature*] as house or framework [*armature*]' (Deleuze and Guattari, 1994, p. 179). The house, we might say, is a third element, between landscapes and those who are undergoing a becoming-animal. The house is a kind of scaffolding, a structuring schema of planes, its walls, roof, floor, doors and windows functioning as so many 'frames' (Deleuze and Guattari, 1994, p. 179), in both the pictorial and the cinematic sense, within which forces are delineated and through which forces intercommunicate. The surfaces and openings of the house serve as membranes and conduits for the interaction of forces outside and inside its scaffolding of planes and frames. 'In fact', say Deleuze and Guattari, 'the house does not shelter us from cosmic forces; at most it filters and selects them' (1994, p. 182).

In the course of articulating the concept of the house, Deleuze and Guattari expand the notion of the 'landscape' to include the universe as a whole. If affective becomings constitute one element of sensation, and the house a second, 'the third element', they say, 'is the universe, the cosmos. Not only does the open house communicate with the landscape, through a window or a mirror, but the most shut-up house opens onto a

universe' (Deleuze and Guattari, 1994, p. 180). The house is a scaffolding that delimits and frames forces, but the landscape is ultimately unframed and without limits, a plane that extends into infinity. 'The flesh, or rather the figure, is no longer the inhabitant of the place, of the house, but of the universe that supports the house (becoming). *It is like a passage from the finite to the infinite*, but also from territory to deterritorialization' (Deleuze and Guattari, 1994, p. 180). In an initial formulation, then, Deleuze and Guattari state that sensation consists of percepts and affects, '*nonhuman landscapes of nature*' and '*nonhuman becomings of man*' (1994, p. 169). In their final formulation, however, the concept of the house is added and the term 'landscape' is replaced by the word 'cosmos': 'In short', they say, 'the being of sensation is not the flesh but the compound of nonhuman forces of the cosmos, of man's nonhuman becomings, and of the ambiguous house that exchanges and adjusts them, makes them whirl around like winds' (1994, p. 183). At this point it is worth observing that in this triad of universe-house-becomings, we have a version of the three elements that Deleuze argues are basic to Bacon's paintings: the infinite plane of a monochrome field; the isolating structure of a cube, circle or frame of some sort; and the figure undergoing a metamorphosis as forces from the monochrome plane compress and deform it and as the figure's internal forces seek escape through the body and across the structure's isolating membrane to the monochrome field. Hence, though Deleuze seems in *Francis Bacon* to abandon *A Thousand Plateaus*' problematic of landscape and face, in reality he is simply exploring it in different terms, the landscape articulated as monochrome field, the face as figure.

As we will recall, in *What Is Philosophy?* the movement from the house to the universe is said to be '*like a passage from the finite to the infinite*, but also from territory to deterritorialization' (Deleuze and Guattari, 1994, p. 180). Through this association of the house with territory and the cosmos with deterritorialization, Deleuze and Guattari initiate a recapitulation of their analysis of the interconnection of art and nature conducted in the Refrain section of *A Thousand Plateaus*. Indeed, they assert in *What Is Philosophy?* that 'the whole of the refrain is the being

of sensation' (1994, p. 184). The refrain has three inseparable components, or moments: a point of emergent order; a circumference of delimited structure; and a line of flight towards the infinite. In nature, territorial animals build a habitat by extending the rhythms of an emergent point of order to the circumference of a specific territory, but that territory always is open to the cosmos. The refrain is a force of both territorialization and deterritorialization, and the 'territory-house system' (Deleuze and Guattari, 1994, p. 183) communicates directly with the universe. Thus 'if nature is like art, this is always because it combines these two living elements in every way: House and Universe, *Heimlich* and *Unheimlich*, territory and deterritorialization, finite melodic compounds and the great infinite plane of composition, the small and large refrain' (Deleuze and Guattari, 1994, p. 186).[2]

We may thus construct the final composite model: (1) landscape, melodic landscape, respiration-space and skeleton-space, universe, cosmos, monochromatic field, deterritorialization; (2) House, structure, territory and (3) face, rhythmic characters, nonhuman becomings, figure. How might the various arts be situated in regard to this model, if we consider it in its most literal, physical sense? Architecture would seem to be the art most directly related to the model, in that an inhabited building in an open space would be a material manifestation of the triad of landscape-house-becomings. For this reason, Deleuze and Guattari assert that 'architecture is the first of the arts' (1994, p. 186) and that animals, in constructing habitats, are artists. Next would come sculpture, whose three-dimensional objects occupy a physical space, and often an actual landscape. The alliance of architecture and sculpture as modellings of spatial relations, in fact, is such that one might (with considerable caution) regard architecture as a utilitarian form of sculpture. Third would come iconic figurations of the model, such as cinema and painting, in that both arts frequently offer visual analogues of actual landscapes, habitats and inhabitants. (Theatre might be included here, though primarily as performance practice rather than written text.) Music would seem more removed from the model than the preceding arts, Messiaen's creative

'transcriptions' of sonic landscapes and birdsongs providing the most immediate instances of music's deterritorialization of natural refrains, with most musical compositions much less clearly related to physical landscapes and habitats. And the art most distant from the model, I would argue, is literature, especially prose fiction, in that literature's rendering of actual landscapes, habitats and inhabitants takes place not through iconic but through symbolic figuration.

It is in their remarks on literature in *What Is Philosophy?* that Deleuze and Guattari's tripartite model becomes most provocative, especially as regards the landscape. 'The novel has often risen to the percept' (Deleuze and Guattari, 1994, p. 168), they say, evoking various landscapes – 'oceanic percepts in Melville, urban percepts . . . in Virginia Woolf' (1994, pp. 168–9), 'the moor as percept' (1994, p. 168) in Hardy, 'Faulkner's hills, Tolstoy's or Chekhov's steppes' (1994, p. 169). It would seem that Deleuze and Guattari are situating these authors within the ekphrastic tradition, treating them as practitioners of a kind of 'word painting'. And in fact, Deleuze elsewhere explicitly makes this link between literature and painting, in *Foucault* calling Faulkner 'literature's greatest "luminist" ' (Deleuze, 1988, p. 81), and in *Essays Critical and Clinical* first describing Whitman's corpus as 'one of the most coloristic of literatures that could ever have existed' (Deleuze, 1997, p. 59), and then labelling T. E. Lawrence 'one of the greatest landscape painters [*paysagistes*] in literature', as well as 'one of the great portraitists', since in his work 'faces correspond to the landscapes' (Deleuze, 1997, p. 116). Readers might concede that all these authors are particularly successful at evoking landscapes, but few would see such evocations as central to these writers' works, let alone to all literature. In most fiction, landscapes are secondary elements that merely provide the setting within which actions transpire. Fictions involve stories, linear sequences of action, whereas settings, especially landscapes, generally manifest a static or cyclical temporality. As Deleuze and Guattari say, the landscapes of Hardy, Melville, Woolf and others create 'beings of sensation, which preserve in themselves the hour of a day, a moment's degree of warmth' (1994, p. 169). Such

landscapes are clearly instances of what Deleuze and Guattari in *A Thousand Plateaus* call hecceities, 'a season, a winter, a summer, an hour, a date' (1987, p. 261), whose temporality is that of Aeon, a 'floating', 'nonpulsed time', 'the indefinite time of the event' (Deleuze and Guattari, 1987, p. 262).

Of course percepts, '*the nonhuman landscapes of nature*', are inseparable from affects, '*the nonhuman becomings of man*' (Deleuze and Guattari, 1994, p. 169), and in such nonhuman becomings we have actions. Yet Deleuze and Guattari's literary examples of nonhuman becoming, such as Ahab's becoming-whale, or Mrs Dalloway's becoming-city, isolate only a portion of the actions of their respective novels, and not necessarily the central aspects of those fictions. Nor is there much of a plot in Ahab's obsession with Moby-Dick or Mrs Dalloway's dissolution within the London cityscape. Deleuze and Guattari associate the creation of percepts and affects with what they call 'fabulation' (1994, pp. 168, 171), but they do not indicate what *fabulas* might be generated by fabulation. As Deleuze explains in *Cinema 2* and *Essays Critical and Clinical*, fabulation is the process whereby artists invent 'a people to come', a future collectivity not yet in existence. Fabulation is a matter of 'legending *in flagrante delicto*' (Deleuze, 1989, p. 150; translation modified), but Deleuze does not specify what legends might result from fabulation.

In his essay on T. E. Lawrence's *Seven Pillars of Wisdom*, Deleuze treats Lawrence as a *paysagiste* and fabulator, his landscapes and fabulations, according to Deleuze, being 'images projected into the real' (Deleuze, 1997, p. 119). 'The finest writers', says Deleuze, 'have singular conditions of perception that allow them to draw on or shape aesthetic percepts like veritable visions' (Deleuze, 1997, p. 116), and Lawrence's landscapes are such visions, images 'abstracted' from perception, projected onto the external world, and fashioned with such intensity that the image takes on a life of its own. Lawrence also fabulates, in that he evokes the collective identity of an Arab 'people to come', but such fabulation involves again the projection of images rather than the narration of stories. Lawrence's fabulations reveal 'a profound desire, a tendency to project – into

things, into reality, into the future and even into the sky – an image of himself and others so intense that *it has a life of its own*' (Deleuze, 1997, pp. 117–8, emphasis in original). Lawrence's use of 'what Bergson called a fabulatory function', says Deleuze, 'is a machine for manufacturing giants', an image 'projection machine' that 'is inseparable from the movement of the [Arab] Revolt itself: it is subjective, but it refers to the subjectivity of the revolutionary group' (Deleuze, 1997, p. 118).[3]

If, then, we pair percepts and affects with landscapes and fabulation, both are manifest in literature as visions, as images projected into the real and imbued with a life of their own, and such images would seem to have no necessary relation to narratives, even if some of them are 'fabulations'. There is, in fact, an explicit opposition of images to narratives that one can find in Deleuze. In *Francis Bacon*, Deleuze asserts that 'painting has neither a model to represent nor a story to narrate' (Deleuze, 2003, p. 6), which is why Bacon isolates the figures in his paintings. The clichéd images of the world are mere illustrations of conventional stories, and Bacon's isolation of the figure 'is thus the simplest means . . . to break with representation, to disrupt narration, to escape illustration, to liberate the Figure' (Deleuze, 2003, p. 6). The whole of Deleuze's analysis of cinema aims to displace language and narration as the conceptual framework for understanding film. Narratives exist in film, but only as secondary derivations of images. 'Narration is never an evident [*apparent*] given of images, or the effect of a structure which underlies them; it is a consequence of the visible [*apparent*] images themselves, of the perceptible images in themselves, as they are initially defined for themselves' (Deleuze, 1989, p. 27). But most telling is Deleuze's study of Beckett's television plays, in which he treats Beckett as a writer attempting to 'bore holes in language' and create pure images. In order to fashion pure images, Beckett must silence the incessant 'voices and their stories' (Deleuze, 1997, p. 157) that haunt language. Only when 'there is no longer any possibility or any story' (Deleuze, 1997, p. 158) can an image arise, one 'freed from the chains in which it was bound' by conventional language and its narratives.

Beckett's impatience with narrative belies a basic distrust of language, and in Beckett's efforts to go beyond words Deleuze finds one of literature's fundamental aims. In *Essays Critical and Clinical*, Deleuze says that writing's goal is to create 'visions and auditions that are not of language, but which language alone makes possible. . . . It is through words, between words, that one sees and hears. Beckett spoke of "drilling holes" in language in order to see or hear "what was lurking behind". One must say of every writer: he is a seer, a hearer, "ill seen ill said", she is a colorist, a musician' (Deleuze, 1997, p. lv). Writers push words to their limits, evoking images while at the same time forcing language itself to stutter and stammer and thereby produce an asignifying music. Implicit in this valorization of visions and auditions is an opposition of the discursive and the nondiscursive, with nondiscursive visions and auditions arising at the limits of the discursive. Why privilege the nondiscursive dimension of literature? The answer, I believe, lies in Deleuze's *Foucault*, a book that is as much a presentation of Deleuze's thought as Foucault's. Deleuze praises Foucault for recognizing within power relations the incommensurable strata of visibilities and statements. Regimes of light bring forth what may be seen, whereas regimes of signs determine what may be said. The two strata are separate, yet there is also a primacy of statements over visibilities. 'The statement has primacy by virtue of the spontaneity of its condition (language) which gives it a determining form, while the visible element, by virtue of the receptivity of its condition (light), merely has the form of the determinable. Therefore, we can assume that determination always comes from the statement, although the two forms differ in nature' (Deleuze, 1988, p. 67; translation modified). The implication of this analysis is that language has an inherent tendency to dominate the visible and the nondiscursive as a whole. The facialized landscape, coded and coordinated in its operation with the despotic-passional regimes, then, is but one manifestation of this tendency. And the most effective linguistic means of overcoming this tendency is to reverse the asymmetrical relationship between the discursive and the nondiscursive, to push language to its

limits and produce images and sounds, visions and auditions, which escape the hold of regimes of signs and take on a life of their own.

Deleuze remarks that Foucault's approach to visibilities and statements 'is singularly close to the contemporary cinema' (Deleuze, 1988, p. 65; translation modified), in that both treat sound and sight as separate strata, 'a visible element that can only be seen, an articulable element that can only be spoken' (1988, p. 65). Deleuze's approach to literature, I would argue, is equally cinematic, the language of writers like Beckett giving rise to audiovisual strata, asignifying sounds and pure images. And in this cinematic affinity we might find a means of accounting for literary narrative such that it is no longer the mere manifestation of linguistic codes and cultural conventions. The landscapes of the action-image in *Cinema 1* are composites of situations and actions, action-spaces that generate different sequences of images, some in accordance with an englobing 'respiration space', others with a 'skeleton space', unfolding along a 'line of the universe'. Perhaps one could treat literary stories like cinematic narratives, as secondary products of movement-images and time-images, temporal effects of the visions and auditions that arise as authors 'bore holes in language'. But a reading of *Cinema 1* and *Cinema 2* as guides to literary narrative is beyond the scope of this essay.

The landscape of faciality is a landscape of stratification, part of a face-landscape complex co-functioning with the mixed semiotic of the despotic and passional regimes of signs. The landscape of sensation is a landscape of destratification, of percepts which are intimately related to affects. The 'nonhuman landscapes of nature' and the 'nonhuman becomings of man' (Deleuze and Guattari, 1994, p. 169) form part of a triad of cosmos-house-becomings, the 'being of sensation' consisting of 'the compound of nonhuman forces of the cosmos, of man's nonhuman becomings, and of the ambiguous house that exchanges and adjusts them' (Deleuze and Guattari, 1994, p. 183). The house may be part of a territorial habitat, but it always communicates with a plane of deterritorialization. In the

deterritorializing landscape, images take on a life of their own, one that is visual, or perhaps sonic (as in Messiaen's 'melodic landscapes'), but never textual. Literature, like the other arts, creates 'nonhuman landscapes of nature', hallucinatory images at the limits of language, visions interconnected with sonic auditions. Deleuze sees painting, music and cinema as arts that seek to transcend their limits – painting, by rendering visible invisible forces, music by capturing silent forces within sounds, cinema by fashioning a stratum of 'the unspeakable and what can only be spoken' and a stratum of what is 'at once invisible and yet can only be seen' (Deleuze, 1989, p. 260). But perhaps no art is more devoted to overcoming itself than literature, which aspires to create 'visions and auditions that are not of language, but which language alone makes possible', such that the writer becomes 'a seer, a hearer', 'a colorist, a musician' (Deleuze, 1997, p. lv).

Notes

[1] In *A Thousand Plateaus*, Deleuze and Guattari remark on the close relationship between the face and the cinematic close-up (Deleuze and Guattari, 1987, pp. 172, 175, 183–4). In *Cinema 1*, Deleuze discusses the face and the close-up at length (Deleuze, 1986, pp. 87–101), as part of his treatment of the affection-image, but he does not directly mention the landscape in that context. Nevertheless, he does argue that various objects may be 'facialized' through the close-up, and that ultimately the *espace quelconque* ('any-space-whatever') and the 'emptied space' are the genetic signs pertaining to the affection-image (Deleuze, 1986, p. 120). It would seem, then, that the association of the face and the landscape is in effect here, despite the absence of the word 'landscape' itself.

[2] We should note here that the 'territory-house system' includes the habitat and its inhabitants, and hence the dyad of territory-deterritorialization must be regarded as shorthand for the triad of becomings-house-universe.

[3] In *What Is Philosophy?*, Deleuze and Guattari remark that 'Bergson analyzes fabulation as a visionary faculty very different from the imagination and that consists in creating gods and giants' (1994, p. 230, n. 8).

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Chapter 2

Bim Bam Bom Bem: 'Beckett's Peephole' as Audio-visual Rhizome

Colin Gardner

Since its original publication in 1975, Gilles Deleuze and Félix Guattari's *Kafka: Toward a Minor Literature* (1986) has played a catalytic role in the re-evaluation of the works of Samuel Beckett, particularly our ability to reinterpret the Irishman's texts as machinic assemblages, as nomadic rhizomes, rather than hermetically enclosed symptoms of existential and psychological failure. Unlike James Joyce, who reterritorializes the dominant language through 'exhilaration and over-determination', Beckett works through a process of willed poverty, a minimal sobriety of both style and substance that exhausts conventional signification to a point where both character and narrative will-to-power are undermined, leaving only nonsignifying intensities and deterritorialized flux.

Like Kafka, Beckett kills off metaphor, symbolism and signification in order to unleash metamorphosis and movement for its own sake. He accomplishes this by exhausting syntax through endless combinations of disjunctive words and phrases – what Deleuze, in his essay, 'The Exhausted', calls 'Language One' – whereby enumeration and the algorithm replace semantic proposition, and proliferating series replace linear and teleological narrative. This in turn gives way in the later works to a meta-language of expressive sounds and voices – Deleuze's 'Language II' – where Beckett's characters eschew signification in favour of either story-telling for its own sake (occasionally, as in the case of *Not I*, as an excreted stream of verbiage or 'dialogh-orrhea') or as a last resort, stubborn, inexorable silence. But this is not just any silence, for as Deleuze notes, 'It is this problem, to

have done now with words, that dominates Beckett's work from *The Unnamable* onward: a true silence, not a simple tiredness with talking, because "it is all very well to keep silence, but one has also to consider the kind of silence one keeps". What will be the last word, and how can it be recognized?' (Deleuze, 1997, p. 156). In 'Language II', Beckett's characters exhaust words by speaking through the language of others/the Other, creating a multiplicitous inter-penetration of usually distinct binary oppositions such as 'I' and 'Not I', eye and percept, concept and affect, inside and outside. For Deleuze, Beckett's 'Others have no other reality than the one given to them in their possible world by their voices' (Deleuze, 1997, p. 157).

However, if we follow this logic to a structural analysis of the series limit and its fluid, immanent 'place' within the narrative flow – for example between two terms, two voices, or the variations of a single voice – there is yet a further level of discourse: namely Deleuze's 'Language III'. 'Language III' no longer has a need to relate to a referent that can be enumerated or combined, or harnessed to specific voices of enunciation (i.e. the Other), but taking the nonform of hiatuses, holes and tears, it instead looks outside itself as an endless line of flight on a limitless plane of immanence, as an aggregate of images/sounds from which all signifying language acts as a mere subset. Clearly related to Deleuze's taxonomy of the direct time-image in *Cinema 2*, most notably the chronosign and crystal-image,[1] this development reaches its apogee in Beckett's television plays, a medium that the playwright dubbed 'Peephole Art' because it 'allows the viewer to see what was never meant to be seen'. In Deleuzean terms, Beckett's television work bores holes in the surface fabric of conventional signification, creating a 'punctuation of dehiscence', so that what lurks behind the superficial veil of language and interpretation might finally make its appearance: namely an incommensurable, unnameable affect, where the perceived image is unleashed as a powerful event of limitless potential.[2] 'It is television that, in part, allows Beckett to overcome the inferiority of words', notes Deleuze, 'either by dispensing with spoken words, as in *Quad* and *Nacht und Träume*; or by using them to enumerate, to expound, or to create a

decor, which loosens them and allows things and movements to be introduced between them. . . . In television . . . it is always something other than words – *music or vision* – that makes them loosen their grip, separates them, or even opens them up completely' (Deleuze, 1997, p. 173).

Focusing specifically on the television adaptations of dramatic works such as *What Where* and *Not I*, as well as the made-for-TV production of *Quad I & II*, this essay will explore the works' simultaneous centripetal and centrifugal trajectories towards semiotic impasse and, through a concomitant creation of intensities, a liberating visual and sonic movement to both the periphery and – paradoxical as it may seem – the centre, as spaces of proliferation and deterritorialization. The result is a pure televisual nomadism that collapses the difference between inside and outside, smooth and striated, personal and collective, in short an unmappable 'any-space-whatever' through which desire escapes the confines of prestructured literary and dramatic form and becomes instead, as in the case of all minor literature, a procedure or event of pure affirmation.

Composed in French in 1983, *What Where* was adapted for German television in 1985 under the auspices of the Süddeutscher Rundfunk. Four characters (Bam, Bom, Bim and Bem), each, according to Beckett, 'as alike as possible', appear at seasonal intervals, all dressed in the same grey gown and featuring the same long grey hair. However, in the original play, Bam has an additional manifestation as the Voice of Bam (V.), a seemingly transcendental 'Voice of God' that directs and choreographs the proceedings from a 'small megaphone at head level', and judges each outcome to be positive or negative based more on personal whim than any obvious political pragmatics or moral code of conduct. After setting the scene through a wordless rehearsal, in which the four identical figures enter and leave the playing area like pieces in a board game, the Voice calls on Bam (who remains onstage until the very end of the play) and sets events in motion. First, Bam greets Bom, and demands the results of his interrogation of an unnamed subject. His response is not encouraging – although Bom gave his victim 'the works' until he wept, screamed, begged for mercy,

and finally passed out, Bom was unable to make his subject say 'it' (whatever 'it' may be). Bam accuses him of lying, and the Voice then summons Bim. Bam subsequently orders Bim to give Bom 'the works' until he confesses that his earlier victim said 'it' and 'what' (whatever they may be). After a season passes, Bim reports back to Bam, with the same results: although Bom wept, screamed and begged for mercy, he passed out without saying 'it' or 'where'. Bam, increasingly mistrustful and paranoid, now accuses Bim of lying. The Voice summons Bem, and the process goes through yet another cycle, with Bem torturing Bim to reveal what Bom was hiding from Bam. After another season passes, Bem returns with the same negative results. Because he is now the only one of the four remaining, Bam is forced to give Bem 'the works' himself. He leads Bem from the stage, returning alone after another season has passed – his head bowed in obvious defeat, ready to start another cycle. Apparently satisfied, the Voice concludes: 'Good. I am alone . . . It is winter. Without journey. Time passes. That is all. Make sense who may. I switch off.' Fade to black.

What Where is sparse and open-ended enough as a text to invite a broad range of interpretations. Some critics have read it as a political satire – the endless and fruitless interrogations smack of the Gestapo, Stalinist purges and the McCarthy witch hunt – while an existentialist interpretation might see it as an allegory of mankind's fruitless quest for understanding in a meaningless world, including any critical or scholarly attempt to reduce Beckett's works themselves to a coherent oeuvre. Beckett himself seems to have concurred with the latter, once remarking of *What Where*, 'Don't ask me what it means, it's an object.' However, the playwright has also referred to the narrative setting of *What Where* as 'the experimental field of memory' (Gontarski, 1987, p. 121). This suggests a meta-communicative site where signifying and creative processes play through a singular mind fragmented into four discrete images: namely Bam, Bem, Bim and Bom, four semiotic 'figures' placed in a deliberate set of relations individuated only by a change in vowel. This also evokes a Bergsonian mnemic structure – multiplicitous, creative, active, tied to intuition rather than a Freudian or

Lacanian lack – especially as the controlling narrative Voice of Bam seems to revise and constantly regenerate the dialogic text of his memory (in the form of the embedded play) as he goes along in order to perpetuate the narrative. The text could thus be read as a fugitive memory turning over in a singular brain, replayed cyclically as a repetitive interior monodrama, caught in the web of textual forces from which there is no escape. As Elizabeth Klaver argues, 'As a metatextual site, the play examines generative properties of semiosis in its spirals of signifiers and in its use of them as the building blocks of its own construct' (Klaver, 1991, p. 378).

However, the revised television version suggests the possibility of an alternative reading. First, the television screen now replaces the quadrangular playing area of the stage, while the actors now fade in or out of the blank ground as fugitive, disembodied floating faces (much like shimmering death masks) instead of entering and exiting from the margins of the set. Consequently, they become repetitive, ghostly fragments of a broader aggregate of images set against a potentially infinite plane of immanence. Ruptured space – as black hole, tear or hiatus – is thus directly tied to the creative process of memory and the imaginary, replacing the concrete identity of the Self/Other with repetition and difference. This itself becomes a self-fulfilling prophecy, for the phenomenal becomes dependent upon the act of repetition itself – indeed it *demands* repetition in order to sustain itself, as pure affirmation. As Anna McMullan points out, 'The images have to be repeated, and indeed draw attention to their own provisionality, their barely disguised screening of lack and absence. . . . Repetition therefore emphasizes the persistence of desire which continually exceeds its expression and draws attention to the insubstantiality of these "phantoms of the mind" which have continually to be "represented." These elements are central to the television version of *What Where*' (McMullan, 1993, p. 38).

Secondly, as in the earlier case of the silent Buster Keaton vehicle, *Film* (1964), Beckett's experimental meditation on the eighteenth-century Irish philosopher Bishop Berkeley's famous dictum, 'Esse est percipi' ('to be is to be perceived'), the

camera acts as a ubiquitous, constraining and objectifying force in its own right, an unseen and unnameable operand which oppresses the character(s) 'onstage' but from outside the diegesis instead of within. In both *Film* and *What Where*, Beckett defamiliarizes and exposes this artificially objective role of the cinematic apparatus by eschewing the use of the shot/reverse shot technique of traditional cinematic suture, which serves to bind both the characters and the viewing audience into empathetic identification through the use of a common (and interchangeable) subjective filmic 'gaze'.

Finally, the Voice of Bam and the diegetic character of Bam are present on screen at the same time, a distorted face with an electronically altered voice replacing the earlier stage prop of the megaphone. Bam is thus equalized in relation to his other three manifestations within both the master and the diegetic narrative, reinforced by the flattening, horizontalizing effect of the television picture plane, which makes it even harder to individuate the four characters. As Klaver rightly argues, 'Because the television screen is the playing field of memory . . . the act of rewriting uses the technology of television to blur and dissolve the images into each other, laying them down one by one like a visual palimpsest. The play relies on the image-processing method of juxtaposition that is so effective in and typical of television' (Klaver, 1991, p. 379). As in the case of the text itself – and its cyclical corollaries of torture and interrogation – technology is equated with the agency of control over bodily forces. Moreover, with television there is no ostensible spatio-temporal beginning or end, entrance or exit. Instead of semantic closure or understanding, there is merely a switching on or off, in much the same way that networks continue to broadcast whether we are tuned in or not. As a result, the spatial parameters of *What Where* now more closely resemble an audio-visual rhizome or cybernetic line of flight. As semiosis becomes exhausted, intensity and affect become possible, suggesting that the final product of a repetitive matrix is an endless plane of immanence.

If *What Where* sets up a centrifugal movement towards the outside of both the television screen and the dramatic playing area, *Not I* displaces the language of both self-identity and the

theatre itself towards a more centripetal immanence focused on a highly charged and affecting/affective centre. First staged in September 1972 with Jessica Tandy in the leading role, *Not I* was adapted for television in 1977 as a bravura starring vehicle for Billie Whitelaw. It takes the form of an extended monologue spoken by the spot-lit Mouth of a 70-year-old woman – shot in extreme close-up against a black ground in the television version – who relates to a silent Auditor what appears to be an autobiographical account-cum-confession of her lonely and largely uneventful life. Taken as a simple chronological narrative (what the Russian Formalists would call the *fabula*), the story is simple enough. Mouth begins her account with her premature birth, her abandonment by her parents and her lonely childhood in an orphanage, where she was taught to believe in a merciful God. She then tells of how she drifted around in silence for most of her life, punctuating the mundane details of her narrative with brief allusions to an unfulfilling sexual interlude, a court trial where she refused to even utter a plea, shopping at the supermarket and then, once or twice a year, a sudden rush of shameful speech. She describes a catalytic incident one April at Croker's Acres – the scene of her descent into madness while looking for cowslips. It was there at dusk, watching her tears dry on her upturned palms that she found herself face down in the grass, with all light extinguished.

So far so good. However, the plot (or *syuzhet*) of her account is far more complex than a simple reminiscence or autobiography. First, Mouth is adamant that she is not telling her own story – her insistence on speaking in the third person underscores the importance of the 'Not I' of the play's title. Indeed, egged on by the silent Auditor, every time she seems to be slipping into the first person she catches herself and reiterates her position as a split subject who must narrate through the discourse of another: '. . . keep on . . . not knowing what . . . what she was – . . . what? . . . who? . . . no! . . . she! . . . SHE! . . .' Moreover, her account takes the form of an unbroken, rapid stream of consciousness, spewed out in extremely repetitive fragments at breakneck speed, so that there is a physical correspondence between her story and the spectacle on stage – her inability (or

refusal) to sense her physical position as both a body and as an 'I' is echoed by the audience's similar inability to see anything of her body except her mouth. Indeed, Alec Reid has tabulated that Mouth's dialogic stream is interrupted only by two 'brief' laughs, two 'good' laughs, two screams with ensuing silences and pauses necessary for Mouth to recover from each crisis (Reid, 1986, pp. 13–18). Within the play's 12 short minutes, roughly 2268 words are spoken, separated into 726 units by ellipses. This averages 3 words per unit, with 93 per cent of the total containing 5 words or less. One could argue then that the words spoken by Mouth are not just *about* something – they *are* that something itself as pure performance. Beckett himself acknowledged this harnessing of form by affect, admitting that: 'I hear [Mouth] breathless, urgent, feverish, rhythmic, panting along, without undue concern with intelligibility. Addressed less to the understanding than to the nerves of the audience which should in a sense share her bewilderment' (Cohn, 2001, p. 316). Although Mouth is obviously at the end of her tether and verging on incoherence, her speech is never completely without meaning. Instead, she flattens out the effect of her language into a stream of pure intensity. *Not I* thus condenses all three 'stages' of Deleuze's taxonomy of language: Language I (endless recombinations of disjunctive words and phrases); Language II (story telling for its own sake as a means of survival; the adoption of the Other as alter ego); and Language III (the hole or hiatus as the portal to what lies behind the veneer of Mouth's dialoghorrhea).

The expressive role of Language III is reinforced by the televisual *mise-en-scène* and its spatial transformation into a centripetal *mise-en-abyme*. In the original play, the Auditor is defined primarily by his role as listener. He is dimly lit and plays little part in the play's spectacle. His gender is uncertain, as is his relation to Mouth. In a sense, he reflects the audience's role back at them from within the performance – thus subverting the audience's usual position as privileged and detached observer. Instead, we actually come to share and empathize with Mouth's disorder because we are unable to hear or understand a large part of her speech. However, all three roles are still held firmly in place by the traditional framework of the

theatre and the identificatory role it casts for them. By removing the role of the Auditor, the television screen sets up a direct scopic correspondence between spectator and Mouth – she is both an extension of us (albeit displaced – a case of 'Not Eye' become oral cavity) and a reiteration of our desire as the always unfulfilled desire for the Other. More importantly, the room that 'frames' our television acts as the first, outer perimeter of an extended *mise-en-abyme* that collapses into the centre of the image, passing through the frame of the TV monitor, the staging outline of Mouth herself, her lips and teeth as the inner rim of an oral/vaginal hole of speech as pure affect. This is itself the verbal 'frame' of Mouth's narrated events, which in turn express originary lack and a becoming towards death. In this way, Marshall McLuhan's famous notion of television as the quintessential analytic or 'cool medium' is neatly subverted, for never has the black hole of a literal and implied vanishing point expressed such affecting intensity as in *Not I*. Mouth's – and by extension, Language III's – performance thus subverts the conventional symbolic structures of semiotics by redistributing them as desystematized, dissipative intensities (creating, essentially, a body-without-organs). In their place, we become aware instead of a semiotics of the inexpressible via an awareness of the material qualities of text as pure voice: text, in effect/affect, as a form of music.

This inexorable movement towards musical form reaches its apogee in *Quad I & II*, first transmitted in Germany by Süddeutscher Rundfunk in 1982 under the title *Quadrat 1 + 2*. Indeed, Deleuze has described both works as a form of ritornello, after the recurring passage or refrain that recurs in different keys throughout a given movement in baroque music. The ritornello's form is the series – journeys possessing no object except their own status as recurring and fugitive lines of flight. As its title suggests, *Quad I* takes the spatial form of a quadrant, filmed from a high angle down using a fixed camera, so that the television frame roughly approximates to the four sides of the stage. The four gowned and cowled players – 'As alike in build as possible . . . sex indifferent' (Beckett, 1986, p. 453) – enter the square, one by one, until all four walk simultaneously. Each

of the monk-like figures paces four times along a side and a diagonal of the square, always avoiding the square's centre by an abrupt leftward movement. In fact, the centre is described by Beckett as 'a danger zone' because of the threat of collision. Just as the players enter the square separately, so they also leave it, one by one, until the set is quiet. The four players wear different coloured garments, and each is accompanied by a different percussion instrument. In all, the entire series of courses is performed four times. When Beckett saw the German television technicians checking the colour print of *Quad* on a black and white monitor, he improvised the idea for a second, much slower performance in monochrome, using white robes and neutral light with the original permutations reduced to a single series. In this second version, *Quad II*, a simple metronome replaces the original percussion, which accentuates the sound of shuffling feet. The result is a ghostly allegory of *Quad I*, emphasizing both the repetitive, nonteleological nature of the series, as well as the semiotic properties of the medium itself.

Deleuze, as one might expect, reads *Quad* as a spatial intensity, or, as he puts it, 'a closed, globally defined, any-space-whatever. Even the characters – short and thin, asexual, wrapped in their cowls – have no other singularities than the fact that each of them departs from a vertex as from a cardinal point, "any-characters-whatever" who traverse the square, each following a given course and direction . . . in themselves, they are only determined spatially; in themselves, they are modified by nothing other than their order and position. They are unmodified protagonists in an unmodifiable space. *Quad* is a ritornello that is essentially motor, whose music is the shuffling of slippers – like the sound of rats' (Deleuze, 1997, p. 162). All that counts is the series, its course, its order, its speeds and slownesses, which are in turn dependent upon the appearance and disappearance of the protagonists. For Deleuze, 'The order, the course, and the set render the movement all the more inexorable inasmuch as it has no object, like a conveyor belt that makes moving objects appear and disappear' (Deleuze, 1997, p. 163).

Quad thus once again raises the question of exhausting space. However, as in the case of *What Where* and *Not I*, this should not

be read as negation or lack, but as the construction of a new realm of the possible, unleashing the actual *potentiality* of the square: 'Potentiality is a double possible', concludes Deleuze. 'It is the possibility that an event, in itself possible, might be realized in the space under consideration: the possibility that something is realizing *itself*, and the possibility that some place is realizing *it*. The potentiality of the square is the possibility that the four moving bodies that inhabit it will collide – two, three, or all four of them – depending on the order and the course of the series' (Deleuze, 1997, p. 163). The nodal point of this potentiality is the centre, or more specifically the slight dislocation or hiatus that occurs at the centre as the four protagonists swerve to avoid each other. Just at the very point that space seems to be physically emptied out, it is filled up again as intensity, as pure potential. More importantly, its paradoxical role as a decentred any-space-whatever activates the unlimited, immanent space of the quadrant's periphery, that area of endless comings and goings which evoke the discontinuous blocks and segments characteristic of Kafka's *The Trial*. Both Beckett and Kafka's seemingly confined spaces have back doors that are contiguous and link up with the unlimited any-space-whatever of an extended line of flight. In *Quad I & II*, everything that is seemingly distant and segmented is also contiguous at the same time, so that our TV set thus becomes a rectangular portal that connects us to the boundless and infinite space lurking in the margins off-screen.

Given Beckett's obvious compatibility with Kafka and minor literature, how should we contextualize his television work in relation to Deleuze's writings on cinema as a whole? In *Cinema 2*, Deleuze discovered the roots of the direct time-image in the crisis of the action-image that began with 1940s *film noir* and subsequently flourished in the immediate aftermath of World War II. Citing the specific example of Italian neorealism – particularly the work of Rossellini and de Sica – Deleuze notes an aesthetic break separating a movement-based cinema based on narrative linearity and historical agency from a 'false movement' whose intrinsic time is nonlinear, repetitive and discontinuous – what Deleuze, as we noted above, calls 'crystalline cinema'. However,

it is important to realize that Deleuze allows for these two types of temporality – indirect and direct time – to coexist. He refuses to think them through dialectically or attempt to overcome the contradictions between them. Instead, Deleuze teases out and celebrates the *aporias* that arise from their conjunction, without coping with their inconsistencies. Indeed, if we reread *Cinema 1*'s movement-image in light of *Cinema 2*'s time-image, we find the latter always already immanent in the former (we might reread Eisenstein, for example, less in terms of the dialectical shock *across* images, and more in terms of the immanence of historical time that lies hidden *between* them). Marie-Claire Ropars-Wuilleumier has, correctly I believe, read this move as an attempt to transform matter (images in movement) into memory (images as time), so that the present becomes doubled with the virtual image of the past it must inevitably become. Cinema itself expresses time, its present always ahead of itself, its actuality a becoming-virtual at all times. She makes the logical conclusion that Deleuze has moved out of a Bergsonian ontology into a directly Nietzschean one: 'It is to Nietzsche that Deleuze intends to graft the cinema, a Nietzsche for whom the circular becoming of time precipitates (as it does in modern cinema) short-circuits, bifurcations, detours, and irrational divisions, where the notion of intensity is substituted for that of truth' (Ropars-Wuilleumier, 1994, p. 256). Post-war cinema – and we should certainly include Beckett's film and television work within this larger rubric – is thus marked by a paradoxical Nietzschean time, a circuitous temporality of repetition and eternal return, whereby the logic of sense is itself the logic of paradox, for 'sense confirms itself only in the experience of nonsense, because it expresses itself only in a language that, while speaking, runs after the sense of what it says' (Ropars-Wuilleumier, 1994, p. 256). We thus discover a new *aporia* at the heart of the time-image, between C. S. Peirce's exhaustive cataloguing, that was so pertinent to the more indirect form of the movement-image, and Nietzsche's paradoxical logic that seems to defy all attempts at classification. Ropars-Wuilleumier stresses the import of the *aporia*-as-paradox as central to a cinema of pure *durée*: 'this ephemeral instant, when sense and being coincide, belongs to the cinema

as an art of the figure, in that cinema restores the possibility of making this instant coexist with the awareness of paradox' (Ropars-Wuilleumier, 1994, p. 260).

If, as Deleuze has argued, the irrational apex of the modern post-war cinema is the '*unsummonable* of Welles, the *inexplicable* of Robbe-Grillet, the *undecidable* of Resnais, the *impossible* of Marguerite Duras, or again what might be called the *incommensurable* of Godard (between two things)' (Deleuze, 1989, pp. 181–2; emphasis in original), Beckett's rhizomic deterritorialization of language-as-space through exhaustion and a 'punctuation of dehiscence' would seem to be a worthy addendum to this list. For as Deleuze points out in specific reference to Beckett's television work in *The Exhausted*, 'it would seem that an image, inasmuch as it stands in the void outside space, and also apart from words, stories and memories, accumulates a fantastic potential energy, which it detonates by dissipating itself. What counts in the image is not its meagre content, but the energy – mad and ready to explode – that it has harnessed, which is why images never last very long' (Deleuze, 1997, p. 160). And which is also why images can only be glimpsed through the tears and holes in the fabric of pure time itself.

Notes

[1] The chronosign is 'an image where time ceases to be subordinate to movement and appears for itself'; while the crystal-image or hyalosign constitutes 'the uniting of an actual image and a virtual image to the point where they can no longer be distinguished' (Deleuze, 1989, p. 335).

[2] Beckett first outlines this concept in his 1932 fragment, *Dream of Fair to Middling Women*, where the character Belacqua desires to write a book whereby 'the experience of my reader shall be between the phrases, in the silence, communicated by the intervals, not the terms, of the statement' (Cited in Bogue, 2003, p. 178).

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Chapter 3

Where Has Gertrud(e) Gone?

Gertrude Stein's Cinematic Journey from Movement-Image to Time-Image

Sarah Posman

In June 1927, Kenneth Macpherson, editor of the brand new film magazine *Close Up*, asked Gertrude Stein if she would consider contributing to the journal. By his account, 'greatly increasing numbers of people . . . [were] coming to regard films as a medium for the possible expression of art in its most modern and experimental aspects'. Since, according to Macpherson (1953), Stein's writing 'is so exactly the kind of thing that could be translated to the screen', any poem or article 'would be deeply appreciated'. Stein, always eager to publish, happily complied.[1] Although the screen quality of her literary avant-garde experiment can be called questionable, Macpherson's cinematic take on her writing is not all that surprising.[2] Stein had a life-long obsession with movement. Looking back on her career in 'How Writing Is Written [1935]', she notes:

> In the Twentieth Century you feel like movement. The Nineteenth Century didn't feel that way. The element of movement was not the predominating thing that they felt. You know that in your lives movement is the thing that occupies you most – you feel movement all the time. (1974, p. 153)

By Stein's account ('Portraits and Repetition'), it was the cinema and series production that summed up movement in the twentieth century. And since she felt 'bound to express what the world in which we are living is doing', she teamed up the movement

she sought to express in her early portrait writing with the cinema (Writings 2, p. 294). Despite the fact that in her lecture 'Plays' (Writings 2, p. 251) she states she 'never [went] to the cinema or hardly ever practically never and [that] the cinema has never read my work or hardly ever', she stresses in 'Portraits and Repetition' (Writings 2, p. 294) that those early portraits were doing 'what the cinema was doing'.

But what exactly was the cinema doing? And just how far would Stein's analogy take her? I argue that Gilles Deleuze's take on cinema can help us out in answering both questions. Obviously, the two *Cinema* books centre on film yet Deleuze (2005b, p. 268) stresses that his theory is not ' "about" cinema, but about the concepts that cinema gives rise to and which are themselves related to other concepts corresponding to other practices'. It is exactly this intersection of practices – of what Deleuze and Guattari in *What Is Philosophy?* call the three great forms of thought: art, science and philosophy – that I take to heart when I add to Deleuze's Bergsonian perspective on cinema the literary one of Gertrude Stein.[3] Ever advocating new encounters, Deleuze shows himself to be the perfect go-between in staging a gathering between Bergson and Stein – two contemporaneous advocates of (cinematic) movement whose affinity has thus far all too often been ignored.[4]

According to Deleuze, what early twentieth-century cinema was doing is something philosophy had long since been struggling with; it exposed the dynamics of time. From antiquity on to the modern scientific revolution, movement was consistently reconstituted from fixed instants or positions on a timeline. Time came in second to something that takes place in it, to a spatial realm in which things move and change but which does not move itself. In such a scheme, movement was little more than the regulated transition from one privileged instant to another. By Deleuze's account, cinema changed all that. Unlike photography, which captures its object in a static cast, cinema succeeds in 'moulding itself on the time of the object and of taking the imprint of its duration as well' (Deleuze, 2005a, p. 25). Yet there is more to cinema than moving pictures. Such early experiments as Muybridge's and Marey's chronophotographs,

for example, cannot be called cinema proper since those only give us an image in movement, an immobile section to which movement is added. The cinema, by contrast, 'immediately gives us a movement-image' and thus renders movement as such (Deleuze, 2005a, p. 2).[5] It is by virtue of the discovery of montage and the mobile camera, which radically altered the viewer's perspective, that the moving pictures were able to conquer their own novelty. Both montage, which is the continuous connecting of various shots, and a mobile camera, which makes the shot become mobile itself, can create dazzling viewpoints in hopping back and forth between several moving bodies. A movement-image, consequently, does not track a single moving unity yet neither does it give way to a disparate collection of moving objects. '[I]n extracting from vehicles or moving bodies the movement which is their common substance,' the cinema succeeds in showing that which happens between various objects or parts as a unity (Deleuze, 2005a, p. 24). Thus, Deleuze explains, 'movement relates the objects between which it is established to the changing whole which it expresses and vice versa' (2005a, p. 11). Central as movement may be, the films Deleuze discusses in *Cinema 1* are not abstract experiments featuring movement per se. He focuses on classics with stories built on a basic sensory motor scheme of action and reaction.[6] These movement-images, basically, present characters responding to the particular situations in which they find themselves, thus creating the successive pattern of events that guides the story.

By Deleuze's account the philosophical equivalent to the cinematic revolution is Henri Bergson's philosophy of time. Throughout his oeuvre Bergson urges his readers to take the imprint of time's duration into account.[7] Again and again he expresses his astonishment over the fact that the time we live by, the time of science and common sense, does not endure.[8] The common representation of time by means of a timeline is a mere symbolic rendering of time, a static, artificial demarcation of past, present and future. Real time escapes such representation since, in Bergson's words (1992, p. 12), '[t]he line one measures is immobile [and] time is mobility'. According to Keith Ansell Pearson (1999, p. 21) the novel modernity Deleuze

applauds in Bergson lies exactly in his opposition to an abstract mechanics and his conception of the durational character of life. Bergson, however, did not find the durational character of life compatible with that most modern and experimental art form, the cinema. In *Creative Evolution* (1998, p. 306) he even downright rejects the medium, reproaching it for mechanically projecting a series of static single frames and obstructing the 'inner becoming of things' by recomposing it artificially. Whereas real duration implies 'an infinite multiplicity of becomings variously colored', the contrivance of cinema – analogous to that of our intellect, language and natural perception – consists in substituting this infinite multiplicity by a bland abstraction (Bergson, 1998, p. 306). Deleuze, however, 'outBergsons' Bergson in showing that he should have taken to film.[9]

According to Deleuze (2005a, p. 3), 'the discovery of the movement-image, beyond the conditions of natural perception, was the extraordinary invention of the first chapter of *Matter and Memory*.' In this chapter, Bergson seeks to think perception anew, unencumbered by either idealism or realism.[10] What is really at stake in perception, Bergson contends, is neither idealism's representation nor realism's thing but an aggregate of images.[11] Images are quite simply all there is. Taken together they constitute the Bergsonian model of perception, which is open to that infinite multiplicity of becomings real duration implies. In this scheme there is no hierarchy of becoming, there are no points of anchorage or centres of reference (Deleuze, 2005a, p. 60). All you can say about this 'gaseous state' is that it is made up of images that continuously 'act on others and react to others, on all their facets at once and by all their elements' (Bergson in Deleuze, 2005a, p. 60). The Bergsonian images are in effect defined solely by their actions and reactions and stretch only as far as this sensory motor scheme takes them. Perception, then, does not as idealism or realism would have it, serve pure knowledge but movement. Since images are everything, there cannot be anything more than or external to movement.[12]

That is not to say that in Bergson's project free-floating movement discards all conscious action or subjective perception. Apart from those straightforward images where a given impulse

(action) automatically triggers a response (reaction) according to 'what are called the laws of nature', there are special types of images, which are selective in the actions they receive and in the reactions they exert (Bergson, 2005, p. 20).[13] It is thanks to an interval between a received movement and an executed movement that the living image that is your brain is able to select one out of a plurality of possible reactions.[14] So, contrary to natural perception, which tends to add movement as something extra to an immobile object, perception on Bergson's terms is made up solely of movement-images. It is their sensory motor scheme with its plethora of actions and reactions that gives expression to the nature of time, an open whole that is all the time changing, moving, enduring.

While Bergson may have missed out on the revolutionary potential of cinema, Gertrude Stein did not. Of course, when she characterized the twentieth century as the age of cinema and series production, she was largely giving voice to what was in the early twentieth-century air. Cinema and series production, the invention of the telephone, the wireless telegraph, x-rays, the automobile, the airplane and the introduction of a standard time constituted a very tangible change in the everyday experience and conception of time and space. Scientific and philosophical inquiries into the nature of time and space, moreover, did not take place in ivory towers but could count on enormous public interest. In literature, Stein would add her idea of a continuous present to the famous time experiments of Marcel Proust, whose *A la recherche du temps perdu* gave memories a pace entirely their own, and of James Joyce, whose *Ulysses* has Leopold Bloom retrace Odysseus' steps in sixteen hours.[15] Stein desperately wanted to update the time sense of contemporary literature. Nineteenth-century compositions, with their chapters in a neat successive order, stuck too close to the humdrum course of daily living and the manageable time of common sense. Neither was a twentieth-century concern.[16] Her idea of a continuous present, which sought to express the present in all its novelty at the very moment she was living it, was. How exactly such a continuous present comes about is not quite clear. Throughout her lectures, the closest thing available to a

Steinian poetics, she gives away little more than that the time sense of compositions 'bothered' her.

The biggest stumbling block appears to have been that 'a thing goes dead once it has been said' ('What Are Masterpieces', Writings 2, p. 361). Stein stubbornly refused to submit to the time interval that separates perception from artistic creation. In the early portraits, which she started composing at around 1910, expressing a thing's liveliness is essentially bound up with the act of perceiving.[17] Her idea of a continuous present where perception and creation coincide is, in other words, all about immediacy.[18] Such a new literary time sense calls for a new literary language and thus Stein's famous 'new constructions of grammar' where present participles abound and nothing stops her from 'beginning again and again' came about (Stein, 1974, p. 155; Writings 1, p. 524). Such beginning again and again has nothing to do with repetition. Everyday descriptions of things may be repetitive but, Stein explains in 'Portraits and Repetition', once you set out to recreate the things themselves and give shape to their 'being existing', repetition has to give way to 'insistence'. Insistence implies emphasis 'and if you use emphasis it is not possible while anybody is alive that they should use exactly the same emphasis' (Writings 2, p. 288). Just as, when a frog is hopping every single hop will be quite unique, no two persons can perceive – and hence express – a thing in exactly the same way.[19] And when it comes to conveying unique experience Stein does seek recourse to the cinema. It is the cinema that provides her with the solution to escape repetitive descriptions and set about saying and hearing 'what [the object of her portrait] says and hears while he is saying and hearing it' ('Portraits', Writings 2, p. 293):

> Funnily enough the cinema has offered a solution of this thing. By a continuously moving picture of any one there is no memory of any other thing and there is that thing existing, it is in a way if you like one portrait of anything not a number of them. (Writings 2, pp. 293–4)

The cinema, by Stein's account (Writings 2, p. 295), succeeds in touching on the person's or thing's unique liveliness since it

'has each time a slightly different thing to make it all be moving'. Moreover, it knows how to unite these slightly different things in 'one portrait . . . not a number of them' (Writings 2, p. 293). Stein's early portraits, then, in quite the Bergsonian fashion, aim for a differential 'moving' whole.

The first portrait of Picasso, for example, is truly a 'continuously moving picture'.[20] The three-page sequence of variations on the opening sentence 'One whom some were certainly following was one who was completely charming' brims with present participles creating the agile new grammar Stein was after ('Picasso', Writings 1, p. 282). Sentence after sentence, moreover, she adjusts her take on the artist. After introducing him as 'one whom some were certainly following', she characterizes him as 'one working' and 'bringing out of himself then something' – key phrases on which she will vary incessantly. At no point, however, does she present her readers with a still of Picasso at work or a clear picture of his output. By constantly insisting that he is working, or 'needing to be working', and that a multitude of things are 'coming out of him', viz. 'solid', 'charming', 'lovely', 'perplexing', 'disconcerting', 'simple', 'clear', 'complicated', 'interesting', 'repellent' and 'very pretty' things, she touches on the artist's ever-developing frenetic activity – as she perceives or realizes it ('Picasso', Writings 1). The differential force she accredits to the cinema translates into her rendering 'the successive moments of [her] realizing them' with 'each moment having its own emphasis [or] its own difference' ('Portraits', Writings 2, pp. 307–8). Each moment, each sentence, Stein begins again.

What fuels her incessant 'beginning again and again', she explains in 'Portraits and Repetition' (Writings 2, p. 296) is the technique of 'talking and listening' by which she hopes to bring about 'action and not repetition'. In her early portraits listening and talking replaces the old perceptive model, which she associates with looking.[21] Looking, she explains, 'inevitably carries in its *train* realizing movement' (italics mine) and such – perhaps surprisingly – is to be avoided. What Stein actually means by 'realizing movement' is a break with movement. She wittily lets on that with 'a *train* moving there is no real realization of it

moving if it does not move against something' (italics mine). 'Moving against something' of course implies an abrupt stop and deriving movement from its stops is exactly what characterizes the old take on movement and time. Stein's new take on movement, would, ideally, make it possible to show 'that it is moving even if it is not moving against anything'. Her ceaseless dialogic scheme of listening and talking, of opening herself to all of a person's or object's stimuli and responding to them, aims for a smoothly running portrait without halts. She maintains that it is of no use trying to separate talking and listening or have one neutralize the other for 'like the motor going inside and the car moving, they are part of the same thing' ('Portraits', Writings 2, pp. 287–90).[22] Talking and listening, action and reaction, together constitute the enduring, differential unity that makes up the whole of the portrait – or movement-image.[23]

Let us have a look at the first paragraph of the Picasso portrait:

> One whom some were certainly following was one who was completely charming. One whom some were certainly following was one who was charming. One whom some were following was one who was completely charming. One whom some were following was one who was certainly completely charming. ('Picasso', Writings 1, p. 282)

Here, Stein insists on inter-sentence difference by means of subtle syntactical changes. She adds a word, leaves it out again and moves it about. Each sentence differs from the previous one and constitutes one of those successive moments she wants to track. In each sentence the game of impulse (listening) and response (talking) is given a different outcome. Stein, you might say, is her own mobile camera. She does not stay put and watch Picasso evolve. She is rather listening and talking, moving, perceiving all the time. She is recreating the artist's energy in sprightly sentences from which she extracts the course of movement itself. Stein, in other words, is doing what Deleuze would have had Bergson realize the cinema was doing.[24] In tune with the Deleuzian/Bergsonian movement-image, then,

a Steinian cinematic portrait 'does not *resemble* an object that it would represent'. Resemblances, Stein and Deleuze seem to agree, are unnecessary detours quite alien to cinema.[25] The movement-image opts for immediacy, for the thing itself. In Deleuze's words, '[t]he movement-image is the object; the thing itself caught in movement as continuous function.' It continuously and successively tracks the movement inside and as such it creates difference. There is no opportunity for an object to solidify into a cast or mould, like it would in a traditional portrait or photograph, since the movement-image implies 'a putting into variation of the mould, a transformation of the mould at each moment of the operation' (Deleuze, 2005b, pp. 26–7). There is consequently also no opportunity for the viewer (or reader) to grasp the object once and for all. A Bergsonian movement-image does not offer you one clear point of view to identify with but instead presents a world 'deprived of all its centres' (Deleuze, 2005b, p. 35). Or, in Steinese, '[it] act[s] so that there is no use in a center' (Tender Buttons, Writings 1, p. 344).

Talking and listening served Stein well in rendering the continuous present of her early portraits but after more than a decade of experimenting with the dialogic format in various constellations, she 'began to feel movement to be a different thing than [she] had felt it to be':

> It was to me beginning to be a less detailed thing and at the same time a thing that existed so completely inside in it and it was it was so completely inside that really looking and listening and talking were not a way any longer needed for me to know about this thing about movement being existing. ('Portraits', Writings 2, p. 310)

Movement, for Stein, starts folding back upon itself. She wants her writing to have 'more movement inside in the portrait and yet it was to be the whole portrait completely held within that inside'. She is no longer on the outlook for the concrete movements that make up (her perception of), say, Picasso. What she aims for is a new kind of totality, a 'whole', containing more movement yet movement that is contained instead of extending

into action. The cinematic perception she experimented with in the portraits is consequently no longer of use to her. At this point in her literary development she may have been 'as usual looking listening and talking perhaps more than ever', what she actually sees, hears or feels has to give way to something 'more vibrant than any of all that'. 'It was about that time that [she] wrote Four Saints' ('Portraits', Writings 2, pp. 310–11). The opera 'Four Saints in Three Acts', written in 1927, is almost unique in her oeuvre because it enjoyed huge popular success. It moreover differs poetically from what she had written before in that it takes the time sense of her compositions in a new direction.[26] The world in 'Four Saints' is no longer that of Stein's personal experience. It is populated with characters that did not come to her 'from inside, from her own perception or experience, [but] from outside, from history' (Dydo, 2003, p. 199). Still, it is history on Stein's terms. The opera's protagonists, the Spanish Saint Theresa and Saint Ignatius, may have been each other's sixteenth-century contemporaries, they were not Stein's, though she approaches them as such. She draws on several centuries at once yet turns those into a panorama of presents where action, central to the portraits, is of little importance. The less gets done the better, or so it seems. She explains: 'A saint a real saint never does anything, . . . a really good saint does nothing, and so I wanted to have Four Saints who did nothing and that was everything' (1993, p. 109). Now how can such inertia rhyme with Stein's fast moving world? And what happened to the cinema? It is again Deleuze's cinematic Bergsonism that illuminates Stein's poetics.

In *Cinema 2* Deleuze discerns an evolution in cinema from movement-image to time-image. Where the movement-image renders 'the course of time: a successive present in an extrinsic relation of before and after', a time-image succeeds in rendering time itself (Deleuze, 2005b, p. 259). In a time-image, action no longer extends into reaction. It is not that movement no longer matters, even though there is often little of it in the time-image. What happens, rather, is that the relation movement – time alters radically. In the movement-image time derives from movement: 'movement in its extension was the immediate

given and the whole which changes, that is time, was indirect or mediate representation' (Deleuze, 2005b, p. 265). The time-image by contrast subordinates movement to time. In revealing 'the hidden ground of time' it takes you back to the point where the actual images (which in the movement-image extend into action) are still bound up with their own virtual images (Deleuze, 2005b, p. 95). In this pre-sensory motor realm, if you like, nothing is as yet decided and budding possible reactions proliferate. Deleuze, in other words, replaces an organic conception of time where virtual gives way to actual and past turns into present, with a crystal one. In the latter, the actual and virtual, real and imaginary, past and present find themselves bound up together in a single time crystal. Where the protagonist of the movement-image was the *actant*, the time-image calls for the figure of the *voyant*. And what this *voyant* sees when he or she looks into the time crystal is time itself, time splitting itself continuously in two – into the actual image of the present which passes and the virtual image of the past which is preserved.

It is this incessant bifurcating of a passing present and a present past – which is paradoxically static since 'there is never a completed crystal; each crystal is infinite by right, in the process of being made' (Deleuze, 2005b, p. 85) – that makes up the hidden ground of time. It is again to Bergson that Deleuze owes the idea central to the time-image, viz. the unity of time, or the coexistence of present and past.[27] In *Bergsonism* Deleuze (1991, p. 55) explains that in the Bergsonian universe the present never is, but rather always acts: '[i]ts proper element is not being but the active or the useful.' By contrast, the past, precisely because it no longer acts, is caught in an inactive, impassive being. As such, past and present coexist: 'the past does not follow the present but . . . is presupposed by it as the pure condition without which it would not pass' (Deleuze, 1991, p. 59). Coexistence, however, does not imply an order of simultaneities, but 'a becoming as potentialization' (Deleuze, 2005b, p. 264). The challenge of the Deleuzian/Bergsonian time-image, then, like the whole of Deleuze's project, lies in its potential to open our eyes to difference. Actual images come along with a multitude of virtual other images and it is these other possibilities

that the time-image knows how to make visible. This is also the path that Gertrude Stein's 'Four Saints' explores.

Stein was rather satisfied with what she accomplished in 'Four Saints'. In 'Plays' (Writings 2, p. 269) she states that 'it did almost what I wanted, it made a landscape and the movement in it was like a movement in and out with which anybody looking on can keep in time.' Stein's problem with the theatre had always been 'the different tempo there is in the play and in yourself' (Writings 2, p. 245). In a traditional play her emotions could not keep track with the emotions on stage, but in one of her own landscapes they could:

> I felt that if a play was exactly like a landscape then there would be no difficulty about the emotion of the person looking on at the play being behind or ahead of the play because the landscape does not have to make acquaintance. You may have to make acquaintance with it, but it does not with you, it is there and so the play being written the relation between you at any time is so exactly that that it is of no importance unless you look at it. (Writings 2, p. 263)

The thing about a Steinian landscape, in other words, is that it contains everything at once. There is no chronology of emotions, no Aristotelian development that forces you to keep up. Or, in Stein's words (Writings 2, p. 267): 'a landscape does not move nothing really moves in a landscape but things are there.' Everything is there for you to explore at once, there are as many ins and outs as you want there to be. As such, a Steinian landscape is no longer congenial to the cinematic portraits, which sought to render the thing 'being existing', that is, on Stein's terms.[28] It should be no surprise, then, that cinema is actually in disfavour: 'there is yet the trouble with the cinema that it is after all a photograph, and a photograph continues to be a photograph and yet can it become something else' (Writings 2, p. 259). What the cinema as Stein conceived of it and photography share is their claim on empirical reality. She had turned to cinema when she sought to convey the 'thing being existing' and she was well aware of photography's pretensions. Empirical

reality, however, was no longer what she was interested in. She wanted to go beyond experience. '[T]he thing more vibrant than any of all that' she aimed for in the landscape of 'Four Saints' nevertheless unwittingly announces the future of cinema, i.e. the time-image.

A landscape may not develop from one stage to another – 'its quality is that a landscape if it ever did go away would have to go away to stay' – it does not represent a frozen microcosm. Quite to the contrary, it bustles with activity, 'mirroring the movement of nuns, very busy and in continuous movement'. The excitement Stein feels concerning 'Four Saints' lies exactly in the fact that 'it moves but it also stays' (Writings 2, p. 269). Stein's convent comparison is, however, quite misleading if you take it to stand for a hierarchically organized, closed system. The text itself belies any such notion on several fronts. When it comes to the acts and scenes, for example, Stein mocks an orderly sequence of chapters. Act one is only announced six pages into the opera and furthermore almost immediately followed by 'Repeated First Act', which opens with 'A pleasure April fool's day a pleasure' (Writings 1, p. 613). Readers are fooled over and over again. Acts, repeated acts and scenes proliferate. Towards the end of the opera the only possible answer to the question 'how many acts are there in it' is that by which Stein (Writings 1, p. 648) parries the similar question 'how many saints are there in it', viz. 'as many as there are in it'. The opera mocks order, first and foremost the traditional temporal sequence of a five- or three-act play, which tries to dictate the audience what to feel when.

In 'Four Saints' order is simply all up to the reader since he or she is given all the possible sequences at once. By taking her audience back to a virtual unity of past and present, Stein seems to have found an answer to 'the question of confusing time' that bothered her ('Portraits', Writings 1, p. 302). It is no surprise, therefore, that in the opera she makes it possible for different generations to make each other's acquaintance:

> Four saints were not born at one time although they knew each other. One of them had a birthday before the mother of

> the other one the father. Four saints later to be if to be one to be to be one to be. Might tingle. ('Four Saints', Writings 1, p. 612)

The saints are presented at the junction of their pasts (their respective birthdays) and presents (their possible future unity) – an exciting, 'tingl[ing]' spot indeed. Stein's virtual unity also allows her to show Saint Theresa as a saint *and* as nun withering storms in Avila *and* 'as a young girl' (Writings 1, p. 613; p. 616). There is no story of the saint becoming a saint, she is everything at once; she is 'half in doors and half out of doors', 'seated' and 'not seated', 'very nearly half inside and half outside the house' and so on (Writings 1, pp. 612–14). Saint Theresa who had always 'meant to be complete completely' hence finds herself in the very heart of time: 'Saint Theresa in time' (Writings 1, p. 623).[29] In this novel universe anyone wanting to know the time will have to make do with 'clock o' clock' (Writings 1, p. 641). Seasons and days of the week are as unreliable. All are out of joint and appear simultaneously: 'Those used to winter like winter and summer. / Those used to summer like winter and summer' (Writings 1, p. 621). 'When is exchangeable' and even 'night and day cannot be different' (Writings 1, p. 635). The opera leaves actual (temporal) divisions behind 'never to return to distinctions' and trades in definite answers for a vast range of possible answers (Writings 1, p. 638). Nothing much gets done this way, yet all the more seems possible.

Little may get realized in the opera itself, Stein nevertheless makes sure that 'Four Saints' reverberates with a call for action. Ever concerned with the new that she felt the twentieth century had in store, she made sure her virtual abolishing of the old (temporal) order reflected on her day and age, an era in which new configurations were *actually* coming about. Of all the virtual compositions 'Four Saints' encompasses, there is at least one whose turning actual Stein advocates in one of the opera's key scenes, Saint Ignatius' vision. The vision starts with the saint seeing 'pigeons on the grass alas' added to by a 'magpie in the sky' (Writings 1, p. 637). As we can expect, no answer is given with respect to the meaning of these birds. They might very

well stand for a bathetic reversal of the holy order with the dove turning into an ordinary pigeon stuck on the ground and such a common bird as the magpie taking its place in the sky. A teasing 'they might be very well very well they might be' is all we get for an answer. Much more outspoken is the conclusion of the vision which ends on the sequence 'Let Lucy Lily Lily Lucy Lucy let Lucy Lucy Lily Lily Lily Lily Lily let Lily Lucy Lucy let Lily. Let Lucy Lily' (Writings 1, p. 637). Here the visionary is pleading a different order in much less enigmatic terms. The sequence reads as a prayer for women, 'Lucy' and 'Lily', to be given a chance ('let') at (religious) power, both politically with 'Lucy' conjuring up 'Lucretia', the name of the only female pope ever, and symbolically with the lily standing for the Holy Virgin.[30] In her opera Stein welds the virtual time-image of a new time with its newly configured order, open to women, to the actual mid 1920s concern of women's suffrage thereby making clear that virtual and actual will not be severed.

So, on her own literary terms Gertrude Stein has added to some of the twentieth century's most enthralling discoveries into the nature of movement, time and perception. Avant-gardist to the core, she wanted to break free from the (literary) constraints of the nineteenth century and give shape to the new era. In order to achieve this, she allied her efforts with the cinema and, implicitly, with the thought of Henri Bergson. Using Gilles Deleuze's cinematic Bergsonism I have not only shown how Bergson's concern for the movement of time speaks much the same language as Stein's early portraits, that of early cinema thriving on movement-images, I have also argued that in evolving from her cinematic portraits to the landscape of her opera 'Four Saints', Stein announces the future of cinema in creating a time-sense quite like the Bergsonian time-image. In evolving from movement-image to time-image, then, Stein was indeed doing what, by Gilles Deleuze's account, the cinema would be doing. Still, for all these enthralling philosophic/cinematic entanglements, one should keep in mind that what mattered most to Stein was *literary* sovereignty for 'in English literature in her time she is the only one' (Autobiography of Alice B. Toklas, Writings 1, p. 738). From whichever angle you choose to read

Gertrude Stein, you will always have to be prepared to have her go her own way – to have her 'climb about and remind you that a woman in this epoch does the important literary thinking' (Geographical History, Writings 2, p. 473).

Notes

[1] Stein's portrait 'Mrs. Emerson' was published in the 1927 August *Close Up* issue. One of her longer pieces, 'Three Sitting Here', was spread over the magazine's September and October issues.

[2] The cinematic quality of Stein's writing continues to fascinate critics. Recent explorations can be found in Sarah Bay Cheng's *Gertrude Stein's Avant-Garde Theatre* (2005), Julian Murphet and Lydia Rainford's *Literature and Visual Technologies* (2003) and Susan McCabe's *Cinematic Modernism* (2004).

[3] In *What Is Philosophy?* Deleuze and Guattari maintain that 'sciences, arts and philosophies are all equally creative' (Deleuze and Guattari, 1994, p. 5). Each field has its own do's and don'ts but, the authors stress, 'what to us seem more important now are the problems of interference between the planes' (Deleuze and Guattari, 1994, p. 216). In his *Cinema* books, moreover, the specificity of cinema does not hinder Deleuze from opening up to literature. In *Cinema 2* he writes: 'the direct time-image always gives us access to that Proustian dimension where people and things occupy a place in time which is incommensurable with the one they have in space. Proust indeed speaks in terms of cinema, time mounting its magic lantern on bodies making the shots coexist in depth' (Deleuze, 2005b, p. 37).

[4] The relation between Gertrude Stein and Henri Bergson is often alluded to but has thus far only been the pivot of Joseph Riddel's "Stein and Bergson" in *The Turning Word: American Literary Modernism and Continental Theory* (1996). In the one study that explicitly deals with Gertrude Stein and the philosophy of time, Allegra Stewart's *Gertrude Stein and the Present*, Bergson crops up as one of the philosophers to whom Stein relates but her Radcliffe teachers, George Santayana and William James, and Alfred North Whitehead take preference over Bergson. By contrast, Stein's modernist peers like T. S. Eliot, Virginia Woolf, Willa Cather, Wallace Stevens and James Joyce have been subjected to exhaustive 'Bergsonian' interpretations. This near lacuna in Stein criticism is all the more peculiar since, for their contemporaries such as Mina Loy, Mabel Dodge Luhan and Wyndham Lewis, Stein and Bergson seem to have been obvious allies.

[5] Deleuze elaborates: 'Cinema proceeds with photogrammes – that is, with immobile sections – twenty-four images per second (or eighteen

at the outset). But it has often been noted that what it gives us is not the photogramme: it is an intermediate image, to which movement is not appended or added; the movement on the contrary belongs to the intermediate image as immediate given' (Deleuze, 2005a, p. 2).

[6] *Cinema 1* deals with 'the movement-image of the so-called classical cinema' characteristic of the first half of the twentieth century. In *Cinema 2* Deleuze elaborates on the time-image of post-World War II films. Although he takes the Second World War as a break, this division is not rigid. Movement-images live on in contemporary films and 'conversely, we must look in pre-war cinema . . . for the workings of a very pure time-image which has always been breaking through, holding back or encompassing the movement-image' (Deleuze, 2005b, pp. xi; xiii).

[7] For a Deleuzian answer to the question 'what is duration?' see Keith Ansell Pearson's *Germinal Life* (1999, pp. 33–40) and chapters three, four and five of D. N. Rodowick's *Gilles Deleuze's Time Machine* (1997).

[8] According to Keith Ansell Pearson '[t]his does not prevent Bergson from appreciating the success of science; on the contrary, it is such insights into the specific character of science that enables him to appreciate the reasons for its success, namely, the fact that it is contingent and relative to the variables it has selected and to the order in which it stages problems' (1999, p. 58).

[9] Deleuze solves the problem of Bergson's rejection of cinema by stating that the cinema Bergson fulminated against was a primitive cinema and that 'things are never defined by their primitive state but by the tendency concealed in this state' (Deleuze, 2005a, p. 26).

[10] Both idealism and realism, Bergson contends, go too far (2005, p. 9). The former reduces matter to the perception we have of it and the latter makes it a thing able to produce in us perceptions yet of a different nature.

[11] These images should be conceived of as an in-between category, 'placed halfway between the "thing" and the "representation"' (Bergson, 2005, p. 9). By means of images, Bergson wants to forego the dissociation between existence and appearance. Images are all there is; you perceive them when your senses are opened to them and you do not when they are closed (Bergson, 2005, p. 17).

[12] In *Bergsonism* Deleuze explains: 'the brain does not manufacture representations, but only complicates the relationship between a received movement (excitation) and an executed movement (response). Between the two, it establishes an interval (écart), whether it divides up the received movement infinitely or prolongs it in a plurality of possible reactions . . . By virtue of the cerebral interval, in effect, a being can retain from a material object and the actions issuing from it only those elements that interest him. So that perception is not the

object *plus* something, but the object *minus* something, minus everything that does not interest us' (1991, pp. 24–5).

[13] These living images, 'allow to pass through them, so to speak, those external influences which are indifferent to them; the others isolated, become "perceptions" by their very isolation' (Deleuze, 2005a, p. 64).

[14] Our actual perception, moreover, is but one tiny part of a vast, multifarious '*pure* virtual perception' which is impersonal and coincides with the perceived object (Deleuze, 1991, p. 25).

[15] Stein introduces the term 'continuous present' in her lecture 'Composition and Explanation' where she teams it up with 'beginning again and again' and 'using everything'. Although she contrasts it with what she calls 'the prolonged present' the difference is not clear. The lecture shows Stein 'grop[ing] for solutions rather than theorizing'. Dydo stresses that the notion 'continuous present' does not come with a clear definition but taps into Stein's desire to 'be in the present' (Dydo, 2003, p. 94).

[16] In *The Geographical History of America*, where she meditates at length on time, Stein makes the contrast between the old and the new clear by opposing two characters, 'Bennett' and the 'Uncle of Bennett'. Although they are about the same age, their take on life is very different. Bennett belongs to the here and now, chapters mean very little to him, 'but there are chapters in the life of the Uncle of Bennett'. For the uncle, '*some* time is a time that he can look forward [to] and remember' – static, measurable, manageable time (Writings 2, p. 385, italics mine). Furthermore, in 'What Is English Literature?' Stein digresses on the contrast she discerns between old, nineteenth-century English literature and new 'American' literature. The latter was not concerned with daily living 'because it is not an American thing, to tell a daily living, as in America there is not any really not any daily daily living' (Writings 2, p. 220).

[17] For Stein's portraits, see Wendy Steiner's *Exact Resemblance to Exact Resemblance: The Literary Portraiture of Gertrude Stein* (1978), Randa Dubnick's *The Structure of Obscurity: Gertrude Stein, Language and Cubism* (1984), Charles Caramello's *Henry James, Gertrude Stein and the Biographical Act* (1996).

[18] In 'How Writing Is Written', Stein (1974, p. 155) sums up the whole of her writing from *The Making of Americans* onwards as 'trying in every possible way to get the sense of immediacy'.

[19] In 'Portraits and Repetition', Stein writes: 'It is very like a frog hopping he cannot hop exactly the same distance or the same way of hopping at every hop' (Writings 2, p. 288).

[20] 'Picasso' was written *c.* 1910–1911 and first published by Alfred Stieglitz in a special issue of *Camera Work* in 1912. In 'Portraits and Repetition' Stein mentions the poem as one of the earliest examples

of her 'saying what I knew of that one as I talked and listened that one' (Writings 2, p. 299).

[21] In her later portraits she 'was to more and more include looking to make it a part of listening and talking' (Writings 2, p. 303).

[22] In Stein's dialogic format intent on expressing the complete present, there is no room for an interval between action and reaction.

[23] In 'Gertrude Stein's Machinery of Perception', Julian Murphet interprets Stein's early portrait sequence '*Tender Buttons* and the portraits which immediately predated it' as an 'aesthetic break into cinematic movement-images for which the paragraphs of *The Making of Americans* served as chronophotographic prototypes' (2003, p. 78).

[24] Stein's sentences coincide with the moments of perception: 'each sentence is just the difference in emphasis that inevitably exists in the successive moment of my containing within me the existence of that other one achieved by talking and listening inside in me and inside in that one' ('Portraits', Writings 2, p. 307).

[25] In 'Portraits and Repetition', Stein likens resemblances to the realm of memory: 'Listening and talking did not presuppose resemblance and as they do not presuppose resemblance, they do not necessitate remembering' (Writings 2, p. 293). In her writings Stein repeatedly discards memory. Remembering, for Stein, implies you can store time somewhere and recall it when you want. Such was incompatible with her take on perception, which always takes place in the present. Bergson, by contrast, reappropriated the force of memory as constitutive of actual perception.

[26] 'Four Saints in Three Acts', Stein's first opera, done in collaboration with Virgil Thomson, had a successful opening performance at the Hartford Atheneum on 8 February 1934 and ran successfully in New York as well as Chicago.

[27] In *Creative Evolution* Bergson writes: 'Duration is the continuous progress of the past which gnaws into the future and which swells as it advances' (1998, p. 4).

[28] Cinema could please Stein more than classic theatre because it did not force a whole tradition of elaborate and artificial subdivisions upon the audience. In mixing up 'the short story and the stage' the cinema was, by Stein's account, quite close to the melodrama of Gillette. Both were able to escape her critique on theatre 'because there everything happened so quietly one did not have to get acquainted and as what the people felt was of no importance one did not have to realize what was said'. Rather than dividing storylines into numerous acts and scenes, the cinema and melodrama made everything happen so quietly, so smoothly, that acts and scenes seemed of little importance. While 'the being at the theatre' was 'something that made anybody nervous' cinema and melodrama were able to convey 'silence stillness and quick

movement' ('Plays', Writings 2, pp. 245; 259). Yet the trouble with cinema, Stein found out in the 1920s, is that it too provides you with choices already made. I do not fully agree with Steven Meyer who presents Stein's dissatisfaction with the cinema as falling short in the capacity to render movement and change (2001, cf. p. 203 and note 48). That is not quite in tune with what Stein wrote on her early portraits in the 1934 lecture 'Portraits and Repetition'. As we have seen, the lecture tracks a change in her thought on movement which has little to do with an evolution from inadequate to adequate. Stein simply 'began to feel movement to be a *different* thing' (italics mine). In Deleuzean terms, she translates movement from the level of the actual, where choices are made, to the virtual, where choice is in the making. If you focus on her play 'Photograph' (1920), which is made up of elaborate allusions to reproduction, it becomes clear that Stein situated the chief quality of photography in its pretension to reproduce what is actually there. This keeping to the level of the actual is moreover, also a central feature in the second of the two 'scenarios' she wrote. In this 1929 scenario 'Film: Deux Soeurs Qui Ne Sont Pas Soeurs', a photograph of two white poodles amazes everyone by turning into a real poodle sitting in a passing car with two women – hence truly becoming something else.

[29] Stein's inspiration for the opera partly came from her fascination for the sequences of photographs she came across in a shop where 'they take a photograph of a young girl dressed in the costume of her ordinary life and little by little in successive photographs they change it into a nun' ('Plays', Writings 2, p. 268).

[30] Tellingly, the scene following on the vision adds to this feminist interpretation by showing Saint Ignatius into housekeeping: 'Saint Ignatius prepared to have examples of windows of curtains of hanging of shawls' ('Four Saints', Writings 1, p. 637).

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Chapter 4

(Giving) Savings Accounts?

Karen Houle

Spur Lines

In the best book of all time, *Housekeeping* (1980) by Marilynne Robinson, no men make an appearance. The nameless, faceless patriarch is perhaps better identified as a modest and ultimately failed legacy-attempt. He goes to the bottom of the local lake in a train wreck by page three: a fading watermark. The rest of the story involves his wife, the jerry-rigged family home, a housewife, his sirings (three daughters), and their sirings in turn: two more daughters. In plant genetics this sort of arrangement is called a 'sterile line'. In the language of trains, a 'spur line': a branch from the main with uncertain direction, and temporary utility. One can easily imagine that the lives of ladies on such a spur line are lives primarily in the mode of salvage: '*To take (esp. by misappropriation) and make use of unemployed or unattended property*.'[1] In this case, to take (over) from the upstanding patriarch the work of *making a living*, and to make good use of what he left them until it runs out. That is: they can only try to save (themselves) until it is all spent. One can easily imagine that the remaining 216 pages would have a pitiful feel to them. They don't. But *that* we can so easily imagine the life left to these women as life-*less* is what I explore at the beginning of this chapter. We go by way of Foucault, on what is and is not, easy to imagine, and why.

Whether there is anything left to those lives, *after that imagining*, is what the end of the chapter asks. And how that connects with the perpetual incitation, the joy, that this book's reading seems to provoke in me, each time anew.

Foucault Flips

One thing Foucault taught us is that sometimes what we think is true is not true. In fact, the exact opposite of what we think is true, is probably true. After Foucault we get the nauseating feeling that we ought to doubt that what we take to be the case *is really the case*. We ought to be on high alert. Not for some vague threat lurking in a barbaric corner but right before our eyes. Right under our noses. In a brilliant Cartesian inversion, Foucault suggests that whatever strikes us as *clear and distinct*, whatever seems *indubitable*, whatever it is we seem *not able to doubt*: that is the best place to look for falsehood and deception. In the *History of Sexuality: Vol. One* Foucault took a *nearly indubitable total fact* about 'Victorian England' – that it was *the* most sexually repressive regime of all time, a fact subsequent archivists and gossips repeated as truth as they investigated and confirmed the depth and breadth of its extraordinary repressivity – and he turned this 'truth' on its head(s). He suggested that the very opposite *might*, in fact, be the case: that 'Victorian England' was perhaps the *best* example of a *total and perpetual sexualized fact* in the whole history of humankind. We can call these 'hypothèses folles': '*inversions*'.

A Nearly Indubitable Total Current Fact

Which present truths are so plain as to approach the banal? Which facts of the matter so pervasive and *common-sensical* that doubting them borders on lunacy, on the heretical?

A cluster of truths about virtue, justice, debt, saving (conservation), rates of expenditure, distribution and fairness. These include but are not exhausted by the following: (1) That we are, by nature, acquisitive *and* possessive individuals; (2) That responsible man, the good citizen, the very best and most desirable kind of person is one who *saves* rather than squanders, or more precisely, saves judiciously *and* spends well; (3) That justice is primarily a matter of distribution, and its main challenge thus the problem of *scarcity*; (4) That a proper ratio of savings to

spending, and a proper rate of saving (a 'just savings principle') to spending, is what *justice requires*; and is the means of progress;[2] (5) That it is simply right and good to save for future generations**.** Libertarians, Communitarians, Utilitarians, Deontologists and Virtue Ethicists all take these truths to be self-evident.[3] They disagree about the details. Their ubiquity and self-evident nature make these claims excellent candidates for Foucauldian inversion.

What *if*, in fact, the exact opposite were true about the virtues of saving for the future? What if, in fact, it was right and good to spend everything, now, and as quickly as possible? What *if*, in fact, the happiest and most noble man and country were *not* the ones which saved well, or shared well – opening heart and home, coffers and borders, overflowing honey to the less fortunate, the weak and the poor?

And since, '[i]n any age, only a limited number of things can be said and seen' (Bogue, 2004, p. 48), we wonder not only about the correctness or falseness of the 'standard facts' compared with their challengers, but also about the *means* by which an alternative hypothesis might even be said, and seen? What avenues of effective protest and contestation of *plain truths* are even open to us? What would it take for unsayable statements to be heard? What it would take to *make visible* the inverted and invisible truths of these *given ones*? What could constitute an effective method to breach the armour of this despotic signifying regime?

Foucault's 'Inversions' are Complex

The simple negation of a hypothesis – *if there were even such a thing* – would be a text filled with little-known but crucial facts denouncing the ubiquitous common-sense 'facts', and showing the dominant hypothesis to be untrue. In the case of 'Victorian England' that might be a saucy book with the sexy title: 'Victorian England was Not Repressive!' One possible mode of negation of a truth, then, is to forward a set of opposing facts, counter-evidence.

Yet, recall that the 'inversions' of Foucault were *not* simple negations, the mere down-stroke of a nay-saying historian!

Foucault's 'inversion', his *method* of contestation, was more complicated. He contested the *content* claim of a 'clear and distinct' truth by way of the *formal features* of the discourse in which that hypothesis functioned. Foucault's contestation of the fact, the *what*, of repressivity of 'Victorian England' (noncirculation; zones of silence; uptight, squashed-down*ness*) involved his demonstrating the remarkable high degree of proliferation, abundance and lavish expenditure that was 'Victorian' discourse. Foucault writes,

> The central issue, then . . . is *not* to determine whether one says yes or no to sex, whether one formulates permissions or prohibitions, whether one asserts its importance or denies its effects . . . but to account for the fact that it is spoken about . . . What is at issue, briefly, is the over-all 'discursive-fact' the way in which sex is 'put into discourse'. (Foucault, 1978, p. 11)

Foucault modelled how a *form* of discourse can *discredit* the content that discourse professes. Since '*a regime of signs constitutes a semiotic system*', and that '*there is always a form of content that is simultaneously inseparable from and independent of the form of expression*' (Deleuze and Guattari, 1987, p. 111), we can assume that further variations of discrediting strategies are possible: That the form could credit, and thus compound our faith in a claim. In *This is Not A Pipe* (1982) Foucault shows how the calligram, or the shape of a message, can point to and symbolize that very message; or alternately confuse and distract from it. We can also imagine that other formal features of a regime of signs – its positive and negative conceptual personae, its major qualities and rhythm-habits, its aftertaste & its affective registers – could be involved in the extension and accreditation, *or*, the countering and discrediting of any hypothesis.

In terms of the *plain truths about justice* identified above, their contestation or affirmation could involve any or all of the following: That the *language* we use to exert the claim of our being, by nature, acquisitive and possessive individuals might itself be dispossessive and nonaccumulative: that while trying to keep the lines of transmission of a truth *true and proper* 'we participate',

to use a lovely phrase of Judith Butler's, 'in a certain wild future of [its] inheritance' (Butler, 2005, p. 32). That the man who espouses 'the good man saves judiciously and spends well' might himself, in the act of espousing, spend very badly, *taking* his sweet time to tell us about *giving*. That tome upon tome claiming *that* justice is primarily a matter of distribution belie *how* justice is as much matter of the sheer weight of words, of force pinning a possible asset or resource or tale, in one place. That all this talk about the problem of scarcity really means the problem is overproduction. And that the widely circulating dictum: 'it is right and good to save for future generations' is an insidious mode by which lavish spending happens now and saving is ever *postponed*. Justice discourse, like the discourse of pleasure, is a proliferative and spending modality. Bataille suspected that we create in order to expend, and that if we retain things we have produced it is only to allow ourselves to continue living, and thus destroying. What Foucault, Deleuze and Guattari add to Bataille's inverted insight are the many ways that signifying practices constitute the conditions for creation, continuity and destruction of *everyday truths*.

Cleaning House?

In this chapter, I originally set out to write about the novel *Housekeeping* and why it was a contestation of, or at least an impressive struggle with, those *plain everyday truths* about savings and spendings, especially about the roles of men and women in salvation pumps, worldly and other-worldly. *Housekeeping* seemed an exemplar of the aneconomic, or perhaps even the general or 'feminine economy'. I thought the main character, Sylvie, was perhaps a new figure for 'the nomad', albeit a feminine one, a female Bartleby with a kid to prefer not to mind. I wanted to give that lesson. I read *Housekeeping* as an allegory for a certain set of expectations incumbent upon persons if they are to count as persons, and to not end in nothing, as the central figure, Sylvie, seems to. Those expectations are offspring of the *plain everyday truths* I've been discussing here. The progressive

appropriateness of: indulgence in sentiment; of hoarding and shining; of *taking on* the work of working; of private ownership and passing on things in 'good condition'; of making children and passing them on, and things on to them, in good condition; of caring about status; of taking pleasure in appearance; the pleasure of heritability; the necessity of investment and the promise of redemption. In short: of saving and being saved.

Sylvie chooses to occupy her life otherwise: in silence (she is silent most of the time, there's no 'idle chatter'), in impulse (she eats cake when she wants and gives it to the children she 'mothers' for breakfast), in enjoying ruin (she goes regularly to a caved in house in the hills), even in cultivating a measure of ruination and disruption. She lacks an interest and aptitude in the required attribute of thrift,

> The parlor was full of newspapers and magazines. They were stacked neatly. Nevertheless they took up the end of the room where the fireplace had been. Then there were the cans stacked along the wall opposite the couch. Like the newspapers, they were stacked to the ceiling. Nevertheless, they took up considerable floor space . . . Sylvie kept them, I think, because she considered accumulation to be the essence of housekeeping, and because she considered the hoarding of worthless things to be proof of a particularly scrupulous thrift. (*Housekeeping*, p. 180)

Sylvie is what Kristeva calls, 'the woman-non-mother . . . the sister' (1969, 314). Spurning men, investment, repairs, having 'her own' children, the accumulation of *valuable things*, a concern for the future, not only does Sylvie *not* extend into the future in some form of herself to reap what she sows, she ends up without even a present, a *now*, to inhere in. In return for her choosings, Sylvie isn't 'allowed' to 'keep' the shelter of the family home she was born in, and is the only living heir to. Nor is she allowed to 'keep' the shelter of the love she cultivates, deliberately and with skill, in the child, Ruthie. By the end of this story, the 'family home' is ruined. The Despot, vanished. Son did not appear, dwell or return. The Mothers have all suicided

and abdicated. Daughters teetered in the absence of feminine dress-rehearsals, ruined.

We can too well imagine that such a story could not end happily.

For Sylvie, utterly failing to take up any of the available personae – Father, Mother, Son or Daughter – is levelled by the very form of judgement itself. Ruthie, the narrator, turns to ask us, the readers to

> Imagine the blank light of Judgment falling on you suddenly. It would be like that. For even things lost in a house abide . . . and *many household things are of purely sentimental value*, like the dim coil of thick hair, saved from my grandmother's girlhood, which was kept in a hatbox on top of the wardrobe, along with my mother's grey purse. In the equal light of disinterested scrutiny such things are not themselves. They are *transformed into pure object*, and are horrible, and must be burned. (209)

And here, now, we think we've learned all possible lessons *Housekeeping* has to give us: we are well spent.

'A More Devious and Discreet Form of Power'

Saying that Foucault put us on high alert vastly understates the situation. For we haven't yet thought about the ways that authors and readers of texts (including me and you, and *Housekeeping*, and *A Thousand Plateaus*) are chief, if blind, participants in inversions. More damning: prime enjoyers of precisely *what* it denies, and by *virtue of that denial*.

For it is not enough to ask *how* sex is 'put into discourse'? Foucault showed us, in the first instance, that forms of proliferation contradict the hypothesis of repressivity. This required that we equate proliferation itself with 'sex', with pleasure. A more excruciating question is how sex (expenditure, proliferation) is *continuously* put into a discourse which manages to *continuously* disavow it? For Foucault showed us, in the second

instance, and using his own work as exemplar, that this 'proliferation' was not merely the dry pleasure of endless textual humping. There were *distinct extra* pleasures available to the archivist, to the writer and the readers of the repressive hypothesis, *by virtue of its proliferation under repression*: The pleasures of talking while claiming talking cannot happen, the pleasures of talking about what one cannot talk about, the pleasures of getting away with what one is denouncing, the pleasures of giving and taking what is not one's to give, the pleasures of making the absent present, the pleasures of perpetual incitement and energetic sustained intercourse with multiple, unidentifiable (albeit bookish) partners.

Foucault's sick genius was to solder *these* pleasures to their repression, a repression confirmed by reiterating, by confirming *as true* the content of the original hypothesis. About Victorian repressivity, Foucault wrote, 'What is interesting is not whether we are repressed or not, and in which ways, but that we keep saying over and over, in a million ways, and incessantly, *that we are*.' An impossibly complex mechanism carries and circulates the opposite of what it avows; is able to perpetually forward what it disavows, and these counter-truths proliferate to the extent that they are successfully hidden from purview. The complex structures and forces (the kinesis, the dynamis, the topologies) of regimes of signs means that, even in our so-called informed and critical postures (analysis, contestation, debate, conceptual clarification) we constitute something like the fabric and supply the force of what cannot be noticed, cannot be called into question. Thus Foucault's work commands that we backbend *any* of our common-sense hypotheses offered in or as texts, towards the *features of ourselves* which produce and extend the selective grounds of our inquiry in the first place: to question the very things we aren't capable of calling into question, and then to question *that*. In the case of the widely circulating truth of the 'Victorian repressive hypothesis', Foucault charges us, and himself, with participating in and enjoying excruciating forms of discredited pleasures. All that talk, all those PowerPoints about a lack of pleasure *enables* pleasure to

happen – a lot – but also, crucially, plasters over that pleasant *counterfact*.

Foucault has put us on extreme and *im*possible alert. For, we are not *merely* to imagine that the basic facts we take to be true are possibly false, nor simply that the *structures* of discourses can contradict or further the claims a discourse makes, but to *try to imagine, even try to deceive ourselves into imagining* that we are inextricably involved in the production and proliferation of *everyday truths* via forms and modes of production (imaginings and material) and proliferation which enable us to participate in and to enjoy *as true and good* the very things we denounce *as false and vile*.

Without our *knowledge*

To put this in terms that could apply to *any* 'discursive regime': The *what* of a particular plain truth is confirmed via a feature of the *how* of its truth-making, but that complex *how also* performatively contradicts the content of the *what* claim. Moreover, that contradiction itself enables, for some, a kind of invisibilized, *perpetual*, perpetuate-*ed* enjoyment of its very counter-truth, a hidden and silent and protracted enjoyment and pay-off.

To put this in terms of the despotic regime of saving-as-justice, we have to *try to ask* just exactly *how* 'justice as saving' is put into a discourse which manages to perpetually dispute that very claim? And, what is our complex involvement in the disputation and advancement those claims and their formal inversions? What do we get to suffer and enjoy? To paraphrase: *What is interesting is not whether we are not saving enough or not, and in which ways, but that we keep saying, over and over, in a million ways, and incessantly, that* ***we must***.

Suddenly these two discursive regimes – the regime of pleasure and the regime of saving/spending/justice – crossover onto one another. Not only is all discourse – even protestation – a kind of spending, wasting, delaying indulgence; but engaging in any discourse is a sure means of accreditation (even for instance, avowing the 'gift economy'). But also, the structural

'performance' – the proliferation and wild spending which *is discourse* – insofar as it contradicts the overt lessons about keeping the measure, about deferring spending, about being accountable, must itself be a kind of silent hydraulics and gradients, *indeed a structure of perpetual* dissimulating deferral which extracts and pays, handsomely. Especially judgement.

Deleuze and Guattari assessed the intolerable wrack of the 'doctrine of judgment' which lies at the heart of the very burden that saving and spending well promise to mitigate and throw off. The origin of debt, perpetual origin, requires a debt: that it is infinite and thus unpayable. The infinite and endless debt requires an infinite and endlessly indebted debtor – hence the necessity of the doctrine of the soul's immortality. ' "The debtor must survive if his debt is to be infinite." The debtor's debt can never be discharged and in this sense judgment, as final judgment (or Last Judgment) is perpetually deferred. Judging, then, as an endless and forever uncompleted process, is directly related to deferral: "it is the act of deferring, of carrying to infinity, that makes judgment possible". . . . Deferral is the act . . . [which] takes place within an order of time, an infinite straight line of moments extending toward a perpetually receding end point. Judgment, then, does not create but instead presupposes this relation between existence and infinity and this order of time: "to *anyone* who stands in this relation is given the power to judge *and* be judged" ' (Bogue, p. 157–8; emphasis added).

What Bogue and Deleuze are suggesting here is that what we 'get', what we recuperate without fail, from advocating or protesting that set of *basic beliefs* about justice – as I was attempting when I enumerated the lessons Sylvie gives us – is a self *itself and its time*. Both advocating and protesting require and mobilize the despotic resonating operation of judgement. *That* relation, just like the pleasure Foucault showed is the form of relationality itself, can *not* be contradicted, nor discredited, nor resisted. Nor can we be freed from it: not by any negating content claim and not by any formal claim, since no form of formal claims can ever do anything but *extend* a discourse and *keep* its shape. Sylvie did not stand in this relation, and hence was a being with only the power to be judged.

On the Passional Regime, and Not Being Able to Confirm It

Clearly, I have hamstrung myself. Whatever I might still want to say about how Sylvie, and becoming-woman (and hence I) might manage to escape, to flee, the dual clutches of salvation and judgement, to break into the passional, post-signifying regime, will, without fail involve a measure, a whiff, of that very judgement and salvation. That might be the way all stories end.

But can we not even imagine we *might try* to find fault – *that this rupture can be in complicity with the law, or, rather that it can constitute a point of departure for even deeper changes?* (Kristeva, 1974, p. 494). Where, if anywhere, in such a totalizing signifying field as this are there genuine escape holes and not just nausea-inducing return-hatches?[4] How could we engage in healthy, untimely disavowals, dispossessions and deterritorializations without thereby opening a lucrative Swiss bank account in the unconscious, in the academia, or in the press? What conceptual personae, if any, might we adopt or laud as revolutionary who will not merely turn out to be members of the Righteous Family von Trappe, even if an unpopular one? What kinds of critical, signifying practices – shapes, after tastes, affective registers – in the very question of saving and spending will 'not to help us get our bearings or to find ourselves, but to lose our bearings and our "selves", to *get lost*' (Baugh, 2006, p. 224)? To lose track. To not count. To not offer (us) something to count on.

Yet, something still palpably live-able. Each time anew. A description of Sylvie?

Sylvie as Non-Relation: Dis-lodged?

There are ur-features of the life that is Sylvie which sketch affirmation without recuperation, motion without coming and going, living without having saved up for it, viability without form. Sylvie thrives without plan. The relations that she inhabits, without compulsion (hence violence), without creating (hence owning or sharing), and without destroying (hence guilt) are

what we could call, for the time being, '*non-relationing*'. Here are two sketches of these:

a. Other thrivings thrive

Early in the book a sick worry comes upon the abandoned young sisters (Ruthie and Lucille) after an incident in which the limited resources of the elder aunt-made-surrogate-parents become painfully obvious: The girls, playing on the newly flooded and frozen lake way after darkness falls get home 'lethally chilled', and the non-mobile aunts are in a fright which could 'not really be mollified'. '*Granting that this and even subsequent winters might spare us, there were still the perils of adolescence, of marriage, of childbirth, all formidable in themselves, but how many times compounded by our strange history*?' (36). Yet, the girl children *do* grow into young women, and not exactly fail to thrive, but fail to thrive in a very particular fashion: as would-be wifely types. Their final surrogate mother *and* father, Sylvie, propped up at the elbows by local church women bent on her salvation, fails also to thrive in the same fashion *as motherly or fatherly type*. Sylvie knows that she ought to make progress on the house, on her own female appearance, on her prospects, and above all, on the prospects of her 'children' and their lives (present and future), but she has neither the proper habits (she prefers to eat in the quiet in the dark, she wears her shoes to bed), nor the fully functional inclination, nor the means to muster an appropriate level of accumulation (of things of use, of learning, or discipline or of godliness) required to be a socially viable candidate for the position of mother or father, and then grandmother, and on in hallowed memory. It is not that she is reticent and needs encouragement, nor correct to say that she is ignorant and needs tutoring. She is very intelligent, and curious, and joyful, and adept: just not at the 'right' times and in the 'right' ways. It is that she has not developed the proper set of inclinations, nor does she want to anymore, if she ever did. The girls skip school to play on the lake and follow paths into the woods. At first Sylvie simply doesn't know. When she first finds out, she tries to argue them to a return to normal, and writes notes to the teacher, trying

to come up with explanations. Ultimately she herself takes the girls out during the day to her own secret hiding places in the woods. The girls *are* able to resettle themselves around this other queer life she fashions: one girl (Ruth) is content, dare I say, happy. Lucille slides away towards a less queer life with normal girls from the drugstore and another surrogate mom, the Music teacher, who teaches her to do her hair and sew a dress.

b. Life but no 'journey'

Sylvie's initial journey outward *from* her girlhood and her girlhood home can in no way be described as a quest*full* odyssey towards wisdom or meaningful gain. Early in the novel she is described as putting on her mother's gloves one day on *the spur of the moment* and heading out to visit her older sister in Seattle. Perhaps she arrived there, perhaps she did not. The two old aunts wishing to summon Sylvie to replace them in the role of guardian write to the address on the single, pleasant note she ever sent home. Sylvie ducks back into the novel, abruptly, in a plain beige overcoat, and with nothing in her pockets but her reddened hands. She is met at the door by the fact that, '*grandmother's will did not mention Sylvie. Her provisions for us did not include her in any way*' (41). Her return is in no way a prodigal moment, an arc-y telos. She does not personify 'Spirit discover[ing] that the truth it sought outside itself is in fact its entire historical development, comprehended systematically as a series of conceptually related stages that both negate and complement each other . . . accomplish[ing] a "return to itself". . . . Spirit's odyssey toward truth is in truth a homecoming, a reconciliation with itself.' (Baugh, 2003, p. 2) Sylvie could not be said to *return* to her girlhood home, to her family, to her *home*town anymore than she could have been said to have fled it. She did not go, with rocks in her pockets, like wilful Woolf, making sadness drown out life's efforts. Sylvie is simply in motion, almost untrackable. *Spur.*

Sylvie and the last girl, the last of the family line, just leave in the night. First they set fire to the house. Or was it an accident, the quasi-cause of the lit match causing 'effects ever beyond intentions'? (Levinas, 1998, p. 3). They walk all the way across

a dangerous rail bridge over the lake, and jump freight in the morning, with nothing salvaged, nothing in their pockets.

In the end *nothing comes of it all. Housekeeping* is, or has, an ending without an ending.

When the Homing Instinct Fails: 'Higher than all Reconciliation'?

In *Housekeeping*, the family home, the family, and the entire contents of their lives rotate away from one set of relations ('proprietary, property, proper') towards something else entirely, some other form of life, the significance of which the novel, and this chapter are an effort to gesture towards. It is a form of life, not without meaning, or affect. Sylvie is the pivot for an asymptotic flight from 'proprietary, property, proper' and from the futurality that such forms of belonging entail. This pivoting involves an unarticulable set of moves and relations, and yet the character or expression of that difference is distinctly feminine, and joyous.

What is profound about *Housekeeping* is two-fold. First, it bears witness to the possibility that there are alternatives to the dominant pattern and habits called 'human life' of which the *self evident truths about justice* I listed form the spine. We hear that 'the years between her husband's death and her eldest daughter's leaving home were, in fact, years of almost perfect serenity. My grandfather had sometimes spoken of disappointment. With him gone they were cut free from the troublesome possibility of success, recognition, advancement. They had no reason to look forward, nothing to regret' (13). Second, it does not set up as alternative a nihilistic rant or suicidal cave-in. It is 'something else entirely', revealed to us about, but not in, our own lives, at moments when the common-sense that props us up is under immense strain. As when Henry Perowne, protagonist of Ian McEwan's *Saturday* is sorting his mother's things.

> As the shelves and drawers emptied, and the boxes and bags filled, he saw that no one owned anything, really. It's all rented, or borrowed. (1995, p. 274)

The life glimpsed and gestured in *Housekeeping* is not unhappy, not unjust, not unloving, not empty of beauty, not senseless, nor does it lack logic. It lacks a *particular kind* of logic. What's more: *that* we *can* be moved by it; *that* we can *imagine it*, that we can borrow that thought without debt – suggests that the so-called unthinkable alternative to what is, is not so much a lesson as what we should try to not lose sight of. Without counting on it.

Notes

[1] Oxford English Dictionary.

[2] Rawls imagines a 'last stage of society in which justice is achieved and indefinitely maintained, the goal for the sake of which saving was required' (Paden, 1997, p. 4).

[3] Hindus, Buddhists, Muslims, Christians too, hold a closely related set of 'truths', though not expressed in secular terms: debt to a creator, saving oneself, salvation in an afterlife, bad karma, heaven, filial piety, acquiring sin and discharging it in confessional modes, reaping what one sows. Just like the set of premises found in the 'secular political' these rely on a cluster of concepts based in the 'closed economic': measure, distribution, exchange, commerce, trafficking.

[4] Nausea-traps such as one discovers, crawling on all fours, in Gregor Schneider's 2001 Venice Biennale Ur-house installation (http://www.designboom.com/snapshots/venezia/germany.html).

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Part II

Image/Art

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Chapter 5

Sensation: The Earth, a People, Art

Elizabeth Grosz

Art reminds us of states of animal vigor; it is on the one hand an excess and overflow of blooming physicality into the world of images and desires; on the other, an excitation of the animal functions through the images and desires of an intensified life – an enhancement of the feeling of life, a stimulant to it.

Friedrich Nietzsche, The Will to Power *#802 (422)*

Art comes not from a uniquely human sensibility, not from reason, recognition, intelligence, nor from man's higher accomplishments, but from something excessive, unpredictable, lowly and animal. Art comes from that excess in the world, in objects and living things, which enables them to be more than they are, to incite invention and production. Art is a consequence of that force that puts life at risk for the sake of intensification, for what can be magnified in the body's interaction with the earth. In other words, there is a connection between the energies of sexual selection, the attraction to possible sexual partners[1] and the forces and energies of artistic production and consumption. Art is the consequence of that energy or force that puts life at risk for the sake of intensification, for the sake of sensation itself – not simply for pleasure or for sexuality, as psychoanalysis might suggest – but for what can be magnified, intensified, for what is more.

Psychoanalysis has the relations between art and sexuality half-right. Art is connected to sexuality. But for psychoanalysis sexuality transforms or converts itself into art only through representation, through the desexualization or reorientation

of libidinal energies into nonsexual or creative outlets: art is the expression of sublimated, that is, renounced or displaced sexual impulses. This capacity for displacement is, for Freud, a uniquely human capacity, the result of the untethering of the drive from a seasonally regulated sexuality, that is, from the drive's capacity, through vicissitudes, to transform itself into something nonsexual.[2] It is only the sexual drive that can be deflected into nonsexual aims.[3]

It will be my claim here that it is not exactly true that art is a consequence of the excesses that the sexual drive poses, for it may be that sexuality needs to function *artistically* to be adequately sexual, that sexuality needs to harness excessiveness and invention to function at all. A genealogy or evolution of the visual and plastic arts need not reduce art to the forces and effects of natural selection but can think them in terms of the excessive expenditures entailed by sexual *selection*.

For Darwin, the living being is 'artistic' to the extent that its body or products have within them something that attracts or entices members of the opposite sex (as well as members of the same sex and even members of different species!). This attraction is largely but not exclusively heterosexual and involves bodily intensification or a magnification of sexually specific characteristics. Sexual selection produces increasing morphological differences between male and female, for it magnifies and emphasizes these morphological differences in ways that enhance their sexual appeal. This calling to attention, making one's own body into a spectacle, involves intensification. Not only are organs on display engorged, intensified, puffed up, but the organs which perceive them – ears, eyes, nose – are also filled with intensity, resonating with colours, sounds, smells, shapes, rhythms.[4]

This may be why Darwin claims the males of many species of fish, including salmon, trout, perch and stickleback change their colour during the breeding season, transforming from drab to iridescent seasonally.[5] This is not a functional colouring that acts as camouflage, protecting fish from predation. Konrad Lorenz has suggested that this spectacular colouring may act as a form of aggression, the vivid marking of territory. In other

words, for Lorenz and other Neo-Darwinists, this excess is not really excessive: it is the bodily expression of something like a territorial imperative, a key element in natural selection, the struggle for survival. These striking colours, shapes, organs, act as territorial markers, posters of possession that function to scare rivals and defend territory. In being rendered functional, all excess and redundancy are eliminated: sexual selection is reduced to natural selection.[6] For Darwin, these markings, which he acknowledges may serve aggressive functions, are *not* the conditions of territoriality but are the raw materials of sexual selection, excesses that are produced for no reason other than their possibilities for intensification, their appeal.[7]

Many battles between rivalrous males fought apparently over territory are in fact undertaken, in Darwin's opinion, primarily to attract the attention of females who may otherwise remain indifferent to male display. In the case of battling birds, the territorial struggle is primarily theatrical, staged, a performance of the body at its most splendid and appealing, rather than a real battle with its attendant risks and dangers: in the case of the *Tetrao umbellus* (the ruffed grouse), the battles between males 'are all a sham, performed to show themselves to the greatest advantage before the admiring females who assemble around; for I have never been able to find a maimed hero, and seldom more than a broken feather' (1981, Book II, p. 50). Ornamental display occurs in the most successful and aggressive males, and even those males who are most successful in fending off predators and rivals do not always attract the attention of desirable partners.

Territoriality is indeed bound up with the production of intensities, that is, with sexual and artistic production, the creation of rhythmical or vibrational qualities – but not as precondition; rather, territory is an *effect* of erotic intensification.[8] Territory is produced when some property or quality can be detached from its place within a regime of natural selection and have a life of its own, to resonate, to attract, just for itself. Territory is artistic, the consequence of love not war, of seduction not defence, of sexual not natural selection. Art is of the animal precisely to the degree that sexuality is artistic.

Sensation and the Plane of Composition

Each of the arts addresses the forces of the earth through the extraction of qualities using its own materials and techniques, and each does so in the light of the contributions of all the earlier forms of that art (and of all the other arts). The plane of composition can be understood as a composite field of all art works, all genres, all types of art, the totality of all the various forms of artistic production, that which is indirectly addressed and transformed through each work of art.

Deleuze and Guattari affirm the plane of composition is the collective condition of art-making: it contains all works of art, not specifically laid out historically, but all the events in the history of art, all the transformations, 'styles', norms, techniques and upheavals, insofar as they influence and express each other. This is not a literal plane (otherwise it itself would have to be composed) but is a spatio-temporal 'organization', a loose network of works, techniques and qualities within which all particular works of art must be located in order for them to constitute art. These works do not require recognition as such, they do not require any form of judgement to assess their quality or relative value: they simply need to exist as art objects.

All works of art share something in common, whatever else may distinguish them: they are all composed of blocks of materiality becoming-sensation. Art produces sensations and through them intensifies bodies. Works of art monumentalize, not events or persons, materials or forms, only sensations (Deleuze and Guattari, 1994, p. 164). Does this mean that works of art exist only to the extent that they are sensed, perceived? The sensations produced are not sensations of a subject, but sensation in itself, sensation as eternal, as monument. Sensation is that which is transmitted from the force of an event directly onto the nervous system of a living being.[9]

Sensation is the zone of indeterminacy between subject and object, the bloc that erupts from the encounter of the one with the other. Sensation impacts the body, not through the brain, or representations, signs, images or fantasies, but directly, on

the body's own internal forces, on cells, organs, the nervous system. Sensation requires no mediation or translation. It is not representation, sign, symbol, but force, energy, rhythm. Sensation lives, not in the body of perceivers but in the body of the art-work. Art is how the body senses most directly, with, ironically, the least representational mediation, for it is only art that draws the body into sensations never experienced before, perhaps not capable of being experienced in any other way, the sunflower-sensations that only Van Gogh's work conjures, the 'appleyness of the apple' (Deleuze, 2003, p. 23) in Cézanne, the 'Rembrandt-universe' of affects (Deleuze, 2003, p. 177), or Bacon's meat-sensations. Sensation draws us, living beings of all kinds, into the art work in a strange becoming in which the living being empties itself of its interior to be filled with the sensation of that work alone.

The art-work is a compound of sensations, sensations composed through materials in their particularity. Sensations are not coloured, shaped, formed in the art-work, but through the art-work are colouring, shaping and forming forces. The art-work arrests a look, a gesture, an activity, from the transitory chaos of temporal change. Art arrests this endless chaotic becoming into a becoming of its own: the art-object now becomes sensation, not eternal in the sense that the sensation is continually experienced in one and the same way over time, but in the sense that sensation is now forever tied to this smile, this Rembrandt-face, this yellow, this flower.

Art brings sensations into being when before it there are only subjects, objects and the relations of immersion that bind the one to the other. Art allows the difference, the incommensurability of subject and object to be celebrated, opened up, elaborated. The arts are not just the construction of sensations but the synthesis of other, prior sensations into new ones, the coagulation and transformation of other sensations summoned up from the plane of composition. Art is this process of composing, extracting from the materiality of forces sensations capable of affecting life, that is, becomings, that have not existed before and may summon up future sensations, new becomings.

Becoming-Other

Sensations are mobilizing forces, not quite subjective or experiential (this is Deleuze's disagreement with phenomenology) and yet not fully objective or measurable in a way that material objects are. Sensations lie mid-way between subjects and objects, the point at which the one converts into the other. This is why art is the major way in which living beings deal with and enjoy the intensities extracted from the natural world, chaos. Art is where intensity is most at home, where matter is most attenuated without being nullified. Art is where life most readily transforms itself. In this sense, art is not the antithesis of politics but politics continued by other means.[10]

Sensation has two dimensions, two types of energy: it is composed of affects and percepts. Sensation extracts affects from affections and percepts from perception, which is to say that it disembodies and desubjectifies affection and perception.[11] Sensation, like the plane of composition, is an incorporeal threshold of emergence,[12] an unpredictable overspilling of forces that exist hitherto only beyond and before the plane of composition, on its other side, that of chaos. Art is the way in which chaos can return in sensation: this is how art returns us to the unlivable from which we came and gives us a premonition of the unlivable power to come. Percepts and affects are inhuman forces from which the human borrows and which may serve in the transformation and overcoming of the human. Percepts and affects summon up a 'people to come', something beyond the subject of reflection and recognition, no longer a public, an audience, but something inhuman.[13]

Affects are the ways in which the human overcomes itself: they are the 'nonhuman becomings of man' the virtual conditions by which man surpasses himself and celebrates this surpassing (as only the overman can, with only joyful affects) by making himself a work of art, by his conversion into a being of sensation. Affects are man's becoming-other, the creation of passages between the human and animal, cosmic becomings the human can pass through.[14] If affects characterize a subject's relation to nonhuman becomings, percepts, those 'nonhuman

landscapes of nature' (Deleuze and Guattari, 1994, p. 169) are the transformation of the evolutionary relations of perception that have finely attuned the living creature to its material world through natural selection into the resources for something else, something more, for invention, experimentation or art.

The materials of perception – the bodily relations between states of things and subjects – become the resources of the unlivable percept; the materials of affection – our sufferings, joys, horrors, our becomings – become the expressions of our possibilities for inhuman transformations. Perceptions become enshrouded with affect: popes, or disembodied mouths come to embody the scream in Bacon's works, Van Gogh's head becomes captured in a web of becoming-sunflower. And affections are embedded in percepts, as in Cézanne's mountains and landscapes, or in Georgia O'Keefe's Southwest.

Art is where properties and qualities take on the task of representing the future, of preceding and summoning up sensations to come, a people to come, worlds or universes to come. Art is political, not in the sense that it is a collective or community activity but in the sense that it elaborates the possibilities of new, more, different sensations than those we know. Art is where the becomings of the earth couple with the becomings of life to produce new intensities and sensations that summon up a new kind of life.[15] Unlike politics, sensation does not envision a future different from the present, it en-forces, a premonition of what might be directly inscribed on the body.

Painting Sensations

Each of the arts aims to capture something equally accessible to all the other arts, a kind of foundation or unity, the unity in difference of the universal forces that impinge on all forms of life. This is why each of the arts brings with it fragments and residues of all of the others. When Bacon wrenches a scream from the screaming popes, he brings with it not only all the visible forces that a scream enacts, not just the force and intensity of prior pope-representations, but the scream-sensation in all

its multi-sensory richness. When he has managed to 'paint the scream more than the horror' (Bacon quoted in Deleuze, 2003, p. 34), the scream only functions as sensation to the extent that we can feel and hear it, that it vibrates as a scream, that as visual, it nevertheless functions as an auditory cry, resonating or vibrating through us as a scream.

Painting aims to make every sense function as an eye, as music makes all sensation, and the whole body, contract into an ear: painting aims to enable us to see sound, as music aims to make us hear colours, shapes, forms. Each of the arts is concerned with a transmutation of bodily organs as much as it is with the creation of new objects, new forms: each art resonates through the whole of the sensing body, capturing elements in a composition that carries within it the underlying rhythms of the other arts and the residual effects of each of the senses.[16]

Sensation can only be generated to the extent that each art brings into being something that the other arts could also access, something they all share, the forces that make each possible and connect each to the (invisible, inaudible, intangible) forces of the universe and the sensitive mass of nerves and organs that make up a living body. It is because each of the senses – for each of the arts orients itself to the sensory filling up of at least one of the senses (there are after all arts for all the body's perceptual organs) – lays claim to forces of the universe that all of the others are drawn to as well.[17]

Deleuze suggests that this is because there is indeed a common force shared by the universe itself, all of the arts, and the living bodies that generate sensations out of material objects. This is precisely vibratory force, perhaps the vibratory structure of sub-atomic particles themselves (?), which contracts sensations as neural reactions to inhuman forces. Perhaps it is vibration and its resonating effects that generate a universe in which living beings are impelled to become, to change from within, to seek sensations, affects and percepts which intensify and extend them to further transformations. Such resonance creates the very means by which the arts undertake their compositional activity: to create rhythm, the ordering and structuring of resonance, the meeting of different vibratory forces.

Rhythm (another name for difference) is what runs from inhuman forces and material objects to organs, resonating as the qualities of the art objects which carry sensations, returning to the universe a new rhythm, new forces. The common ground for all of the arts is the rhythmic, durational, universe of invisible, inaudible forces, whose order can only be lived as chaotic. These chaotic forces do not reveal themselves to lived bodies except through the processes of composition that lay them out for visual or auditory consumption: they are fundamentally unlivable. We can extract something of these forces, nothing that resembles them, for they cannot present themselves, but something that partakes of them. Bacon extracts a kind of gravitational force, the force that convulses and contorts bodies, not through torture but through everyday positions which have collapsed upon themselves, until flesh descends from bone into meat, an invisible, unheard gravitational pull. The arts present these elementary forces like 'pressure, inertia, weight, attraction, gravitation, germination' (Deleuze, 2003, p. 48) we cannot control but can adapt for our own intensities. At bottom, Deleuze suggests, it may be that the arts share, not a common past but a shared future, a shared commitment to the future: they aim to capture the force of time, opening up sensation to the future, making time able to be sensed, even if that means becoming-other.

Painting Today

Modern painting could be divided into three broad lines according to the relations that each develops between sensation and chaos. Each is a response to the crisis of realism and representation posed by the advent of photography as art-form in the nineteenth century. The first is abstraction in, for example, the Russian constructivists, as well as Mondrian, Klee, Kandinsky and others. Chaos remains the source for art, but chaos is carefully organized, often through a mystical code, to produce a kind of optical geometry, an artistic Platonism, where art takes on the function of a kind of spiritual salvation.[18] The second

line is abstract expressionism, perhaps represented most clearly by Jackson Pollock and Action Painting. Here instead of being directed through codification, chaos is 'deployed to a maximum' (Deleuze, 2003, p. 68), spread throughout the work itself, cramming every inch of the painted field. Painting comes as close as it can to falling into chaos. Instead of the optical or geometrical frame that structures abstractionism, the haptic and the manual dominate. A pattern is no longer discernible and all standard frames of reference (top/ bottom, figure/ ground) are subverted. The eye is at the mercy of the chaotic or random movements of the hand.[19] Thus far we have either a kind of code-painting or a kind of catastrophe-painting. Deleuze describes the third line, following Lyotard (1971), as figural. Here Deleuze includes works (by Cézanne, Bacon and Soutine) that rely on visceral force (unlike abstraction) yet aim to contain it to part but not the whole of the painted field (unlike expressionism). The figural is, for Deleuze, the end of figuration, the abandonment of art as representation, signification, narrative, though it retains the body, planes and colours from the figurative. The figural is the deformation and submission of the figurative to sensation.

I myself have nothing particular invested in Deleuze's schema which, while contestable, is certainly not an exhaustive overview of the art of the last hundred years or so. I am more interested in looking at an art that had barely emerged when Deleuze wrote his study of Bacon's paintings, the works of the Western desert artists of Australia.[20] I don't want to suggest that contemporary Aboriginal art is Deleuzian, for no art is Deleuzian. At best Deleuze provides some concepts that are useful, or not, for understanding another dimension of the various arts than is available to aesthetic contemplation alone.

Western desert art not only comes out of a nomadic tradition that has had little to do with Western art practices until less than four decades ago,[21] it defies the terms by which twentieth century Western art has been categorized. Instead of falling into the stylistic schools of either abstraction or expressionism, or the 'middle' position of the figural, much of Western desert art occupies all three positions simultaneously. These arts share

an obsession with a mystical code along with a fascination with geometrical forms and abstraction; they are also concerned with the direct expression of rhythm and force, movement and embodiment that characterizes expressionism; and they are no less concerned with the figure, alone, coupled, boxed in, deformed, subjected to invisible forces, than the works of Cézanne or Bacon.

I can really only undertake a sampling of this work, the briefest of detours, to look at the work of two major artists from the Western desert: Kathleen Petyarre (from Anmatyerr, a region northeast of Alice Springs, painting at Utopia) and Clifford Possum Tjapaltjarri (also an Anmatyerr, painting at Papunya), two of the most internationally well-known Indigenous artists. The work of each is an attempt to map out the history compressed in the geography of their Dreaming, a cartography of both the events, the landscape and the animals that link to the artist's own bodily and clan history. Many of these works are remarkable for their capacity to envision from an aerial point of view the detailed topography of a land that has been primarily traversed by foot, in which the slightest undulations or natural formations may hold ceremonial and ancestral significance.

To take only one example from Kathleen Petyarre's productive oeuvre: she shares a Dreaming with a number of her painter-sisters and brothers,[22] the Mountain or thorny Devil Dreaming, a typical conjunction of territory and animal, of animal traversing territory, of territory inscribed by animal movements and the qualities and sensations capable of being released through their coupling, the eruption of colours, speed and stillness, of a terrain illuminated by reptile movements and through the humanized history of reptile ancestors. She and her sisters produce many versions of the Mountain Devil Dreaming, each varying minutely, taking a different element or aspect of the Dreaming and extracting from it a vibrating series of dots, which resonate op-art style with haptic effects, reproducing while transforming the Devil-movement through linking it to the becoming of the terrain or landscape. Devil-skin marks the land, devil-arcs of movement provide paths or tracks for lines of flight which transform a hostile earth into territory.

The Mountain Devil is a very small, spiky, ominous-looking lizard that inhabits much of the Central Australian desert. It has the chameleon-like capacity to enervate visual qualities. It usually has ochre and earth colours, especially in unthreatening conditions; it moves in a characteristic semi-circular path, leaving parallel tracks that inflect in a gentle arc of circular movements, then back again, snaking in one direction then in another, creating an undulating pathway as it heads in a particular direction.

It can freeze on recognizing possible predators, and when threatened, change colour very rapidly from ochre to brilliant reds and yellows and to transform back into its ochre/olive colouration again when it feels safe. The Mountain Devil, a wily and wise character, a traveller or nomad, has many adventures and must rely on her skills and wisdom to survive. Kathleen Petyarre and her sisters have grown up, studied and in some sense become, through these Dreaming stories, these hardy and 'artistic' creatures who make their own bodies into a canvas of predator-sensations.

None of her paintings provide an image or a portrait of the Mountain Devil, but each is a becoming-Devil of paint itself, the coming alive of the corrugations and patterns of its skin, its tracks, the arcs of its movements in its terrain, the belonging together of both the skin, the movements and the earth, the home country of Kathleen and her people, and the earth and its secret locations which sustains them through its excesses and their ingenuity.[23] The terrain is mapped in detail in a number of massive, elaborate paintings that contain not only a map but also the history of the animal and human events that occur there, from the ancient and more recent past – the Darwin massacre of Aboriginal peoples 1869, the Coniston massacre in the 1920s, various devastating bushfires, forced and voluntary migrations from traditional lands through the intervention of various governmental policies directed to assimilation into white culture.

In Petyarre's work, the land, the Mountain Devil, the weather and catastrophic events that occur to the land – hail, storms, drought, fire, – are not readily distinguishable from the earth

itself, the skin is part of the land, the land is made by what occurs on it and in turn has its effect on those events which are hitherto marked by their origins, and the people who inhabit the land, including the artists who sing and paint its ceremonies.

Clifford Possum Tjapaltjarri was probably the most well-known indigenous artist of his generation, second only in fame to the luminous works of Emily Kame Kngwarreye (an aunt to Kathleen Petyarre and the yardstick or measure of white success for many Indigenous artists in terms of her acceptance by museums, galleries and auction-houses, whose record breaking auctions have only recently been bettered by Clifford Possum's sales).[24]

Originally a wood-cutter and carver of considerable skill, Clifford Possum joined the Papunya Tula Artists Cooperative in 1972, becoming chairperson of the cooperative in the early 1980s. His most stunning and complex works, like Kathleen Petyarre's, are huge paintings, each an elaborate topography of his people's Dreaming. His early (1970s) paintings with his brother, Tim Leura Tjapaltjarri, including the Warlugulong series, focused on painting the Dreaming of a catastrophic bushfire, which was the result of a long series of transgressions by two brothers.

The painting refers to a site around 200 miles from Alice Springs where the Blue-Tongued Lizard Man started a great bushfire, the primordial or original bushfire in which his two sons perished, probably because they ate all of a sacred kangaroo without sharing with their father or group, a double-barrelled transgression that demanded the severest punishment. The Warlugulong paintings are diagrams of the sons, the fire, the father, the kangaroo, painted as if they were sand paintings, on the ground, where their orientation and the location of up and down becomes irrelevant. The bushfire Dreaming repeats and elaborates sensory motifs and regions of the Warlugulong series, the two skeletons of the two brothers bringing more and more dynamic and less traditional colours to canvases now saturated with several Dreaming stories.

For Clifford Possum and his patrilineal descent group, the primary Dreaming, explicated in the Warlugulong series, is

the Love Story, which involves a man named Liltipility who falls in love with his classificatory mother, with whom he is forbidden various types of contact, especially sexual contact. The paintings that make up the Man's Love Story series are visual interpretations of elements of this narrative, explorations of sites and locations where it took place, and of animals and insects, honey ants, rock wallabies and possums, who shared this terrain.

As embedded as they are in history and collective narrative, however, these contemporary works require a pop, 'a flash', in Clifford Possum's own words, the eruption of sensation, to work as contemporary art-works rather than to serve only as non- or pre-artistic religious rituals.[25] Their colours are as dazzling, iridescent and luminous as territorial deep sea fish, the dots make the landscape sing and dance with a buzzing resonance of poster-display.[26] It is not only the (animal) body that is on display, rendered sensation, but the very earth itself, with every feature, characteristic and undulation now laden with its events, the very forces used for a sensory elevation of colour to the 'cry of the earth', more clearly here a summoning of a 'people to come' perhaps than in any other form of art today!

These works represent both a history and geography that is both indigenous and alien, both autonomous and brutally colonized, a history embedded in the land and the living creatures it supports, that the paintings celebrate even as they look forward to a time in which the earth is returned to its custodians. Is this not precisely the kind of territorializing, deterritorializing and reterritorializing structure, hovering between the animal and the human, between the earth and territory, that Deleuze has claimed is the basis of all of the arts? And don't these artists, with their blazing vision of the earth and its possibilities for life, make sensation the means by which their very culture can live again? This affirms the very multi-sensory unity of the arts, where painting summons up and incites song and dance, and where narratives, transformed into musical rhythms and themes, become emblems of the earth itself and the future life it might sustain.

Becoming Cosmic

Life forms have no choice but to respond to these cosmological events, which must be addressed through the creation of new morphologies and behaviours. In addition to the necessities imposed on life by these forces of the universe (the separation of day from night, the separation of waters from dry land, the separation of continents and migrational pathways, regional, climatological and geographic features, etc.), there is also the production by these forces of an excess, of more than living creatures need for survival.

Bare survival is rare in even the most harsh climate and conditions. The more difficult the region, the more ingenuity and artisticness is involved in the production of qualities. The Mountain Devil is capable of survival in even the driest climate because it is able to live on the water generated by condensation; yet it does so much more than survive. Not only does it produce the most vivid and striking colours and colour-changes, it has also perfected the theatrical arts of stillness and speed, it inspires totemic identifications, it serves for many Aboriginal peoples, and perhaps 'Europeans', as an emblem, a Dreaming, of many of their own daily and historic struggles and triumphs. It is because there is an animal-becoming, a Devil-becoming, in the co-existence of Indigenous groups and the thorny mountain lizards in a common terrain where they live in shared conditions, that human subjects become inscribed with animal-becomings, the movements, gestures and habits of animals and that animals, even lizard subjects, become endowed with human qualities: wisdom, fortitude, cunning, calm, envy, gratitude.

As songbirds are themselves captivated by a tune sung by their most skilful and melodious rivals, and fish are attracted to the most striking colours and movements, even if these are not of their own species, so these qualities – melody, sonorous expression, colour, visual expression – are transferable, the human borrows them from the treasury of earthly and animal excess. But art is not simply the expression of an animal past, a prehistorical allegiance with the evolutionary forces that make one; it is not memorialization, the confirmation of a shared past but

above all the transformation of the materials from the past into resources for a shared becoming, a shared future.

Cézanne yearns for a future in which the solidity of objects and forces can be felt, sensed, real; Bacon yearns for a future in which reality directly impacts the nervous systems, where forces are liberated from their artistic boundaries; Papunya and Utopia artists yearn for peoples, Aboriginal and white, reconnected to their lands, no longer only through animals but through what the West has to offer them, through Europe, as a world-people, as custodians of a world-dreaming. In making sensation live, each evokes a people and an earth to come, each summons up and pays homage to the imperceptible cosmic forces, each participates in the (political) overcoming of the present, and helps bring a new, rich and resonating future into being.

Notes

[1] For Darwin, not all members of any species need to reproduce: it is not clear that sexual selection is directed only to reproductive aims. There is a high biological tolerance for a percentage of each group not reproducing with no particular detriment for that group and some advantages: '[S]election has been applied to the family, and not to the individual, for the sake of gaining serviceable ends. Hence we may conclude that slight modification of structure or of instinct, correlated with the sterile condition of certain members of the community, have proved advantageous: consequently the fertile males and females have flourished, and transmitted to their fertile offspring a tendency to produce sterile members with the same modification' (Darwin, 1996, p. 354).

[2] In Freud's writings, sublimation is the capacity for exchanging a sexual for a desexualized aim which 'consists in the sexual trend abandoning its aim of obtaining a component or a reproductive pleasure and taking on another which is related genetically to the abandoned one but is itself no longer sexual and must be described as social. We call this process "sublimation", in accordance with the general estimate that places social aims higher than sexual ones, which are at bottom self-interested. Sublimation is, incidentally, only a special case in which sexual trends are attached to other, non-sexual ones' (Freud, 1917, p. 345).

[3] 'The sexual instinct . . . is probably more strongly developed in man than in most of the higher animals; it is certainly more constant,

since it has almost entirely overcome the periodicity to which it is tied in animals. It places extraordinarily large amounts of force at the disposal of civilized activity, and it does this in virtue of its especially marked characteristic of being able to displace its aim without materially diminishing in intensity. This capacity to exchange its originally sexual aim for another one, which is no longer sexual but which is psychically related to the first aim, is called the capacity for *sublimation*. In contrast to this displaceability, in which its value for civilization lies, the sexual instinct may also exhibit a particularly obstinate fixation which renders it unserviceable and which sometimes causes it to degenerate into what are described as abnormalities' (Freud, 1908, p. 187).

[4] Alphonso Lingis has spent considerable effort discussing the powerful effects of 'organs to be looked at' which function well beyond the logic of natural selection: the more spectacular fishes often live at depths where either they or their predators are blind or operate through other senses than vision. This makes it clear that there is an excess, left over from or in addition to the needs of survival, a morphological capacity for intensifying bodies and functions that does not operate only or primarily in terms of an external (predatory?) observer: 'The color-blind *octopus vulgaris* controls with twenty nervous systems the two to three million chromatophores, iridophores and leucophores fitted in its skin; only fifteen of these have been correlated with camouflage or emotional states. At rest in its lair, its skin invents continuous light shows. The sparked and streaked coral fish school and scatter as a surge of life dominated by a compulsion for exhibition, spectacle, parade . . . The most artful blended pigments the deep has to show are inside the shells of abelones [*sic*], inside the bones of parrotfish, on the backs of living cones, where the very abelones [*sic*] and parrotfish and cones themselves shall never see them. The most ornate skins are on the nudibrachia, blind sea slugs. In the marine abysses, five or six miles below the last blue rays of the light, the fish and the crabs, almost all of them blind, illuminate their lustrous colors with their own bioluminescence, for no witness' (Lingis, 1984, p. 8–9).

[5] Darwin discusses the transformations in coloring in various species, ranging from birds to reptiles and fish, which undergo seasonal colour changes that intensify their appeal for the opposite sex. In the case of the stickleback, for example, a fish that can be described as 'beautiful beyond description', Darwin quotes Warrington: 'The back and eyes of the female are simply brown, and the belly white. The eyes of the male, on the other hand, are "of the most splendid green, having a metallic lustre like the green feathers of some humming-birds. The throat and belly are of a bright crimson, the back of an ashy-green, and the whole fish appears as though it were

somewhat translucent and glowed with an internal incandescence." And after the breeding-season these colours all change, the throat and belly become of a pale red, the back more green, and the glowing tints subside.'

'That with fishes there exists some close relation between their colours and their sexual functions we can clearly see; – firstly, from the adult males of certain species being differently coloured from the females, and often much more brilliantly; – secondly, from these same males, whilst immature, resembling the mature females; – and lastly, from the males, even of those species which at all other times of the year are identical in colour with the females, often acquiring brilliant tints during the spawning-season' (Darwin, 1981, Book II, pp. 14–15).

[6] Lorenz argues that the four great biological drives – hunger, sex, fear and aggression – must each be understood in terms of natural selection alone. Like other neo-Darwinians, he reduces sexual selection to natural selection, thereby simplifying and rendering evolution mono-directional, regulated only by the selection of randomly acquired characteristics and not by the unpredictable vagaries of taste and pleasure that sexual selection entails.

While inter-species aggression may indeed be linked to questions of species-survival, as Lorenz recognizes, intra-species aggression, which no doubt imperils individual males nevertheless seems to benefit the species to the extent that the strongest male rivals will prevail in the propagation of the next generation. Striking colouring, powerful singing abilities, various ritual behaviours – those which I suggest, following Darwin, serve sexual selection – are, for Lorenz, substitutes for aggressive behaviour and serve to perpetrate its aims. See Lorenz (1974), Deleuze and Guattari's critique of Lorenz's reductionism (Deleuze and Guattari, 1987, p. 315), as well as Bogue (2003, p. 57) and Genosko (2002, pp. 48–49).

[7] Darwin argues that although it is possible that the brilliant colouring of fish may serve to protect them from predators – Lorenz's claim – it is more likely that it makes them more vulnerable to predators, which tends to affirm their function as sexual lures rather than aggressive placards or banners: 'It is possible that certain fishes may have been rendered conspicuous in order to warn birds and beasts of prey (as explained when treating of caterpillars) that they were unpalatable; but it is not, I believe, known that any fish, at least any fresh-water fish, is rejected from being distasteful to fish-devouring animals' (Darwin, 1981, Book II, pp. 17–18).

[8] As Deleuze and Guattari suggest, it is not the mark that is formed to protect a pre-existing territory, as Lorenz implies, but rather the mark creates territory, territory itself presumes art: '[In Lorenz's account] a territorial animal would direct its aggression, starting at the point

where that instinct became intraspecific, was turned against the animal's own kind. A territorial animal would direct its aggressiveness against members of its own species; the species would gain the selective advantage of distributing its members throughout a space where each would have its own place. This ambiguous thesis, which has dangerous political overtones, seems to us to have little foundation. It is obvious that the function of aggression changes when it becomes intraspecific. But this reorganization of the function, rather than explaining territory, presupposes it. There are numerous reorganizations within the territory, which also affects sexuality, hunting, etc.; . . . The T-factor, the territorializing factor, must be sought elsewhere; precisely in the becoming-expressive of rhythm or melody, in other words, in the emergence of proper qualities (colour, odour, sound, silhouette, . . .).

'Can this becoming, this emergence, be called Art? That would make territory a result of art. The artist: the first person to set out a boundary stone, or to make a mark. Property, collective or individual, is derived from that, even when it is in the service of war and oppression. Property is fundamentally artistic because art is fundamentally *poster, placard*' (Deleuze and Guattari, 1987, p. 316).

[9] 'Sensation is the opposite of the facile and the ready-made, the cliché, but also of the "sensational", the spontaneous, etc. Sensation has one face turned toward the subject (the nervous system, vital movement, "instinct," "temperament" – a whole vocabulary common to both Naturalism and Cézanne), and one face turned toward the object (the "fact," the place, the event). Or rather, it has no faces at all, it is both things indissolubly, it is Being-in-the-world as the phenomenologists say: at one and the same time I *become* in the sensation and something *happens* through the sensation, one through the other, one in the other. And at the limit, it is the same body that, being both subject and object, gives and receives the sensation. As a spectator, I experience the sensation only by entering the painting, by reaching the unity of the sensing and the sensed' (Deleuze, 2003, p. 31).

[10] Deleuze suggests as much in his provocative and rather strange discussion of the work of Gérard Fromanger, that art is politics with affirmation and joy: 'It is strange, the way a revolutionary acts because of what he loves in the very world he wishes to destroy. There are no revolutionaries but the joyful, and no politically and aesthetically revolutionary painting without delight' (Deleuze, in Deleuze and Foucault, 1999, pp. 76–77).

[11] '. . . the aim of art is to wrest the percept from perceptions of objects and the states of a perceiving subject, to wrest the affect from affections as the transition from one state to another: to extract a bloc of sensations, a pure being of sensations' (Deleuze and Guattari, 1994, p. 167).

[12] See Deleuze (1990, pp. 6–8) for a further discussion of the event as an incorporeal that is located at the surface of states of affairs.

[13] As Rajchman makes clear: 'As a presupposition of a "becoming-art," the people that is not yet there is not to be confused with "the public" – on the contrary, it helps show why art (and thought) is never a matter of "communication," why for [Deleuze and Guattari] there is always too much "communication" ' (2000, p. 122). Colebrook (2006, p. 94) makes a similar point: 'Percepts and affects are *not* continuous with life and are not effects of a synthetic activity of consciousness. Affects and percepts stand alone and bear an autonomy that undoes any supposed independence of a self-constituting consciousness.'

[14] 'Becoming is the extreme contiguity within a coupling of two sensations without resemblance or, on the contrary, in the distance of a light that captures both of them in a single reflection' (Deleuze and Guattari, 1994, p. 173).

[15] 'This is, precisely, the task of all art and, from colors and sounds, both music and painting similarly extract new harmonies, new plastic or melodic landscapes, and new rhythmic characters that raise them to the height of the earth's song and the cry of humanity: that which constitutes the tone, the health, becoming, a visual and sonorous bloc. A monument does not commemorate or celebrate something that happened but confides to the ear of the future the persistent sensations that embody the event' (Deleuze and Guattari, 1994, p. 176).

[16] 'Painting . . . invests the eye through color and line. But it *does not treat the eye as a fixed organ* . . . Painting gives us eyes all over: in the ear, in the stomach, in the lungs (the painting breathes . . .). This is the double definition of painting: subjectively, it invests the eye, which ceases to be organic in order to become a polyvalent and transitory organ objectively, it brings before us the reality of a body, of lines and colors freed from the organic representation. And each is produced by the other: the pure presence of the body comes visible at the same time that the eye becomes the destined organ of this presence' (Deleuze, 2003, p. 45).

[17] 'Between a color, a taste, a touch, a smell, a noise, a weight, there would be an existential communication that would constitute the "pathic" (non-representational) moment of *the* sensation. In Bacon's bullfights, for example, we hear the noise of the beast's hooves; . . . and each time meat is represented, we touch it, smell it, eat it, weigh it, as in Soutine's work . . . The painter would thus *make visible* a kind of original unity of the senses, and would make a multisensible Figure finally appear' (Deleuze, 2003, p. 37).

[18] '[Abstraction] . . . offers us an asceticism, a spiritual salvation. Through an intense spiritual effort, it raises itself above the

figurative givens, but it also turns chaos into a simple stream we must cross in order to discover the abstract and signifying Forms' (Deleuze, 2003, p. 84).

[19] 'In the end, it was abstract painting that produced a purely optical space and suppressed tactile referents in favor of an eye of the mind: it suppressed the task of controlling the hand that the eye still had in classical representation. But Action Painting does something completely different: it reverses the classical subordination, it subordinates the eye to the hand, it imposes the hand on the eye, and it replaces the horizon with a ground' (Deleuze, 2003, p. 87).

[20] There is something about Western desert art that corresponds quite closely to the reading practices associated with abstractionism, which may be why there was a relatively ready acceptance of indigenous artists almost from the beginning: 'The basic Western desert painting techniques: the dots, the lines, the monochrome backgrounds, the effects of super-imposition, are basic to modern western painting also – which is why the results looked to audiences of the 1970s and the early 1980s like modernist abstracts. But the painters derived all these methods originally from their own ceremonial paintings and the ancient rituals of the ground mosaic. The classic Western Desert painting ambiguously depicts actual geographical ceremonies in which these connections are re-affirmed by the Dreaming's custodians. These contents are fused into a coherent visual image using a code of abstract symbolism which makes modern western experiments with abstraction look naïve' (Art Gallery of South Australia, p. 26).

[21] The inception of dot painting using acrylic paints and canvas can be very precisely located in 1971, with Geoffrey Bardon's working with members of the local community to create a mural in western art materials for the Papunya School, and the subsequent creation of the Papunya Tula Artist's cooperative. (See Nicholls and North, 2001, p. 19 ff.).

[22] Utopia is a somewhat misnamed generic label for about 20 small settlements in the Northern Territory of Anmatyerr and Alyawarr speaking groups. Petyarre worked for nearly 20 years, from 1969–1988 as an assistant teacher at the Utopia school which educated the children from these groups. Shortly after the opening of the Papunya art school, Utopia also developed into an artists' community, primarily directed to the production of works by women artists. Petyarre and her many sisters, including Violet, Gloria, Myrtle and Nancy began as batik and print-makers and only turned to painting in the 1980s. She had her first solo exhibition in 1996. The land around Utopia was returned to its traditional owners after a land claim, made primarily on behalf of women and their ceremonial ties to the land, in 1980.

[23] 'In Kathleen's art, as is the case with other Anmatyerr, Centralian, and Western Desert artistic production, *Arnkerrth* [the Mountain Devil] is not represented figuratively but conceptualised spatially. In Anmatyerr art all living creatures, including human beings, are depicted as predominantly spatial rather than psychological beings, interacting in natural and cultural landscapes that occupy space over time . . . The spatial information or patterns that Kathleen creates in her art correspond to and can be mapped onto existing geographic features in Atnangker country, for example, the rockholes, hills and mulga spreads that Arnkerrth encountered in the course of her epic travels during the Dreaming. Satellite imagery and computer-generated overlays indicate a surprisingly loose correspondence to the work of traditionally oriented Indigenous artists, including that of Kathleen Petyarre' (Nicholls and North, p. 10). Johnson makes a similar point: 'The peoples of the Western desert are justly renowned for their uncanny mastery of their terrain and its resources. Their phenomenal skills of site location, tracking and spatial orientation in apparently featureless country almost defy explanation for those dependent on maps to find their way around . . . They do not need to read directions off a map because they know how to read the ground itself' (Johnson, 2003, p. 79).

[24] Possum's Warlugulong painting was sold for well over $2 million, breaking all records for a twentieth-century Australian artist on 24 June 2007.

[25] When asked by Vivien Johnson what gave him the idea to compress two or more stories into a single art-work, he answers: 'Nobody. My idea. I think, I do it this way: make it flash' (Johnson, 2003, p. 79).

[26] Clifford Possum was very aware that the traditional ochre palate, colors derived directly from the earth and its products, had become predictable, perhaps even clichaic, and he sought out, through combining ochres and the use of Western acrylics, a new range of colours, and with them new possibilities of sensation: 'I gotta change'm see? Make'm nice colours. Nobody try to mob me on this, because colours – I gotta change'm. I tell'm everyone, soon as I saw my canvas, I gotta be changing colours. Not only this same one, same one – colours, I change'm all the way along. Gotta be different' (Clifford Possum, quoted in Johnson, 2003, p. 180).

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Chapter 6

Matisse with Dewey with Deleuze

Éric Alliez and Jean-Claude Bonne
Translated by Rafael Winkler
Revised by Robin Mackey

There is perhaps no art of the first half of the twentieth century more capable of proving the relevance and the fruitfulness of the concept of 'superior empiricism', in the most rigorous Deleuzian sense of this expression, than that of Matisse. Having, on his own account and with no compromise, submitted his practice to the aesthetic demands which the notion of superior empiricism implies in its 'experience' (or experiment), Matisse will alter the very conception of art and open it up to a new paradigm signifying the irruption of the contemporary in modernity. The operation carried out by Matisse in, against and with art – in this case painting – will lead him to develop it systematically in the most empirical experimentation, violently pushing back its limits (which are those of the Painting-Form within the Art-Form)[1] to the point of taking it outside itself by obliging painting to join with an outside, its outside – in this case, architecture – in a reciprocal becoming-other: A becoming-otherwise-singular and otherwise-intense in which a 'superior empiricism' of art is negotiated through a new pragmatics.

Ordinary empiricism – or should we say a supposedly 'common' empiricism which in fact is nothing but the common retrospective representation of empiricism as being a matter of 'observation' resting on a 'theory of self-evidence' – consists in relying on the supposed experience of a sensible truth that can be grasped by a common sense called 'representation', in philosophy as in art. Now, representation in general, whether

in the field of ideas or artistic productions, implies the subordination of difference to identity, of cognition to recognition. If empiricism was to stick with a representational conception of sensible experience, it would also remain indexed to a dogmatic conception of thought – be it sceptical or relativistic as regards ideas, or variable and even inventive as regards art, because to change manner or style does not tear us away from representation. One needs 'the power of a new politics which would overturn the image of thought' (Deleuze, 1994, p. 137) in order for art to be worked through and energized by an active difference which is not of the order of representation but of the processual conditioned by the requirements of innovation determining it as nonsynthesizable. Although the emphasis on the processual is not enough, in itself, to distance oneself from formalism, or the returning of painting to its supposed essence (the modernist conception of art reflexively turning back to the material purity of its means and its process, towards abstraction). So that processual difference does not itself become a mere object of (non-) representation, it is thus necessary to make the hypothesis of a superior empiricism, renouncing the 'founding of aesthetics . . . on what *can* be represented in the sensible' or indeed on the 'inverse procedure . . . consisting of the attempt to withdraw the pure sensible from representation and to determine it as that which remains once representation is removed' (Deleuze, 1994, p. 56).[2] This ultimately means that the aesthetic question cannot be posed in terms of figurative and/or abstract *forms* and that it concerns henceforth a superior or transcendental empiricism. To follow the Deleuzian argument, this empiricism requires that, in a sensation that is insensible from the point of view of common empiricism or an empiricism of the ordinary, thinking experiences itself as a differential power of individuation, braving 'free or untamed states of difference in itself' so as to bring 'the faculties to their respective limits'. However we understand these faculties, what can transport each of them 'to the extreme point of its dissolution' is an 'element which is in itself difference, and which creates at the same time the quality in the sensible and the transcendent exercise within sensibility:

this element is intensity, as pure difference in itself, at once the insensible for empirical sensibility – which grasps intensity only already covered or mediated by the quality which it creates – and that which can only be perceived from the point of view of a transcendental sensibility which apprehends it immediately in the encounter' (Deleuze, 1994, pp. 143–4). Now, let us conclude with Deleuze that the 'difference in potential' is 'that which can only be sensed' from the point of view of a superior empiricism that from the start looks to the *lowest* materialism of sensation, in order thereby to *potentiate* the question of construction. A constructivist vitalism in the guise of the rise to power of the aesthetic.

Under the name of Fauvism, the continuous revolution inaugurated by Matisse in 1905 will consist precisely in substituting for the traditional qualitative conception of painting, subordinated to the representation of (forms of) things and/or the exposition of the medium, an intensive conception in which it is the reciprocal differential quantities of colours that *are* their qualities, instead of their being covered or mediated by phenomenal qualities in whose service their creative power had hitherto been placed. The intensity of colours, which Matisse will know how to test to their full extent, will fuel the expansiveness of the canvas which it energizes from within, to the point of taking it beyond its limits, in other words outside the Canvas-Form of painting. To go beyond the limits of painting will not at all have meant for Matisse going beyond painting (*à la* Duchamp, as a way of responding to the exhaustion of the Canvas-Form of painting), but rather opening it to the resources – resources which do violence to the Art-Form of art – of a heterogeneous outside capable of revitalizing it by taking it outside itself. A process not unrelated to Deleuze's understanding of the importance of associationism for empiricism: To establish 'relations external to their terms' in virtue of their heterogeneity – this, he explains, is the discovery – vital rather than theoretical – of the empiricists. 'This exteriority of relations is not a principle, it is a vital protest against principles'; or again: it is 'a certainty of life, which changes one's way of living if one truly holds to it' (Deleuze and Parnet, 1996, p. 69).

Matisse held to this certainty, and it changed his manner of painting. Because the rupture with the Canvas-Form of painting was not possible without the discovery with which, for him, fauvism is associated – namely that the canvas is a matter of the *construction* of colours in relations of forces whose *expressive* power is intrinsically vital, vital/vitalist rather than purely pictorial. Matisse understood, and put to the test in his work, the fact that the basic expressivity of colours which his contemporaries (Cézanne, Van Gogh, Gauguin) sought, but did not manage to subtract from all aesthetization and all representational mediation, could only be of an energetic nature. In 1908, summing up the Fauvism of recent years, Matisse, in '*Notes d'un Peintre*', makes his vitalist declaration of faith:

> I cannot distinguish between the feeling I have of life [*le sentiment que j'ai de la vie*] and the way I translate it. (Matisse, 1972, p. 46)

Another formula, at the beginning of the forties, strongly states the energetic principle of this chromatic vitalism:

> For me, colour is a force. My paintings [*tableaux*] are composed of four or five colours that jostle together, that give sensations of energy.[3]

This 'rising up' to the surface of a vital ground,[4] this becoming-sensible heralding a new (i.e. a superior) 'expressionism', is indissociable from its production as a (chromatic) surface in an energetic constructivism for which *the quantitative – or potential – differences of colours are their qualities* – a principle constantly affirmed by Matisse. This processual materialism or vitalism is diametrically opposed to the post-romantic exasperation to which the Fauvist 'movement' of 1905 is generally reduced. Matisse did not even balk at invoking a *strict quantitative order* in a formula that constitutes for us his most technical definition of fauvism:

> At the time of the Fauves, *what constituted the strict order of our paintings* [tableaux] was *that the quantity of colour was its quality.*[5]

The intensive quantity of colours (their saturation, their luminescent value) varies for Matisse with their reciprocal extensive quantity (their surfaces and the modes of organization of the latter). The most famous statement of this principle reads: '1 square cm of blue is not *as blue* as a square meter of the same blue.'[6] For Matisse, the quality of colour is wholly constituted by intensive, or differential force. As Deleuze says: 'each intensity . . . reveals the properly qualitative content of quantity' by expressing the difference in quantity (Deleuze, 1994, p. 222). The intensive is *ontologically and operationally* primary in that the extensive results from relations of forces. Deleuze again: 'Intensity is everywhere primary with regard to specific qualities and organic extensions' (Deleuze, 1994, p. 251). But here Deleuze introduces a very important distinction between extension and extensity: '*intensio* (the intensive) is inseparable from an *extensio* (extensity) in which it "explicates itself" ', that is to say, in which it develops the implicated being of difference, 'and this extensity [*extensio*] relates it to the extension [*l'étendue*] in which it appears outside itself and hidden beneath quality' (Deleuze, 1994, pp. 227–8). This is a particularly invaluable distinction in that it allows us to clarify the properly empirico-transcendental privilege of Matisse's art compared to other artistic practices: Matisse will have known how to make sensible, how to privilege, *extensity* – in other words, *the intensive inherent to the extensive* – in the extension of surfaces produced by the reciprocal relations of colours or of black and white in the drawing. In Matisse's work, the extension (of figures) and space (where they are situated) appear not as (phenomenal-empirical) given(s) in and through forms but as momentary *results of the equilibrium of the forces of colours*. So that the extensive differences must be ordered according to the intensive differential: the painter who 'wants to give an *expressive character to the meeting of several surfaces of colours*' must take into account 'the pure colour *with its intensity, its reactions on neighbouring quantities*' ('Notes sur la couleur', Matisse, 1972, p. 206; italics added). If the intensive has naturally always been at work in painting to some degree, it is Matisse's fauvism that systematically laid bare a *chromatic energy* that is fully affirmative (to the extent that it is no longer

mediated) – an expressivity that is the sensible reason of vitalism without which fauvism would lose its principle of immanence. Or again: colours in Matisse are not identitarian qualities as in a 'representational' system which necessarily cuts off the forms of *differential forces* constituting the material base of their production in order to disclose the identity that stabilizes them and enables them to be recognized in *their formal and thus structural differences* (resemblance is the law of quality as *form of representation*). When intensive difference is submitted to representation and thus to identity, 'quality then comes to cover intensity', Deleuze concludes in those pages where colour was taken as philosophical example.[7] On the contrary, when representation is submitted to the differential of forces, the field of their confrontation covers over the formal differences, *bearing them away* (in both senses of the word) in this chaosmos. Nonidentitarian, colours are nevertheless individuating energetic differenciations whose singularities are always in relation of forces with one another, relation of forces which ensure their resonance and/or internal/external expansiveness in this intensive field of individuation which the canvas *is*, or *becomes*. Every individuating force thus affirms itself by communicating immediately with others in an 'aesthetic of intensities' whose processual *chaosmic* immanence can be called an 'implicated art of intensive quantities' inasmuch as it explicates the 'fluctuating world of Dionysius' by restoring intensive difference as the vital being of the sensible (Deleuze, 1994, p. 245).

The quantitative-energetic determination of colours leads Matisse to identify Expression, Construction and Decoration:

> *Expression* for me does not lie in the passion which bursts forth from a face or which is affirmed by a violent movement. It lies in the whole arrangement of my painting: the place that the bodies occupy, the empty spaces around them, the proportions, everything plays its part there [= the expression of quality results from the construction of quantity]. Composition is the art of arranging in a *decorative* way the various elements the painter has at his disposal to express his feelings. (Matisse, 'Notes d'un peintre' 1908, Matisse, 1972, p. 42)

The notion of the 'decorative', too – a notion which Matisse constantly makes use of ('for me', he says, 'a painting should always be decorative') – no longer has anything to do with what was traditionally understood by decoration. What matters for Matisse is no longer a composition that aesthetically and/or thematically exalts the milieu in which it is placed, but one which has, to cite Matisse again, 'a force of expansion that vivifies the things that surround it' (Matisse, 'Notes d'un peintre' 1908, Matisse, 1972, p. 43). Expansiveness implies that the painting [*tableau*] does not close up on itself in search of an autonomy that would imply a contemplative absorption, as the claims of modernism demand. Matisse rejects composition understood as a self-centred construction on a Canvas-Form. So that for him, 'decoration' essentially indicates two things (1) an internal expansiveness: namely an *all-over* or rhythmic circulation through the entire work ('no point is more important than another', there should be no hierarchy between the figure and the ground, the centre and the periphery . . .) and (2) an external expansiveness: an *all-around* radiation of the work beyond it, around it. Matisse's 'decoration' thus aims at the opening-up, both necessary and necessarily experimental, of art to the outside. It is because Matisse's vital constructivism is energetic-quantitative-intensive that it is also expansive, and it is because it is expansive from the fauve period onward that he will manage to procure an opening onto the Outside. The becoming-decorative of Matisse's art will tend more and more to eliminate every form of opposition between art and the milieu of life, between the exterior and the interior of the work, so that the latter might 'take possession of space'.

The vitalist energetics of colour which was the invention of early fauvism (1905–1906) will obtain a superior *pragmatic* dimension by passing from easel-painting to mural painting (from the 1930s onwards), even if the expansiveness of Matisse's paintings [*tableaux*] since the fauve period already made them radiate on the wall like furnaces of energy (except for one period of his work in the 1920s). For him, painting on a mural scale will take possession of space *in another way* by no longer simply treating it as a place of radiation (and *a fortiori* as a place

to decorate aesthetically and symbolically) but as a milieu of life with which it should dynamically be articulated *to vivify it* (according to Matisse's word). And this 'decorative painting at one with architecture'[8] will not be conceived – architected – merely *as a function of the latter* ('site specificity') and as dependent upon it; rather it will be realized in its *mural* quality – it will realize itself *as* this quality – reciprocally, as a *function* – an *architecting function – of architecture.*

This double architectural function of mural painting refers the easel-painting back to its private relation with a contemplative gaze:

> the painting [*le tableau*] circumscribed by its frame . . . cannot be penetrated without the attention of the spectator specifically concentrating on it. . . . To be appreciated the object must be isolated from its milieu (unlike *architectural painting*).[9]

Moreover, the public dimension of architectural painting invites us to believe in 'the possibility of an art in common', to *dream* 'of making painting a collective thing', by founding ourselves on the social dimension of architecture without falling back on the idiosyncrasies of 'a propagandist art'.

> Art for the people? Admittedly, if by people one understands young minds that are not already fixed in a traditional art. . . . I prefer ignorant pupils to pupils whose heads are filled with old truths.[10]

It is only when his mural art becomes properly environmental, and to this extent breaks with the old tradition of decorative art as much as with his contemporaries' attempts to renew it, that Matisse will not only leave behind easel-painting, but will break definitively with the Painting-Form and the Art-Form of art. If he reaches that point, it is by making painting and architecture the occasion of an encounter, creating between them a zone of indetermination which enables them to draw together relations of proximity in which painting and architecture become to some extent indistinguishable in their very differences, so as to

allow a mutual transfer of forces. It is in contact with Dewey that Matisse's practice will work out this *superior empiricism* of architectural painting, and it is in contact with Matisse that Dewey will deepen his own conceptions.

The mutation that will lead Matisse's work from mural painting – which is still a type (although less arthodox) of enlarged painting, albeit unorthodox – to a properly architectural and then bioenvironmental painting, can be observed in a fashion at once paradigmatic and accelerated in the sequence of the three great versions of *The Dance* from 1931–1933 (oil on canvas in three panels), a monumental decorative composition created by Matisse on the request of Albert Barnes, to be placed in the great hall 'filled with painted canvasses' of his Merion foundation in Pennsylvania. It is there that Matisse came into contact with John Dewey: the author of the treatise *Democracy and Education* (1916) who was associated with the foundation from its inception, and remained an important influence upon it.

In 1931 Dewey gave the 'lectures on aesthetics' at Harvard which were published in book form in 1934 under the title *Art as Experience*. This work, dedicated to Barnes, has a decisive importance for an institution intended to 'support education' and the study of art by targeting 'a category of people for whom these doors are usually closed'.[11] As for Matisse, he does not doubt the capacity of the Foundation 'to destroy the artificial and crooked presentation' of art bathed 'in the mysterious light of the temple or the cathedral'. He wants to believe in its adequacy to 'the shape and the spirit' of America, which he defines as 'a great field of experiments' whose 'constant dynamism' will be able 'to transform itself, in the artist, into artistic activity'.[12]

Dewey's book introduces the conception of a physiology of art refusing the museological spiritualization of the fine arts in forms that separate it from common life ('the common or community life', 'the stream of life', 'the actual life-experience', . . .). It is a matter of soliciting 'the ordinary forces and conditions of experience which we do not usually regard as aesthetic' (Dewey, 1980, p. 4) in order to intensify them; 'of restoring continuity between those refined and intensified forms of experience that are works of art and the everyday events, doings, and sufferings

that are universally recognized to constitute [the] experience' (Dewey, 1980, p. 3) of the 'live creature' (title of the first chapter: 'The Live Creature'). Following William James – in his point of greatest convergence with the Bergsonism of *élan vital* – experience is for Dewey basically 'activity', from which we are to understand a mixture of action and reception, stability and struggle, disconnections and connections in which the 'most intense life' seeks the path of harmony while rendering man 'capable of aesthetic quality'. Without an energetics fuelling the intensification of experience in which 'the creature as a whole invests itself', art is no more than an order without rhythm, imposed from without (aesthetic *disengagement*) (Dewey, 1980, p. 14). Engaging all the relations that every living being sustains with the world, in an expression that is also a construction (the plane of construction of experience), this *total experiment* at which art aims, through a process of creation and impersonal emotion unlimited in principle, relies necessarily on 'the biological character which man shares with the bird and the animal'. In other words: the sources of aesthetic experience are identified with the resources of animal life – a life whose 'grace' lies in the absolute continuity between sensibility and movement, so that, resonating with the vaster rhythms of nature, all the senses are equally of the order of the *qui vive* (Dewey, 1980, p. 19). Or again, rediscovering here the animalist formula around which Deleuze and Guattari's vitalist aesthetic turns: *qua* interactive process irreducible to the finished and isolated product (the 'art product'), and insofar as the true *work* of art is nothing but 'what the product makes of and in experience' ('its working'), art is this organization of energy which starts with the bird building its nest. We thus verify, with this extreme vitalist path posing art as life's line of flight, that art could not develop in a living way without intensifying the somatic immediacy specific to any aesthetic experience, without implicating the environment of our common life in order to transform it in the direction of the community, without investing the social force that constitutes it, with all that the 'productive force of aesthetics' (according to Adorno's expression) implies and upon which it exercises itself, according to a process of creation that is at once infrapersonal

and transindividual. So in this sense, art as experience implies *experience as art* in this expansive movement which 'enables us to forget ourselves by finding ourselves in the delight of experiencing the world about us' (Dewey, 1980, p. 104) in this movement of construction of *an* experience which Philip W. Jackson proposes we name *Experience as Artifice* (1998).

This allows us to grasp the properly *architectonic* character of the historical excursus proposed by Dewey from his very first lesson: before the rise of capitalism and its decisive influence on the development of the museum as 'home of the fine arts' separated from everyday life, he explains, 'painting and sculpture were organically one with architecture, as that was one with the social purpose that buildings served' (Dewey, 1980, p. 7). It is difficult, here, not to think of the Barnes Foundation, since these lines recall its physical reality no less than its social philosophy, oriented towards the model of a democratic community.[13] Whence also, with the image of the radical empiricism of William James and his pluralist philosophy of experience according to which 'everything is present to *every other thing*' (James, 1919, p. 310), a constant monist inspiration which refuses and refutes point by point all the dichotomies that have structured the philosophy of art (man/nature, body/soul, sensible/intelligible, matter/form, form/substance, subject/object, aesthetic/cognitive, . . .) by attacking the weak link of the elitist tradition of *l'art pour l'art*, 'museum art', namely the *falseness* of the opposition between the so-called applied arts and the fine arts, which are demonstrated to have emerged from the former (James, 1919, p. 327). It is in this *anti-formalist* context that we can understand the full significance of the reference to Barnes and Matisse, constantly associated by Dewey with the challenge launched by art against philosophy.[14] Here lies the whole importance of this passage, introduced by a long citation of Matisse's '*Notes d'un peintre*':

> form is not found exclusively in objects labelled as 'works of art'. . . . Form is a character of every experience that is *an* experience. . . . *Form may then be defined as the operation of forces that carry the experience of an event, object, scene, and situation to*

> *its own integral fulfilment.* (Dewey, 1980, p. 137; emphasis in original)

Which presupposes that this 'form' is informed by a rhythm that raises Matisse's decorative dynamics, 'unrivalled among the decorative colourists of the present day' (Dewey, 1980, respectively p. 169, p. 129), to the rank of exemplar for an aesthetic education which proposes to apprehend the quality of the experience of art by placing itself on the terrain of the spectator – 'to whichever condition he belongs'[15] – so that he reaches, in his real life – 'such that he does not need to divide or go outside himself'[16] – *an actively unified vitality.*

As Matisse declares, 'the artist draws around him all that is capable of feeding his internal vision', 'he incorporates, assimilates by degrees the external world until the object he draws has become a part of himself, until he has it in him and is able to project it on the canvas as his own creation.' And it is in the expression of this rhythm of the outside which informs the inside of the work that 'the activity of the artist will be really creative' of a 'new rhythm'.[17] It is to Dewey's credit to have perfectly defined the *social rationale* for this constructivist naturalism when he posits its necessity for any art worthy of the name as the 'fundamental motif of the relation of the living creature to its environment', conceiving this 'motif' as making it possible to escape the conventions of perception. In a very 'Matissean' way, the philosopher opposes this Naturalism to Realism, concluding by making the point that 'the immediate effect of the plastic and architectural arts is not organic' insofar as their 'moving and organizing rhythm' expresses *the enduring environment world* (Dewey, 1980, pp. 151–60, Chapter VII: 'The Natural History of Form'). Experience is the 'American' name for this endurance of the world in a rhythm, a dance, which has arisen from the encounter of an environmental art destined for a new people. An art whose characteristic 'is to participate in our life' (Matisse-in-America, Guichard-Meili, 1967, p. 231) so that 'all that is heavy becomes light: all that is weighty turns into a dance' (Nietzsche).

It would be necessary here to follow step by step Matisse's putting in place of the environmental bioaesthetic in the three

successive versions of *The Dance* for the Barnes Foundation. This demonstration having been carried out elsewhere (Alliez and Bonne, 2006), we will content ourselves with summarizing its principal moments from the point of view of a superior empiricism.

The form and average dimensions of the three canvases which constitute the work and which vary somewhat from one version to another, were originally determined by the layout of the premises where the work was to be placed, namely three spaces in the form of lunettes of a height of approximately 3.50m., and rather dark since located under an arching ceiling, above 3 French windows 6m. high and approximately 2m. wide, located on the same wall and giving out onto a lawn. The whole – 'made especially for the place . . . like a fragment of architecture'[18] – is over 13 meters long.

The first version, undertaken in 1931, is known as *The Unfinished Dance* (Museum of Modern Art, Paris) since Matisse stopped its execution. In spite of the simplification of the figures, their reduced volume and the sobriety of the colours, this first composition remains something of a painting merely magnified and subjected to the paradigm of *istoria*. It constructs in a purely internal manner the spatio-temporality of a figurative action whose rhythmic unity is based only on the gestural and it treats the architectural framework as the quasi-theatrical framework of the scene.

The second version of *The Dance* was installed at the Barnes Foundation. As opposed to the first version, which tended to close up on itself, this one, obeying a more rigorous principle of the association of heterogeneities, much more narrowly accords painting to architecture, obliging the former to go outside itself to take into account its 'site specificity'. First, the static blue background is replaced by broad oblique bands, painted alternately in flat blue, pink and black tints and sweeping uninterruptedly through the whole field. This painted device functions as an architectural component of the wall because it is articulated with its partitions – namely with the vaults and their pendants around the three panels. In addition the eight dancers have more simplified forms and are treated in flat

tints of grey which makes them mural since, as Matisse specifies, it is 'between black and white, like the walls in the Merion room' (Interview with Dorothy Dudley, Matisse, 1972, p. 140.) These figures no longer detach themselves from an inert background, their play proceeds in counterpoint with the rhythm of the bands. Moreover, the connection between the interior and the exterior of the composition is not limited to the relationships between the triple decorative panels and the curved arches which frame it; it takes in the whole of the wall, windows included. Indeed, Matisse had to find a way of compensating for their strong glare, which was likely to compromise the visibility of his composition when placed in their backlight. He did so by creating an even more intense contrast in his composition between the black and the other less saturated colours (and the white vaults). Pushing still further the association of heterogeneous terms, Matisse asked that the windows not be covered by curtains, so that his composition constitutes as it were a sky for the external landscape. But Barnes did not accept that painting could be deterritorialized to this point, including nature in the artifice of its arrangement.

The practice of associating heterogeneities (as in the fundamental experimentalism which characterizes empiricism) does indeed produce a deterritorialization of the connected terms. *The Dance* of Merion thus leads Matisse to a radical overcoming of organicism: 'In architectural painting, as is the case in Merion, the human factor appears to me to have to be moderated, if not excluded', because 'this painting has to be associated with the severity of a great volume of stone',[19] which Matisse carries out by renouncing all the manners and mannerisms of the painter (the play of brushes, pictorial effects) and by using a house painter to apply colours whose impersonal and nonpictorial uniformity – the flat tint – *exhibits* the relations of quantity as the underlying reason of their sensible quality. That all of this is carried out under the aegis of an associationism as demanding as it is perfectly self-conscious, is borne witness to by Matisse's formula: 'the mind of the spectator cannot be blocked by the human character with which it *would identify itself and which, immobilizing it, would separate it from the great harmonious, living*

and animated association of architecture and painting' (Letter to Alexandre Romm, 1936, Matisse, 1972, p. 146; italics added). The organicism of the figures at once cuts them off from their surrounding, and in the same movement invites the spectator to *identify* with their humanity which in its turn, *by immobilizing him, separates* him from the movement which should make of him the agent of the constructive association of the work with its architectural surrounding and even to its 'cosmic' (vital) opening-out.

The Merion version also has its limits. The conditions imposed on it by the depth of the vaults and the width of the pendants led Matisse to split the whole into 'three [quite distinct] centres of composition' comprising a symmetry with regard to the central panel and thus privileged orientations and a certain closure – all things that once more block the double principle of the *all-over/all-around*.

The leap into a *milieu* where all these limits are exceeded is accomplished in the last version. Presented for itself, without architectural framework (at the Museum of Modern Art, Paris), it functions independently of all 'site specificity'. The rhythm of this new composition is more regular and more powerful. The broad black and blue bands are now connected in a series of large chevrons which urge on the pink interstitial triangles. This assemblage outlines a type of continuous (*all-over*) and open (*all-around*) frieze. As for the nymphs, now only six in number, they are no longer coordinated with one another in a gestural way but are parallel and directly coupled or confronted only with the monumental system of the bands. The Paris *Dance* owes its exceptional force to the fact that, in an intensive-mutual-becoming-other, the dancers – bodies without organs entirely opened onto a rhythm which they share with the bands – function like pseudo-bands; the bands which they cross, like pseudo-humans. The apprehension of this construction which no longer admits of either centre or symmetry, beginning nor end, and suggests no temporality, is made in an afocal manner, as though in passing and as though accompanying a passage, in the smooth and rhythmic time which invites the spectator to *become* in turn the *vivified* actor of this intensive

process as inhabitant of the *milieu* – not as contemplator of a work of art.

In becoming architectured-architecturing, painting recovers and recasts the territory it had set out from, in an 'association' (a Matissean term, as we have seen, with an empiricist resonance) where architecture and painting mutually deterritorialize and reterritorialize each other: 'Art starts not with the flesh but with the house; this is why architecture is the first of the arts' (Deleuze and Guattari, 1991, p. 177).[20] Matisse would thus be assured that the decorative-pragmatic paradigm which the Paris *Dance* opened up, outside all 'site specificity', was generalizable and could thus take on a truly environmental dimension (at least) in the House.[21] This is what made possible the systematic adoption of the *papiers découpés* technique (first used by Matisse to develop the great coloured surfaces of *The Dance*): numbers of sheets painted beforehand with gouache by the anonymous hand of assistants are cut up with scissors by Matisse who, as a sculptor, dynamically cuts the colours into essentially biomorphic forces-forms, then pins these parts on his walls, allowing himself permanent readjustments of their forms and reciprocal positions in a continuous, free and (nomadically) open variation of assemblages. Above all, Matisse gives over his own apartment as a base for this experimentation intended to 'take possession' of an inhabited place, 'to vivify it'. Thus the split apartment/studio was abolished along with the museal destination of such works, as is abundantly testified by the photographs of these compositions that are composing themselves *with* the interior and *within* the living conditions that were his. Concurrently with the great mural decorations (stained glass, tapestry, ceramic boards, . . .) which are often commissioned and which he conceives on this principle, from 1945–1946 up until the end of his life in 1954, Matisse makes multiple *papiers découpés* compositions of variable formats which can comprise one or several motifs. Those are most often in the form of more or less infolded palmette or alga ribbons, but there are numerous alternatives as well as combinations with other elementary motifs (spiral, regular or pointed star, heart, mask, wave silhouette, rosette, undulations, screw thread, . . .).

Even the more strictly geometrical compositions have a chromatic dynamic and have inflections and polyvalencies which embrace the entire field. Although each composition was carried out independently of the others (which is not at all to say that they were conceived independently) and thus can be seen as self-sufficient, in fact Matisse assembles them on the walls of his apartment in a vast patchwork whose assemblage changes and whose parts are not always in their final state.[22] Instead of contradicting each other, these violently juxtaposed panels mutually exalt each other because their expansiveness projects them towards or against one another. Some of them are themselves *internal* assemblages of heterogeneous elements that this new *external* assemblage disassembles and reassembles in other ways according to multiple dynamic combinations. These leaps from one configuration to another, the changes of format and thus the shifts of levels, are like the sudden jolts of a formidable chaosmos whose permanent heterogeneous becoming bursts out in all directions and whose energy, perpetually renewed, is spent in a joyous bio-poly-morphic intoxication: crazy choreography, pirouettes, juggling, evergreen pantomimes, ... The juxtapositions seem at once *random* because of the heterogeneity of the panels, and *arranged* [agencées] because of their relationships or their alternations of formats and colours. Empiricism passes here to a still higher power by making itself exponential. Thwarting any mechanical and any overall structural composition alike, the abstract-vital *machine* races on and actualizes or suggests otherwise unthinkable virtualities. It greedily devours any external term that passes within its range, not to assimilate it but to allot it a provisional, hazardous place which, by electrifying it in contact with others, makes the (nonsynthesizable) whole itself still more electric. There is neither (anticipatory) program nor (synthesizable) overview; not chaos (now that sensation is 'in an irremediably confused state')[23] but chaosmos, because of the rhythm which improvises sequences some of which can be held to be more dynamic and thus preferable to others. It ceaselessly (re) composes itself without ever amounting to a composition; it stops at nothing, but equally, it passes through everything.

This machinic multitude is at once in a collective becoming, since the parts move or change themselves and others rejoin them, and in a singular becoming, since its direct or indirect (memorial) capacity to multiply and activate virtualities causes new connected, contrasted parts, or others which can just as well be aggregated with the patchwork as detach themselves from it. The ensemble develops in a far too unpredictable way and at far too great a scale to be controllable. Such is the most heterogeneous and thus most intense assemblage produced by Matisse so as to invest the House with the Sensation of pure Mobility, and to construct the Common Space through connections sufficiently novel to deterritorialize art within a life conceived as a process of creation.

Notes

[1] Matisse, by casting suspicion on the traditional conception of painting in terms of forms, what we call Painting-Form [*Forme-Peinture*], has more radically cast suspicion at the same time on that which it grounds itself, namely the very notion of art understood in terms of forms, what we call Art-Form [*Forme-Art*].

[2] G. Deleuze, 1994, p. 56. The formalist abstraction bears in fact only on the elimination of the representational content.

[3] Matisse's statement reported by P. Courthion in 'Avec Matisse et Bonnard' (2004, p. 173).

[4] In the sense in which Matisse declares in 1936, in a text titled 'Constance du fauvisme': 'when the means have become so refined, so reduced that their power of expression becomes exhausted, it is necessary to return to the essential principles which formed the human language. It is, then, the principles that 'rise up', which take on life, which *give us life*. The pictures [*tableaux*] that have become refinements, subtle degradations, fadings without energy, call for beautiful blues, beautiful reds, beautiful yellows, materials which stir up the sensual bottom of men. It is the starting point of Fauvism: *the courage to find the purity of the means*.' H. Matisse 'Propos rapportés par Tériade' (extract from 'Constance du fauvisme' in *Minotaure,* II, 9, 1936); Matisse, 1972, p. 128 (italics added).

[5] H. Matisse, 'Entretien avec Tériade' (1929), Matisse, 1972, p. 98 (italics added).

[6] A formula reported by Aragon, Matisse, 1972, p. 129, n. 95 (italics added).

[7] Cf. Deleuze, 1994, pp. 227–8: 'a multiplicity like color for example is constituted by the virtual coexistence of relations between the genetic or differential elements of a certain order. It is these relations that actualize themselves in qualitatively distinct colors, at the same time as their singular points incarnate themselves in distinct extensities that correspond to these qualities.'

[8] Letter to Simon Bussy of 7 March 1933, Matisse, 1972, p. 140, n. 4.

[9] Letter to Alexandre Romm of 17 March 1934, Matisse, 1972, p. 148 (italics added).

[10] Respectively, a declaration to Fels (1929), to Zervos (1931) and to Lejard (1951), Matisse, 1972, p. 120, n. 78.

[11] A. C. Barnes in *The New Republic*, March 1923 (cited by R. J. Wattenmaker, 1993, p. 6). 'Le docteur Albert C. Barnes et sa Fondation' in *De Cézanne à Matisse. Chefs-d'oeuvre de la Fondation Barnes*, Gallimard/Electra/Réunion des musées nationaux, 1993, p. 6.

[12] H. Matisse 'Entretien avec Tériade' in *L'Intransigeant*, 19, 20 and 27 October 1930, Matisse, 1972, p. 112 and 110.

[13] Matisse will be only more disappointed by it when it becomes obvious that Barnes refuses to open the doors of the Foundation to a larger audience after the installation of mural decoration: it is indeed from his point of view a contradiction in the terms of his moral and philosophical agreement with Barnes.

[14] 'The Challenge to Philosophy' is the title of Chapter 12 of *Art as Experience*.

[15] According to the variant version of the famous passage of 'Notes d'un peintre' on the *good couch* suggested by Florent Fels in *Propos d'artistes*, Paris, 1925, Matisse, 1972, p. 50, n. 16.

[16] Un propos de Matisse rapporté par Fels (*Henri Matisse*, 1929), Matisse, 1972, p. 50, n. 16.

[17] H. Matisse 'We must view the whole of life with children's eyes', subject reported by Régine Pernoud for *Le Courrier de l'U.N.E.S.C.O.* (vol. VI, n. 10, October 1953), taken up in Matisse, 1972, pp. 322–3.

[18] Letter to Alexandre Romm, 19 January 1934, Matisse, 1972, p. 145.

[19] Letter to Alexandre Romm, 14 February 1936, Matisse, 1972, p. 146.

[20] We read earlier that 'Art begins with the animal that carves out a territory and makes a house.' Since 'it is with the territory and with the house [that the expressivity already diffused in life] becomes constructive' (1991, p. 174). We rediscover here, as we have seen, the same 'animal formula' in Dewey's *Art as Experience*.

[21] We know that for Deleuze and Guattari the territory must open onto the universe and that we must therefore move 'from the house-territory to the city-cosmos' (1994, p. 177). In default of a public order, Matisse could not extend his environmental paradigm to an entire

architecture except in the Chapelle de Vence and partially in the nursery school of Cateau-Cambrésis.

[22] Picture of a wall of Villa Le Rêve in Vence, covered with cut up sheets in 1948, picture Michel Sima/Selon (reproduced in Matisse, 1993, p. 220; another example, p. 226).

[23] As Deleuze declares a propos the Action of Painting (Deleuze, 1981, p. 71).

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Chapter 7

Mad Love

Nadine Boljkovac

> *[T]he nature of emotion as pure element . . . in fact precedes all representation, itself generating new ideas. It does not have, strictly speaking, an object, but merely an* essence *that spreads itself over various objects, animals, plants and the whole of nature.*
>
> *Gilles Deleuze,* Bergsonism *(1991), p. 110*

From its foreboding first strains[1] and the black and white still image of a deserted airport pier, *La Jetée*'s cumulative audio-visual-tactile image, a *free indirect discourse and vision* (cf. Deleuze, 1989, ch. 7), overwhelms both screen and viewer as it evokes an experience akin to its music – that which is ever-new and of 'great variety, . . . unexpected progressions, and expressive of every motion, and accent; almost savage in strength and spirit at times, but more often melancholy'.[2] Perhaps the most renowned and arguably most beautiful of Chris Marker's several films and multi-media works, *La Jetée* (1962) derives its multi-sensory passionate force from its aura or *essence*, a particular *thisness* or sensual singularity that 'pierces' and wounds a body. As its contemplation of experience in an often intolerable world profoundly calls upon the senses, this short film imagines an emancipatory freedom or potential beyond our bodies' corporeal, fragile human suffering through the most productive and creative means possible. Via a vibrating screen that expresses itself synaesthetically through its details, traces and *essence* that are not bound to characters or subjectivities but affect and are affected by other bodies in this Spinozian sense, *La Jetée* newly discovers sensations of happiness, peace and sadness, intangibles at once so elusive and yet tactile.

If 'feeling is that which is in continual exchange' as Deleuze contends, feelings in fact 'become characters' and music, as he similarly notes, 'becomes specially important' (1989, pp. 124–5). As do my considerations of Alain Resnais's cinema elsewhere (Boljkovac, 2009), the following study probes the notion of autonomous emotion and feeling as divorced from fixed subjective positions in Marker's cinema in relation to Deleuze's concepts of independent *affect*, by way of Spinoza, and *desire*. Affect in this sense suggests that which is always in continual exchange as an active or reactive force, as Deleuze and Nietzsche claim, with corporeal-incorporeal effects; *desire* then is an experimental, affirmative incessant process or force of affects that creates assemblages and empowers bodies by productive connections. Desire, in this sense Deleuze insists uniquely apart from Kant and in ways through Nietzsche and Spinoza but also Bataille, Marx, Freud and Lacan, is not a nostalgic or romantic longing but a process that continuously forms, deforms and reforms (cf. Holland, 2005, p. 61). With respect to a cinema and most especially a film as moving and seemingly melancholic as *La Jetée*, this essay seeks to discern how the film ventures beyond fixations of tragedy and loss. Detailed discussions of the film's sequences will consider affect and sensation vis-à-vis the production of multi-dimensional experiences that speak to the potential of cinema and its embodiment of time and movement through its dance of sensory images, signs and encounters. In other words, this study ruminates upon the film's poignant whispers, its music, voices, noises, lights and shadows and their relations of speed and slowness, or *durée*, that not only comprise music and the living cinematic medium but also the human bodies they indelibly affect.

Deleuze's filmic analyses, it may be noted, face accusations of a partiality towards a canonical hierarchy of modernist 'art-house' cinema. Yet this seeming preference principally reflects Deleuze's fascination with the capacities of certain films to directly present not merely the flow of nonlocalized movement but also time itself through time-images or signs that liberate a human body from its self-imposed limits as it begins to perceive its world and self differently through select cinematic

experiences. Interestingly however, despite evident admiration for the works of Marker's collaborators and friends, notably Resnais, Deleuze's writings do not acknowledge Marker's cinema although Marker's films, particularly *La Jetée*, remarkably exemplify Deleuze and Guattari's considerations, as does Marker's persona itself. Self-effacing, moreover, always self-redefining, becoming-other or 'deterritorializing', the persona that is 'Chris Marker, the artist' is itself perhaps most synonymous with this beautiful short film. Inasmuch as Marker playfully recreates his persona through various assumed names and puns, in its musings upon memories and ordinary moments, *La Jetée* presents an equally myriad assemblage of things, a hundred tiny details, as Deleuze and Guattari might suggest, which collectively and impersonally affect a body, be it, as Dorothea Olkowski observes, 'chemical, biological, social, or political' (1994, p. 120). The beautiful, Melissa McMahon writes, 'obliges us to think (its singularity poses a *problem*), without there being any concept for thought to settle on' (2002, p. 7). As it attempts to trace what is beautiful and intangible, what is not again a 'what' but rather *this*, a *thisness*, sign or 'trigger', as Steven Shaviro proposes (2002, p. 12), or *haecceity* as Deleuze and Guattari contend, Marker's cinema obsesses over lists of 'things that quicken the heart', as his *Sans Soleil* explains.[3]

This essential 'criterion', as *Sans Soleil*'s disembodied voice terms it, marks Marker's entire practice as one of futurity fully immersed within a creative past and memory. The beautiful, singular, fragile, affective and forever haunting populate Marker's oeuvre with details, faces and places, worlds of detail or the 'infinitesimal' which constitute, as explain Deleuze and Guattari, 'an entire realm of subrepresentative matter' (1987, pp. 218–19). Upon scrutiny, these faces and places can dissolve; to reiterate Deleuze and Guattari's description, 'they are haecceities in the sense that they consist entirely of particles, capacities to affect and be affected' (1987, p. 261); the ever transient quality of which comprises a pure, incommunicable, aconceptual affect that may, by its 'event' in piercing and moving the soul, evoke Barthes' concept of *punctum*. Foreign and yet familiar, obscure though simple, ephemeral albeit acute, Marker's

cinema repeats itself ever newly through explorations that often assume for their points of interpenetrating directions indeterminate meanings of peace, happiness, dreams and memory. Perhaps in contrast to Resnais's cinema that also confronts the shocking horrors and traumas of twentieth- and twenty-first century experience, Marker's films more fully interrogate the simple beauty of a present moment always already past and yet to come, and its lingering sensations of loss where peace, sensitivity and feeling, freed as these sensations may be from unified subjects, are to be found in an affective process that endlessly passes through and reconfigures the bodies of the films and those they encounter. This process of creation that speaks not only to what a body is but also to what it can *do*, to paraphrase Deleuze and Guattari via Spinoza (1987, p. 257), inspires the following exploration of *La Jetée*'s affective beauty, an *essence* that inevitably evades this account of its incommunicable singularity.

> The directors of the experiment tighten their control. They send him back. Time rolls back again. The moment happens once more; this time she is near him. He says something. She doesn't mind, she answers. They have no memories, no plans. Time builds itself painlessly around them. As landmarks they have the very taste of this moment they live . . . and the scribbling on the walls. (*La Jetée*)

The '*punctum*', Barthes writes, 'is a kind of subtle *beyond* – as if the image launched desire beyond what it permits us to see . . . toward the absolute excellence of a being, body and soul together' (1981, p. 59). An experience of *punctum*, a nonsignifying intensive charge that takes us beyond our*selves*, may well be contemplated in relation to that *thisness* Deleuze and Guattari discern as *affect* that viscerally shocks a body, a body that may be defined as any whole aggregate of relational parts and speeds that affect and are affected by both internal and external actions–reactions or encounters with other bodies. All that remains beyond transcendent truths and illusions are 'bodies', Deleuze writes, 'which are forces, nothing but forces' (1989, p. 139). To assess the means and

effects of a violent singular beauty and love as released through Marker's film the 'relation between one force and others' must be considered, 'the shock of forces, in the image or of the images between themselves', as Deleuze explains (1989, p. 139). To conceive of an image or body without form, an assemblage of heterogeneous parts without binding organization, a *body without organs* as Deleuze and Guattari propose through Artaud, is to dismantle the notion of a hierarchized organism, traditional psychoanalysis and its theory of subjectification and the dominance of linguistic signs through which language and meaning are most often structured. Although a body can never entirely free itself in that its becoming exists within the regime it endeavours to crack, inherent to a body's dynamism and movement is nevertheless a risk of madness through the incorporeal wounding and very real scarring of a corporeal body. Of such madness *La Jetée*'s voice speaks:

> Nothing tells memories from ordinary moments. Only afterwards do they claim remembrance on account of their scars. That face, which was to be a unique image of peacetime to carry with him through the whole wartime, he often wondered if he had ever seen it or if he had dreamed a lovely moment to catch-up with the crazy moment that came next. . . . Only later did he realise that he had seen a man die.

Upon these words the screen darkens to a blackness pierced only by a subtle subterranean reverberation over which the droning voice continues: 'And soon afterwards Paris was blown up.' The irrationality and sheer madness of Paris's destruction resounds through the sensory image as its emerging light reveals a startling sight of an uninhabitable new Paris beset by radioactivity. The visual image track, momentarily layered with the cavernous tones, fully materializes with light and a choral reprisal whose majestic a cappella refrain augments the disconcerting tone of the entire stratigraphic image. Black and white still images of an unrecognizable Paris dissolve into one another; their merging superimposed skies of deadly, deathly dust and clouds extend the limits of the screen. This ominous image

surge that profoundly infringes upon the senses drives thought beyond dualisms of authenticity and representation as it infuses the screen with an emotive immediacy. A suppliant cry, the flow of ruins and requiem persists at a steady yet pausing pace as the visual images linger briefly while the elegy soars and the camera ascends along the remains of the Arc de Triomphe. Such sublime effect embodies Deleuze's apt description

> It is a matter of giving 'emotional fullness' or 'passion' back to the intellectual process. . . . 'intellectual cinema' has as correlate 'sensory thought' or 'emotional intelligence', and is worthless without it. . . . we go from a thinking of the whole which is presupposed and obscure to the agitated, mixed-up images which express it . . . the drunkenness, the pathos which bathes them. (1989, p. 159)

As the film's camera ventures beneath ground along the galleries of the Palais de Chaillot, tremors that echo through the sinister soundtrack and visibly trembling shots give way to nearly imperceptible whispers, their sharp enunciation of frenzied German made more pronounced by the quickening rhythm of cuts between images.

> [*whispers*. Then:] The prisoners were submitted to some experiments of great concern apparently to those who conducted them. The outcome was disappointment for some, death for others and for others madness.

Through the experimenters' frantic whispers, a score of plaintive strings and a series of shadows that reveal mere skeletal silhouettes in a prophetic unmasking of faces, identity and personalization, the agitation of the audio-visual-tactile image, as actualized through such virtual intensifications of sight, sound and bodily sensation, escalates only to fade and accede to a moment's silence. An affective anxiety continues to pervade the image; its ghostly ethereality emanates alongside the man's bodily fear and these incorporeal and corporeal forces, at once unearthly, indistinct and visceral, jointly engulf the image in

an '[i]nternal monologue' that, as Deleuze infers, 'goes beyond dream, which is much too individual, and constitutes the segments or links of a truly collective thought' (1989, p. 159). Which is to say, analogous to Deleuze and Guattari's project as Daniel Smith well defines it, *La Jetée* is also an 'analysis of delirium, . . . the delirium that lies at the heart of the self (schizophrenia) [which] is one and the same thing as the delirium that exists at the heart of our society' (2007, p. 75). This is a Paris in decay and decomposed, an urban embodiment of a self's unravelling and confrontation with mortality whose immanent survival indeed lies only through time and madness.

> If the human race survives, future men will . . . look back on our enlightened epoch as a veritable age of Darkness. . . . They will see that what we call 'schizophrenia' was one of the forms in which . . . the light began to break through the cracks in our all-too-closed minds.[4]

The 'price to be paid, in cinema as elsewhere' Deleuze suggests, is 'always a confrontation with madness' (1989, p. 201). The inanity of the man's outer world, a ravaged Paris, finds its counterpart in the recesses of the underground galleries from wherein the man, held captive by the experimenters but moreover by the restraints of fixed identity, self and ego, seeks flight through the haunting memory of a woman's face. The man yet fails to perceive that a 'line of flight' or new becoming lies through an endlessly double process, coincidence or *between* of two terms or forces, beauty and fear, for instance, hope and despair, life through death, 'a process that produces the one within the other and couples the machines together' (Deleuze and Guattari, 1983, p. 2),[5] an encounter, becoming or 'nuptials' that fractures the limits of a well-defined 'self' and identity as it invents, zigzags, 'passes or happens *between* two' (Deleuze and Parnet, 1977, pp. 6–7). Deleuze explains

> an encounter is perhaps the same thing as a becoming, or nuptials. It is from the depth of this solitude that you can make any encounter whatsoever. You encounter people (and

> sometimes without knowing them or ever having seen them) but also movements, ideas, events, entities. (Deleuze and Parnet, 1977, p. 6)

If existence is an endlessly connective synthesis of 'machines', and each thing itself a machine connected to the flows of another body or machine as Deleuze and Guattari propose, life might be viewed as a moving assemblage of bodies and machines propelled though desire, a *desiring-machine* that 'causes the current to flow, . . . flows in turn, and breaks the flows' (1983, p. 5). Only through self-experimentation and the making of his body as one without organs, a decoded, dynamic body that would extend the limits of his perception and mortality, can the man in *La Jetée* discover a freedom that would challenge the illusions of chronological time and a stable self.[6] In this sense madness is not a psychological disorder but a disordering of political and historical consequence and revolutionary potential (cf. Holland, 1999, p. x), a breakthrough rather than breakdown,[7] a decoding and destroying of repressive codes and beliefs that constitute a self and society and that delimit the flows of life's movement.[8]

From amongst the prisoners the man is selected and as he awaits his fate at the hands of the experimenters, his audible heartbeats punctuate the image.

> He was frightened. He had heard about the Head Experimenter. He was prepared to face the Mad Scientist, a Dr Frankenstein. Instead, he met a reasonable man who told him in a relaxed way that the human race was doomed. Space was off-limits. The only link with survival passed through Time.

This line between madness and reason is as illusory, *La Jetée* suggests, as the notion of truth through representation, a repressive construction that fragments life's dynamism and contingency. 'There are mad faces', Deleuze and Guattari write, 'that do not conform to what one assumes madness should be' (1987, p. 177). When sensory experience and creative possibilities are diminished through immutable morals, codes and theories of madness, truth and subjectivity, the profound connections and

sensations between all things cannot be sensed. Definitions of the real and perceptible constrict life and movement and yet, if thought might perceive that that which takes place 'takes place in one world', or 'univocally' as Deleuze stresses, the seemingly separate worlds of reality and representation would coalesce (1989, p. 130). The cinematic image would not seem to exist distinctly from 'real life' and a 'body' might be recognized in a manner Henri Bergson describes, as another expression of existence's one substance or 'immanence', as an 'aggregate of the material world, an image which acts like other images, receiving and giving back movement' (1991, p. 19). To glean this revolutionary concept of life is to perceive that all memories, imaginings, perceptions and fictions are as 'real' as the Histories, Truths and Universals society holds dear. The degrees to which 'we' are affected and affect ever newly comprise the very real sensations and intensities of life, each moment of a synthesized past-present-future forever open to a future freed from any totality of ego-centric time.

As it assesses these affective, asubjective, impersonal forces, sensations and 'machines' that constitute our bodies and give rise to intensely intimate, touching encounters, *La Jetée* plummets beneath ground to plumb an obscure underworld of such coexistent temporalities, unidentifiable processes and endless imperceptible momentary events that underlie the world of entrenched thought and reason. The film performs, that is, a geological quest to discern the indiscernible, the material remnants and minutiae of quotidian life, as it sifts through debris and layers of subterranean strata. Deleuze and Guattari might define such an experiential, sensory exploration of certain *thisnesses* and forces as anti-historical.

> Nietzsche opposes history not to the eternal but to the subhistorical or superhistorical: the Untimely, which is another name for haecceity, becoming, the innocence of becoming (in other words, forgetting as opposed to memory, geography as opposed to history . . .). . . . Creations are like mutant abstract lines that have detached themselves from the task of representing a world, precisely because they assemble a new

> type of reality that history can only recontain or relocate in punctual systems. (1987, p. 296)

In pursuit of the ephemeral and ever-new, *La Jetée* explores the power then of a 'pure ontological' memory whose creative force emerges from stratigraphic planes of such 'subhistorical' layers of past in the face of which conventional time and faces and bodies themselves lose organization and resist the 'reterritorializing' of social production and overcoding. In a world where all known truths have vanished, the man locates in this madness a truer truth that eluded simple expression in the world he knew. He confronts not his own personal memory but this vaster world-memory, an architecture of memory (Deleuze, 1989, p. 117), through a tactile sensuality, *beauty, thisness or haecceity* emanating from his encounters with a foreign world and otherness of self, life and language, a becoming that surfaces most intensely through a face. This woman's face, a corporeal landscape and intensive surface evocative of Deleuze and Guattari's concept of faciality and the layers that engender a face, is itself a politics that breaks through and dismantles the 'black hole' of subjectivity, human consciousness and memory, reason and language (1987, pp. 186–9). There is risk, of course, in becoming trapped in an alluring idealization of a face without seeing through to the traits, zones, becomings and details of its composition. 'A language', write Deleuze and Guattari, 'is always embedded in the faces that announce its statements' (1987, p. 179); how tempting it is, that is, 'to latch . . . onto a *face*' and be guided by the seduction of aesthetic interpretation and its qualifications of beauty and authenticity (1987, p. 187). How can we then see beyond a face, can the man gaze past such a 'unique image of peacetime' and loveliness to look 'no longer . . . at or into the eyes but . . . swim through them' as Deleuze and Guattari urge? (1987, p. 187). Inasmuch as *La Jetée* asks how we might think beyond psychological definition and aesthetic idealization to exceed ourselves through strange encounters of love, faces and bodies, the very means of this questioning via the film's release of certain singularities from their formal properties into a pure realm of affect demand that the film itself be seen as a living

form, body or aggregate of singularities and affects that might generate empowering joy or disempowering sadness, a true cinema of ethics and ethics of cinema.

In the underworld he first assumes to be overrun by madness, the man's captors shield his face with a mask, an act that manifests the process of the man's becoming towards 'asignifying, asubjective, and faceless' sensory experience when faces become nothing but haecceities (Deleuze and Guattari,1987, p. 187), 'set[s] of nonsubjectified affects' (1987, p. 262), series of movements, speeds and slownesses, images and interactions. Even a mask, Deleuze and Guattari write, can become '*the face itself*', an '*inhumanity of the face*', once more a politics whose unravelling entails a definite risk of madness (1987: 181, emphasis mine). What then is love's relation to such madness? 'Schizophrenia is like love', Deleuze and Guattari claim, both flows a productive and reproductive desiring-machine (1983, p. 5). Indeed, love too seems an affective decoding, a series of flows coupled by desire that, by their associations and conjunctions, enhance certain bodies whose encounters multiply their own bodies yet not through, as Deleuze explains (Deleuze and Parnet, 1977, p. 18), union or juxtaposition but the surfacing and proliferation of *thisnesses* that pass *between* two, 'that something [that] happens between them' (1977, p. 15). 'If you cannot grasp the small trace of madness in someone, you cannot be their friend', Deleuze maintains. 'But if you grasp that small point of insanity . . ., that point of madness is the very source of their charm.'[9] Can it be *this* that moves the soul and extends the crack between the self and its beyond, incorporeal life and corporeal death, or immanent dying and personal death, bringing us nearer the potential to fully, selflessly embrace the singular, beautiful and different while not compromising mortal life, language and survival?

There are ways, Deleuze suggests, 'in which the association of the two [faces of personal and impersonal death] may be brought about', among these madness, suicide, drugs or alcohol (1990, p. 156). Although art is not, Deleuze and Guattari admit, 'an end in itself', the cinema, as an art of automatic movement unlike other arts, does possess the potential to expose this

cracking of experience via its images of time dechronologized and 'out of joint' (1987, p. 187). These direct time-images reveal becoming itself, the past and future on either sides of the crack, as they expose coalescing lines of the personal and impersonal. Yet to break through walls of a face, identity and unified organization is to confront the limits of 'what a body can do' as it crosses through its-self towards a singular beyond. The violence is undeniably real as its incorporeal virtuality becomes actualized in a corporeal body. By its evocation of a love that is 'itself inseparable from an experience of mortality' (Fynsk, 1991, p. xv), *La Jetée* enacts this risk of a becoming-imperceptible through an impersonal yet most personal death as it negotiates these faces of death and time: that of the 'most fully present' with respect to which the future and past are determined and, on the other hand, a contracted present of the 'mobile instant' (Deleuze, 1990, p. 151), simultaneously always past-future. Such shatters existence ever preoccupied with mortal death as it 'calls the subject out and beyond itself' (Fynsk, 1991, p. xv; see also Houle and Steenhuisen, 2006, p. 22).

There is, Deleuze explains, a dualism that 'corresponds to the two aspects of the time-image: a cinema of the body, which puts all the weight of the past into the body, all the tiredness of the world and modern neurosis; but also a cinema of the brain, which reveals the creativity of the world, its colours aroused by a new space-time, its powers multiplied' (1989, p. 205). There is, in other words, potential for a 'line of flight' or new becoming via the cinema whose time-images might reveal the double process or encountering of both the despair and exhaustion of a past and the hope of a present 'with all its future potentialities, . . . the two making up one and the same world, ours, its hopes and its despair' (1989, p. 205). If what is important is 'no longer the association of images . . . but the interstice between two images', once more it may be said that this coincidence or *between* of two terms or forces, hope and despair, speaks to the potential of life through death, an impersonal immanent death through a becoming-imperceptible or other, a folding and taking into the self of every element of nature (1989, p. 200). Ian Buchanan asks how an externalization 'of

an impulse which, when released in the world, takes on an exuberant life and existence of its own', can be 'conceived as an inward fold, when surely that must imply internalization?' (2000, p. 52). This folding, this coupling process of producing one within another in fact, as Buchanan clarifies, is both an externalization of a self's becoming-other beyond it-self, and an internalization of the subject as the self is enfolded into a larger fold. Through a truer death than the one the self internalizes and personalizes, a body might find freedom through a depersonalized death, which necessitates, as Buchanan further states, 'a disavowal of an individual past (one's memories) in favour of a common future' and a 'coming to terms with a common past so as to have an individual (but not personal) future, one's own death' (Buchanan, 2000, p. 137). If we might become 'worthy of what happens to us', as Deleuze urges, 'and thus to will and release the event, to become the offspring of one's own events', we might indeed perceive that one's personal death is at once a rebirth (1990, pp. 149–50). This is the point, writes Deleuze, at which not only 'I disappear outside of myself' but also 'the moment when death loses itself in itself, and . . . [in] the figure which the most singular life takes on in order to substitute itself for me' (1990, p. 153).

An encounter is perhaps the same as a becoming, or nuptials.[10]

Launched once more into the middle of a brightly coloured, sensual and tactile 'dateless world which first stuns him by its splendour', the man finds that face, that 'loved or dreamed-of' landscape whose beauty overwhelms and affronts him and between the two, this man and this woman, a love arises more true than the self he was (Deleuze and Guattari, 1987, pp. 172–3). This is where madness also resides, in the smallest of connections and details, between things. In relation to the two processes or aspects of the crack that divide a self, Deleuze considers the notion of a human couple. 'Here is a man and a woman', he writes, 'and why couples, if not because it is already a question of movement, and of a process defined on the basis of the dyad?' (1990, p. 154). With poignancy and a tactile ethereality,

the film reveals the otherworldly love of lovers whose interactions, forever without memories and plans, enact the process of a self's encounter with its limits. 'A truly perfect relationship', Deleuze and Guattari propose through D. H. Lawrence, 'is one in which each party leaves great tracts unknown in the other party' (1987, p. 189). And the images flow now as if in a dream. The man in fact no longer knows 'whether he is driven, whether he has made it up, or whether he is only dreaming'. Cinema 'spreads', Deleuze suggests, 'an "experimental night" or a white space over us; it works with "dancing seeds" and a "luminous dust"; it affects the visible with a fundamental disturbance, and the world with a suspension, which contradicts all natural perception' (1989, p. 201).

Suspended in this 'limbo', in between past-present-future time and forever affected by 'the memory of a twice-lived fragment of time', lost and yet free and driven by a love for a woman that takes him beyond himself as their love manifests a 'process of *their passing into each other*' (Massumi, 2002, p. xviii), the man rushes inevitably towards a death. Yet, by such a death the man enacts a substitution of his self for a liberation of the singularities that affect the collective dimensions and multiplicities of his body and we, the film's viewers, are potentially also moved (Deleuze, 1995, pp. 6–7). For at the heart of this lovely film, from between its mesmerizing, lyrical images and most affective sequences, a beauty arises and strikes us by its flowing series of emotively evocative moments, each 'unexpected flash', as Barthes might suggest, another *punctum* (1981, pp. 94–6). And so, through confrontation with the body of this film 'I' feel my own body moved; 'something inside me' is touched by my relationship with this intensive screen of affects comprised of 'liberated singularities, . . . things, animals, [and] little events' (Deleuze, 1995, pp. 7). In reference to the gap between content and expression, Brian Massumi writes of 'the immanence of their mutual "deterritorialization" ' and through the smallest of details, *La Jetée* embodies as much by way of two lovers whose process of passing into each other through the unravelling of a self reveals a potential opening to new experience and perception via such a startling singular love (Massumi, 2002, p. xviii).

The encounters between the man and woman, the man and his self, myself and the film itself enact a 'depersonalization through love' through the lovers and the ways they 'understand and complement, depersonalize and singularize – in short, love – one another' (Deleuze, 1995, p. 7).

> he wanted to be returned to the world of his childhood, and to this woman who was perhaps waiting for him. . . . he thought in a confused way that the child he had been was due to be there too, watching the planes. (*La Jetée*)

As it liberally etches time's past-future fissure within itself, that 'silent trace of the incorporeal crack', *La Jetée* deepens this scaring within the body of the man. Through a production of an affirmative *desire*, the 'fugitive beings' (Deleuze and Guattari, 1987, p. 271) and bodies of *La Jetée* preclude distinct definition, understanding or categorization. Inasmuch as the lovers resist such definitive description and analysis, his 'memory' then is more accurately an assemblage of singular sensations, bodily encounters of connections, actions and reactions. He is a prisoner within an unimaginable, unrecognizable world of crumbled ruins that once were known as Paris, his virtual images seeming remnants of this past existence. Yet, as Deleuze and Guattari write, '[*b*]*ecoming is an antimemory*', and through his process of depersonalization, the man discovers a contemporaneousness of his adult and child as he becomes *a* body, a multiplicity, a man becoming-woman, -other, imperceptible (1987, p. 294).[11] The child whose story the film tells is *a* child, '"a" molecular child', whose assemblage or block of singular sensations and perceptions are not of the man's childhood but of a new world becoming, a new memory-world formed by the lovers' encounter whose virtual images permeate a vast virtual and impersonal world-memory and past (1987, p. 294). 'Is it possible to maintain the inherence of the incorporeal crack while taking care not to bring it into existence, and not to incarnate it in the depth of the body?' Deleuze demands (1990, p. 157). Perhaps *La Jetée*'s beauty is the potential it extends to its viewer to 'extend the crack' a little further, 'not enough to deepen it

irremedially' within ourselves, but to at least 'go farther than we would have believed possible' towards new life through a haunting love (Deleuze, 1990, pp. 157–8, 161).

La Jetée's heartbeat, its tracing of love, indeed evinces Bergson's classification of an 'image' as that which exists 'halfway between the "thing" and the "representation" ', once more a *thisness* (1991, p. 9). The film's experiment, the perception of a self within time by a self deepens the crack within the 'thickness' of the film, the man's 'noisy body' and my own (cf. Deleuze, 1990, pp. 156–7). I am deeply moved by this film whose love and tender vulnerability touches me by its sensual 'telling of memories from ordinary moments', its most sensitively embodied movements across personal–impersonal lines and its tenuous balance along the crack's edge between two deaths that calls me from myself. The film maps a love through death, and we are called to consider such experience anew. The man's quest, and that of the film, may seem to be a tracing of a deeply wounding scar and yet the film's joyful revelation of a love encounter exceeds personal space-time dimensions, discounting any melancholy affect. Our 'capacity to be affected' is diminished, Deleuze explains through Spinoza, if '*our power of action is reduced to attaching itself to . . . traces*' (Deleuze, 1992, p. 246); such is a 'diminution of the power of acting . . . called *sadness*' (Deleuze, 1988, p. 40). The film does not then recover, re-present or redeem a memory, truth or authenticity but reverberates effortlessly via its flowing *punctum*, its series of images that request a death of ourselves, and via its vulnerability and fragility 'we' are infected by its mad love.

Notes

[1] The film's credits identify the 'Russian Liturgy of the Good Saturday'.

[2] N. Lindsay Norden writes that '[t]hose who have heard [the Russian Liturgy] never forget it, so forceful and so wonderful is the impression it creates'. She quotes another who states that the music 'contains melodies of great variety, full of unexpected progressions, and expressive of every motion, and accent; almost savage in strength and spirit at times, but more often melancholy in character. The Russian people have not found their existence an altogether happy one'. Indeed, as

Norden claims, '[t]he imagination and emotion of the Russian people have found their freest expression in music' (1919, p. 426).

[3] '[B]y learning to draw a sort of melancholy comfort from the contemplation of the tiniest things, this small group of idlers left a mark on Japanese sensibility much deeper than the mediocre thundering of the politicians. Shonagon had a passion for lists: the list of "elegant things", "distressing things" or even of "things not worth doing". One day she got the idea of drawing up a list of "things that quicken the heart". Not a bad criterion I realize when I'm filming; I bow to the economic miracle, but what I want to show you are the neighbourhood celebrations'. [*Sans Soleil*, dir. Chris Marker, Argos Films, 1982.]

[4] Deleuze and Guattari quote R. D. Laing (1967, pp. 154–5) in *Anti-Oedipus* (1983, p. 131).

[5] Here in *Anti-Oedipus* Deleuze and Guattari also explain: 'Everything is a machine. Celestial machines, the stars or rainbows in the sky, alpine machines – all of them connected to those of his body. The continual whirr of machines' (1983, p. 2).

[6] See *Dialogues II*: 'experimentation on oneself, is our only identity, our single chance for all the combinations which inhabit us' (Deleuze and Parnet, 1977, p. 11).

[7] See *Anti-Oedipus* for a passage in which Deleuze and Guattari acknowledge Foucault and quote R. D. Laing: 'Madness need not be all breakdown. It may also be breakthrough' (1983, p. 131).

[8] See Deleuze, 'Cours Vincennes : the nature of flows – 14/12/1971', lecture, *Les Cours de Gilles Deleuze*, 14 December 1971, 19 June 2007 <http://www.webdeleuze.com/php/texte.php?cle=119&groupe=Anti%20Oedipe%20et%20Mille%20Plateaux&langue=2> (accessed 5 Jan 2009). 'At this stage, psychoanalysis proves less and less capable of understanding madness, for the madman is really the being of decoded flows.'

[9] See Charles J. Stivale's extremely useful Deleuze site for a summary of the Deleuze and Parnet filmed interviews, dir., Pierre-André Boutang, *L'Abécédaire de Gilles Deleuze, avec Claire Parnet (Gilles Deleuze's ABC Primer, with Claire Parnet*), 1996, Charles J. Stivale, Web Resources, Wayne State University, 1/11/2005 <http://www.langlab.wayne.edu/CStivale/D-G/ABC1.html> (accessed 5 Jan 2009).

[10] Gilles Deleuze, 'Letter to a Harsh Critic' (1995, p. 6).

[11] Elsewhere Deleuze and Guattari write: 'The BwO [body without organs] is a childhood block, a becoming, the opposite of a childhood memory. It is not the child "before" the adult . . .: it is the strict contemporaneousness of the adult, of the adult and the child, their map of comparative densities and intensities, and all of the variations on that map' (1987, p. 164).

Filmography

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Chapter 8

Affective Imagery: Screen Militarism

Felicity Colman

Paradigms of community emerge when there are shifts in social parameters of all kinds. We begin to see what kind of place it is that we inhabit, and how its constitution informs our disposition to that community. Technologically driven, social relational networks of various sorts draw up different modes of behaviour, political allegiances, and new ways of acting – giving shape to communities, but also providing different modes for social aesthetics to form. In this chapter I consider how an aspect of a current aesthetics of sociality has formed new ontological rituals for its communities. I will discuss some of the ways in which the parameters of screen-based recording technologies of military cultures have shifted the dimensions of communities, and explore how a confident movement in free communications and information access has breached an irreparable gulf in the historical relations between a community's economic circuit of people, and their hierarchical subjectivation.

Technological enablers undoubtedly create shifts in terms of the reflexive perceptual paradigms of a community, marking off new generational orientations. As the extensive spread of actions of militarism through the globe continues, screen mediations of this production of specific social communities highlight and frame the military machine's constructions of being. Activities of militarism direct and orient a community's perceptual consciousness, thereby altering the sense of that community. Under militarism, individuals are absorbed by mortally configured networks of utility. Tech-augmented subjectivity is continually produced and tweaked through the vernacular screen concerns of a particular community. The affective imagery of screen-based

modes of militarism – including critically reflexive war film, personal soldier documentary, Hollywood patriotic genre film, sentimental televisual serial, trophy videos of war, or computer game shoot-em-up or warfare game – has the effect of *situating* subjectivity as never singular, but as a component of the communities of warfare. In considering an example of just one of those modalities – the military trophy video – I want to explore this as a screen event that affectively frames some core ritual activities that in turn enable a particular social aesthetic. This attenuated, techno-delirious aesthetic is one that facilitates the intermeshed counterpart movements of the politics of continual auto-modification of communal actions and inactions, within modes of militarism.

The affective imagery of militarism is located in the tableaux of social networks that circulate imagery of violence and death. These are complex and although they can be indicated in terms of chronological markers and names, these are only some of the multiple points of the contagion of militarism festering today.[1] The first Persian War (GW1) was in 1991. And although it supposedly ended in 1992, the extensive bombings by Western military on targets in the Persian Gulf continued throughout the 1990s. The history books chart the Third Balkan War as taking place from 1991–2001, including the 1995 NATO military action against Bosnia and Herzegovina and the1999 NATO action against The Federal Republic of Yugoslavia. Militarism erupted in the United States in 2001, leading to the extensive bombing of the country of Afghanistan, and ignited a chain of terrorist activity across the world against targeted communities: Madrid, Bali, London.[2] The ongoing militarism of the Israeli Defence Forces continues against its neighbouring communities of Palestine and Lebanon. The current Gulf war (GW2) began in 2003. The grasp of such militarism's affective zones extends its sticky fingers into our brains, creating communities of powerless subjects, media-zombies. The screen-data of militarism is a social aesthetic whose logic alters the behaviour of the participant. Militarized screen imagery readily available since the green night screen vision of the first Persian war (2001–2003) provided an affective composite modality of

thinking about the above points of conflict. The intense visualization provided by screen-war lends to people the ability to perceive their community – identifiable through screen data as an affective body. Its forces direct communities towards certain places or activities. Surrounding the specifics of each and every act of militarism is the ever engorging war-event which moves at different speeds in part according to its technological largess – the pursuit of economic imperialism under the guise of the need for ethno-realist divisions of the human community, such as we see in those dogmatic walls of Rome, China, Germany, Cyprus, Mexico/United States, Israel. The deaths of individuals, the intentional release of munitions, the psychological threats of terrorist activities, laws of sedition and forms of public control over the human body, and censorship of art and information in all forms, are each militarized *vectors* of thought in action with which to chart some of the paradigmatic aesthetics of the reality of war-events as they mutate.[3]

What are some of the communal affective results of militarism? First, in its broadest sense, we can note that all forms of militarism routinely perform the (clinically observable) schizophrenia which Deleuze and Guattari referred to as instances of a *delirium* – an effect of automatism (1977, p. 22). The activity of making war has produced a militarized modal force, a drift into the schizo-life where subjectivity is under the fetishizing affect of the irrational capitalist ethic. As Guattari described, capitalism 'works as a substitutive religion. Its role is to regulate repression, to "personalise" it' (1984, p. 257). Current commodity driven culture demands that every aspect of 'individual' life is documented, and the advent of cheap, portable digital video and mobile telephone cameras proved to be a multifaceted enabler of all manner of rituals that constitute an attenuated, techno-fetishizing personality, an identifiable modal marker of subjectivity, which further offer the recording fallacy of militarized vision, as a cheap screen affect. In the current Iraq war's battalion of bloggers, amateur and professional recorders from all participants in the conflict, divergent modes of personality-ideologies, subjectivation of individuality and the forces of cultural divergences as digitally archived, display the actions and

rituals of localized social communities, thereby extending the immanent values of the militarism of the capitalist network of enslavement. This networked participation then, forms the second, and core intermeshed component of the militarized community. Public share servers mediate all data into screen affect, thus making the activities of warfare into any other commodity on the marketplace, one that presents both a threat and an opportunity – this is the social war aesthetic.

Militarism in the twenty-first century has both undone and produced a breadth of societies. Communities are made and bound through common interests and the cultivation of aptitudes supportive of the collective environment. A community maintains its operational strengths through the enhancement and enforcement of its collective abilities; its cohesiveness is drawn from and sustained through an affective circuit of engendered values, even when individuals or group activities cause new configurations of the community. Subjectivities can belong to a community only when they perform the rituals of shared networked relations to the satisfaction of the other members, and until that time, subjectivity may be determined as alterity; unfit, unable or simply undesirable. As Deleuze and Guattari describe, following Paul Virilio, under the war machine, the vectorial movements of the entire economy of violence (technologies of weaponry, 'the hunt', the relations between victor and victim, nationalist, ethnic, religious concerns, etc.) cause certain affective relations between territorial forces of combatants to 'release' their force into a 'free and independent variable', a 'dromocracy' (Virilio's term), wherein *destruction* instigated under militarism causes certain affective results (Virilio, 1989; Deleuze and Guattari, 1987, pp. 395–7).

Out of GW2 (also known as the Iraq War) of 2003 came a number of mass media circulated still images of war: Torture, mutilation, the gore of dead bodies and body parts, post military conflict, the impassive faces of violated humans, of raped women and children and beaten men. The Abu Grahib prison images (2004) revealed more of the zombie affects of militarism. From then, a flood of images of war zones began to gather momentum, and attention across media channels. In particular,

moving images replaced the focus on the still photograph in terms of discerning the modality of the militarized-zone, as free video share servers such as YouTube (with its tag line of 'Broadcast Yourself') opened in 2005. Videoblogging and 'trophy videos' revealed soldiers' activities in their sectors, often showing off the tools of their trade: The latest night-vision technologies, or the in-helmet video camera of the Royal Marines with which to record the *live action* of engagement.[4] Other common digital video, mobile and filmed footage posted from Iraq include those of bored soldiers messing with the local's livestock, or filming explosions of distant targets. Not only soldiers partake in this recording of the behavioural affects of screen-action-affect-militarization. A shaky hand held mobile telephone is often deployed to record the movement of the crowd and its energies. In 2006, one posted on YouTube was mobile telephone video film recording the final living moments of a young girl as she was surrounded by a group of 80 men and then stoned to death, in an 'Honour' killing, a misogynist practice still common in fanatical communities. The sounds of her attackers jeering each other on is as chilling as seeing her body cease movement. Sara Ahmed provides an excellent discussion on the affective politics behind such hatred of an other body (Ahmed 2004, pp. 42–61). Ahmed shows how this kind of event must be considered for the complexity of its often reciprocal affective relations, and in the case of an honour killing, we understand the poles of love–hate as they are worked into the gendered social narrative (in this case, facilitated by screen media) in order to enable emotion (Ahmed, p. 43).

In 2005, a video known as the 'Aegis' trophy video was posted across the internet, on video share sites.[5] The Aegis video contains four separate 'scenes' shot on a dv camera out the back window of an SUV by contracted private security personal. The security people are shooting at civilian cars along different sections of the road from Baghdad city to the airport (a territory described at the time in the sensational terms of it being 'the world's most dangerous road'). The British company for which they worked has denied that there was any untoward actions on their part; as far as they and the military that employed them

are concerned, they were simply doing their job, as contracted, and under U. S. Department of State and Coalition military law, which states the '*Rules of Engagement* allow for a structured escalation of force to include opening fire on civilian vehicles under certain circumstances'.[6] Iraqi civilians are seen fleeing from one of the damaged cars under gunfire at one point. The *situation* of 'real' on-location shooting provides the dyad of the 'creative and destructive function' of what Deleuze will call a 'direct' presentation of time, of a 'hallucinatory' landscape (1989, pp. 128–9). This event is the time of the military-image, and it has been a long time running. This digital landscape is a now conversant site of the social war aesthetic. As Paul Virilio argues, technology controls what we produce (Virilio and Lotringer, 1983). To imagine otherwise is to subscribe to the recording-fallacy aesthetic of militarism as it presents an attitude towards death that has become a generic equation – cultivated through the entertainment value of conflict action on screens of perpetual war.

The Aegis trophy video provides an encounter with a certain type of screen consciousness recognizable in style and tone for the screen participant familiar with any kind of 'shoot 'em up' scenario. Human bodies are nothing but the energy needed to drive and steer the cars on the game-like circuit. However, what transforms this *post-vanitas* commodity into the Nietzschean realm of an affective *ars morendi* is the image and its sound.[7] In the Aegis video, Elvis Presley's song *Mystery Train* provides the disconcerting sound-track. That someone has – impulsively or otherwise – chosen to accompany the images of a shooting-spree with this particular song, displays a certain gormless *aesthetic* that we have come to associate with our news media's realm of infotainment, where montaged images of [insert your disaster of choice] are overlaid with popular music according to the most basic of stylistic criteria. Instructions for dying are also instructions for the living. Through the song, the underlying material noises of the event can still be discerned – the texture of the road surface outside through contact with the rubber tyres of the vehicle, the wind velocity against the vehicle, gunfire and conversation within the shooting SUV. Elvis's hillbilly song turns out to be the perfect background for this overt

demonstration of target practice. The song serves as a fixed historical point for the movement and general relativity of the on-screen events. In this degree of immobility, the song provides us with a ritual vector, a ceremonial point to the trophy which communicates its aesthetic of the social war, and creates and maintains its community through the force of its affective *nomos*: The place doesn't change, but the community that controls it has. The undulating melody of *Mystery Train* suggests a historical ease with which the men handle their guns in the situation, and the video feels like watching footage of a seasonal sport. 'Weapons are affects and affects weapons', Deleuze and Guattari noted, and in this sense the imagery in this video operates as affect; an affective 'discharge of emotion' (1987, p. 400). We smile blindly at death because the infectious rhythm of the song masks the horror of the image, and moves us into the emotive environment of the hillbilly hunter. *Mystery Train* grounds the meaning of the most extraordinary images, simply by being the literal collusive anchor – the song does not move in its own historical tableau, even though images that it accompanies do so. As *post-vanitas*, the materiality of the sound situates this ritual killing at the site of its manufacture, taking us psychologically back into a past, an exchange of the dusty Baghdad road for an Elvis studio of safety in play-event actions. (To sing this song = to kill).

In this sense then, trophy videos of war, and cinemas of militarism may be understood as human markers of cultural-economic rituals, however we can, by way of the Spinozan field of ethical propositions that seek to *clarify* the gestural movements of such human expression (against the *fixed* physical laws Descartes advocated). To begin to explore the conditions of these gestures – these distortions of life and their causes, we can look to this field, *as a system of movement*, as it articulates a substance in terms of its modification, or its mode. The question is, what types of structures can this system produce? Following Spinoza, Deleuze sees the possibility of a modal essence in terms of *degrees of power* (1990, p. 191). Deleuze makes the point of stating that what Spinoza calls a 'modal essence' is not a 'logical structure, nor a mathematical structure, nor a metaphysical

entity, but a physical reality, a *res physica*' (1990, pp. 192–3). In other words, a mode's essence has a physical quality (even if that mode does not actually exist, such as an idea), and an identifiable essence.

When a modality becomes a physical reality, we can see that a situation has been created, wherein relationships between *powers* – as in the Deleuzian *puissance* – form immanent connections. As a communicative device, an image is a site of modal powers, of actions and affective acts, yet, as Deleuze described of Spinozist power – power is not to be thought of as causal, rather power is indicative of an essence (of a substance) that may (yet) be affected (1990, p. 93). Centralized points in systems of communication – such as those images of Abu Grahib, or the trophy video of Aegis, or (any collectively known image from your community) operate as modal vectors in our figuring of the behavioural tendencies of communities. The screen image is a point that we can describe, and explore as a dynamic site, or impact that different modes of communication have had on the types of political actors that comprise any community. As an essence, a political actor's measure of power lies in their modal essences, and attributes to affect a certain type of passion. Thought, and the mind, holds the power to affect changes within his/her community, the affective power to imagine and alter the world. In *The Ethics*, Proposition 46, Spinoza writes, 'If anyone is affected with pleasure or pain by someone of a class or nation different from his own and the pleasure or pain is accompanied by the idea of that person as its cause, under the general category of that class or nation, he will love or hate not only him but all of that same class or nation.' (Spinoza, 1982, p. 131). And in the corresponding proof (reference Proposition 16), Spinoza points to the notion that we love or hate the thing even though 'the point of similarity is not the *efficient cause* of these emotions' (1982, p. 114; emphasis added).

To return to what emerges as part of a question of the differential construction of being: how do we utilize modal essences in our figuring/thinking of the *intolerable* of the world – the fact that people can randomly shoot, maim and kill other people? The control of a particular social group and its sovereign

functions are assigned to 'creators' by the majority of media-communications, yet we know this is largely untrue of how aesthetic-ethical preferences are controlled and maintained. In order to keep the loyalty and collaboration of a community, order is expressed through ideas, and policed through what Spinoza described as attributes, qualities, or modes. Attributes are the things that comprise life, and may be expressed as modes, such as in the small forms of vector, a mode of communication wherein the body and thought have become one bluetoothed subject, able to be dispersed, globally monitored, destroyed. This is not a representation or image of a human, or of the world, but a display of the control of thought, through digital observation and direction. Under any given radial vector of historical or communicative ritual, every deed (whether anarchic or communal) possesses the essential attributes of propaganda. With that, speech's tendency towards its exterior element, debate, is exaggerated and exploded under organized communication.

Thought manifests itself in many ways in our contemporary communities. A particular tattoo, the veil, the colour of the skin, the call to prayer, the pinning of a certain badge on one's lapel – such activities are of course paradigms of habitual aesthetics: genetic forces and political fashions all contributing to the formation of a crowd of specific modal organization for its story to tell. In numerous cases, the ritual required for belonging in a community is the act of recording it – part confessional witness (in the case of the soldier/journalist as 'witness'), part compulsive gathering of the fetishized materials of the community – in this case, the war vernacular. The militarized war-screens of this century (Fallujah, Iraq) – digital-media war-events posted online by civilians in war zones and soldiers in combat and under military operations – have formed new social networks, complete with their own laws and affective direction.[8] The continuous live feeds from media news services such as the American company Time-Warner's television news and entertainment company CNN's 'Iraq Report Card' (continuing the war via *reportage*), or the full-frontal confrontation of the war on Allied Media Corporation's Al Jazeera's Arabic news channel all participate in

this social aesthetic of militarism.[9] Bringing a 'global' attention to 'local' events, however, does not make for a global *community* in the sense of the communal production of the shared interests of a group.[10] Under the mediated conditions of recording, economic interests define the communication and perception of any given people defined as a social group, where *community* can be recognized in terms of the levels of freedom or coercive forces managing individual direction. As CNN's advertising tag articulates in the spirit of this construction of a market: 'Some think global news. We think global opportunities.' Heralded in the time of the Iraq War, what CNN describes with such an economic imperative is the spectatorial immersion in the whole war assemblage, the affects of which are an Artaudian delirium of omnipotent militarism. This is not the same as militancy. Neither is this delirium productive of peaceable civilians. It is a militarized delirium that has produced a community of unseeing voyeurs; the war-impacted schizophrenics. It is a delirium that has enabled many weakened nation states to enhance their levels of control over their constituents. Such praxes produce and maintain rituals that demonstrate community collectives of thought in their affective repetition, *making vectorial promises* for forms of future community.

Is there capacity for radical-political thought to exist in the topologies of such ritual images? Deleuze expressed his doubts about the ability of humans to think outside of the opinions and possibilities of the sensibility to which we are immersed. In *Difference and Repetition* and in *Cinema 2* he repeated the same phrase from Heidegger to stress this point: 'Man can think in the sense that he possesses the possibility to do so. This possibility alone, however, is no guarantee to us that we are capable of thinking.' (Deleuze, 1994, p. 144; Deleuze, 1989, p. 156). However, in examining Artaud's infamous break with the cinema (in 1928 Artaud is championing the cinema as a new art form, but by 1933 he denounces it as an 'idiot world of images' [Artaud, 1976, p. 314]), Deleuze realizes Artaud's position on the affective force of images is in 'absolute opposition' to Eisenstein's quest for dialectical materialism achieved through montage, of events of militarism, such as in his films *Battleship*

Potemkin (1925), or *October* (1927), which Deleuze sees as enabling a form of the sublime (1989, pp. 128–67).

Artaud's discovery, says Deleuze, is akin to Heidegger's comments, and despite similarities with the phrasing of Eisenstein's argument concerning the capacity of the image to transform through the shock effect of a 'collision' of images (Artaud, 1976, p. 149; Eisenstein, 1949, p. 37; Deleuze, 1989, p. 158), in fact the neurological shock that the screen delivers is '*the fact that we are not yet thinking*' (Deleuze, 1989, p. 167; original emphasis). Deleuze stresses that we cannot think a whole through montage, there is a 'powerlessness to think the whole and think oneself, thought which is always fossilized, dislocated, collapsed' (1989, p. 167). (In the case of the Aegis video, the montage is the ameliorating dialectic created through the cute song over vision of death). Rather, it is in such forms where (and when) the 'unlinking' of images takes place, that Deleuze sees an affective metaphysics that might enable thought. The vector-disassociation is in fact necessary in order to begin to think, it is what returns us ordinary cinema/video/screen viewers, to 'a little time in the pure state' (1989, p. 169). This temporal modality of the cinema is nothing if not metaphysical, psychic, and because of its non sensory-motor nature, the image we look at is in fact thought itself, as 'unthinkable' as extended duration may be. For example, we may view the films shot at the opening of the Nazi concentration camps of the twentieth century and still experience the intensity of the 'psychic situation' that has been confined by the image (Deleuze, 1989, p. 169). Deleuze writes, 'For it is not in the name of a better or truer world that thought captures *the intolerable* in this world, but, on the contrary, it is because this world is intolerable that it can no longer think a world or think itself' (1989, p. 170). This is the 'dark glory and profundity of cinema' that Artaud discovered, where the moving image not only *prevents us from thinking*, substituting the cinematic world of imagery for our own thoughts, but at the same time it reveals the 'powerlessness at the heart of thought' (Deleuze 1989, p. 166; emphasis added). This 'inpower' [*impouvoir*] of thought, Blanchot's 'figure of nothingness' as Deleuze interjects between Heidegger

and Artaud, is in itself an affective force when it arises from the sound-image of the cinema (Deleuze 1989, p. 168).

I have suggested that the affective force created in the disjunction between soundtrack and image of the Aegis video acts as a vectorial point for discerning aspects of the war and its specific aesthetic paradigm of militarism. There is nothing to suggest which critical camp one might fall into when being affected by this force. However, as Deleuze points out, there have been moments in the cinema where the points in a continuum of sound-images offer *variable distribution of meanings*, such as in the affective work of Alain Resnais, particularly his commissioned film on the Nazi concentration camps. How is one to make a film about these camps, asks Resnais throughout his film *Nuit et brouillard* (1955 [*Night and Fog*]) – what kind of image could one possibly supply that would attest/bear witness/describe? Resnais settled for a visual epistemology, creating a world memory that describes the function of his film as well as his content. '200,000 dead in 9 seconds' he narrates over images of the camps. Showing us a technicolour sunny grassy Auschwitz field of 1955, he notes, '9 million haunt this landscape'. Can we discern the spectres of the dead? Just as the rhythms of *Mystery Train* create vector-fusions with ritualized aesthetic outcomes, the sounds of Resnais' narration of displaced corporeal time provides vector-intervals, resulting in what Deleuze calls a 'restoration of intervals to matter'; a form of perceptual montage that Vertov employed (Deleuze, 1986, p. 81). Repairing the rents in the world – and inserting new ones. Catholic redemption[11] – and damnation. Time for ghosts to appear and whisper to us. The history of events nevertheless holds a forcible position in relation to the composition of such images (Iraq/Auschwitz). 'History is never scenery,' Deleuze noted (1989, p. 95); dependent upon its temporal modality, it contributes to the creation of a very specific affective result on screen. The aesthetic economy of the gestures and speech of imagery is of course, contextual to its history – we see how communities of thought are thus *serviced* through their ritual communications. The affect of civilization in the twentieth century, has been that of the production of this sense of movement,

where nations are governed by militaristic maypoles, a continuum of war, and 'the spiritual automaton became fascist man' (Deleuze, 1989, p. 164); *the ordinary fascist man*: that's you and me as we partake of the screens of death.

Examining Resnais' depictions of the vile nature of the concentration camp, Deleuze further notes that Resnais succeeded in showing 'by means of things and victims [in the film we get shots of piles of stored human hair, skin, books, suitcases, spectacles, the material elements of the rooms of the camp, etc.], not only the functioning of the camp, but also *the mental functions*, which are cold and diabolical, almost impossible to understand, which preside over its organization' (1989, p. 121; emphasis added). It is in the examination of functionality, says Deleuze, that we can realize that 'men themselves are only mental functions, or "neuronic messengers" ' (1989, p. 121).[12] In other words, the undeniably spectacular and affective *aesthetic* of imagery (and text) articulates what is forced by current militaristic economies: there has been a paradigmatic perceptual shift in thinking, caused by the psychomechanics of militarism.

Evidence of the militarized consciousness is found in participants' *inability* to act and even react. As spectators we no longer recoil at the *immensity* of the spectrum of militaristic power and its products. The faded sites of the concentration camps of Weimar Germany built in the late 1930s maintain an incredible load, but it is a dead weight shrouded in a permanent spectral chill. Masked under the regrowth of the beautiful *buchenwald*,[13] these sites offer themselves as delirious traps for subjectivation, a return to a fetishistic worship of our ancestors; of our dead and fallen. A more recent collapse of the community of humanity unfolded in the Yugoslavian region at the end of the twentieth century. Journalist David Rieff describes an early scene in this conflict:

> 200,000 Bosnian Muslims died, *in full view* of the world's television cameras, and more than two million other people were forcibly displaced. A state formally recognized by the European Community and the United States on April 7, 1992, was allowed to be destroyed. While it was being destroyed,

> UN military forces and officials looked on, offering 'humanitarian' assistance and protesting that there was no more will in the international community to do anything more. (Rieff, 1995, p. 23)[14]

What is the nature of our soldiers and of ourselves as witness/participant to such an unthinking war? Deleuze, searching for answers as to the nature of the power of the cinema writes, 'Artaud makes dream pass through a diurnal treatment' (1989, p. 167). In the mastery of fantasy, war has passed into the vernacular of essential conditions of living. This is the affective narrative of the 'ordinary', as Ahmed terms it (2004, p. 43), produced on screen. The screen will suspend the intolerable, making it an ordinary experience; the experience of the cinema (Deleuze, 1989, pp. 168–9).

Moving into the twenty-first century, we are called, perhaps more than ever, into the site of the intolerable. The necessary function of a political cinema is where the topology of the intolerable offers a self-conscious, resistant mode of participation. Instead of just recording a world, this cinema must explore *the affect of civilization*, wherein the physics of the 'naturalistic' worlds of humanity is coded as a style of 'realism'. What we can observe in the communication of contemporary life in art, film and video, and mobile technologies, is a ritualistic and metaphysical *post-vanitas* of humanity, adrift within its own (frequently) nightmarish localities, a differential continuum of human being.

Notes

[1] Ian Buchanan has catalogued this moment in 'Treatise on Militarism' (2006).

[2] Deleuze addressed the escalating 'terrorist' violence in the world in a number of his papers, being particularly critical of what he saw in 1991 as France's position of servitude to the United State's actions in GW1. I discuss Deleuze's position on this in F. Colman (2007).

[3] I use the term 'event' in the Deleuzean sense of the event as an entity produced over variable and continuous duration. 'Events are produced in a chaos, in a chaotic multiplicity, but only under the condition that a sort of screen intervenes.' Gilles Deleuze,

'What Is an Event?' (Deleuze, 1993, pp. 76–82; see also <http://pratt.edu/~arch543p/readings/Deleuze.html> (accessed 5 Jan 2008). I addressed this psychodynamics of this aesthetic further in my paper, 'To Make War: the Apollonian-aesthetic of the war-event' at 'The Deleuzian Event' (Manchester, UK: Manchester Metropolitan University, 8 September 2007, <http://www.eri.mmu.ac.uk/deleuze/journal06_3.php> accessed 5 Jan 2008). The vector is a term drawn from differential calculus, utilized by Deleuze, and Deleuze and Guattari to indicate the magnitude, type, and possible direction of forces that might determine the conditions of any type of space, including the dimensions of a surface-space.

[4] For example see 'Royal Marine Gets Shot While Wearing A Helmet Camera',<http://www.youtube.com/watch?v=buDDqa0Mgr4&feature=related> (accessed 5 Jan 2008); or review the material at Blacklisted News, 'Israeli Snipers Killing U. S. Troops in Iraq', <http://www.blacklistednews.com/view.asp?ID=1263> (accessed 5 Jan 2008).

[5] This video does not have a stable URL as it is under investigation at the time of writing. Search for 'Aegis video' on the net. Video last accessed April 20, 2007 at <http://www.truthout.org/docs_2005/112805A.shtml>; see also <http://www.flurl.com/uploaded/Bareknucklepoliticscom_EXCLUSIVE_10122.html> (accessed 5 Jan 2008).

[6] Cf. *Rules of Engagement* (RoE) of the Coalition Military (CENTCOM), the U. S. Department of State, and Coalition Provisional Authority Order Memo 17. See also the Aegis Security Company site for its terms of engagement, and their services, including 'Pathfinding', 'Maritime' and 'Physical' Security Services, <http://www.aegis-world.com/> (accessed 5 Jan 2008).

[7] *Vanitas* are the genre of Dutch still-life paintings practised in the sixteenth and seventeenth centuries in Flanders and the Netherlands where painted objects symbolized the social community of their patron. All communal groups and class structures provide instructions on the activity of death and dying, in the tradition of the *ars moriendi* of the fourteenth century's mechanism for guidance after the black death decimated huge numbers in Europe.

[8] For examples and a discussion of military amateur Iraq War videos see <http://chris-floyd.com/fallujah/> (accessed 5 Jan 2008).

[9] Cf.<http://www.cnn.com/SPECIALS/2007/news/iraq.benchmarks/>. Al Jazeera: http://www.allied-media.com/aljazeera/> (accessed 5 Jan 2008).

[10] Aside from the example of war-machines, consider the commodification of 'talent', through the variations of television screen-entertainment such as *Idol*, or *The Iron Chef*.

[11] Deleuze gives frequent asides to what he sees (after Bazin) as 'the Catholic quality to the cinema' (1989, p. 171).

[12] Deleuze cites Gaston Bounoure's use of this term in relation to Resnais.

[13] German for beech forest, and also in reference to the Buchenwald Concentration Camp near Weimar in Germany, site of the Nazi internment of many political prisoners, jews, homosexuals, gypsies, resistance fighters and Allied soldiers captured during the Second World War, and then a camp used by the Soviets for internment of many German prisoners through the 1950s. This site is now a museum and memorial.

[14] The ethnic conflicts and tensions induced by the media, NATO and the military in this war is fatefully articulated in Danis Tanovic's film *No Man's Land* (2001). For further discussion of the media and the United States' military role in current conflicts, see Rieff (2005).

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Chapter 9

Hyperconnectivity Through Deleuze: Indices of Affect

Jondi Keane

One of the expressed aims of the conference 'Deleuze: Text and Image' was to examine Deleuze's work in relation to art. As one of the practising artists at the conference, I felt it was important to discuss the ways in which Deleuze makes his concepts available to artists, precisely because so many art practitioners are influenced by his concepts of process. The purpose of this chapter is not only to discuss the connections that Deleuze makes available, but to also indicate how one practises or enacts such connections. The way in which connections are constructed has direct bearing on the way theory may be understood as practice. To a great extent a person's ability to create and interact with concepts begins with the embodied activities that connect the virtual and the actual.

Brian Massumi's discussion of the 'connectibility' of concepts and the use made of concepts from the sciences by practitioners of the arts (Massumi, 2002, p. 21) sets the stage for my interest in a range of tactics of self-experimentation commonly associated with art practice. Those who run or fly with Deleuzian concepts, as if from the scene of the crime,[1] treat ideas, concepts and processes as environmental information available for the co-construction of a constantly forming world. When reading Deleuze, one immediately becomes aware that his work both invites connectivity and systematizes connectibility; to that end, it operates on a broad spectrum of connectibility, ranging from the most literal and tactile connections forged in the act of writing to the most attenuated, dispersed and abstracted forms of touch in yet-to-be materialized lines of flight.

Rather than engaging particular concepts, or the program of Deleuze's ideas, this chapter focuses on affects that can be read in, staged from or understood through Deleuze. The following discussions re-enter the experience of reading Deleuze using concepts that point to or invoke differing approaches to the embodied processes involved in conceptualization, perception and action: Agamben's 'linguistic being' and Arakawa and Gins' 'architectural body'. Agamben articulates the paradox in language regarding the way being is designated as both a set (the tree) and a singularity (a tree) (Agamben, 1993a, p. 9) while Arakawa and Gins (1997, 2003; Gins and Arakawa, 2002) situate language within the body-wide modes of sensing. Robert Verbrugge offers a unique perspective by reconsidering language as event perception.[2] The aim of these discussions is to investigate the extent to which Deleuze's writing affects a person's ability to enact modes of individuation.

For any practitioner, the intersection of know-how and how-to poses particular issues worth puzzling over. One such intersection – the relation of the virtual and the actual – was highlighted for me by Constantin Boundas during his opening plenary lecture at the Deleuze conference. He pointed out that the univocity which makes all the lines of flight possible exists in advance of our ability to trace them, adding that 'the actual is constructed while the virtual is extracted' (Boundas, 2007). The relation of the virtual to the actual hinges upon the meaning and mode of activity referred to as 'extraction' and the awkward spatio-temporal relationships it implies. The space-time of linguistic expression undermines nonlinear space-time and the immanent nature of concepts such as the virtual. From such a perspective, it seems that the virtual too must be constructed within the world. As bodies-in-process, all we can do is constantly review the relation of the virtual to the/an outside and specify the kind of outside we are taking about in a relentless effort to construct modes of extraction most conducive to 'becoming'.

If we recognize the process of reading (in general, and specifically through this context of Deleuze) as an embodied

experience, a series of questions arise regarding the relations between and among:

- touch and connectibility;
- sensation and systematicity; and
- embodied cognition and language.

The lived implications of the second term in each of these dyads highlight the move towards abstraction and, as Massumi puts it, 'systemic connectibility without the system' (Massumi, 2002, p. 21). To the extent that one can read the event of writing in a text, Deleuze seems to write from, through and towards bodily conditions. The extent – or perhaps the limit – of the role of language in the configuration of embodied activity is the crucial link in these transformations which converge or diverge at the point where the idea of connection meets the system of connectibility. Hyperconnectivity is a way of describing the variegated 'connectibilities' of words to bodies which are simultaneously proximity-bound and outside the system of touch.

The starting point for an inquiry into ways in which 'the body must either escape or re-enter habitual patterns of action – habitual actions that have customized life into a few standard patterns' (Gins and Arakawa, 2002, p. 62) begins by looking at events that include language but are not confined to language. Re-entry requires a person to use language as prompt and measure of all the sites of oneself – 'as the familiar passes through itself' (Arakawa and Gins, in Benjamin, 1994, p. 73). In order to develop a practice of embodied cognition – or what artists-turned-architects Arakawa and Gins (Gins and Arakawa, 2002) call an 'architectural body', language and nonlinguistic activities must be considered together. They insist that: 'What will need to be studied is which types and combinations of bodily movements are most conducive to an optimal *tentative constructing toward a holding in place*, and which constructed discursive sequences best constrain them.' (2002, p. 59)

Re-entry allows both heuristic and transformational interactions enabling persons to circumscribe, circumvent and circumnavigate the rules of their self-organization. Numerous

projects call for this kind of material practice – from Guattari's (1995) resingularization through chaosmosis to Latour's (2005) democratization of the human–nonhuman collective (2005) and Olkowski's (1999) call for a science of the singular, among others. Reconfigurative strategies must begin with a practice of embodied cognition. It is by way of the body and its existential insistence in the production of concepts that we can actively forget the hold language has on cognition by making language stammer (Deleuze and Guattari, 2004, p. 109). In 'He Stuttered' (1994), Deleuze observes that 'if the system appears to be in perpetual disequilibrium, if the system bifurcates – and has terms each of which traverses a zone of continuous variation – language itself will begin to vibrate and to stutter, and will not be confused with speech, which always assumes only one variable position among others and follows only one direction' (1994, p. 24). The site of connection between language and bodily event can be examined through the experience of lived abstraction, which can be made to dilate and be engaged heuristically as invitation to further action.[3]

There are many persons who have become, or are becoming, autodidactics of resingularization by reconfiguring multi- and cross-modal cognitive connectibility. Arakawa and Gins suggest that exemplars of transforming an 'organism-person-surround' into an 'architectural body' include Helen Keller, whose multimodal perception produced emergent senses of body and of self; Ian Waterman, whose deafferant condition led him to work out how to direct all motor functions through visual control; Karl Dahlke, the blind mathematician who attributed tactile qualities to patterns in visualization in order to work on topological problems; or Temple Grandin, whose autism and brain physiology predispose her to process language in the visual cortex. Madeline Gins' book *Helen Keller or Arakawa* (1994) makes the textures of explanation and demonstration, thought and feeling, sensing and understanding, observing and enacting commingle. Gins slows and enlarges the processes by which the indeterminate and atmospheric boundaries of Helen Keller form and shift. Gins performs the 'tentativeness' invoking the 'thoroughly proprioceptive-kinaesthetic (and tactile)

graphicality' necessary for supposition and position to interact (1994, p. 12). In a later discussion of texture and distance, Gins voices what I take to be the condition of a destratified yet fully embodied person:

> Von Senden reports that to a blind person who had only recently recovered her sight, a house that was miles away was thought of a being nearby, but requiring the taking of a lot of steps. *In* the blind, either there's no distance or all of distance. Certainly for the deafblind, at least, there's no perceiving at a distance whatsoever. (Gins, 1994, p. 143)

In light of the potential for individuals to explore cross-modal perception and perform resingluarization, John Rajchman's (2000) discussion of affect in Deleuze is relevant. He notes that, for Deleuze (via Spinoza), affect

> becomes the sensation of what favours or prevents, augments or diminishes, the powers of life of which we are capable each with one another; and it is in something of this same 'ethical' sense that Deleuze proposes to extract clinical categories (like 'hysteria' or 'perversion' or 'schizophrenia') from their legal and psychiatric contexts and make them a matter of experimentation in modes of life, in art and philosophy, or as categories of a philosophical-aesthetic 'clinic'. (Rajchman, 2000, p. 132)

By extracting sensations, affect becomes a 'kind of construction . . . thus art is less the incarnation of a life-world than a strange construct we inhabit only through transmutation or self-experimentation, or from which we emerge refreshed as if endowed with a new optic or nervous system' (Rajchman, 2000, p. 135).

If Rajchman's assessment of Deleuzian affect is correct, then language is one of many activities constituting the ecological folding of inside and outside, virtual and actual.[4] Self-transmutation of the body through affect requires a connection between ideas and their anatomical basis. Hyperconnectivity

consists in the doubling and paradoxical literalness of touch which may exist as the viscous prompt to change or as abstract and 'distinct from the terms of the relation' (Bains, 2006, p. 17). It is my hypothesis that the spectrum produced by the combination of Deleuze's sensitivity to touch, the intensity of his transmission of affect within and across texts, the intimacy of his immaculate buggeries and the timbre of his writing collaboration constitute *indices of affect* which are moving towards the systematicity of thought and of sensation, rather than towards self-experimentation and alternative ways of distributing connections through embodied cognition.

Though Giorgio Agamben (1993a, 1993b) has theorized linguistic being as a two-way street between universalized singularity and situated specificity, the choice of the term 'linguistic being' emphasizes the linguistic over the bodily, inadvertently contributing to the ease with which concepts are exploited for general application. However, Agamben makes this systemic connectibility perceivable by passing the biosphere of contingency through the systematicity of the history of ideas. From this intersection and interference emerge the 'signifier of the signifying function' (1993b, p. 84), the 'intelligence of an intelligibility' (1993a, p. 2) and the 'expropriation of all identity, so as to appropriate belonging itself' (1993a, p. 11). Agamben then applies these modes of lived abstraction to various sites. When applied to situated contingencies, 'whatever singularity' (1993a, p. 5) emerges; when applied to the site of person, 'linguistic being' (1993a, p. 9) surfaces; when applied to language, the 'example' (1993a, p. 9) disperses the system of connections. In this way, Agamben charts the history of abstraction as the way in which absoluteness has participated in the pragmatics of realization. I would suggest that it is the *systematicity* of language moving in all directions at once that requires attention and re-entry. The indexical character of language holds the most promise when investigating the affect that arises from the interaction or interference of top-down conceptual processing with bottom-up perceptual processing.

Robert Verbrugge's 1987 essay 'Language and Event Perception' reconsiders the basis of lived abstraction and

searches for what might be called the *indices of affect* or the affective potential of 'whatever singularity' and 'linguistic being'. He offers a theory grounded in perception and action that juggles the hyperconnectivity of embodied action in both its literalness and its increasing diffuseness. Verbrugge calls for the opening of language, through its indexical aspects, to the extra-linguistic. His ecological perspective on the biology of language suggests an alternative to the adversarial roles of language and perception; he argues against the tendency to understand the relation of perception to events as parallel to the relation of words to things (1987, pp. 162–3). He proposes to reverse this traditional analogy by making event perception and language mutually supportive (1987, p. 164), which may well be what Deleuze's logic of sense attempts to connect.

Approaching language as a constraint and directing event dissolves the divide between comprehension and perception in an effort to treat comprehension as a brand of event perception where language is its specific medium. For Verbrugge, language and perception approach one another in the 'quality of knowing they permit' (1987, p. 167). The aim of producing new perceptions, sensations and emotions that open the body and make new though possible are consistent with the Deleuzian ethos.[5] Both types of knowledge (perception and language) reposition the role of metaphoric language from representing correspondences to preparing a person for further action. In other words, language 'attunes' a person to the invariant features available in the environment through both virtual experience and precise description. For Arakawa and Gins' 'architectural body', however, attuning through language means providing triggers that enable modes of perception to be coordinated across different scales of action in the organism-person-environment. Verbrugge proposes that events constitute environmental information that is pragmatically unique because it is context-dependent. His notion of information expands to include the 'affordances'[6] provided by communication, imagination and perception, and considers them to be equally a part of the environmental array and interactive situation. In this theory of specific interaction, language and art

act as catalysts which trigger events that 'constrain the flow of imaginings' without containing representations of their own process or results (1987, p. 170).

The implication of Verbrugge's theory subsumes all language into index. He states: 'my extension of the term index to cover all language is based on what I see as an existential relation between all words and their natural occasions' (1987, p. 179). Language is an event that is neither representative nor arbitrary, but related to some 'natural' constraint, as are typical indexes such as a footprint, thunder, a bad cough or a pencil line (1987, p. 177). The indexical trace or concrete instance, however, is not the footprint of the body in language but the activity of language as it folds into and from the personal and interpersonal sites in which language happens: 'While language constraints may be abstract, they can nonetheless be *unique*. For the seasoned listener, the catalytic effect of words can be very precise.' (1987, p. 181) The important point here is that an index needs more than a signifier and a referent: 'people and their catalysts develop together', but only 'if we view language as an event integral to our environment and not an arbitrary associate of it' (1987, pp. 180–1). Verbrugge argues that language is not a collection of descriptive surrogates estranged from the world (1987, p. 183), but rather constituent parts of the world that would allow integration of the theory of language with other activities in the organism, and that this accounts for the persistence of language as a reliable tool for the exploration of adaptation, learning and coordination.[7]

Like Verbrugge, Arakawa and Gins (1997, 2003; Gins and Arakawa, 2002) are dissatisfied with the segregation of language from the study and practice of bodily engagement of an organism with its environment. Their observation that 'the body and its person, co-extensional only up to a point, share events but not extent' (Benjamin, 1994, p. 68) situates language within the realm of touch, rather than perceiving it as a mode of transcendence.

In *Kafka: Towards a Minor Literature*, Deleuze and Guattari (1986) provide a complex description of embodied affect, an

affect which I find to be consistent throughout my experience of reading Deleuze:

> As Kafka has the ape in 'A Report to an Academy' say, it isn't a question of a well-formed vertical movement toward the sky or in front of one's self, it is no longer a question of breaking through the roof, but of intensely going 'head over heels and away,' no matter where, *even without moving*; it isn't a question of liberty as against submission, but only a question of a line of escape or, rather, of a simple way out, 'right, left or in any direction,' as long as it is as little signifying as possible. (1986, p. 6)

This description moves away from linguistic being towards what Arakawa and Gins (Gins and Arakawa, 2002) call the 'architectural body' and 'procedural architecture'. Procedures are 'constructed as built propositions, [that] marshal existing logical connectives and position newly invented ones into the "real," steering, regulating and guiding interaction between the body and the bioscleave' (2002, pp. 58–9).[8] Language is one node within the changing and changeable body-wide modes of connectibility. If, as Guattari (1995, p. 6) proposes, we should develop pragmatic interventions that occur at the intersections of asignifying systems with other semiotizing systems, we must be careful not to disconnect our absolute potentiality entirely from the environment of meaningful consequences, even when expressed through the hyperconnectivity of systematicity. Although Deleuze carries out infinitesimal degrees of initiating and brings forth movement in which effects precede and exceed their causes, I would assert that he is caught between linguistic being and architectural body, between concepts of process and the connectibility of material processes. For anyone who makes use of Deleuze's work to pursue modes of individuation, it is more difficult to investigate the ways in which the exteriority of relations *is* a part of the conditions of contingency and contiguity.

The subtitle of Paul Bains' book, *The Primacy of Semiosis: An Ontology of Relations*, seems to promise an investigation of the embodied conditions of language and languaging. He often

refers to Guattari's enaction – a concept of reciprocal specification between the knower and known – to insist that relations are real. However, Bains' reality moves away from Guattari's material practices by making language into the systematicity of relations that 'goes beyond the relative exteriority . . . to an absolute outside which is not that of an external world, but of the exteriority (and univocity) of relations to their terms' (Bains, 2006, p. 135). Unfortunately, this pure systematicity leaves out the connectibility of 'lived abstraction' which Massumi (2002), for one, sees as necessary part of 'operative reason' – the materiality of thought, perception and action (2002, p. 128). In his discussion of the sensation evident in operative reason, Massumi uses Stelarc's 'Suspension' works to conclude that:

> To perform the conditions of evolution is to reproblematize them. For an immortalized cyborg future-present, natural selection would no longer be the operative principle of evolutionary unfolding. The old way of generating evolutionary solution-cases will no longer hold. (Massumi, 2002, p. 125)

By approaching language as events within an evolutionary landscape which operate in relation to processes and direction of change, the materiality of cultural and metacultural selective mechanisms comes into play (Sheets-Johnstone, 1996, p. 15).

Through the Stoics, Bains recognizes that Agamben and Deleuze push towards a similar consideration of the event of language as separate from particular being. Bains valorizes Agamben's relentless move towards systematicity as a novel procedure. For Agamben and for Bains: 'Language is the capacity to signify rather than an actual signification, and what is expressed is communicability itself' adding 'for if language is potentiality, the "coming community" will not belong to the state but rather will appropriate its own being-in-language, or belonging itself without affirming a representable identity, and exist as absolute potentiality' (Bains, 2006, p. 137).

How does a person appropriate being-in-language? What is the bodily process by which this occurs? I am concerned that Paul Bains finds a way – and historical support – to disconnect

the body-person (yet again) from an environment of meaningful consequences by removing the reality of relation to a pure and safe haven in the virtual. The more difficult task is to find how the absolute pure relation, under all known aliases, is drawn back into local scales of action. This would require that we examine the biology of language and study the capacity of persons to gerrymander the boundaries of their biological systems in order to utilize the embodied affects and effects of pure relation. As Maturana and Varela (1980, p. 13) explain, the nervous system expands its cognitive domain by making it possible to interact with 'pure relations' or 'abstract thought'. They describe 'abstract thinking' as the inclusion of cognitive domains within the cognitive domain, or the ability to include 'interactions with one's own internal states as if these were independent states' (1980, p. 13). Maturana and Varela seem to be describing the autopoietic basis for self-experimentation, since the biological mechanism for indirectly interacting with as-if scenarios (projected into/onto an external world in anticipation of the affects) is well established.

Arakawa and Gins propose that the way to anticipate and interact with the pure potential of language is to tactically build the questions that one may ask of the body-person. This process is what Arakawa and Gins call *parlaying indirectness* (2003, p. 20), and it is also what Maturana and Varela described as expanding a cognitive domain within the cognitive domain (Maturana and Varela, 1980, p. 13). Here the body-person is the mechanism that acts upon language as event and constructs a way to extract virtual states from the affective processes of the body.

If the biology of language plays a crucial role in forming 'what may happen next', the degree to which Deleuze is caught between linguistic being and the architectural body is a function of the interaction of the affects foregrounded in his writing and the modes of connectivity available in language. Perhaps we should consider the painful whorls of Deleuze's hypersensitive fingertips when thinking about the turbulent affects of his writing which sends us simultaneously towards the molar and the molecular. Hypersensitivity affects the perception of all textures – surfaces, objects, atmospheres and thoughts – not

just the texture known to cause pain.[9] In turn, such sensitivity might enhance the understanding of hyperconnectivity, a form of touch-without-touch inherent to language, and become infused in the act of writing. The intensity of touch and the avoidance of touch inflect Deleuze's text with embodied context, and paradoxically allow readers to feel-think (understand) either the intensity of affect or an elision of the body. As an artist, I am fascinated with both of these experiences – neither of which can be quarantined within the skull. This is to say, the imagination is a body-wide activity and thinking the unknown, the unknowable, the infinite, the impossible, the immaterial, the unstratified, the virtual and even the Real takes place within organism-person-environment, perturbing its homeostatic relationships.

Returning to the puzzle of how a person might extract the virtual, we are confronted by the notion that virtual events are quasi-causal (Boundas, 2007). Destratification may become the creative process by which the indirectness of causation can be parlayed and developed into a practice. Deleuze and Guattari describe the dangers of too-sudden destratification in bodily terms – suicidal or cancerous[10] – because all constructions, including philosophical constructions, occur within artistic poiesis *and* organic autopoiesis. The extent to which language can be configured as one mode of embodied activity among many depends upon how the virtual is deployed: as the outside of the inside, as Deleuze suggests, or as the recourse to an outside, as Latour warns.[11]

The case of Deleuzian affect is significant because he chose to intensify both the affects of language: the sensations that flow between word and body; and the most distributed filaments of hyperconnective (systematized) passage. To go 'head over heels and away' describes a heavy-handed embodied mode of action. To go 'even without moving' describes an intangible hyperconnective mode of passage from virtual to actual. In the realization of living, there is only the outside that we project and then extract from our projections to catalyze action (Verbrugge, 1987, p. 170). Whether we can become comfortable with the 'productive paradox' of the virtual (Massumi,

2002, p. 38) depends upon our ability to achieve a state of connectedness in which body, site and surround become variegated textures under the most deregulated conditions of selection, which Arakawa and Gins call 'atmospheric intricateness' (2003, p. 25). The literalness of this ecological approach prompts the hyperconnectivity of linguistic events to pass through the indices of affect and emerge as the anatomical basis of becoming.

Notes

[1] Brian Massumi discusses the 'issues of thefts from science for the humanities' through the notion of connectibility, observing that scientists might rightly object that a stolen or appropriated concept has ceased to have anything remotely scientific and function as a metaphor (2002, p. 29). To avoid taming concepts, Massumi advocates treating scientific concepts the way any other concept is treated – with creative violence sensitive to the concept's arrival and departure in the flow of language and how it tends to relay into other concepts (2002, pp. 19–20). The connectibility of concepts from science for the humanities applies to the connectibility of concepts from philosophy for practitioners under discussion here.

[2] See Gorgio Agamben, *The Coming Community* (1993a); Arakawa and Gins' exploration of the relationships between and among an organism, person (1997, 2003; Gins and Arakawa, 2002); Verbrugg (1987).

[3] See Alphonso Lingis's discussion of 'direct expressions' (2003) and Barbara Bolt's (2004) insights into Peirce's 'dynamic objects' and 'immediate objects'.

[4] In his discussion of the way Foucault avoids resuscitating old notions of interiority, Deleuze states that 'the outside is not a fixed limit but a moving matter animated by peristaltic movements, folds and foldings that together make up an inside: they are not something other than the outside, but precisely the inside of the outside' (1988, pp. 96–7).

[5] Brian Massumi's last comment in the introduction to *A Thousand Plateaus* suggests that he believed the value of the book lay in the possibilities it opens in thought through the body (2004, p. xvi).

[6] The term 'affordance' was used by ecological psychologist James J. Gibson to emphasize what the environment affords an individual in the way of discrimination (1966, p. 23). The term emphasizes the perceiver-specific use-value for a particular action capabilities related to a category of potential encounters (Warren and Shaw, 1985, p. 12).

[7] By 'natural', Verbrugge means part of the lived environment, which bears a similarity to what Arakawa and Gins call 'sited awareness' (Gins and Arakawa, 2002, p. 50) or the 'shape of awareness' (2002, p. 86).

[8] In *Architectural Body*, Arakawa and Gins state: 'Architecture's holding in place occurs within and as part of a prevailing atmospheric condition that others routinely call biosphere but which we, feeling the need to stress its dynamic nature, have renamed bioscleave' (Gins and Arakawa, 2002, p. 48). Cleaving, to adhere (to) or to divide (from), is the dynamic movement which is crucial for persons to understand about their own world-forming capacities. They introduced the term 'cleaving' in *To Not to Die* (Arakawa and Gins, 1987, pp. 40–50).

[9] 'One might also note, looking at my fingertips, that I haven't got the normal protective whorls, so that touching anything, especially fabric, causes such irritation that I need long nails to protect them.' (Deleuze, 1990, p. 5)

[10] Deleuze and Guattari, 'Conclusions: Concrete Rules and Abstract Machines', *A Thousand Plateaus* (2004, p. 554).

[11] Bruno Latour in *Politics of Nature* provides a historical critique that warns of the dangers of maintaining 'recourse to an outside' (2005, pp. 34–41). He sees such recourse as a gambit of science which has kept it from taking part in political ecology.

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Chapter 10

Deleuze, Guattari and Contemporary Art

Stephen Zepke

The critique of phenomenology and analytical philosophy offered by Deleuze and Guattari in *What Is Philosophy?* reveals both their mutual implication, and their shared complicity with capitalism. Phenomenology was an important influence on the art movement of Minimalism, just as analytic philosophy influenced Conceptual art, and their rejection by Deleuze and Guattari poses crucial questions to contemporary art emerging in their wake. The status of contemporary art practices must also be considered in relation to Deleuze and Guatarri's emphasis on painting, and their interest in the Modernism of Clement Greenberg and Michael Fried. It is common to claim, somewhat apologetically, that here Deleuze and Guattari are simply showing their age, and couldn't quite keep up with contemporary art. I would like to argue instead that the philosophical reasons Deleuze and Guattari give for their rejection of minimalist and conceptual practices allow us to understand how contemporary art is, or could be, or *should* be, the production of a sensation that takes us beyond the 'lived experience' of a phenomenological flesh, and opposes the info-economy of cognitive capitalism. This sensation is not restricted to any medium, and is defined instead as a vector of transformation. Sensation is the expression of a becoming-inhuman, and whether in a painting or a direct social intervention, it operates politically. In this Deleuze and Guattari return to the art of our time, and offer it what it wants – a *politics* – but inside what it doesn't – *sensation*. It remains to be seen if contemporary art is interested.

The Phenomeno-logical Problem

The problem with logic, and by extension with analytic philosophy, is that it turns the concept into a function. The function is, on Deleuze and Guattari's account, the mechanism by which science establishes a plane of reference on which a virtual chaos can be actualized in co-ordinates, and described in a proposition. Via the function, science descends from the virtual to the actual, while philosophy, via the concept, ascends in the opposite direction. Science and philosophy's 'opposed paths' (1994, p. 126) are 'inseparable but independent' and 'necessarily intersect' (1994, p. 161). Indeed, philosophy has a 'fundamental need' (1994, p. 162) of science, which it uses to orient its concepts towards the contemporary rather than the eternal world.[1] Logic, however, turns the concept into a function by demanding that it determine the conditions by which a proposition referring to a state of affairs can be verified as being either true or false. This is what Deleuze and Guattari call logic's 'infantile idea of philosophy', (1994, p. 24) an idea that is *not* the becoming-child of philosophy, but is instead the expression of 'a real hatred' and a 'will to supplant philosophy'. In this way, and Deleuze and Guattari could hardly put it any more starkly, logic 'kills the concept' (1994, p. 140).

In fact, by reducing the concept to a function defining propositions about the world, logic never goes further than providing a form of recognition – the true and the false – by which information is communicated. This, Deleuze and Guattari declare, is both 'impoverished and puerile' (1994, p. 139) and is complicit with contemporary forms of capitalism. Furthermore, as philosophy it doesn't work. Here *What Is Philosophy?* repeats an argument from *The Logic of Sense*, where Deleuze showed that the truth or falsity of a proposition cannot be grounded according to its logical conditions, and in fact requires '*something unconditioned* capable of assuring a real genesis of denotation and of the other dimensions of the proposition' (1990, p. 19). It is precisely this ontogenetic event, this extra-linguistic 'instant' of sense, 'this new world of incorporeal effects [events] which makes language possible' (1990, p. 166), that logic is unable to express in

a proposition, nor refer to an object (1990, p. 165).[2] About this event, Deleuze and Guattari rather sarcastically claim, 'logic is silent, and it is only interesting when it is silent' (1994, p. 140). Logic nevertheless attempts to fill this silence by using a function defining a universal of lived experience to ground the truth or falsity of a proposition referring to an actual state of affairs. Thus logic is founded by 'functions of the lived' (1994, p. 142), and Deleuze suggests in *The Logic of Sense* that Husserlian phenomenology perhaps provides its 'rigorous science' (1990, p. 21).

These 'functions of the lived' discovered by Husserl and developed in the phenomenological tradition establish a transcendental subjectivity composed of *Urdoxa*, or what Deleuze and Guattari call 'proto-opinions', providing a 'transcendental logic' that 'serves as the primordial ground for formal logic' (1994, p. 142). In *The Logic of Sense* this *Urdoxa* is shown to form a faculty of common sense, one in which the transcendental subject 'retains the form of the person, of personal consciousness, and of subjective identity', and phenomenology remains 'satisfied with creating the transcendental out of the characteristics of the empirical' (1990, p. 98). It is at this point that phenomenology requires art, for it is in art that the sensations of the lived body embody their transcendental conditions, and what Merleau-Ponty calls its 'interior armature' (1968, p. 149) or 'diagram' becomes visible, 'illustrating and amplifying the metaphysical structure of our flesh' (1993, p. 128–9).[3]

By proposing the *Urdoxa* as 'functions of the lived', phenomenology never leaves the realm of human perceptions and affections, and under these conditions the recognition of a proposition's 'truth' simply reflects existing orthodoxy. In this, Deleuze and Guattari argue, phenomenology is 'already political' (1994, p. 145). This is a politics of consensus, because in phenomenology the function is simply the majority view, whose propositions (their logical truth not withstanding) never communicate more than 'the simple opinion of the average Capitalist' (1994, p. 149).

These critiques of logic and phenomenology are directly applicable to two fundamental shifts that acted as the necessary

conditions for the emergence of contemporary art. The first is the 'expanded object' of Minimalism and its focus on lived experience produced through the site specificity of installation practices, and the second is the elevation of the analytic 'concept' to the status of art by Conceptual art, and its emersion in the info-economy.

Phenomeno-logical Aesthetics

It is well known that many Minimalist artists drew on phenomenology in their attack on Clement Greenberg. Greenberg defined modernist painting as a neo-Kantian process of immanent critique[4] exploring art's fundamental 'flatness' ('Modernist Painting', 1993, p. 87) and colour in order to produce visual 'sensations, the irreducible elements of experience' ('Towards a New Laocoon', 1985, p. 30). For Greenberg then, painting 'uses the most self-evidently corporeal means to deny its own corporeality', which is another way of saying it discovers a transcendental dimension – beyond mind and body – with empirical means ('Byzantine Parallels', 1961, p. 169). The 'disembodied energy' of Modernist painting (Michael Fried, 'Morris Louis', 1998, p. 106) transcended the space of lived experience to reveal, as Michael Fried put it, the 'conditions of seeing' (Fried, 'Three American Painters: Kenneth Noland, Jules Olitski, Frank Stella', 1998, p. 224). Against painting's 'spiritualized' transcendental conditions, and the 'disinterested contemplation' of aesthetic judgement (Greenberg, 'Towards a New Laocoon', 1985, p. 29), the minimalist 'expanded object' encompassed the subject and object in spatio-temporal relationships including art work, viewer, gallery space, light, force and so on, as they unfolded in real time and three dimensions. This lived experience, Robert Morris argued, works 'to eliminate the viewer to the degree that these details pull him into an intimate relation with the work' (1994, p. 19). Drawing on Merleau-Ponty,[5] Morris argued that this 'intimacy' is organized by 'gestalts' of simple geometric forms and formal relations such as figure/ground, constituting 'those aspects of apprehension that are not coexistent

with the visual field but rather the result of the experience of the visual field' (1994, p. 6). Morris's phenomenological understanding of the minimalist object posits lived experience as a plane of immanence treated as a field of consciousness. This makes experience 'immanent to' the gestalt, which acts as *Urdoxa* or common sense 'opinions' that ground experience in a still-human transcendental subject. Minimalism, like the phenomenological philosophy it draws upon, thereby '*thinks transcendence within the immanent*' (Deleuze and Guattari, 1994, p. 47). At this point we could imagine Deleuze and Guattari as being unfashionably sympathetic to Michael Fried's famous criticism of the 'anthropomorphic' quality of the minimalist object, animated, he claimed, by an 'inner, even secret, life' (Fried, 'Art and Objecthood', 1995, p. 129).[6]

Both Minimalism and Modernism understood aesthetic experience in terms of its transcendental determination,[7] but in Deleuze and Guattari's terms the transcendental subjectivity explored by Minimalism remains human, whereas the American critics saw it as being 'selfless' (Greenberg, 'The Case for Abstract Art', 1993, p. 81). This distinction operates according to Deleuze and Guattari's minimum condition for art, that it creates an inhuman sensation, and as we shall see this is also their minimum condition for an aesthetic act of resistance. Minimalism's use of industrial materials, production processes and functionalist logic followed Russian Constructivism in developing a machine aesthetic that sought to make industry immanent to art, and, perhaps, aesthetic production immanent to social production.[8] Against the disembodied 'opticality' of Modernist painting and its audience of connoisseurs, Minimalism explored democratic sensations structuring a common flesh. But the 'neutrality' of the transcendental gestalts structuring Minimalism could disturb neither subjective nor social identities, inasmuch as it simply displaced their ground onto formal universals derived from human experience.[9] The neutral universality of Minimalism's transcendental subjectivity produced a functional utility whereby, as Donald Judd put it, the minimalist object 'opens to anything' (1992). This 'opening' made art, Morris argued, part of the 'cultural infrastructure

of forming itself that has been in use, and developing, since Neolithic times and culminates in the technology of industrial production' (Morris, 1994, p. 27). Minimalism's embrace of industrial functionality therefore gestures towards a democratic assimilation of art into life, but at the price of any real resistance to the dominant mode of social production. Although Morris recognized the contemporary political landscape where the 'control of energy and processing of information become the central cultural task' (1994, p. 34), he was not interested in separating art from these wider 'cultural' – but better 'capitalist' – processes.[10] Echoing the Russian avant-garde, Minimalism brings modern life into the sphere of art, but it does so by producing 'neutral' sensations that enable art to be instrumentalized by capital's organization of life. As a result, Minimalism's sensations are, as Morris calls them in an apt description of late-capitalism, simply the 'performance of service beyond the existence of the object' (1994, p. 38). Minimalism therefore represents and reinforces the *Urdoxa* of what Deleuze and Guattari call the existing 'cultural formations' of 'the human community' (Deleuze and Guattari, 1994, p. 47). Minimalism, like the phenomenological philosophy it draws upon, thereby confirms 'the cynical perceptions and affections of the capitalist himself' (Deleuze and Guattari, 1994, p. 146).

Conceptual art rejected both Minimalism's phenomenological ground and its industrial production processes in embracing the wider shift of the 1960s towards 'a culture of the sign' (Buchloh, 2003, p. 310).[11] Art becomes the production of concepts rather than sensations, and embraces an alternative avant-garde trajectory to that of the Constructivists, one that begins with the work of Marcel Duchamp. Duchamp's readymades famously turned art into a conceptual decision of the true/false type: this is, or is not, art. Inspired by analytic philosophy, the conceptual artist Joseph Kosuth proclaimed Duchamp the end of philosophy and the beginning of art. Drawing on the work of the analytical philosopher A. J. Ayer, Kosuth's essay 'Art After Philosophy' argued that 'works of art are analytic propositions' (1991, p. 20). Kosuth claims that an art work is analytic when its tautological proposition defines its own 'art condition' as a

function laying out a plane of reference that is entirely conceptual in nature. This gives us what Kosuth famously called 'Art as Idea as Idea', where art is dematerialized in its 'linguistic turn', and purged of all metaphysics.[12] Here, 'the "purest" definition of conceptual art would be that it is inquiry into the *conceptual* foundations of the concept "art" ' (1991, p. 25). In Kosuth's work linguistic signs conduct analytical investigations into their conditions of possibility, as art. Deleuze and Guattari dismiss this outright. Conceptual art cannot 'substitute the concept for the sensation' they say, because its (denied) materiality means it 'creates sensations and not concepts' (1994, p. 198). As Guattari succinctly puts it, Conceptual art remains, for all its attempts at dematerialization, 'an embodied composition' (1995a, p. 95).

More interestingly perhaps, Deleuze and Guattari condemn Conceptual art in aesthetic terms for seeking a 'dematerialization through generalization' that installs a 'neutralized plane of composition' by which the readymade is turned into 'information' (1994, p. 198).[13] This merge of art with life means 'everything takes on a value of sensation reproducible to infinity', as for example the chair, its photograph, and its dictionary definition, as Deleuze and Guattari point out in a description of one of Kosuth's most well known works (1994, p. 198). At this point it is merely the 'opinion' of the spectator that decides whether or not the work is art, and Duchamp's conceptualization of art evaporates into banality.[14] Art as analytic philosophy produces a concept-function defining a proposition about an object in the world – *it's art!* – but this *analysis* nevertheless conforms to the form of recognition (the true and the false) by which all information is communicated. 'Certainly', Deleuze and Guattari write in terms directly applying to Conceptual art, 'it is painful to learn that *Concept* indicates a society of information services and engineering' (1994, p. 11). Conceptual art, and this criticism echoes that of logic, is 'a lot of effort to find ordinary perceptions and affections in the infinite and to reduce the concept to a *doxa* of the social body or great American metropolis' (1994, p. 198).[15]

While the break with autonomous subjectivity Minimalism found in lived experience produces a transcendental subject

as 'Ur-capitalist', conceptual art produces functions conforming to capitalism's 'universals of communication' (Deleuze and Guattari, 1994, p. 11). Two interrogations of contemporary art are to be found here, one concerning its 'expanded practice', and the other its relation to contemporary capitalism. Minimalism explored installation through a phenomenological sensation that remained passive in the face of industrial capitalism, while nevertheless opening up the body (now encompassing subject and object) to what we might optimistically call 'life'. Conceptual art rejected the body and turned to the opinion of the masses as producers of concepts – qua art – circulating in the sign-economy. Extrapolating from Deleuze and Guattari, contemporary art must avoid becoming incarnated in a passive flesh, just as it must avoid becoming information. As Deleuze says, 'A work of art does not contain the least bit of information' ('What is a Creative Act?', 2006, p. 322). Nevertheless, despite Minimalism and Conceptual art's failure to resist industrial and info-capitalism, they are important because they recognized both capitalism's contemporary forms, and the fact that any resistance to them requires a method of immanent critique. Minimalism and Conceptual art therefore bequeath to contemporary art expanded practices and the sign-economy as fields of experimentation, but they fail to produce, in Deleuze and Guattari's terms, a resistant sensation.

Art as Sensation

The question we must now ask, and it is the condition of a political art practice, is what is a sensation? For Deleuze and Guattari it involves composing lines and colours, an activity they usually find in painting. Here we find the full scope of our problem, because given that Deleuze and Guattari predominantly discuss visual art in terms of colour and painting, how can this be understood in relation to contemporary art – precisely art after Minimalism and Conceptual art – where neither colour nor painting are important concerns? To answer this question we must return to *What Is Philosophy?* in order to extend Deleuze

and Guattari's concept of 'sensation' across the break with painting achieved by Minimalism and Conceptual art.

Deleuze and Guattari are formalists first of all: 'Composition is the sole definition of art' (1994, p. 191). Art composes material expressions – sensations – of differenciating forces, and so it is a formalism of forces, a forming of abstract and yet material movements or vibrations into an individuating sensation. Here art becomes indiscernible from Nature as a process that contracts, or 'contemplates', the movements composing it, and by which it is composed 'with other sensations that contract it in turn' (1994, p. 212). Art constructs sensations that express the becoming of the world. 'We become Universes. Becoming animal, plant, molecular, becoming zero' (1994, p. 169). In Nature-Art the 'Thought-brain' becomes subject in inhuman sensations (1994, p. 210). This brain is a '"true form" as Ruyer defined it: neither Gestalt nor a perceived form but a *form in itself*' (1994, p. 210). This form 'remains copresent to all its determinations without proximity or distance, traverses them at infinite speed, without limit-speed, and makes of them so many *inseparable variations* on which it confers an equipotentiality without confusion' (1994, p. 210). Sensation turns this 'true form' into a quality, a material expression of a plane of composition. This aesthetic event expresses its real conditions, conditions that define an experience's genesis and not its conditions of possible experience. These real conditions are expressed in sensation's *trajectory* beyond the phenomeno-logical. 'Trajectories constituted within a field of forces proceed through resolution of tensions acting step by step [. . . as] a *survey of the entire field*. This is what Gestalt theory does not explain' (1994, p. 209). This *plane of composition* and the sensation that *surveys its field* enables art to 'create the finite that restores the infinite' (1994, p. 197). These asubjective individuations (sensations) are events that convulse the force field, the Thought-brain, at once expressing and constructing the infinite movement of this living, material and inorganic Nature. In this sense, Éric Alliez writes, 'art opens onto cosmic-forces it both contracts and modulates' (Alliez, 2004, p. 75).[16]

Despite this sounding very far from the concerns of contemporary art, it in fact outlines an ontology of art which has the

avant-garde at its core. For Deleuze and Guattari art is always immanent with life. 'Perhaps art begins with the animal', Deleuze and Guattari suggest, the becoming-animal of the (avant-garde) artist whose 'expressiveness is already diffused in life' (1994, p. 183). This animal-artist 'becomes constructive' by celebrating qualities 'before extracting new causalities and finalities from them' (1994, p. 84). Art is here a question of 'natural technique' (1994, p. 185) where 'it is always a matter of freeing life wherever it is imprisoned' (1994, p. 171). This political dimension to art is at once personal and social, at once singular and cosmic. 'It is a question only of ourselves, here and now; but what is animal, vegetable, mineral, or human in us is now indistinct – even though we ourselves will especially acquire distinction. The maximum determination comes from this bloc of neighborhood like a flash' (1994, p. 174). Art is neighbourhood politics, and as we'll see it involves building houses. But it does so entirely on its own terms, because art only ever constructs social housing through a sensation. It remains to be seen what form this sensation could take in contemporary art.

This question rings all the louder given Deleuze and Guattari's formalism, and an unapologetic commitment to 'Modernism' that implies the uncomfortable return to a tradition whose rejection could almost be thought of as the foundational moment of contemporary art practice. Minimalism and Conceptual art are both vituperous in this sense. As good modernists however, Deleuze and Guattari's avowed taste in art more or less ends with their rejection of the ' "flatbed" plane' (1994, p. 198), a term that refers to the proto-postmodern style of Rauschenburg, and its horizontal organization of readymade information.[17] Deleuze's claim that Greenberg and Fried 'took the analysis of abstract expressionism very far' reflects his and Guattari's interest in both Pollock, and the Americans' reading of his work (Deleuze and Guattari, 2004, pp. 646–7), an interest that goes as far as to claim that the Americans' 'creation of a purely optical space' – a space Deleuze and Guattari deny – was simply 'a quarrel over words, an ambiguity of words' (Deleuze, 2003, pp. 106–7). This very sympathetic reading reflects Deleuze and Guattari's interest in Greenberg's connection of

Kant's immanent critique to the sublime in modern painting. Deleuze and Guattari make this connection a foundation of the sensation, which emerges in a qualitative infinity – *flash* – exceeding all transcendental faculties of possible experience, whether objective or subjective. But Deleuze and Guattari read the sublime through a Nietzschean filter that removes its romanticism, making of sensation the overcoming of the self in an emergence of a new life – and even of a living Nature – that is utterly inhuman.[18] At this point they leave the Americans, and their version of Kant, inasmuch as art no longer has anything to do with redemption.

Modernism, for Deleuze and Guattari, involves an aesthetic auto-critique that explodes the form of the human subject in launching experience on a trajectory through the cosmic force-field.[19] On this trajectory there is no construction without destruction, and the modernist artist has become 'the cosmic artisan: a home-made atom bomb' (Deleuze and Guattari, 2004, p. 377). This sublime explosion is how art begins its work of social production. Deleuze and Guattari's differences from the Constructivists become clear here, because although they share a desire to turn art revolutionary, this will involve making life into art rather than the other way around.[20] This is not the same as making Proletarian art, which required, according to the Constructivists, the rejection of both Nature and the autonomy of art. In this sense Constructivism rejects the political possibilities of art *work* for Deleuze and Guattari, which rests on its autonomous expression of Nature in visions 'which have no other subject or object but themselves' (1994, p. 171).

This inhuman trajectory of art and politics frames Deleuze's explicit embrace of the avant-garde: 'There is', he says, 'no other aesthetic problem than that of the insertion of art into everyday life' (Deleuze, 1994, p. 293). But this embrace of the avant-garde seeks to avoid both the Duchampian reduction of art to a sign of its own concept, and Constructivism's refusal of any autonomy to art within industrial production. This is the beginning of a genealogy of sensation that takes us beyond the break instituted by Minimalism and Conceptual art, and allows us to come to grips with installation and the sign as

art's contemporary realms of research. What must be done is to extend sensation into a contemporary context by following the avant-garde aspirations of performance art, installation and conceptual practice, inasmuch as these genealogies are *entirely materialist, and express and construct an inhuman life.* This would be to accept, following Minimalism and Conceptual art, the contemporary immanence of capitalism and experience, and an aesthetic plane of composition co-existent with social life. But it would be strongly critical of both Minimalism's aestheticizing of industrial production, and Conceptual art's embrace of the dematerialized info-economy that 'neutralized' its plane of composition. These strategies have failed because they have not maintained the necessary distance between art and life, the distance that allows art to express, and bring to bear on social production its alterity, its inhuman force. Art must 'insert itself into a social network', Guattari says, but only in order to 'celebrate the Universe of art as such', to celebrate its cosmic plane of composition. These sublime sensations act micro-politically by 'rupturing with forms and significations circulating trivially in the social field' (*Chaosmosis*, 1995a, pp. 130–1). This rupture is an 'event-incident' (Guattari, 2000, p. 52) that confers 'sense *and* alterity' to part of the world, it is a 'mutant production' that 'leads to a recreation and reinvention of the subject itself' (*Chaosmosis*, 1995a, p. 131). This is art as intervention, a contemporary art *work* acting as 'an aspiration for individual and collective reappropriation of the production of subjectivity' (*Chaosmosis*, 1995a, p. 133).

This echoes *What Is Philosophy?* where Deleuze and Guattari suggest that art is a kind of social architecture, and compare sensation to a house that opens onto the universe and 'dissolves the identity of the place through variation of the earth' (1994, p. 187). To build the finite that restores the infinite – this is a utopian politico-aesthetic program by which 'Constructivism unites the relative and the absolute' (1994, p. 22). The immanence of art and life is expressed and constructed in the qualitative sublime of sensation, the 'infinite field of forces' (1994, p. 188) where art and life overcome our humanity to create Cezanne's *material* plane of composition: 'the world before man

yet produced by man' (1994, p. 187). It is when the material passes into sensation that art is constructed without recourse to 'transcendence or paradigmatic models' (Minimalism and Conceptual art) (1994, p. 194), and abstraction can emerge in its contemporary guise, as an abstract materialism finally shorn of any 'spiritual being' (1994, p. 198). This nonspiritual and material abstraction appears as diagrams of lines of flight transforming both subject and institution, and as such they are sensations participating in Nature's *political* dimension of social production. Sensation therefore intervenes directly in life, but it does so from a position of irreducible difference. This intervention is unrestricted by any of art's formal boundaries – and here contemporary art clearly approaches Deleuze and Guattari – making contemporary practice a wide-open field defined only by its production of sensation. This is the reason Deleuze and Guattari finally reject Greenberg, because, as they say, 'it is so wrong to define sensation in modern painting by the assumption of a pure visual flatness' (1994, p. 194). The alterity of art's sensation enables its cosmic vision, but this vision, this *flash – a politics of ecstacy* – directly affects, here and now, the processes of subjective and social production. Any contemporary art practice must produce such a sensation.

Contemporary Art

If we accept, as Guattari does, that 'the growth in artistic consumption that we have witnessed in recent years should be placed in relation to the increasing uniformity of the life of individuals in the urban context', then art's commercial success, as well as its integration into the culture-industry, is a direct reflection of its instrumentalization (1995a, pp. 131–2).[21] In this sense, minimalist and conceptual strategies of opening art onto life merely turned it on to the profits available from the production of uniformity.[22] Nevertheless, by embracing their wider social networks these movements integrated art into the economies of affect and info-commodities, and introduced the possibility of *an immanent critique of contemporary capitalism operating through the work of art.*

By taking this as the 'problem' defining a post-1960s contemporary art practice, it is possible to avoid the failures of Minimalism and Conceptual art, while developing their immanent critique of subjective experience and the sign into resistant practices. One possible trajectory for such a genealogy has already been alluded to, that of a 'Modernist abstraction' exploring 'the great monumental types, or "varieties," of compounds of sensation' (Deleuze and Guattari, 1994, p. 168). This could include lines of experimentation as diverse as painting (why not?), the experimental cinema of Paul Sharits, Gordon Matta-Clark's 'anarchitecture', or the materialist performance practice of Otto Mühl. Although this keeps the contemporary field open to a wide range of practices, its understanding of 'sensation' still rests on painting, and this tends to distance it from the most important streams of contemporary art. More precisely, it is Deleuze and Guattari's insistence upon sensation's appearance in *visual* art – 'everything is vision' (1994, p. 169) – that presents most problems for contemporary art practices that take their conceptual content for granted. We must therefore consider an example of contemporary art practice that accepts the end of aesthetic categories achieved by Conceptual art, and favours a politics of discursive strategies, in order to assess its potential for producing a sensation.

This example departs from the explicitly political tradition of institutional critique that emerged from Conceptual art. Here art's immanent critique receives its 'contemporary' form (as opposed to its 'modern' one) in being oriented towards the discursive framework in which art appears as such, a critique that has undergone a series of transformations up to the present day. Institutional critique begins by exploring the limits of the museum through strategies of negation (Marcel Broodthaers, Hans Haacke and Daniel Buren). Its 'second-wave' appears with artists who entered institutions in order to reveal their racist and sexist mechanisms (for example Michael Asher, Fred Wilson, Louise Lawler or more recently Andrea Fraser). This was followed by the current phenomena of 'relational aesthetics' as championed by Nicolas Bourrioud, whose artists work within the museum in order to create poetic and personal

processes that overflow its boundaries. Finally there are the networks of artists and curators who build temporary and self-organizing 'parallel institutions' (for example the curator Maria Lind [2007], or the 'European Institute for Progressive Cultural Policies' based in Vienna).[23] There seems two aspects to these practices that need to be examined, one is their critical positions, and the other is their constructive project. The respective critiques these positions offer define the nature of the 'line of flight' they embody, and in this sense the first three forms can be distinguished from the last. The first three offer critique not only as means but also as end, and in this sense art-as-institution remains their condition of possibility, whether as negated as in the first wave (Buren),[24] deconstructed as in the second (Andrea Fraser),[25] or redeemed through affect as in 'relational aesthetics' (Bourriaud).[26]

Indeed 'relational aesthetics' seems to occupy one vanguard of contemporary art's turn to political engagement. It creates, Bourriaud argues, 'social *interstices*' within the gallery space, 'that elude the capitalist economic context' while fitting 'more or less harmoniously and openly into the overall system' (Bourriaud, 2002, p. 16). It is by no means clear that these 'forms of conviviality' – to use a phrase championed by Bourriaud – produce inhuman sensations in Deleuze and Guattari's sense. Indeed, it seems to me that 'conviviality' is hardly a sensation at all, and relational art's adoption of the 'horizon of human interactions and its social context' as its 'subject' in fact produces work that repeats the problems of Minimalism and Conceptual art by simply re-presenting normalized bourgeois experience (Bourriaud, 2002, p. 16). Nevertheless, relational art does exemplify contemporary art's desire to engage directly in the world without recourse to traditional aesthetic criteria, or materials, in order to break with capitalism's production of subjectivity. It is no accident then, that Bourriaud is keen to hang relational aesthetics on Guattari's work.[27]

Although he claims that art 'has become the paradigm for every possible liberation' (*Chaosmosis*, 1995a, p. 91), Guattari's work contains very few references to actual art works, and one suspects that for him 'art' acts as a purely nominal term for a

politics of heterogenesis contesting the 'production of subjectivity'. Here, Guattari and contemporary art are very close, inasmuch as both explore 'transversal' strategies that escape their institutional regulation to produce new polymorphous signs. At this point our last version of institutional critique becomes relevant, that which attempts to forge an 'Exodus' from the institutions governing social production (now mainly understood in terms of media), and to reterritorialize aesthetic activity within temporary and horizontal structures held open to receive, create and amplify at once political and artistic 'events'.[28] In broad terms this type of institutional critique emerged in Latin American Conceptual art of the late 1960s (see Katzenstein, 2004), and continued in the 1970s with the Italian *autonomia creativa* movement, and its subsequent manifestations in Collective A/traverso and Radio Alice, with which Guattari was directly involved.[29] These represented early experiments with strategies designed to subvert the mass-media's production of standardized and commodified experience through semiological delinquency and user-based content. These movements can be seen as forerunners to the current plethora of artistic 'psuedo-institutions', whether on the internet or as 'artist-run spaces', that attempt to utilize the open and horizontal architecture of 'networks' to institute what Guattari calls a 'post-media age'. Here, according to Guattari, 'the media will be reappropriated by a multitude of subject-groups capable of directing its resingularisation' (Guattari, 2000, p. 61). A class working like an art *work*, perhaps.

Despite the interest of this final form of institutional critique, and its affirmation by Guattari himself, it remains to be explained how such practices of media activism and self-organization can be understood in terms of sensation as it appears in *What Is Philosophy?* This is not to say that it cannot be done, but simply to register the distance between the political ambitions of institutional critique and the politics of sensation found in *What Is Philosophy?* Institutional critique tends to reject sensation as spectacle, and in so doing sets up 'political' criteria by which to assess art.[30] This is something Deleuze and Guattari never do. In *What Is Philosophy?* sensation opens (and in this

sense its alterity is never *against*) the spectacle to an outside, an overcoming that operates as an aesthetic micro-politics of *life*.

The final manifestation of the question posed by *What Is Philosophy?* to contemporary art would then be how do Deleuze and Guattari's last book and Guattari's solo work meet up? *What Is Philosophy?* as well as Deleuze's book on Bacon offer an ontology of sensation, and the outlines of its genealogy in twentieth-century art. This genealogy traces a field of forces (Nature-Cosmos) and its individuation in an inhuman sensation as the expression and construction of the immanence of art and life. But we must also acknowledge the way that contemporary art has, after Minimalism and Conceptual art, tended to abandon sensation in favour of discursive representations seeking to intervene into the realm of the 'political'. This means we must rethink concepts like 'abstraction', 'sensation' and 'modernism' in terms of the new materials and media of today's art, but we must also find ways by which these contemporary sensations can resist late-capitalism's instrumentalization of 'creativity', and of 'art' itself. This last poses difficult questions to Deleuze and Guattari's 'faith' in art's powers of resistance, and perhaps already offers us the outlines of a new break. This would be the final lesson drawn from the failures of Minimalism and Conceptual art: the necessity of thinking sensation after art.

Notes

[1] On this point, and much else in this essay, see Éric Alliez (2004, p. 35).

[2] Alliez argues that this return of the Stoic 'Event' in *What Is Philosophy?* not only evades logic's analytic functions, but is also the mechanism by which 'science *as inspired by Stoicism*' evades logic (2004, p. 45). Deleuze suggests this in *Dialogues II* (Deleuze and Parnet, 2006, p. 50).

[3] Painting reveals this 'diagram' as 'the parent, the genesis, the metamorphosis of being into its vision' (Merleau-Ponty, 1993, p. 128).

[4] Painting, on Greenberg's account, analyses its own conditions 'through the procedures themselves of that which is being criticized'. In this sense Kant is 'the first real Modernist' ('Modernist Painting', 1993, p. 85).

[5] Merleau-Ponty's *The Phenomenology of Perception* was translated in 1962.

[6] The furious reaction to Fried's accusation that Minimalism was 'theatrical' was not only seen in performance practices, but in a wider acceptance that Minimalism had, in fact, introduced art to 'post-modern' interests.

[7] This connection reflects that between phenomenology and Kant (Deleuze and Guattari, 1994, p. 142). As Deleuze elsewhere states: 'Kant can be considered as the founder of phenomenology' (Seminar, 1978).

[8] Minimalism's own understanding of this inheritance was somewhat less political. Morris saw the Constructivists as being the first to free sculpture from representation and establish it as an autonomous form through abstraction and a literal use of materials (Morris, 1994, p. 3).

[9] In 1975 the Marxist artists Karl Beveridge and Ian Burn wrote of Donald Judd: 'The neutrality which this art assumes excludes the possibility of a critical relation to a capitalist form of life' (quoted in Buchloh, 2003, p. 185).

[10] Benjamin Buchloh locates Minimalism's failure here, arguing that its echo of the Constructivist shift from artisanal to industrial modes of sculptural production could not 'redefine the phenomenology of public space and social relations within the terms of an emerging post-industrial society of information, administration, and spectacle' (2003, p. 310). For Buchloh this opens the way for Conceptual art, whose linguistic turn directly engaged the information economy and its immaterial commodities.

[11] Buchloh describes this break in a typically long but brilliant passage: 'a culture of the sign was about to displace the culture of material objects: more concretely, that the production of advertising and consumer culture had eroded *all* previously autonomous spaces of social experience to such an extent that any claim for an exemption and relative autonomy of objects and spaces from these regimes would instantly mythify the actually governing forms of experience' (2003, p. 310).

[12] 'For the artist as an analyst', Kosuth writes, 'is not directly concerned with the physical properties of things. He is concerned only with the way (1) in which art is capable of conceptual growth and (2) how his propositions are capable of logically following that growth' (1991, p. 20).

[13] Kosuth's work illustrates this apotheosis best, by using dictionary definitions, Thesaurus rules, and other linguistic functions as 'readymades'.

[14] Conceptual art therefore follows the Logic it is based upon, and 'is always defeated by itself, that is to say, by the insignificance

of the cases on which it thrives' (Deleuze and Guattari, 1994, p. 139).

[15] 'This is the same thing as saying that information is exactly the system of control' ('What is a Creative Act?', Deleuze, 2006, p. 321).

[16] Alliez pitches the aesthetic event of sensation directly against phenomenology: 'As aesthetic, the event starts to exist *in itself* once the sensation ceases to represent to itself the matter of perception, returning instead to the impersonality of the *element* of the sensible and to the non-organic life of a becoming which ignores the ontological frame of the lived body' (2004, p. 72).

[17] The term 'flatbed plane' comes from Leo Steinberg's book *Other Criteria, Confrontations with Twentieth-Century Art*. Steinberg argues that Duchamp is perhaps 'the most vital source' (1972, p. 85) for the 'flatbed' plane, and that in its primary example – the work of Robert Rauschenberg – this surface 'stood for the mind itself' (1972, p. 88) and the banality of its processes and products (1972, p. 90).

[18] This sublime is specifically developed by Deleuze in this way in relation to Rossellini's film *Stromboli* (1950) in *Cinema 2* (1989, p. 18).

[19] 'If there is a modern age, it is, of course, the age of the cosmic' (Deleuze and Guattari, 2004, p. 380).

[20] Deleuze and Guattari, 'Balance-Sheet Program for Desiring Machines' (Guattari, 1995b, pp. 119–50).

[21] Deleuze is just as categorical on this point: 'On the other hand, art necessarily produces the unexpected, the unrecognizable, and the unacceptable. There is no such thing as commercial art. It's a contradiction in terms' ('The Brain is the Screen', 2006, p. 288).

[22] Alexander Alberro has explored the relationship between Conceptual art and advertising in *Conceptual Art and the Politics of Publicity* (2003).

[23] See <www.eipcp.net>.

[24] For example, Buren's statement, made in 1967 with Olivier Mosset, Michael Parmentier and Niele Toroni: 'Art is the illusion of disorientation, the illusion of liberty, the illusion of presence, the illusion of the sacred, the illusion of Nature. . . . Not the painting of Buren, Mosset, Parmentier or Toroni. . . . Art is distraction, art is false' (Buren, 1999, p. 28).

[25] Fraser writes: 'We are the institution of art: the object of our critiques, our attacks, is always also inside ourselves' (Fraser, 2006, p. 307).

[26] Bourriaud argues: 'This is the precise nature of the contemporary art exhibition in the arena of representational commerce: it creates free areas, and time spans whose rhythm contrasts with those structuring everyday life, and it encourages an inter-human commerce that differs from the 'communication zones' that are imposed on us' (2002, p. 16).

[27] For a blistering attack on Bourriaud from Deleuze and Guattari's perspective see, Éric Alliez (2007).
[28] For a more detailed discussion of this form of institutional critique and its relation to Guattari's work see, Stephen Zepke (2007).
[29] For an excellent account of Collective A/traverso and Radio Alice, and their place within Deleuze and Guattari's 'minor politics' see Thoburn (2003).
[30] See Brian Holmes (2007).

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Chapter 11

Why is Deleuze an Artist-Philosopher?

Julie Kuhlken

My question will strike some as a bit hasty. In *What Is Philosophy?*, written with Félix Guattari, Deleuze is very explicit in his differentiation of philosophy from both science and art. For them, not only do these disciplines generate very different products, they work with very different materials:

> [F]rom sentences or their equivalent, philosophy extracts *concepts* (which must not be confused with general or abstract ideas), whereas science extracts *prospects* . . . and art extracts *percepts and affects* . . . In each case language is tested and used in incomparable ways. (Deleuze and Guattari, 1994, p. 24)

However, and as I will argue, to call someone an artist-philosopher is not to imply that he is somehow *not* a philosopher, and thus does not challenge the distinction made by Deleuze and Guattari. Rather, the notion of the artist-philosopher introduces the very Deleuzian idea that philosophers collaborate with practitioners of other disciplines to generate their concepts. As Deleuze and Guattari say themselves in the continuation of the above passage: 'In each case language is tested and used in incomparable ways – but in ways that do not define the difference between disciplines without also constituting their perpetual inbreeding' (Deleuze and Guattari, 1994, p. 24).

In this light, the notion that Deleuze is an artist-philosopher gains some plausibility, but it still begs the equally reasonable alternative – particularly given *What Is Philosophy?* – that we should be asking why Deleuze is a scientist-philosopher. In response, I

can quickly say that there is nothing, either in what I am proposing or Deleuze, to suggest any incompatibility between being an artist-philosopher and a scientist-philosopher. In fact, the real contrast may rather be between these and another option, which is being a philosophers' philosopher. Nevertheless, my choice to focus specifically on the artist-philosopher potential deserves some explanation.

Beyond Philosophers' Philosophy

I prioritize the artist-philosopher, because whereas Deleuze and Guattari go to lengths to distance themselves from certain versions of 'science-philosophy', they return frequently to the potential partnership of artists and philosophers.[1] For instance, they are quite ruthless in their criticism of logic, and its pretension to science-philosophy, saying that it 'is always defeated by itself . . . by the insignificance of the cases on which it thrives' (Deleuze and Guattari, 1994, p. 139). By contrast, they are quite generous towards various forms of 'inbreeding' between art and philosophy. Not only do they compare the history of philosophy 'to the art of the portrait' (1994, p. 55), and celebrate the achievements of 'hybrid geniuses' such as Kafka and Artaud (Deleuze and Guattari, 1994, p. 67),[2] they implicate artists in the very becoming of philosophy itself:

> The artist or the philosopher is quite incapable of creating a people. . . . But books of philosophy and works of art contain their sum of unimaginable sufferings that forewarn of the advent of a people. They have resistance in common – their resistance to death, to servitude, to the intolerable, to shame, and to the present. (Deleuze and Guattari, 1994, p. 110)

This collaborative effort of resistance and popular forewarning may even be a short answer to the question of why Deleuze is an artist-philosopher. However, it should not satisfy us, because we have not yet addressed the essential Deleuzian concern of 'How it works?' How *do* the artist and philosopher collaborate to 'forewarn of the advent of a people'?

As one might expect, it is easier to identify how it does *not* work. One of these false ways is what one might call 'philosophy as usual'. As Deleuze and Guattari say in *What Is Philosophy?*, 'those who criticize without creating, those who are content to defend the vanished concept without being able to give it the forces it needs to return to life, are the plague of philosophy' (Deleuze and Guattari, 1994, p. 28). And one cannot help but read this comment in the light of Deleuze's self-reflection in *Negotiations* that he like many of his generation were 'more or less bludgeoned to death with the history of philosophy' (Deleuze, 1995, p. 5). In other words, he singles out for abuse 'those who criticize without creating' partially because he understands all too well the ease of falling into such a mode of philosophizing. Even though he feels he 'copes' with this temptation in his early work by seeing 'the history of philosophy as a sort of buggery', it is quite evident that even early on he is looking for other ways of making philosophy work. Even though 'taking an author from behind, and giving him a child that would be his own offspring, yet monstrous' (Deleuze, 1995, p. 6) – such as he describes his 'buggery' – keeps him creative, it does not allow him to reach beyond the history of philosophy, and beyond a philosophy intended for fellow-philosophers.

For this is very much at stake with Deleuze: He is ultimately not content with such philosophers' philosophy – not only is this reflected in his comments about a potential 'popularity' for philosophy, it is also evident in the diversity of his actual readership. His self-transformation from philosophers' philosopher to artist-philosopher is gradual. In the early 1960s, when he writes *Kant's Critical Philosophy*, his ideal reader is clearly still a fellow philosopher. In fact, the very brevity of the treatise at only 75 pages contains an almost ironic gesture in that one must read over a thousand pages of Kant to make any sense of it. Only at the end of the 1960s do Deleuze's efforts at being the consummate philosophers' philosopher end, with the publication of *Difference and Repetition*, which in Hegelian fashion recasts nearly all of the continental tradition of philosophy in Deleuzian terms.

Thus, asking why Deleuze is an artist-philosopher is also to ask why he stopped being a philosophers' philosopher. Given his skill at the latter, it seems a particularly important question. To answer it, we need to put some meat on the notion of an artist-philosopher – a term that is bandied about quite a bit without, to my knowledge, receiving much definition. Deleuze's suggestion that it involves collaboration between artists and philosophers offers a good starting point, but this says nothing of the type of machine such collaboration makes possible. Moreover, it does not explain why this particular machine provokes such strong negative reactions. Many philosophers would rather be charged with doing uncreative criticism – the very plague of philosophy, according to Deleuze – than be called an artist-philosopher.

Philosophy as Assemblage

The term 'artist-philosopher' is most often used to criticize a philosopher for doing philosophy *like an artist*, and thus implicitly to not be doing philosophy at all. The evidence presented against this philosophical transgression usually consists in an unseemly interest in art, combined with an improper use of rhetorical language. The fact is however, neither taken singly, nor taken together, do these characteristics help identify artist-philosophers.

Consider, for instance, the first charge: that artist-philosophers exhibit an unseemly interest in art. Clearly there are plenty of philosophers, some of whom even write almost exclusively about art, who are not artist-philosophers. Noël Carroll is an obvious example. He is a master of the analytical tradition of aesthetics, has written on almost every aspect of art, and yet could never been seen as an artist-philosopher. Why? Because even as he writes so much about art, he does not allow art to actually affect the philosophy itself. In other words, his reason for writing about art is only to answer the question 'What is art?' and presumably if he ever arrived at a definitive answer he would simply stop writing. For him the answer to the question 'What is art?' is external to the question 'What is philosophy?'

in a way that is never the case for an artist-philosopher.[3] The artist-philosopher's view that art and philosophy are inseparable gives his work a self-referential character, which probably explains why he is often accused of an overly liberal use of rhetorical devices. However, it takes just as much rhetorical artistry to separate the question of 'what philosophy is' from 'what art is' as it does to consider their interrelatedness.

And thus we are back where we started, wondering what being an artist-philosopher really entails. If, and contrary to prevailing opinion, being an artist-philosopher resides neither in the choice of subject matter (that is, art), nor in the approach taken to that subject matter (that is, rhetorical), maybe what we need is a clear-cut example. Nietzsche, for instance, is very often at the receiving end of the 'artist-philosopher' critique. He writes frequently – even obsessively – about art, and is concerned enough about the rhetorical character of philosophy to pen the philosophical novel *Thus Spoke Zarathustra*. Nevertheless, it must also be noted that Nietzsche never loses sight of his distinct identity as philosopher. As his many critical engagements with the philosophical tradition indicate, he views his work as inescapably indebted to that of previous thinkers – to Schopenhauer in particular. What makes him different, however, is that his critical tongue is as likely to lash out at artists as it is at philosophers. For him, artists' works are just as relevant as philosophers'. As he puts it in his dedication to Richard Wagner in *The Birth of Tragedy*, 'I am convinced that art is the supreme task and the truly metaphysical activity of this life in the sense of that man, my noble champion on that path, to whom I dedicate this book' (Nietzche, 1993, p. 13).

In his attempt at a characterization of artist-philosophers, Alain Badiou has called this tragic-heroic relation between art and philosophy – such as is expressed by Nietzsche in *The Birth of Tragedy* – philosophy's 'age of poets'. During this 'age', philosophers supposedly '*hand philosophy over to poetry*' in search for help out of a perceived impasse or crisis (Badiou, 1992, p. 74). The strength of Badiou's tragic-heroic theory is his recognition that the relevant philosophy is not *like art* as much as it is connected or 'sutured' to art, and thus retains its distinct identity

as philosophy (1992, p. 70). Just the same, Badiou's weakness is that he insists that the moment of 'desuturing' must come . . . or even *has* come.[4] This is a weakness, because he thereby assimilates Nietzsche and other artist-philosophers into the same philosophical outlook as the art-hating Plato, who proposes a connection between art and philosophy only *from the perspective of its dissolution*, and thus only as a guardian of their state-sanctioned separateness.

By contrast, what makes Nietzsche and other artist-philosophers distinctive is precisely that they do *not* view their connection with art and artists as something historical – or mythical, as in the case of Plato[5] – and rather as something quite present. In fact, the tendency to view art from the perspective of its present condition may be what best characterizes artist-philosophers, because to view art as part of the present is to raise a question posed by many artists themselves: namely, as Artaud puts it, the question 'of [artworks'] absolute receivability, of their very existence as [art]' (2004, p. 69). To the extent that art requires reception *as art* in order to *be art*, to approach art as part of the present is to view one's reception of art as part of art's very existence, and thus to see reception as inseparable from participation. It is in this regard that an artist-philosopher *acts like an artist* – and not in his philosophical style or aspirations. At the same time, the participation in art leaves traces in philosophy itself which is enhanced, but also changed, by the introduction of new material. On this basis, an abyss yawns between philosophers' philosophers and artist-philosophers. For the former, the material of philosophy is immanent and homogeneous; for the latter, philosophy is, to put it in Deleuze's terminology, an *assemblage*.

In what follows I am going to consider Deleuze's treatment of art in the light of just one artist, Antonin Artaud. Several commentators, including Ian Buchanan, have noted Artaud's exemplarity for Deleuze.[6] Moreover, Artaud's exemplarity is particularly complex, and engages with the multiple ways art can be made to be philosophically present. On the one hand, a philosopher can focus on what art achieves. This is to treat art as exemplary in the terms laid out by Kant in the *Critique of Judgment*,

for whom art's 'products must be models, i.e. *exemplary*' (Kant, 1951, p. 150).[7] In this mode of analysis, a philosopher strives to acknowledge what the artist achieves relative to others. Deleuze on Artaud and Carroll in *The Logic of Sense* perfectly reflects this approach. As it is, Artaud's exemplary achievement receives an additional twist in that Deleuze sees it as primarily negative. For him, Artaud is the great iconoclast who undermines a prevailing image of thought. As directed towards thought, Artaud's iconoclasm works against both text and image – transforming the former to unspeakable breath-words and the latter, as in film, to disassociated figures.[8]

However and on the other hand, as much as this achievement is lauded – and its main lines restated and repeated so as to breath new life in them – *as an achievement*, its ultimate destiny is to slip out of the present and become a piece of history. For this reason, Deleuze also acknowledges another more potent exemplarity for the artist, one that embraces what the artist *does*. In this mode, rather than simply philosophically *describe* what the artist achieves, the philosopher actually *does* what the artist does – with a difference, of course, since he is doing it *as a philosopher*. Deleuze and Guattari's adoption of Artaud's concept of the Body without Organs undertakes this more performative relation between philosopher and artist.

In what follows, we will first look at Artaud the iconoclast as he appears in *Difference and Repetition* and *The Logic of Sense*. Subsequently, we will examine how Deleuze and Guattari take up the mantle of Artaud's Body without Organs in *Anti-Oedipus* and *Thousand Plateaus*, and try to activate it as a philosophical concept.

Theorizing Artaud

What is striking about Deleuze's appeal to Artaud in *Difference and Repetition* is the context in which he does it. What is at stake is nothing less than the fundamental philosophical problem of how to begin. Early on, he acknowledges that he will need a partner if he is to avoid starting off from the perspective of

'common sense' that assumes that we all know what 'everybody knows':

> [I]t is a question of someone – if only one – with the necessary modesty not managing to know what everybody knows, and modestly denying what everybody is supposed to recognise. . . . Not an individual endowed with a good will and a natural capacity for thought, but an individual filled with ill will who does not manage to think, either naturally or conceptually. Only such an individual is without presuppositions. Only such an individual effectively begins and effectively repeats. (Deleuze, 1997, p. 130)

Deleuze needs a partner, in other words, because he cannot be a 'modest' person. As he makes abundantly evident in his extended analysis of the various postulates of representative thought, he has no trouble at all in managing to think. Nevertheless, he sees his intellectual ability as a philosophical liability. Since for him a philosopher equipped with 'a natural capacity for thought' simply '"rediscovers" the State, rediscovers "the Church" and rediscovers all the current values' (Deleuze, 1997, p. 130), he is barred from the 'new, with its power of beginning and beginning again' (Deleuze, 1997, p. 136). Like Nietzsche before him, Deleuze wants to 'create values', and to do so he must discover 'authentic repetition in a thought without Image' (Deleuze, 1997, p. 136).[9] Only in a 'fundamental encounter' can such iconoclastic force be generated.

This encounter with '[s]omething in the world [that] forces us to think' (Deleuze, 1997, p. 139) starkly contrasts with the commonsensical relation to the world, which is satisfied to simply recognize that which passes in and out of a field of vision – which Deleuze humourously identifies as the litany of 'this is a table, this is an apple, this the piece of wax, Good morning Theaetetus' (1997, p. 135).[10] However, as sympathetic as we may be to Deleuze's notion that thought must stake itself in something other than banal acts of recognition, a very real problem arises as to how Deleuze (or anyone) could present such an encounter philosophically. Like the proverbial cake, one cannot

have this encounter and describe it too. That is, if Deleuze really were to have such an encounter, he would be too focused on the new to relate it to us, his readers, and if he then got busy relating it to us, it would only be because the encounter had ended and the new had become old. Deleuze's way out of this temporal dilemma – much like Heidegger before him[11] – is to adopt the role of witness to someone else's encounter.

This is why he finds the letters exchanged in 1923 and 1924 between Jacques Rivière and Antonin Artaud so 'exemplary'. Not only do they showcase the intellectual 'ill will' of Artaud, but also present it in the context of an encounter.[12] The letters' exemplarity is accordingly twofold: On the one hand, Artaud's mental experience of 'central collapse' is exemplary, because it embodies the challenge of starting to think inherent in all thought, and as such concerns the very 'essence of what it means to think' (Deleuze, 1997, p. 147). Moreover, since it affects not *what* he thinks as much as the fact *that* he thinks, it puts him in a position to treat his experience impersonally. As Deleuze notes, Artaud 'shows an awareness that his case brings him into contact with a generalized thought process', one that is not simply relevant for himself or even just for other schizophrenics (1997, p. 147). Furthermore, this awareness may explain why he doggedly pursues Rivière, in spite of the latter's apparent incapacity to understand him. On the other hand, then, the encounter with Rivière is itself exemplary because it perfectly confronts these diametrical opposites: Rivière as 'the image of an autonomous thinking function' (Deleuze, 1997, p. 146) on the one side, and Artaud as the 'complete destruction of that image' (Deleuze, 1997, p. 147), on the other.

The actual mechanics of this iconoclastic encounter are surprising: Rather than a lapse into muteness, there is an effusion of words. Following directly on Deleuze's notion that 'an Idea is necessarily obscure in so far as it is distinct' (Deleuze, 1997, p. 146), the 'more Rivière believes himself to be close to an understanding of Artaud . . . the more he speaks of something entirely different' (Deleuze, 1997, p. 147). In other words, the more distinctly Rivière feels himself able to grasp the differential idea manifested by Artaud, the more widely he must cast his

verbal net to express it. By the multiplication of words and text, Rivière contributes to the very iconoclastic power of Artaud's 'terrible revelation of a thought without image' (Deleuze, 1997, p. 147).

In this sense, part of the interest in the Artaud-Rivière correspondence is the fact that Rivière never gets it. Like Socrates' interlocutors, whose only job is to step in from time to time to offer new fuel to the dialectical fire, Rivière's dogmatism borders on the caricatural. This suits Deleuze because it leaves him an active role to play in the encounter: Whereas Artaud and Rivière ultimately leave us in suspense about the outcome of the confrontation – Rivière is as blissfully wedded to the representational image of thought at the end of the exchange as at the beginning – Deleuze can step out of his role as witness to definitely declare what Artaud has achieved: namely, '*Henceforth*, thought is also forced to think its central collapse' (Deleuze, 1997, p. 147; my emphasis).[13] Nevertheless, there is something dubious about Deleuze's certainty about Artaud's example. Wouldn't such certainty be more appropriate for an end of thought than for a new beginning? Once definitively identified, isn't it less a case of an exemplary artist forcing us to think, than simply the case of yet another artist demanding that we recognize?

It is a testimony to Deleuze's philosophical integrity that he himself comes to almost the same conclusion the very next year in *The Logic of Sense*. This investigation of the relation between sense and nonsense from 1969 devotes one entire series to Artaud. In spite of the depth of the engagement, the problems we find in *Difference and Repetition* recur. Rather than appearing in his own voice, Artaud is witnessed at arm's length, almost as a quasi-academic source, and again through the intermediary of another, in this case Lewis Carroll. As before, Deleuze's interest in Artaud lies in his exemplarity – this time as a counter-example to Carroll – but also again the opposition between the paired writers is too clean. The difference this time is that Deleuze himself recognizes the weakness of this paired approach, and the danger that it treats Artaud as an artistic example in the service of a philosophical idea.

How this transpires is as follows: It starts with Artaud's criticism that Carroll 'does not sense the real problem of language in depth' (Deleuze, 1969, p. 104). By working 'at the surface' Carroll exhibits the role of nonsense in 'the production of sense', but not its more profound experiential role. What Carroll shows is that because 'nonsense says its own sense' – namely, nonsense – it sets itself up in opposition to the 'absence of sense' that characterizes commonsensical speech in which words do not say their own sense but have it said for them by other words in series with them (Deleuze, 1969, pp. 85, 89).[14] What Carroll, then, exploits 'at the surface' is the fact that because nonsense does not have sense within a series, it paradoxically gives rise to an *excess* of sense – something similar to the effusion of words we find in Rivière and Artaud. For Artaud, however, this light-hearted fun misses a critical problem of language. Because Carroll maintains a safe, incorporeal frontier between spoken words and the physical body that speaks them,[15] he does not acknowledge the way in which words can penetrate and wound.

The reason that Artaud is so sensitive to this violent aspect of language,[16] is because 'for him [as a schizophrenic] . . . there is no longer surface'; '[e]verything is mixed with body and in the body' (Deleuze, 1969, p. 106). For him, words fragment into syllables and phonemes which penetrate and wound. As a consequence, Artaud directs his linguistic effort not towards 'recuperating sense' from fragmented phonemes – as might be expected from Carroll – but 'destroying the word' itself. He creates an iconoclastic nonsense of unwriteable 'breath-words' and 'scream-words' – what Deleuze describes as the words of a fluid, 'glorious body', a 'body without organs' that would otherwise suffer in the onslaught of decomposing syllables (Deleuze, 1969, p. 108).[17]

For Deleuze this iconoclastic nonsense is of a completely different order from that of Carroll's superficial series. Rather than contribute to the production of sense, Artaud's nonsense 'absorbs, [and] engulfs all sense' (Deleuze, 1969, p. 111). In fact, Carroll and Artaud are so perfectly opposed that they can be contrasted 'point by point'. However, as Deleuze explicitly admits, this perfect opposition also means his own failure to

truly live up to Artaud's 'discovery of a vital body and the prodigious language of this body'. As he puts it speaking of his role as 'commentator', 'Carroll and Artaud never meet . . . only the commentator can change from one dimension to the other, and that is his great weakness, the sign that he does not inhabit either' (Deleuze, 1969, p. 114). In other words, because in *The Logic of Sense* Deleuze approaches Artaud in the mode of a dispassionate example-taker, the latter's 'body without organs' has nothing but theoretical value for his philosophy. It is the task of his subsequent engagement with Artaud to give it problematic value.

Problematizing Artaud

The problematic value of the Body without Organs (BwO) is its function in cutting through the stranglehold of representation. Evidence *that* such a breakthrough is achievable has already been given in *Difference and Repetition* and *The Logic of Sense*. What is missing from the earlier texts, however, is a version of the disintegration of representation that actually puts the mechanism to work – and not simply gives an eyewitness account of it – and for such an operation, Deleuze – now teamed up with Guattari – will have to make the walls of the signifier actually tumble.[18] In other words, in *Anti-Oedipus*, Deleuze and Guattari don't simply acknowledge Artaud's achievement in discovering the BwO, they let it function philosophically. Very much in the spirit – though not letter – of Kantian genius,[19] they try to live up to Artaud's model of schizophrenic action, with the all-important difference that they do it *as philosophers*.

What this action so exemplarily does is to '*scramble all the codes*'. Rather than accept the Oedipal application of social codes on the individual, Artaud, the 'schizo has his own system of coordinates for situating himself at his disposal' (Deleuze and Guattari, 1983, p. 15). In this manner, he disrupts representation, which uses fixed codes and axiomatics to manipulate desiring-production so that individuals not only accept repression by historical social orders but actually desire it. The scrambling

of codes is productive and liberating – rather than simply violent and paralyzing, as one might fear[20] – because it pushes further and faster a process of decoding, or deterritorialization, started – but then repressively denied[21] – by the latest social order: namely, capitalism.[22]

The scrambling of the codes is made possible by the BwO, which ties together schizophrenia and universal history, such that capitalism and its production of schizophrenia serve as history's limit. Working on the BwO, Deleuze and Guattari follow the model of Artaud first acknowledged in *Difference and Repetition*: Just as Artaud takes on representational thought in *Difference and Repetition*, Deleuze and Guattari scramble the codes of representation in *Anti-Oedipus*. Just as Artaud unleashes an effusion of images and texts by his failure to manage to think, Deleuze and Guattari open the floodgates of signs by shattering the monolithic conception of representation into barbaric fetishes, despotic idols and capitalistic simulacra. Rather than treat representation as a dogma, they treat it as phenomena 'organized at the surface of the socius' (Deleuze and Guattari, 1983, p. 262). They describe each regime of universal history as having its own distinct system of representation, such that when we talk about representation after Deleuze and Guattari we have to also ask 'in what context?' – 'as it functions in what way?'

The necessity of these contextualizing – or to put it in their terms, territorializing – questions means that there is no danger of slipping into the position of 'commentator', such as Deleuze criticizes himself for doing in *The Logic of Sense*. By explicitly acknowledging their embeddedness in a certain social order, each of their attacks on representation bears witness to their ability to partially detach themselves from that order, or deterritorialize themselves, and by means of the BwO, displace their perspective without actually changing perspective. And even though they cannot avoid a simultaneous degree of reterritorialization, the resulting plurivocity is at least closer to the free flow of expression over the BwO than the cruel fetishes, terrifying idols and cynical simulacra of representation.

Artist-Philosophers' Philosophy

Or at least this is how Deleuze and Guattari see the Artaud's BwO functioning philosophically. In reality, their conception diverges significantly from Artaud's, even as they heavily rely on his 'discovery' of it. We will conclude with a consideration of this divergence between Deleuze and Guattari and their ostensible model, because it is a fruitful way of restating the specificity of the artist-philosopher. At its heart, the difference is quite simple: Whereas Artaud conceives of the BwO as having some link, even if sometimes tenuous, to the actual experience of physical bodies – most importantly his own – Deleuze and Guattari state quite clearly that '[a]bove all, [the BwO] is not a projection; it has nothing at all to do with the body itself' (1983, p. 8).[23] The reason for the difference is straight forward: As long as the BwO remains attached to the personal experience of an actual body, it cannot be a philosophical concept. Unlike art, whose percepts and affects touch directly on materiality, philosophical concepts – such as the BwO becomes in Deleuze and Guattari's hands – 'survey' states of affairs. Unlike artists properly speaking, their aim is not to create *works* with the BwO, but rather to free it as a 'pure Event' that philosophically speaking, can be re-effectuated infinitely – in despotic regimes, in capitalistic regimes, in the bourgeois family, in Oedipus (Deleuze and Guattari, 1994, p. 21).[24] Like Nietzsche before them, who says that 'one does well to separate the artist from his work', they separate Artaud from his works, his BwOs. Very unlike traditional aesthetics, which views the artwork as representing an artist's highest *achievement*, Deleuze and Guattari's antirepresentational thought sees the work as playing an even more critical role in illuminating an artist's *failure*.

Deleuze and Guattari explicitly articulate this view in *A Thousand Plateaus*. There they devote considerable attention to a letter by Artaud addressed to Hitler. In it, the artist politely tells Hitler that – as per their conversation 'in 1932 in the Ider Café in Berlin' – he (Artaud) is raising the roadblocks in Paris that he himself laid down. In direct contrast to

those who would denounce the letter as a product of madness, Deleuze and Guattari insist upon its existence as a work of art, and call it a 'BwO intensity map' – in this case of Paris, such that 'the roadblocks designate thresholds and the gas waves or flows' (Deleuze and Guattari, 1987, p. 164). However, this open-minded gesture has odd effects for the artist himself. If they had treated the letter as a joke – as something done in a Duchampian spirit – then Artaud would have looked quite lucid. However, because they insist on its seriousness, and its genuine political intent towards Hitler, Deleuze and Guattari underscore Artaud's madness. Like Nietzsche they ensure that Artaud's work will be 'taken more seriously than he is' (Nietzsche, 1996, p. 80).[25] They draw a line that places Artaud and his madness on the one side, and his works – his BwOs – on the other. Such an operation ostensibly sacrifices the artist to save the work of art, but more accurately, denounces Artaud's continued focus on the artistic ego (such as is evidenced by him addressing himself to Hitler) to transform *his* artwork into the impersonal BwO as concept. As they ironically put it, '[e]ven if Artaud did not succeed for himself, it is certain that through him something has succeeded for us all' (Deleuze and Guattari, 1987, p. 164).

The irony of this gesture is that this successful 'something' – which in a self-referential way consists in calling for the very 'we' who would enjoy such a success[26] – assumes the contribution of artist-philosophers, and thus the entrance of yet new egos on the stage. By making the artist's failure the counter-example of their own success as philosophers,[27] Deleuze and Guattari carve out a new role for themselves – as artist-philosophers – that would respond to Deleuze self-criticism in *The Logic of Sense*; nevertheless, they gain this active, problematizing role only by delimiting the artist's efforts in favour of their own.[28] Just the same, it is useful to remember the alternative to artist-philosophers – art that only ever inspires interpretations, and philosopher's philosophy that only concerns itself with what philosophy means, and never ventures out to discover what philosophy might do.

Notes

[1] In fact, rather than speak of partnership between science and philosophy, they propose one between science and *religion*: 'What brings science and religion together is that functives are not concepts but figures defined by a spiritual tension rather than by a spatial intuition' (p. 125).

[2] Deleuze and Guattari also call these same individuals ' "half" philosophers but also much more than philosophers', which arguably points to the appeal of the role of artist-philosopher: it is a way of being more than *just* a philosopher.

[3] See for instance Noel Carroll's analytical introduction to the philosophy of art, aptly named *Philosophy of Art: A Contemporary Introduction* (2002). The reason Carroll can keep the two questions so cleanly separate is that the question 'what is philosophy' has already been answered by the analytical method, which is taken to define philosophy.

[4] As Badiou puts it, 'the Age of Poets is completed, [and] it is thus necessary to de-suture philosophy from its poetic condition' (1992, p. 74).

[5] As in 'The Allegory of the Cave', in which normal experience is described on the model of theatre, thus making life itself imitate art.

[6] Speaking of Deleuze's transcendental empiricism, Ian Buchanan concludes: 'We thus arrive at what Deleuze calls, without irony, either superior empiricism or transcendental empiricism, and while transcendental empiricism attained its greatest refinement in Artaud, it began with Hume' (1999, p. 114). As for notion that Artaud is exemplary, Deleuze himself says as much in 1997, p. 146.

[7] As it turns out the exemplarity of art in Kant is much more complex than this brief reference can reflect, because in addition to the exemplarity of artworks referred to in this citation, Kant explicitly describes an exemplarity of the artist. His definition of the genius requires that he too be an example: 'genius is the exemplary originality of the natural gifts of a subject in the *free* employment of his cognitive faculties' (1951, p. 161). I have addressed both of these forms of the exemplarity of art elsewhere.

[8] 'As much as he believes in film, he credits it, not with the power to return to images, and to link them following the demands of an interior monologue and the metaphoric rhythm, but to de-link them, following multiple voices and internal dialogues, always [with] one voice in another' (Deleuze, 1985, p. 218; my translation).

[9] He relates Nietzsche to the 'new' (Deleuze, 1997, p. 136).

[10] The humour is all philosophical, of course, since each of these apparently banal acts of recognition are also philosophical ones: Plato's

table, the Biblical apple, Descartes' wax and Plato's Socratic dialogue on knowledge.

[11] See for instance his 'Hölderlin and the Essence of Poetry' in *Heidegger: Through Phenomenology to Thought*. Ed. W. J. Richardson. 4th edn (New York: Fordham University Press, 2003), pp. 403–18.

[12] The key text of Deleuze's iconoclastic understanding of Artaud is an exchange of letters between Artaud and Jacques Rivière in 1923–1924. The fact that it is a set of letters and not one of Artaud's artistic works that takes central stage is significant on several fronts. First of all, Deleuze repeats here the gestures of both Heidegger and Nietzsche who derive much of their relations to Hölderlin and Wagner, respectively, out of letters. It underscores the fact that what is at stake for an artist-philosopher is embracing the artist as he exists in life, and not just his effigy as it is frozen in artworks bearing his name. Only in establishing such a link does a philosopher have any hope of making art present in such a way as to uncover new material for philosophy. Second and as regards specifically Artaud, the letters remind us how inseparable his art is from his life – to such a degree that there is a kind of anecdotal quality to everything we know about him. As a consequence, for those (like Deleuze presumably) who never witnessed his 'scream words' and 'breath words' in person there is a desire to make up for a lack of the original aesthetic experience by means of a new experience. The reconstruction of this lost experience is precisely what elucidates the artist's exemplary achievement. However, and as we will see, the results are ambiguous, because in order to breath new life into the experience of the artist, the philosopher cannot help but also expose him to the kind of dispassionate assessment that would make of him an effigy.

[13] The 'henceforth' is significant, because it marks an insistence upon the new. The problem, of course, is that it is a sign that the new is already growing old when one must insist upon it.

[14] In other words, nonsense is not opposed to sense per se, but rather to the 'absence of sense' that marks sense itself, the fact that common sense words do not say their sense but are explained by words in series with them.

[15] '[T]he physical body and the spoken words are simultaneously separated and articulated by a incorporeal frontier, that of sense' (Deleuze, 1997, p. 111).

[16] Deleuze is insistent that this experience is not simply schizophrenic, but is inherent in language itself (cf. Deleuze, 1997, p. 102). For Deleuze, the mode of nonsense found in Artaud is a linguistic change 'of dimension', not the exiting of language altogether.

[17] See also Deleuze, 1997, p. 107 for a description of the 'affect-language' directed against the organs of the schizophrenic.

[18] Like Dan Smith – who makes the keen observation that '*Difference and Repetition* can be read as Deleuze's *Critique of Pure Reason*, just as *Anti-Oedipus* can be read as his *Critique of Practical Reason*' (2006, pp. 43–61) – I very much see in *Anti-Oedipus* the philosophical continuation of arguments initiated in *Difference and Repetition*. Looking at *Difference and Repetition* as a kind of dry-run for the machine that is set in motion in *Anti-Oedipus* and *Thousand Plateaus* is revealing, because it underscores what is missing from the earlier texts: namely, the element of desire. Without an explicit acknowledgement of the central role desire plays with regard to representation, the earlier texts leave us wondering why we should oppose representation so vehemently. By contrast, *Anti-Oedipus*' analysis of the way in which representation inserts itself between desiring-production and social production – condemning us variously to Oedipal sublimation, territorial reigns of cruelty, despotic reigns of terror, and the empty circulation of images under capitalism – at the very least, motivates us to be on our guard against the platitudes of representation.

[19] Kant makes abundantly clear that he does not see genius as relevant to philosophy (see end of section 47 of *Critique of Judgment*, 1951), and thus this kind of 'following' of the model of the artist that one finds in Nietzsche, Heidegger, Danto and others is an innovation of post-Kantian philosophy even if the basis for this peculiar form of active imitation traces to Kant.

[20] There is, of course, much more to say on this issue of Deleuze and Guattari's political thought. Especially towards the end of *Anti-Oedipus*, they speak at length about the risk of investment in the fascistic pole of deterritorialization. Moreover, because this pole is inseparable from the BwO, it can only be evaded rather than eliminated: 'The two sides of the body without organs are, therefore, the side on which the mass phenomenon and the paranoiac investment to it are organized . . ., and on the other side . . . the molecular phenomena and their schizophrenic investment are arranged' (Deleuze and Guattari, 1983, p. 281). In response, Jeremie Valentin suggests (2006, pp. 185–201) that this bipolarity forces Deleuze to choose an 'in-between' political strategy, a perverse political position of 'cruising', which some see as aristocratic (such as Philippe Mengue within the same volume) but Valentin as 'becoming-democratic'.

[21] Because of its 'cynicism' and 'bad conscience', capitalism uses 'archaic' and 'morbid' recodings to cover up its ruthless axiomatics (Deleuze and Guattari, 1983, p. 225).

[22] The logic here is explicitly anti-pharmakological – to appeal critically to Derrida's notion of the *pharmakon*. Rather than a small dose

to overwhelm a much larger force, Deleuze and Guattari argue that capitalism does not go far enough, and that the only response (a schizo one) is to push even further in the process of decoding and deterritorialization begun by capitalism: 'To go still further, that is, in the movement of the market, of decoding and deterritorialization? For perhaps the flows are not yet deterritorialized enough, not coded enough, from the viewpoint of a theory and practice of a highly schizophrenic character. Not to withdraw from the process, but to go further, to "accelerate the process," as Nietzsche put it: in this matter, the truth is that we haven't seen anything yet' (Deleuze and Guattari, 1983, pp. 239–40).

[23] On the very same page Deleuze and Guattari present Artaud's discovery of the BwO as an act of physical self-discovery: 'The full body without organs is the unproductive, the sterile, the ungendered, the unconsumable. Antonin Artaud discovered this one day, finding himself with no shape or forms, whatsoever, right there where he was at that moment.'

[24] As they put it themselves, 'The concept is an incorporeal, even though it is incarnated or effectuated in bodies. But, in fact, it is not mixed up with the state of affairs in which it is effectuated.'

[25] This is a continuation of the passage cited earlier. In *Anti-Oedipus*, Deleuze and Guattari say something similar when they explain: 'People are co-opted, not works, which will always come to awake a sleeping youth, and which never cease extending their flame' (Deleuze and Guattari, 1983, p. 133).

[26] See passage cited earlier about art and philosophy's task to 'forewarn of the advent of a people' (Deleuze and Guattari, 1994, p. 110).

[27] The further implication is that the counter-exemplarity of the artist is a direct extension of his exemplarity. As we said earlier, the exemplarity of the artist means that a philosopher model himself on what an artist does. However, to the extent this involves a philosopher doing what an artist does with the difference that he does it *as a philosopher*, it makes the fact that an artist does it *as an artist*, counter-exemplary.

[28] As such, their gesture functions as much as the paradoxical sign of their potential future failure as it does their current success. To forge a real 'popularity' of philosophy is a likely candidate for such failure. It lies at the heart, but also just out of reach, of Deleuze's complicated philosophical language.

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Part III

Philosophy

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Chapter 12

Gilles Deleuze and the Problem of Freedom

Constantin V. Boundas

I began to think about the place that freedom occupies in Deleuze's philosophy as I was getting over the surprise that Peter Hallward caused me with his claim that Deleuze's problem is not the freedom of the human, but rather freedom from the human (Hallward, 2006, p. 139). I was also reading Todd May's book at the same time (2005), admiring his unparalleled ability to carry Deleuze's message to those who know next to nothing of it, but experiencing a small degree of discomfort at the occasional lapses of voluntarism and decisionism that, as I thought, were evident in it. Pondering over Deleuze's stance on freedom as I was reading May and Hallward convinced me that a number of creative readings of Deleuze for which we are now grateful, even as (or perhaps, because) they do cause disagreements among us, can be brought back to different receptions of the complexity that the concept of freedom carries in the thought of Deleuze. I am thinking of the exchange between Philippe Mengue, Paul Patton and Arnaud Villani on the question of the relationship between Deleuze and democracy[1]; Slavoj Žižek's censorship of Deleuze's allegedly irresponsible frolic with Spinoza's ethical naturalism (Žižek, 2004) – the kind of frolic that runs the risk of provoking the ire of a punitive superego; I am also thinking of the exchange between Toni Negri and François Zourabichvili over the referent of multiplicities and their historical role inside our postmodernist societies (Negri, 2002; Zourabichvili, 2002); and I am thinking of the discussions between Alain Badiou, Arnaud Villani, Jose Gil and Monique Bergen over Deleuze's alleged Platonism and the consistency or lack thereof of his immanence agenda.[2]

The ambition of this chapter is not to settle these disputes, but to make a modest contribution towards reassembling and repositioning the tools, already at our disposal, for the construction of a sustainable concept of freedom. I am convinced that Deleuze's philosophy is a philosophy of freedom, just as committed to freedom as Sartre's philosophy was. After all, the affection that Deleuze had for Sartre is well-known. But, unlike Sartre's, Deleuze's freedom is both a memory and a project – memory and project in a state of reciprocal determination – to use a phrase to which James Williams has given prominence recently (Williams, 2005, pp. 6–7, 13–16). This reciprocal determination permits Deleuze to think of freedom as the affirmation that creates, and to avoid the *negatités* that ground the Sartrean philosophy of action. Whether in the guise of the Stoic 'assent' or in Spinoza's 'self-determination', whether as Leibniz's 'deliberative choice' or Bergson's 'élan vital',[3] the Deleuzian freedom is nothing without the Nietzschean double affirmation of the eternal return, in other words, without the repetition and the counter-actualization that makes the difference. Looking through the indexes of Deleuze's texts for entries under 'free will', 'freedom of the will' or '*libre arbitre*' will yield no results. The creation of the concept, freedom, is possible only after the false problems that confront us with the choice between free will and determinism have been set aside.

It is this point that Claire Colebrook attempts to drive home: 'Freedom', she writes, 'is when we do not respond automatically and immediately . . . freedom is not a human power set over and against the world. It is not a separate judgment of the world; freedom is the very becoming of the world' (Colebrook, 2002, pp. 167–8). Or again: 'The true sense of freedom (is) an embrace of the virtual that is not limited to the possibilities that are contained within our present point of view' (171). My essay is an amplification and contextualization of these claims that mark a promising start for our discussions on Deleuze's freedom and its concept. But the continuing debates surrounding this concept, I think, may have something to do with the fact that our discussions of the virtual and *its* freedom have rarely been pursued in the vicinity of Deleuze's admonition that we

counter-actualize, in order for freedom as a predicate of the virtual to begin to resonate with freedom as a problem of our becoming (post) human. The ambition of my essay is to bring the concept and the problem closer together than recent discussions have done. It may be true that freedom is a quality of the Deleuzian virtual (as it used to be a quality of Bergson's memory and the living force of the total past), but it is also because of this a predicate of the human, being manifested in the latter's counter-actualizing processes by means of which the excess of the virtual over the actual 'informs' and releases the creative act.

It is worth noticing that on every occasion that Deleuze talks of freedom, the creation of paradoxes seems to be inevitable. First paradox: Deleuze advises those who deterritorialize themselves in search of freedom, away from the suffocating reification of institutions, to learn how to trace lines of flight – these very lines of flight, he adds, which, nevertheless, always already pre-exist their being traced by us (Deleuze and Parnet, 1987, p. 125). Second paradox: Deleuze claims that the only ethics worth pursuing today is the kind of pedagogy that promises to make us worthy of the event – the event that is not of our own making – through a process of counter-actualization that is undoubtedly ours to trace (Deleuze, 1990b, pp. 142–7; 148–53). Third paradox: Deleuze is always eager to prevent the explosion of the decisionist temptations looming in the Nietzshean ethical imperative – 'whatever you will, will it as if it were to return infinitely many times'. He never fails to frame it with the sobering reminder that the eternal return is, in the last analysis, itself the principle of selection of the creative difference (Deleuze, 1983, pp. 68–71). Fourth paradox: Deleuze situates freedom in the space of a contradiction between the sterility and impassiveness of the virtual event and the event's resourcefulness in engendering actual states of affairs (Deleuze, 1990b, 4–11). I am led therefore to conclude that Deleuze's *problem* of freedom must be constructed and expressed as a paradox, and that his *concept* of freedom should never be forced to shed the paradoxical structure that guides the formulation of the problem in the first place.

One word now about the strategy that I follow in this essay. In an attempt to unpack the definition of freedom in terms of memory and project, I discuss Deleuze's appeal to the Stoic distinction between bodies and incorporeals – actual states of affairs and virtual events – and to his decision to brush aside the idle speculations concerning free will or freedom of indifference (to depsychologize, therefore, and to dehumanize the issue of freedom) in favour of the 'chaosmic' freedom of virtual memory or of the memory of the virtual that can be found nowhere else but in states of affairs. With the help of Deleuze's reference to Spinoza, later on, I visit one more attempt to depsychologize the question of freedom through an uncompromising emphasis on the principle of sufficient reason and a robust rejection of contingency (Deleuze, 1988; 1990a). From this reference, however, I also retain Spinoza's attempt to hold onto the reality of freedom (read: self-determination), which hinges on the distinction between the un-freedom of constraint and the freedom of acting in accordance with one's own nature. In the sequence, from Deleuze's discussion of Leibniz, I retain the inclusion of the virtual 'world' (the memory of the virtual) inside the actual monad; the qualification of this inclusion in terms of the distinction between predication and attribution – Leibniz's world is being included as a contingency-allowing predicate, and not as an essential attribute that would have made the notion of contingency illicit; and the exclusive disjunctions of the incompossible worlds that limit freedom to those series only, which are compossible under the principle of the maximum possible goodness of the divine calculations. Deleuze's reading of Bergson will then permit me to begin to think of freedom as a project also, given Bergson's decision to situate freedom in the flowing time of the present, and not in the flown time of the past. Finally, Deleuze's vivid interest in Nietzsche will provide me with the opportunity to highlight the moment of freedom as the project of the eternal return of the virtual. It will also permit me to explain the pivotal role that the Nietzschean double affirmation (assent) plays in Deleuze's analysis of freedom as an ongoing process of counter-actualization of (reifiable) states of affairs for the sake of the repetition of a memory of the future.

A Stoic Paradox

The Stoic distinction between *somata* – bodies, states of bodies and their mixtures – and *asomata* or *lekta* – incorporeals – reappears, in the writings of Deleuze, as the distinction between actual states of affairs and virtual events. The way that bodies and events affect one another – their double causality or reciprocal determination – is what drew my attention to the relevance of this Stoic doctrine to Deleuze's construction of the problem of freedom. In the domain of bodies and their relations, causal relations are responsible for the various mixtures of bodies. This domain is also causally responsible for the production of incorporeal events. But the realm of virtual events knows a different kind of linkage – another kind of causality – Deleuze calls it 'quasi-causality' (Deleuze, 1990b, pp. 94–9). Events, the effects of corporeal causes, are never themselves causes in relation to each other or in relation to bodies and their mixtures; they are, writes Deleuze, quasi-causes. The Stoics used to call them auxiliary or proximate causes.

The question is now this: what do we gain for the articulation of the concept of freedom from the Stoic refusal to collapse the two series – the actual and the virtual – into one continuous chain of causes and effects? What we gain is that the distinction safeguards the autonomy of the event, prevents its identification with actual states of affairs, and preserves therefore its virtual resources for the next toss of the dice. Calling events 'quasi-causes' is meant to make it very clear that the relation that events maintain to bodies cannot be described in terms of classical, efficient causality. It cannot, because the linkage that is established between events has more to do with an open whole of structural causality rather than with the linear expanse of efficient causality. Events lack, as Manuel Delanda argued, uniqueness (same cause, same effect), necessity (the effect follows the cause always), unidirectionality (effects do not react back on their causes) and proportionality (the intensity of the effect is proportionate to the intensity of the cause) – all four being indispensable characteristics of efficient causes (Delanda, 2002, pp. 136–40). Events insist in a temporality

defined by contemporaneity rather than succession, and this fact alone suffices to disqualify them from operating as efficient causes of each other. As *The Logic of Sense* has it, events, being always only effects, are able to form among themselves functions of quasi-causes or relations of quasi-causality, which are always reversible.

It is never enough to talk about the actual and the virtual as two different faces of the real; we must always emphasize their radical heterogeneity. We deal with a series of bodies, their actions and their passions, linked by their causal relations in the present, but also with a series of sense-events that are neither substances nor happenings – whose identity, unlike the identity of substances and happenings, does not depend on their spatio-temporal coordinates. If, as Deleuze wants it, these sense-events are best designated by means of infinitives (to green, to battle, to become-woman), not only do they lack individuating spatial and temporal markings, but they are also neutral with respect to both activity and passivity. But without acting or being acted upon, events are sterile and unproductive – and because of this, once again, not qualified to function as efficient causal agents. Notice that it is at this precise point that the Stoic *paradox* strikes with all its force: the unproductive and sterile virtual event engenders the actual by becoming embodied in it – embodied, however, in a manner that guarantees that the virtual insists in the actual, *and nowhere else*, and also that it preserves its virtualities, without having them depleted through an exhaustive identification with the actual body that it comes to inhabit. The sterile engenders; the bachelor machine cranks up assemblages; the immaculate conceives – this is the splendour and the force of the Stoic *paradox*. In his excellent discussion of quasi-causes, Jay Lampert states the Stoic paradox as follows:

> For a sense to be quasi-causal, it really has to effectuate itself on a causal stratum; and at the same time, it really has to remain in its pre-effectuated status. It has to produce a situation that effectively counters its own effectuation, a sense-effect without effect. It must do so not by producing a vague state . . ., but by producing the causal efficacy of those possibilities not

> selected by its production. By selecting one possibility, the quasi-cause must preserve, at a distance, but with no less reality, the power of the possibilities that the selection excludes. (Lampert, 2006, p. 104)

It is in Véronique Bergen's perceptive discussion, and in her decision to place the Stoic *paradox* next to the Kantian *aporia* of freedom and necessity (with which it bears a slight albeit deceptive similarity) that I find the tools for a fuller understanding of what is at stake with the Deleuzian appropriation of the Stoic doctrine (Bergen, 2001, pp. 137–9). Kant's problem was the reconciliation between the causality of freedom and the causality of nature. But, compared to the Stoic solution, the Kantian coordination of the two causalities falls far short, because: (1) It does not provide for the autonomy of effects transcending their corporeal cause; (2) Instead of engendering an incorporeal effect that would be transcending spatio-temporal coordinates, it produces a phenomenon within the pure forms of intuition; (3) It deprives therefore the produced empirical effect of all generating capacity; and finally, (4) It fails to grasp the event in the contradiction of its sterile inefficacy and its genetic resources. The Kantian event is the result of the causality of freedom and its effect is phenomenally incorporated. In other words, an empirical fact is the result of a heterogeneous synthesis of a phenomenal and a super-sensible causality, which is not phenomenal, albeit its effect cannot fail to be a phenomenon. By contrast, the reasons for which the Stoic double causality was evoked are these: (1) To account for the autonomy of a noumenal effect, that is, for its irreducibility to the corporeal chain of states of bodies; (2) To make it possible for an incorporeal sense-event to be liberated from spatio-temporal coordinates; (3) To bring about a derivative sense that would in turn be proven productive; and finally (4) To reconcile the contradiction between the sterility of the effect and its genetic power. The Stoics (unlike Kant) realized that the failure to detach the phenomenal effect from its corporeal cause would inevitably prevent freedom from neutralizing empirical conditionings and from undoing the causal chains of empirical time (Bergen, 2001, pp. 137–9).

Given the advantages of the Stoic theory, it is difficult to understand why its contribution to the discussions of the problem of freedom has not attracted more attention and why Deleuze's interest in it must still be defended against the conclusion that it is only an idiosyncratic attraction to the quaint. It seems to me that the failure to give the theory its due hinges on the fact that we never fail to formulate the question of freedom in terms of possibles: 'She could have done otherwise'; 'he could have chosen otherwise.' But then the quest for freedom is compromised before it starts by the quest for a 'ghost in the machine' – the will – and by our attempt to assign freedom to it. The Stoics knew better. Similarly, in our efforts to reconcile causality of nature and causality of freedom, we tend to think of these two causalities as if they were forming two distinct series, and to imagine their reconciliation in terms of a given point where their intersection could finally be attested. But once again the Stoics knew better. There is only one real, and this one is simultaneously actual and virtual. To say that the actual consists in the unity of bodily causes and that the virtual stands for the conjugation of effects based on a relation of quasi-causality requires that we give up counting – 1 and 1 makes 2 – and that we begin to think in terms of one disjunctive series. As Deleuze used to remind us on other occasions, this kind of distinction is modal and not numerical (Deleuze, 1990a, p. 203). To each actual body or state of body a virtual whole is always attributable because this virtual whole subsists in it as its co-genitor (not as its progenitor). And to each virtual event/effect an actual body or synergy of bodies clings as its own proper cause. If causes are bodies but effects are incorporeal, a chain of cause and effect will not be a simple chain A–B–C, where B is the effect of A and the cause of C; rather, the cause of C is the body of which the effect B has come to be predicable, acting as cause because of the corresponding quality which it now possesses. If I toss a pebble, which in turn breaks my neighbour's window, I am the cause to the pebble of the attribute 'tossed', and the tossed pebble, a body, is then the cause to the window that has now the attribute 'broken'. In fact, the situation is much more complicated than this: the effect B of my example is a single incorporeal entity. But the

transformation of the Stoic doctrine in the hands of Deleuze, wherein, instead of the single B, one ends up with an entire structure of quasi-causally bonded incorporeals that insist in bodies A and C, requires a much more involved example. It bears resemblance to the relation between the syntagmatic and the paradigmatic axes of discourse, provided that virtual paradigms, unlike actual syntagms, are spaces populated with Hjelmslev-inspired disembodied relations and functions – if ever we are to be serious about Deleuze's demand that the virtual should not bear to the actual a relation of resemblance.[4]

Deleuze contends that this extended argument supports the Stoic conclusion according to which 'freedom is preserved in two complementary manners: once in the interiority of destiny as a connection between causes, and once more in the exteriority of events as a bond of effects. For this reason, the Stoics can oppose destiny and necessity' (Deleuze, 1990b, p. 6). We, on the other hand, may think that Deleuze's conclusion is at this point premature because it is reached without considering that the Stoics' ability to accept destiny and to reject necessity hinges on the role they attribute to assent. The Stoics held the view that human beings and other living things are capable of self-movement without actually initiating their own motion. They maintained that the beginning of motion is in the world of external objects, and that self-movement consists in the response to those external causes. Self-movement as the response to external causes requires assent – and assent is within our capacity to give or to withhold. Perhaps the silence of *The Logic of Sense* about the central role that assent plays in the Stoic theory of freedom is due to the fact that the Stoic assent was introduced as a condition for the ascription of moral responsibility, whereas Deleuze's attitude towards ethics is already in *The Logic of Sense* resolutely Spinozist: it is the becoming-worthy of the event that counts and not the romance of good or bad conscience (Deleuze, 1990b, pp. 148–53). Deleuze, of course, having already demonstrated his appreciation for Hume (Deleuze, 1991), could have easily invoked the Humean analysis of causality in order to elucidate the Stoic distinction between destiny and necessity: unity of causes and bond of effects may, at most,

give us constant conjunction (the Stoic name for it is 'destiny'); but, as Hume made it clear, constant conjunction is not necessity. Nevertheless, the fact that Deleuze did not choose to evoke the argument from assent in the context of his discussion of the Stoic paradox does not cause the disappearance of 'assent' from his *Logic of Sense*. The discussion of becoming-worthy of the event would not make sense without this notion, nor would for that matter the centrality that Nietzsche's eternal return occupies in this text make any sense without it. (Deleuze, 1990b, pp. 263–5). It is in fact in *The Logic of Sense* that we find the best formulation of the role that the quasi-cause plays in the Stoic-turned-Deleuzian ontology: 'The quasi-cause', says Deleuze, 'does not create, it "operates" and wills only what comes to pass' (Deleuze, 1990b, p. 147). This must be read as an invitation to counter-actualize the present state of affairs – a move that implicates an entire theory of assent – but I want to reserve the discussion of this for a later section.

Spinoza/Leibniz: Freedom and Sufficient Reason

It will be Deleuze's discussion of Spinoza and Leibniz that will offer new and crucial blocs for the construction of the concept of freedom: a sense of self-determination that does not require as its initial condition the indifference of indetermination; a further elucidation of the way in which virtual memory is included in the actual body; and a qualification and arrangement of memory series according to compossibilities and incompossibilities that prevent freedom as a project from going as far as it possibly can.

Were there ever a doubt about Deleuze's commitment to rationalist principles, his choice of Spinoza and Leibniz as his intercessors should have dissipated it. '"Everything has a reason. . . ." This vulgar formulation already suffices to suggest the exclamatory character of the principle and the cry, the cry of Reason par excellence' – that's how Deleuze begins his fourth chapter of *The Fold* (Deleuze, 1993, p. 41). Leibniz and Spinoza, both, shouldered this principle as they demanded that there be a reason

for 'everything that happens to a thing' – *causality included*. But then, common sense has it, from this principle together with the onto-theological thesis to which they both subscribe – that the existence of an absolute, first principle, *Deus sive Natura*, is a necessary truth – it would follow that all truths are necessary truths. But this is precisely the thesis of necessitarianism that renders contingency, choice and freedom of the will mere fictions and, even worse, logical errors. It follows, therefore, that, to the extent that Deleuze wishes to maintain the freedom that his appeal to the Stoic doctrine of the double 'causality' helped him articulate, he must prevent the kind of necessitarianism looming in the principle of sufficient reason from marking the spot. But how will he prevent it?

Spinoza sides with common sense. He draws from the principle of sufficient reason the conclusion that the notion of contingency (that is, the view that alternatives to what there is are in fact possible) is a fiction – indeed a dangerous fiction responsible for all kinds of fanciful ontologies, and for moralities that dangle over our heads the implacable judgement of God. Leibniz, on the other hand, multiplies folds and claims to have shown the compatibility between the principle of sufficient reason and freedom. He maintains, against Spinoza, that contingency does not violate the principle of sufficient reason, provided that we are ready to ground the contingent upon what he calls '*per se* possibles'. What could possibly Deleuze retain from this arcane dispute? It may be worth our while to look at it a little closer.

That there can be change without cause – that there can be exceptions to causality – is something that Spinoza finds abhorrent. The 'possible' and the 'contingent' are fictions. What we casually call 'chance' is not the contingent but the point of the encounter of two series of causes. The event that results from this encounter is undoubtedly the product of causes, and only our belief that each of the two intersecting series is not pertinent to the prolongation of the other feeds the fiction of contingency and chance. Pure possibilities have no place inside being. It follows, therefore, that speculations about *liber arbitrium*, absolute spontaneity, and freedom of indifference have no place in

a rationalism that wishes to be grounded on the principle of sufficient reason.

And yet, Spinoza does not give up the notion of freedom. He gives up the idea that freedom is a state of indetermination, or that it proceeds from such a state, in favour of the view that freedom is self-determination, that is, the ability to determine oneself 'according to the laws of one's own nature'. Already in Spinoza's designation of substance as *causa sui* we find his nonscholastic conception of substance based on the absence of determination by an external to it agent. Spinoza's substance is hailed as *causa sui* because it determines itself absolutely in terms of its modifications. As far as he is concerned, the opposition that must be maintained for freedom to be real is not between the free and the necessary, but rather between the self-determined and the constrained. Constraint is opposed to freedom because it represents a source of alienation, because it brings about an action that does not follow from an entity's nature or essence – because it does not express it. This is necessity coming from outside, whereas self-determination is the perfect presence of an entity to itself. Spinoza's human beings are free if and only if they are the real and adequate source of their actions. Moreover, Spinoza insists, knowledge of necessity makes a difference to our affective life. Far from leading to the passive acceptance of what cannot be changed, this knowledge is, in the final analysis, an alignment with God's action and freedom, as it permits and directs our efforts to reproduce it (Deleuze, 1990a, pp. 261–5).

It is well-known that what Deleuze expects from such repetitions of our philosophical past is the renewal of our ability to build, in this case, with Spinoza's blocs, a plane of concepts that is not, hermeneutically speaking, Spinoza's anymore, although, from a topological point of view, it should still be homologous with his own. What Deleuze then appropriates from Spinoza and finds it helpful in his own construction of the concept 'freedom' is this: (1) A critique of the possible undertaken for the sake of the emergence of the reciprocal determination of the virtual, one substance and of the actual modal multiplicities. (2) The refusal to identify freedom with freedom of the will or with freedom of

indifference. (3) The centrality of self-determination, which, in Spinoza, rests on a theory of *conatus*, and the ability to go as far as one's *conatus* permits, without any constraint by forces external to it. (4) The 'third kind of knowledge' that aligns the human being with God in acts of authentic creation, and anticipates Deleuze's process of counter-actualization.

When we come to Leibniz (Deleuze will call him 'God's attorney'), we find him to be, no less than Spinoza, opposed to the ideas of *liber arbitrium* and of the freedom of indifference – and for the same reasons: such fictions are incompatible with the principle of sufficient reason and, consequently, they threaten the intelligibility of the world. But unlike Spinoza, Leibniz is committed to the reality of deliberative choice because his moral vision of the world requires it. He regrets that Spinoza's ethics is not based on moral obligation and that moral guilt has no place in it; he resents that Spinoza's man never acts from a principle of evil; that he can indeed annoy his fellow human beings, but that holding him morally responsible makes no sense. He, unlike Spinoza, holds that the creative act cannot be morally perfect unless it is freely determined in view of what is best. The world can be evaluated as 'the best possible' only if it is the object of a rational will, inclined towards the good, which is intrinsic to things. To the extent, therefore, that Spinoza's 'necessity' excludes all deliberation *sub ratione boni*, it is blind. Spinoza's God, according to Leibniz, is no more acting than a circle does when its properties are deduced from its definition, and therefore Spinoza's philosophy cannot be a philosophy of action.

To be sure, Leibnizean monads are not Spinoza's modes. Monads are free to the extent that their freedom is grounded on their ability to choose what is best as a result of rational deliberation. But choice and rational deliberation imply contingency that does not contradict the principle of sufficient reason. Says Leibniz:

> [A]ll contingent propositions have reasons why they are thus, rather than otherwise, or indeed (what is the same thing) that they have proof a priori of their truth, which render

> them certain and show that the connection of the subject and predicate in these propositions has its basis in the nature of the one and of the other, but [one] must further remember that such contingent propositions have not the demonstration of necessity, since their reasons are founded only on the principle of contingency or of the existence of things, that is to say, upon that which is, or which appears to be the best among several things equally possible. Necessary truths, on the other hand, are founded upon the principle of contradiction, and upon the possibility or impossibility of the essences themselves, without regard here to the free will of God or of creatures. (Leibniz, 1916, pp. 22–3)

For Leibniz, the use of 'contingency' in those places where what is implied is that no reason of any kind can be given why something should have happened thus rather than otherwise is totally unwarranted.

It is easy to recognize in this quotation the thesis of 'compatibilism' – compatibilism between causality and freedom – but the difficulty is that even compatibilism requires arguments in order to convince whereas the above quotation only succeeds in reiterating Leibniz's thesis, without providing any argument in its support. In order for Spinoza to be proven wrong, the possibility of contingency must be demonstrated and it is perhaps in Leibniz's doctrine of inclusion, and in his distinction between predicate and attribute, that we may find the proof and the key to the reconciliation of the principle of sufficient reason with contingency (Deleuze, 1993, pp. 41–58).

We know that Leibniz's God first creates the world in which Adam sins, and then includes it in every individual that expresses it. This prompts Deleuze to write that 'Leibniz leaves the impression that he is condemning us even more strongly than Spinoza, for whom there at least existed a process of possible liberation, whereas for Leibniz everything is sealed off from the beginning and remains in a condition of closure' (Deleuze, 1993, p. 69). In fact, though, Leibniz thinks that he can avoid the conclusion that 'everything is sealed off from the beginning' through a subtle qualification of the sense of the inclusion intended that

draws a sharp distinction between predicates and attributes – and Deleuze is quick to notice. Attributes express qualities and designate essences. I am a thinking being, I am a rational animal are examples of attribution. Predicates are relations and events, designated by verbs expressing actions or passions. 'The tree greens' is a case of predication; 'the tree is green' is a case of attribution. That the predicate is a verb, and that the verb is irreducible to the copula and to the attribute, mark the very basis of the Leibnizian conception of the event (Deleuze, 1993, p. 52). And an inclusion that can be understood in the sense of predication begins to resonate with the Stoic strategy of preventing necessity from sealing off the series of events by designating the bond between events, and between events and states of affairs, as quasi-causal. It also gives Deleuze new ammunition in his effort to explain the relation between his virtual (the world within which Adam sins) and the actual (Adam, the sinner). The reality of the eventmental virtual makes the virtual insist or inhere in the actual, Deleuze likes to say. With the help of Leibniz now he is able to explain that the sense of this inherence is that of predication, not that of attribution. The virtual, as we recall, being a quasi-cause, inclines by raising questions and formulating problems; it does not necessitate. Freedom therefore seems to have been salvaged (Deleuze, 1993, p. 73). But ultimately the problem with Leibniz is with his notion of compossibility that falls behind the Stoic double causality and loses its ability to safeguard the autonomy and the resourcefulness of the virtual event, and to render possible the event's repetition for the sake of difference. This problem bears more scrutiny.

Leibniz folds multiple series inside the one virtual horizon of his compossible worlds, with the proviso that, although every individual monad expresses the same world in its totality, it only clearly expresses a part of this world, a finite sequence. The part of the world it clearly expresses is the region determined by its constituent singularities – given that 'singularities', in Tom Conley's succinct formulation – are the zone of clear expression of the monad (Parr, 2005, p. 252). The significance of this move is this. The inclusion of the entire world as

a predicate in each monad would seem to render the notion of a free act problematic, the same way that the coexistence of the entire past with every new present would seem to rob the present of its novelty and to deprive it of its creativity. But let us recall that, at the core of every monad, there exist singularities as requisites of the monad's individuation. Add to this Leibniz's definition of a free act in terms of an act that expresses the wholeness or the amplitude of the soul at a given moment of its duration. And it would follow that the event that results from the actions and passions of bodies, by being a predicate (and not an attribute), is free when a motive or a change of perception can be assigned to it, because, as Deleuze puts it, the soul, in the presence of a motive, bends entirely in one direction or towards another (Deleuze, 1993, pp. 69–70). In this bending, the soul is inclined without being necessitated. Despite the whole world being, therefore, included as a predicate in the monad, the motive is not the effect of the entire past co-existing with the present; it is the expression of the present itself. And Deleuze's conclusion is stated in the following way: 'When Leibniz appeals to the perfect or completed act (*entelechia*), he is not dealing with an act that inclusion would require us to consider as past, and that would return to an essence. The condition of closure, of being shut off, has an entirely different meaning: *the perfect, completed act is that which receives from the soul that includes it the unity proper to a movement that is being made*. . . . The act is free because it expresses the wholeness of the soul in the present' (Deleuze, 1993, pp. 70, 71). And again: 'The automaton is free . . . because every time it constitutes the motive of the event that it produces' (p. 72).

We could again object that, in a sense, this is still old good compatibilism to the extent that it has not yet raised the question whether or not the soul could have constituted the motive for the action otherwise. Could Adam have refrained from taking the apple and could Sextus have spared Lucretia of rape? However, Leibniz has anticipated our question and seems to have thought that there is a dimension of the counter-factual according to which they both could. If the essence of a thing, he maintained, can be conceived clearly and distinctly (and a

non-sinning Adam as well as a non-raping Sextus can be so conceived) then it must be regarded as possible, and its contrary will not be necessary, even if its existence is incompatible with the harmony of things and the existence of God, and consequently excluded from the world. A non-sinner Adam and a non-rapist Sextus are *per se* possible, and only *per accidens* impossible.[5]

Yet, this argument and the entire Leibnizean doctrine of possible and incompossible worlds that it presupposes do not really advance the case for freedom. It may be the case that things could be otherwise in a world different from the one in which we find ourselves. Suppose we concede that the actuality of our world is the actuality of compossible happenings arranged in their compossibility by a god who chooses the world that he creates *sub ratione boni* – namely, under the principle of the maximum reality possible. Suppose, in other words, that we concede that it is the overall best that matters in determining the freedom and goodness of god. Nevertheless, this principle of optimism, Deleuze is right in saying it, may save the freedom of Leibniz's god, but 'human liberty is not itself safeguarded, to the extent that has to be practiced in this existing world' (Deleuze, 1993, p. 69). 'It does not suffice that Adam may not sin in another world, if he is certainly sinning in this world' (p. 69). In order for compossibility and incompossibility to serve us in the construction of the concept of freedom, converging and diverging series of actions, events and singularities have to be rethought and repositioned inside a virtual plane of immanence that would embrace the paradox of inclusive disjunctions. 'The image of thought that governs the construction of Leibniz's plane of immanence', writes Deleuze, 'coincides with the psychotic episode of the Baroque: A crisis and collapse of all theological reason had to take place' (Deleuze, 1993, p. 67). 'The baroque solution is the following: we shall multiply principles . . . we will not have to ask what available object corresponds to a given luminous principle, but what hidden principle responds to whatever object is given. . . . Principles as such will be put to a reflective use. A case being given, we shall invent its principle. It is a transformation from Law to universal Jurisprudence' (p. 67).

But the Baroque eventually implodes and the image of thought that emerges from its implosion witnesses the collapse of all principles and the intrusion of chance to the virtual plane. A world lacking principles will be the perfect table for the roll of the dice and the power of affirming chance. Without principles to dictate a certain coordination of the actual, and without a selection *sub ratione boni* to separate compossibles from incompossibles, the new plane of immanence will witness the inclusion and the affirmation of incompossibles. In a stratigraphic time, Adam the sinner and Adam the sinless may very well coexist as virtualities that would forever be haunting the actual. And the implications of the affirmation of the incompossibles for the construction of the concept 'freedom' are, as we will see, momentous.

Bergson and Nietzsche: Freedom, Cosmic Memory and Cosmic Project

With Bergson, freedom coincides with the eruption of a difference in tension between the duration of matter and the duration of the acting being, and it is this difference that allows our disengagement from the flux of things, in other words, from the rhythm of necessity (Bergson, 1959, p. 359; quoted in Caeymex, 2005). An originary freedom is now postulated as the presupposition of all deliberative acts and all inclining passions. The interval between matter and spirit turns out to be constitutive of freedom. The living, the actions of which have time at its disposal, tends to choose – in other words, it has, thanks to the power of memory, the ability to break, in the interval, the chains of determining causes. But what is it that gives the interval its constitutive power? How, instead of being an empty space and a dumb silence, is it endowed with affirmative and creative function?

As we saw, the Stoics went a long way towards showing the indispensability of the reciprocal determination of the actual and the virtual for the articulation of the problem of freedom. But reciprocal determination does not prevent, all by itself, an

ontological *chorismos* from being established between the actual and the virtual. To show that the coimbrication of the two does not leave room for the return of transcendence, the precise manner in which the virtual is embodied and embedded in the actual must be shown. And Bergson's stratigraphic time – with its two axes – the *Chronos* of the present and the *Aion* of the already past and of the not yet future is meant to address precisely this issue. The free act is produced inside the time that flows – not inside the flown time (Bergson, 1914, p. 169). Each new act is not something that can be added to the past, but rather a total modification of the latter, because the open totality, far from being a sum of possibles waiting to be realized, is a virtual totality, real, because the past has not disappeared – with a reality nonetheless that has to be actualized. And if there is a kind of determination involved in this way of referring to a totality of the past, the totality in question is not closed – it is dynamic. Freedom, therefore, and memory imply each other. Consciousness in remembering the past actualizes it and creates, in each moment, something new. Free causes borrow from the actual what they need in order to dominate it, and this is enough to prevent us from thinking that the differen*c*iation of the virtual amounts to the actualization of a blueprint.[6] Differen*t*iation does not determine the process of actualization; it generates problems, raises questions and seeks out solutions.

Nevertheless, it is not enough to designate the totality presupposed by memory 'open ended'. Its open-endedness must be generated and also shown to be generated. If freedom is memory rather than a Sartrean project, it is still a memory of the future – the sort of memory that must be created in the purifying fires of the eternal return. Deleuze, as we know, was aware of the danger to turn Bergson's *mnemosyne* into Plato's *anamnesis* (Deleuze, 1990a, p. 88) – a danger that is hard to escape as long as the conservation of the entire past (which is Bergson's legacy) is not qualified by means of the *effondement* (the ungrounding) that only the thought of the eternal return can precipitate.[7] The eternal return is to the philosophy of difference what recollection is to the philosophy of identity. It is the pivotal point of Nietzsche's ontology, a veritable memory of the future provided

that – and Deleuze always insisted on this point – it is not taken in the sense of the eternal return of the same, but rather in the sense of the eternal repetition of difference. A repetition of origins seals the ontology of Being and separates and selects epistemologically and ethically the original from the copy. A repetition of the future seals the ontology of Becoming and performs the epistemological and ethical selection of the simulacra that have freed themselves from the dialectic of models and copies. In a deliberately whimsical but effective way, Jay Lampert has this to say about the kind of repetition implied in the eternal return: 'If what one wants is to repeat a virtuality and not a model, it is easier to repeat a future event, which is by nature indeterminate, than to repeat a previous event whose facts are given. The earlier event has to be made earlier by the force of its successor's attempts to resist identifying with it' (Lampert, 2006, pp. 93–4).

It is easier to think of the eternal return as the ethical imperative that strengthens the will and presides over the transvaluation of valuings as it eliminates half-hearted willings: 'Whatever you will, will it as if it is to return infinitely many times.' But this reading of the imperative will represent the triumph of decisionism and voluntarism, as long as, in positing the eternal return as a principle of selection, it does not succeed in shedding some light on Deleuze's claim that 'the principle of selection is neither yours nor mine', but that it belongs to the eternal return itself. 'This power of decision at the heart of problems', he writes in *Difference and Repetition*, 'this creation or throw which makes us descendant from the gods, is nevertheless not our own. The gods themselves are subject to the *Anankē* or sky-chance. . . . The imperatives are those of being, while every question is ontological and distributes "that which is" among problems' (Deleuze, 1990b, p. 199). What could this possibly mean?

Recall that, for Deleuze, the implosion of the Baroque and the erosion of the principles that sustained the old image of thought brought the incompossible to the virtual. The incompossible lit up a terrain where, instead of a well-ordered sequence of efficient causes, it is chance that prevails. Incompossibles are responsible

for the generation of diverging series, which are inclusively disjunctive – vehicles of an élan towards actualization, responsible for the loss of a predictable world. Nevertheless, the loss of predictability has not left us with an unintelligible world. Vice-diction, rather than prediction, is still capable of grounding a new *phronesis* and of guiding processes of counter-actualization in our quest for becoming worthy of the event.[8]

A reference to surrealist strategies for disturbing the deadly repetition of everydayness in Peter Bürger's *Theory of the Avant-Garde* (1984) may help us grasp the sense of the play of to and fro that the eternal return orchestrates between necessity and chance and that counter-actualization facilitates. Bürger explains that what distinguishes the category of the new in modernism from earlier, perfectly legitimate uses of the same category, is the radical quality of the break with what had prevailed heretofore (Bürger, 1984, p. 60). It is no longer artistic techniques or stylistic principles only, but the entire tradition of art that comes under fire and must be displaced. In this context, Bürger goes on to say, the surrealist avant-garde, having denounced a life organized according to instrumental rationality, searched for elements of the unpredictable, the different and the new. It was against this backdrop that an *hasard objectif* (an objective chance) begun to appear as an attractive alternative to the suffocating sedimentations of common and good sense, and that attempts were multiplied at harnessing *l'hasard objectif* for the sake of a thought of the outside. These attempts included the noninterventionist selection of congruent semantic elements in unrelated events that would allude to similarities going unnoticed by ordinary perception; and also interventionist strategies that strove to manufacture chance (instead of merely registering its presence) either in a directly productive way (the arbitrariness and the spontaneity of the artist were counted upon here) or in a mediate productive way, involving the most painstaking calculation possible, provided that such calculation were to focus on means, leaving thereby the result open-ended and unpredictable (Bürger, 1984, pp. 64–8).

I submit that the eternal return of difference – the sublime thought that Deleuze's reading of Nietzsche bequeaths us – is for

the experimenting philosopher what the 'mediate productive' intervention was meant to be in the hands of the avant-garde artist. Often, Deleuze introduces the eternal return (disguised repetition) as the instance that turns becoming into being by means of a double affirmation. Here he is: 'Affirmation as object of affirmation – this is being. In itself and as primary affirmation, it is becoming. But it is being insofar as it is the object of another affirmation which raises becoming to being or which extracts the being of becoming' (Deleuze, 1983, p. 186). To be then is to affirm and to be affirmed and Being is the affirmation of an affirmation. That the eternal return, in displacing the boundaries between pastness and futurity, reveals the inclusively disjunctive nature of time as *enracinement* and *déracinement* is clear. But what does it mean to say that the eternal return, being a principle of selection, involves two affirmations?

Bürger's reflections on the strategies of the surrealists provide, I think, the answer to this question. A simple affirmation of the actual cannot be a harbinger of freedom. Reactive forces and beautiful souls can certainly do that much. But the thinker of the eternal return intervenes through a second, 'mediately productive' affirmation, counter-actualizes the state of affairs given to her, and taps into the resources of the virtual that insist in the actual, becoming thereby the quasi-cause of the free and the new. May 1968, to revisit Deleuze's favourite example, did not have to happen; it happened as an unstable and transient resolution of problems and forces that kept speeding by each other, colliding and being deflected in the open totality of the one-all, and being weighted down by the bodies and the mixtures of bodies clinging to them. A page from Deleuze and Guattari's '*Mai 68 n'a pas eu lieu*' suffices, I think, to shed light on this point. Here it is:

> In historical phenomena such as the 1789 revolution, the Commune, the revolution of 1917, one finds always a part that is irreducible to social determinations and to causal series: this is the event. Historians do not like this thing: they always restore, after the fact, the causal series. But the event marks an unhinging and a break away from causal series. It

> bifurcates, it deviates from the law; it is an unstable state that opens up a field of possibilities. . . . In this sense, it is possible for an event to be opposed, adversely criticized, recuperated, betrayed; it never fails to transmit something that cannot be surpassed. . . . May 1968 belongs to the order of pure events, which is free from every normal and normative causality. 1968 is marked by a host of agitations, posturing, speeches, nonsense and illusions – but this is not really what counts. What counts is that it was a phenomenon of clairvoyance (*voyance*) – it was as if all of a sudden society saw and realized the intolerable that it contained and it also saw the possibility for something different. . . . The possible does not pre-exist the event; it is created by the event. Events create a new existence, produce a new subjectivity – new relations with the body, with time, sexuality, the environment, culture, and work. Whenever a social mutation takes place, it is not enough to draw consequences and effects, in accordance with economic and political lines of causality. Society must be able to form collective arrangements that reflect the new subjectivity, in a way that shows that this society welcomes and wants the mutation. This is what counter-actualization means. (My translation)[9]

We are now in a position to bring the lessons of the Stoics, of Spinoza, Leibniz, Bergson and Nietzsche close to one another and to listen to their resonance. The freedom of the seer and the actor is in their affirmation of what always already insists in the 'virtual otherwise', which can only be found in the actual state of affairs. Freedom is first and foremost the predicate of the virtual. The surplus of reality that constitutes the virtual guarantees the gift of freedom granted to the actual. The counter-actualization of states of affairs through which the gift is acknowledged and treasured illuminates the site of the Deleuzian freedom at the intersection of necessity and chance. But this intersection would not have taken place, if the virtual were not real and, therefore, capable of reassuring us, be it vicedictively, that the same thing is given to being and to thought. The imperative to counter-actualize is not issued by the free

will or for the sake of the assertion and the triumph of the will to will; it rather addresses an 'I' that the eternal return has already cracked and rendered molecular and imperceptible – an 'I' whose freedom lies precisely in the pedagogy of becoming imperceptible and in the discovery and creation, from the vantage point of imperceptibility, of new institutions and new forms of life testifying to the welcoming of the 'mutation' that lives on in the inclusive disjunction between the 'always already' and the new.

Notes

[1] See Mengue (2003; see also Mengue 2005); see also Patton (2005 and 2006) and Villani (2006).

[2] Badiou (2000), Bergen (1998), Gil (1988), Villani (1988).

[3] On Bergson's concept of freedom, see Čapek (2004).

[4] Deleuze, and especially Guattari, made frequent appeals to the Danish linguist Hjelmslev and to his glossematics. Hjelmslev's use of mathematical models, logical reduction and formalism for the representation of the structure subtending linguistic sequences resonated with Deleuze's conviction that transcendental foundations should contain no terms resembling the empirical.

[5] I owe this Leibnizean point to Martin Lin's 'Rationalism and Naturalism', Lecture delivered at Trent University, 12 January 2007.

[6] Deleuze calls 'differentiation' the determination of the virtual content of the Idea, and 'differenciation', the actualization of the virtual; see Deleuze (1994, p. 207).

[7] For a concise discussion of Deleuze's views on time and the centrality of the eternal return, see Faulkner (2005).

[8] According to Deleuze, vice-diction (Leibniz's way), rather than contradiction, is the right method for the gathering of all the elements-tokens of the Idea and for their 'condensation' unto differential types; see Deleuze (1994, pp. 189–91).

[9] Originally published in Les Nouvelles littéraires (May 3–9, 1984, pp. 75–6), this article is reprinted (and retranslated) in Deleuze (2006, pp. 233–6).

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Chapter 13

On Finding Oneself Spinozist: Refuge, Beatitude and the Any-Space-Whatever

Hélène Frichot

But if one truly installs oneself in the midst of these propositions, if one lives them, things are much more complicated and one finds that one is Spinozist before having understood why.

Gilles Deleuze, Spinoza: Practical Philosophy *(1988b, p. 123)*

This present investigation, or activity of becoming Spinozist, begins with a fascination in a concept taken up towards the voluntary conclusion of Gilles Deleuze's life; the concept of *a* life. And in the midst of this concept we discover a further perplexing term, that of beatitude. Beatitude is the mode of being in which one achieves the maximum of active power or force of existing, and the minimum of reactive passions; the mind becomes a cause of its own ideas, and the body that of its actions in relation to an infinite milieu. Beatitude, or what the Seventeenth Century Dutch philosopher Benedict de Spinoza also called the third kind of knowledge, is where one's essence comes to be most fully expressed in a world. Following Deleuze's Spinozist account, the question of a life, which attains absolute potential and absolute beatitude, installs one in the midst of a plane of immanence, which implies a mode of living or a way of life conducted as an affirmative and ethico-aesthetic pursuit. We are in the midst of things, as Deleuze and Guattari are fond of telling us, and in being so unsteadily placed we discover ourselves in the context of certain contemporary political and ethical

problems through which we must grope in an experimental manner. Deleuze reiterates Spinoza when he stresses that 'we experience . . . we experiment' (2003, p. 1),[1] and through such creative experimentation we strive to express the most of our essence of being such that it might offer something up to our present milieu. The structure of beatitude at the same time as representing the pinnacle of our existential striving promises a refuge of sorts from such striving, and also from both sad and joyful passions; it is like the limited place or shelter from which we make all our necessary departures and returns. Our ideas are most adequate from the point of view of this curious blessedness, and as such, it provides the vantage point from which we can observe the infinite curve of the plane of immanence unfurl. Beatitude places us both on the inside and the outside, in contact with the archives of knowledge and exposed to the furious winds of the unthought. There is a diagram inscribed by Deleuze in his book on Michel Foucault that will provide below a helpful image of thought that will allow me to discuss these relations and the question of a life and beatitude further. This will not be a static image of thought that freezes our capacity to feel and experience a life, instead it will be animated like the peristaltic folds of the plane of immanence itself.

In order to further unfold the notion of beatitude I will pass through the structure of the any-space-whatever, a spatial formation Deleuze treats in his cinema books and also where he examines Samuel Beckett's television plays. With respect to the any-space-whatever Deleuze writes 'one can exhaust the joys, the movements, and the acrobatics of the life of the mind only if the body remains immobile, curled up, seated, sombre, itself exhausted . . . What matters is no longer the any-space-whatever but the mental image to which it leads' ('The Exhausted', 1998, p. 169). In order to map this mental image towards which the any-space-whatever apparently progresses, I will not draw on the any-space-whatever in its relation to film and televisual media. I am interested instead in the procedures Deleuze instigates through the activation of the concept. In what follows I will suggest that a relation can be drawn between the any-space-whatever and beatitude in terms of these procedures, and importantly, I

will suggest that the compositional forces that pertain to their relation are articulated as a practical, processual aesthetics animated by the plane of immanence. The diagram that I draw from Deleuze's book on Foucault will allow me to further animate these conceptual relations such that a tissue of text and image will be presented. This diagram, which I wilfully augment, offers a small detail of a cross-section through the undulating plane of immanence, a detail that can be expanded all the way to infinity, as will become apparent below. It will offer an image of thought by which we can conceptually orientate ourselves on the plane of immanence.

Beatitude, the any-space-whatever and, finally, the pressing problem of refuge are the three key concepts by which this tissue of text and animated image will be structured. If it were possible here to think three distinct vectors of thought simultaneously, I would ask you to consider the three concepts of refuge, the any-space-whatever and beatitude. Contracting these three conceptual parts, I am going to attempt to build a composition of sorts that will rely heavily on the aforementioned diagram I appropriate from Deleuze. First, the contemporary geo-political problem of refuge and how this can be considered an architectural question of ethico-aesthetic import; second, Benedict de Spinoza's notion of beatitude, elaborated explicitly in the fifth book of his *Ethics*, and treated by Gilles Deleuze in chapter 19: 'Beatitude', of *Expressionism in Philosophy* as well as ventured in the short essay, *Immanence: A Life . . .* Third, Deleuze's procedures towards the construction of an any-space-whatever, outlined both in *The Movement-Image*, and his essay on Samuel Beckett's television plays, 'The Exhausted', in *Essays Critical and Clinical*. Between these three conceptual moments, refuge, beatitude, any-space-whatever, I will forge conflations and correspondences that will allow each of these terms to fill out and elaborate the structure of the other terms. Refuge is the concrete and practical problem that secures the possible abstractions of beatitude and the any-space-whatever to a here and now, an inescapable contemporary moment.

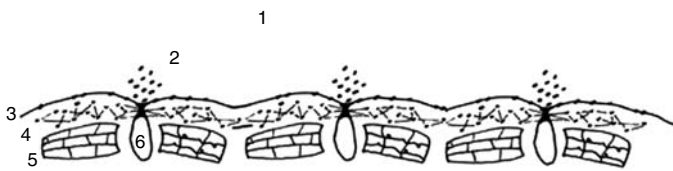
To assist in the laying out of this conceptual composition I will begin with the diagram that Deleuze has sketched to describe

a life within the folds, where he offers homage to the work of Foucault (1988a, p. 120). With the help of the collection of concepts I have gathered above, as well as to further elaborate on these concepts, I want to reanimate this diagram, to invest in its power to make us both think and reinvent new modes of life within the folds. This diagram can be made to do much work, and can help to further discuss the passive and active affections of *a* life. Illustrated clearly in Figure 1, the fold of subjectivation is that refuge I described above, but a refuge that immediately exposes us to an unruly outside, and to the entirety of the plane of immanence. The fold of refuge, or zone of subjectivation, also places us in contact with readily available and newly invented strategies, and locates us alongside the sedimented layers of strata, or the archive of knowledge, that are incrementally built over time. As can be observed in Figure 1, the line of the outside is folded in on itself to create a momentary shelter, the zone of subjectivation. Of this diagram Deleuze writes: 'the outside is not a fixed limit but a moving matter animated by peristaltic movements, folds and foldings that together make up an inside: they are not something other than an outside, but precisely the inside of the outside' (1988a, pp. 96, 97). That is to say, the line of the outside does not support just one fold, but a multiplicity of folds. I want to argue that the diagram depicted in Deleuze's book, *Foucault* is a moment of capture, a snapshot of a line that is not static, but mobile. I have taken Deleuze's diagram as an *image trouvé* and I have added further supplementary textual remarks (Figure 2). I have also expanded the diagram (which I wilfully read from the point of view of the discipline of architecture), as a small detail, a cross section that begins to tell us something more of the plane of immanence, for instance, that the plane is punctuated by innumerable folds that crease into appearance only to disappear again into the ever-mobile plane. If the diagram is taken as a section, rather than merely as the sketch of a mono-dimensional line, then a plane extending to a horizon can be imagined articulated by multifarious folds that appear and disappear over time (Figure 3). That is to say, while the diagram I appropriate from Deleuze (Figure 1) shows but one fold, we can imagine that this fold of refuge, or



1. Line of the outside
2. Strategic zone
3. Strata
4. Fold (zone of subjectivation)

Figure 1 Gilles Deleuze, 'Foldings, or the Inside of Thought'. in *Foucault* (1988a)



1. The outside, unthought, virtual, pre-philosophical
2. Where singularities swirl about
3. Peristaltic, Undulating, mobile line of the outside
4. Strategies configuring relations between singularities
5. Strata or the archive where singularities coagulate and where knowledge is stored
6. Zone of subjectivation ever in process, ever mobile

Figure 2 Section cut through the plane of immanence

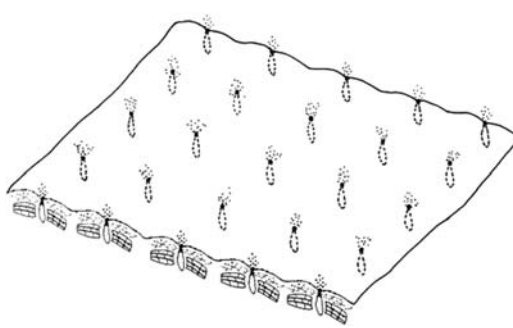


Figure 3 A framed patch of the plane of immanence

zone of subjectivation, is necessarily multiplied *ad infinitum*. And if we understand that this diagram is only a small part of an indefinitely unfurling plane, we can shift our perspective to get a better idea of the extent of the plane and its thickness, which is composed of the surface which greets and absorbs the forces of the outside, the strategic zone where relations are constantly concatenating between singularities, and finally the more stable strata below, where knowledge can be said to be stored. We can animate the peristaltic movements of the plane in order to augment this image of thought that has been left to us by Deleuze. The diagram delivers an image of thought, and as Deleuze and Guattari explain in *What Is Philosophy?* 'what thought claims by right, what it selects, is infinite movement or the movement of the infinite. It is this that constitutes the image of thought' (1994, p. 37). Thought and image cohere to offer fleeting insights to the potential of a life, and how a durational moment of quotidian existence is ever in contact with a point of view on eternity.[2]

The plane that extends all the way to infinity once we allow it to unfurl pertains to Deleuze's account of Spinoza and how in a contemporary situation we make Spinoza relevant to us. Deleuze writes 'to be in the middle of Spinoza is to be on this model plane, or rather to install oneself on this plane – which implies a mode of living, a way of life.' Deleuze goes on to ask 'What is this plane and how does one construct it?' (1988b, p. 125). The plane has to be constructed if one is to live in a Spinozist manner, according to Deleuze. Upon the plane we must consider, first, how bodies and also thoughts of all kinds move in relation to other bodies and thoughts; second, how these bodies and thoughts are affected and affect one another; and finally, how sociabilities and communities emerge from these relations of affect. Relations of speed and slowness activate a body with joy or make it passive with sadness. Deleuze tells us that the absolute velocity of thought is achieved in the third kind of knowledge, where speeds and slownesses, sadnesses and joys would appear to commingle momentarily (1988b, p. 127). Another term that is used to describe the third kind of knowledge is beatitude. The important thing is how to perpetually cope with

the movement across this plane that we construct as we go, through different encounters that arouse differing proportions of sadnesses and joys. Existence, Deleuze explains with the help of Spinoza, 'is a matter of relative proportion' (2003, p. 14). We circulate through the three kinds of knowledge, though this might mean taking liberties with Spinoza's more hierarchical account.

Responding to the theme of this book, which is dedicated to the exchange between image and text, as I proceed the augmented diagram appropriated from Deleuze's *Foucault* should be considered as illuminating the text of this essay and vice versa. I will turn now to a processional through Spinoza's three kinds of knowledge and how the any-space-whatever helps us to elaborate what can be considered as a circulatory process that animates the three kinds of knowledge. Deleuze's diagram, as augmented above, can be considered as that motor which continues to animate the circulation of the three kinds of knowledge upon the plane of immanence.

A First Step towards Beatitude

We can begin with an ordinary, everyday situation: a dark room. Imagine you are sitting in a darkened room full of indistinct shadows (this is an example that Deleuze uses in his series of seminars on Spinoza, where he stresses in particular his preference for a dark room, as though this would provide the best possible milieu for the creation of concepts). In the first instance we can use this darkened room towards a definition of refuge. It also provides us with a familiar image that we can easily call to mind. Deleuze and Guattari's 'Plateau 11: Of the Refrain' from *A Thousand Plateaus*, will be of some help here, as will the three procedures for constructing an any-space-whatever described in Deleuze's *The Movement-Image*. A first step towards refuge: a child gripped with a fear of the dark begins humming a tune: 'Lost, he takes *shelter*, or orients himself with his little song as best he can. The song is like a rough sketch of a calming and stabilizing, calm and stable, center in the heart of chaos' (Deleuze and

Guattari, 1987, p. 311). He finds his way through the shadows, towards hints, streaks or patches of light, as he dimly understands that a battle of sorts is at play between shadow and light producing the illusion of great depth and distorted perspective, as shadow and light wrestle for dominance. In *Cinema 1: The Movement Image* Deleuze elaborates upon 'darkness and the struggle of the spirit', which is given as the first procedure of the any-space-whatever (Deleuze, 1992a, p. 116). This is the realm of signs and inadequate confused ideas aroused by passive affections, where shadows play across the surface of mixtures of bodies, and things collide into each other at random creating smaller and larger shocks. While the augmentation of one's power of being in this milieu is aligned with what Deleuze describes as a lightening, the diminution of one's power of being is described as a darkening (see Deleuze, 2003). Here in the shadows, we exist in the midst of Spinoza's first kind of knowledge, that is, the realm of inadequate and confused ideas from which it is very difficult to escape.

A Second Step towards Beatitude

A second step towards refuge, and it is time to draw a tentative line for 'Now we are at home. But home does not preexist: it was necessary to draw a circle around that uncertain and fragile center, to organise a limited space . . . the forces of chaos are kept outside as much as possible, and the interior space protects the germinal forces of a task to fulfil or a deed to do. This involves an activity of *selection, elimination and extraction*' (Deleuze and Guattari, 1987, p. 311). Selection is 'extremely hard, extremely difficult' (Deleuze, 2003, p. 145), we must leave the shadows and change kind. We construct a makeshift shelter for the time being. It has a floor, a roof, several walls, some windows and a door; we frame and specify a patch of space in order to increase the probability of life. This inaugurates an adventure of light and white, where we pass on the spot 'from one space to the other, from physical space to spiritual space which restores a physics (or a metaphysics) to us' (Deleuze, 1992a, pp. 117, 118). Rather than

battling with the shadows, choices of black, white and grey are made to frame this or that area of light, and views of an outside are selected. Nevertheless, as Deleuze explains 'the rays of light are both prepared for and accompanied by these processes that combine to operate in the shadows' (2003, p. 145). The second step, or second kind of knowledge, still bears a relation to the first kind of knowledge and its inadequate ideas. We discover that bodies are made up of smaller and larger parts, including, for instance, shared zones that overlap between the lived body and the architectural body. A material palette is decided upon, and so forth. A common notion is formed between at least two kinds of body as a minimum, but the maximal case of relations between bodies goes all the way to infinity. Though we are at home, and have constructed our refuge, it is necessary to keep up with its maintenance, day in, day out, for although we have commenced in our creative composition, this structure is still apt to decompose. The choices between black, white and grey suggest that we better understand the causes of our relations with other bodies, our compositions and decompositions, and that we are able to progress from passivity towards activity.

A Third Step towards Beatitude

Finally, the third step towards refuge, which actually takes us into the outside again, 'one opens the circle a crack, opens it all the way, lets someone in, or else goes out oneself, launches forth. One opens the circle not on the side where the old forces of chaos press against it but in another region, one created by the circle itself' (Deleuze and Guattari, 1987, p. 311). Here the atmosphere becomes one of saturated colour and being is seen in all its multi-tonality: 'In short, the area of plain, uniform colour vibrates, clenches or cracks open because it is the bearer of glimpsed forces' (Deleuze and Guattari, 1994, p. 181). The place of shelter that we have actively constructed allows us to venture forth again into further creative projects, to collaborate with other bodies, things, ideas, towards the construction of new compositions that increase our capacity to act, or increase

our active joys, so described by Spinoza. By gathering the greatest number of active joys, and reducing the sad passions to a minimum (and it is a mater of getting the colour mix or the proportion just right) the third kind of knowledge is achieved. In the midst of the third kind of knowledge there resides the greatest pleasure and mental satisfaction (cf. Part 5, Prop. XXVII, Spinoza, 1967, p. 215). This state is called Blessedness; it is the state of Beatitude and intellectual liberty (cf. Preface to Part 5, Spinoza, 1967, p. 199). We arrive at what Spinoza describes as an intellectual love of God, not insofar as we imagine God (or Nature) is present, but insofar as we understand that God (or Nature) is eternal, and so we glimpse the forces of eternity only to discover that we were always in intimate proximity with these forces, which form part of our very composition (cf. Part 5, Prop. XXXIII, Spinoza, 1967, p. 218). The slownesses and speeds that pertained to the sadnesses and joys of the first, and also the second kinds of knowledge would appear to rest momentarily in a hollow of stillness on the plane of immanence: 'where one can live and in fact where Life exists par excellence' as Deleuze describes of that fissure, the fold of subjectivation, that punctuates the plane of immanence (1988a, p. 122).

The vibratory stillness of Beatitude, remaining perfectly still while moving at an infinite speed, surveying the plane of immanence all in one glance, is what Deleuze, in his late essay, *Immanence: A Life . . .* contemplates (contraction, dilation) as a life: 'We will say of pure immanence that it is A LIFE [UNE VIE], and nothing else. It is not immanence to life, but the immanent that is in nothing is itself a life. A life is the immanence of immanence, absolute immanence: it is complete potential, complete beatitude [puissance et, béatitude complètes]' (2001, p. 27). A life, where the stress lays on the indefinite article, is virtuality par excellence, which is, in turn, *merely* actualized in subjects and objects, mixtures of bodies and states of affairs. Though the co-existence and co-presence of these planes of virtuality and actuality should not be underestimated in this 'merely'. It is necessary to pass through existence, to have experienced and experimented with mixtures of bodies and states of affairs, or to become actualized before one can even broach the question

of one's essence and its intermingling with the complete potential and complete beatitude of the plane of immanence.

The steps towards the refuge of beatitude described above, which shift between shadow, colour and light begin to account for the 'tonalities' of sadnesses and joys of Spinoza's *Ethics* (Lectures, 20/01/1981: 19). I have appropriated these tonalities from the procedures for the construction of the any-space-whatever that Deleuze describes in *The Movement-Image*, though I have carefully extracted them from the cinematic paradigm. It is not a gratuitous superimposition that I am in the process of attempting to make. An association between the three steps towards refuge that I take from 'Of the Refrain', a chapter from *A Thousand Plateaus*, and the procedures of the any-space-whatever are also immediately wrought at the conclusion of Deleuze's essay 'Spinoza's Three "Ethics" ', where Deleuze spells out a structure of: 'shadow, colour and light' (1998, p. 151). These, he tells us, are the tonalities that account for the three ethics: a logic of signs, concepts and essences respectively, which belong in that order to Spinoza's first, second and third kinds of knowledge. And, much like the bridges that connect the concepts that populate the plane of immanence, 'each of them sends out bridges across the emptiness that separates them.' At the conclusion of 'Spinoza's Three "Ethics" ', Deleuze insists that each of the three distinct ethics, which correspond to the three kinds of knowledge 'coexists and is taken up in the others, despite their differences in kind' (1998, p. 151). What we discover here is an incitement to conceive of Spinoza's three kinds of knowledge in animated circulation. For the most part the individual is fortunate to escape from the first kind of knowledge and enter the second kind of knowledge. It is rare to be offered a glimpse of the forces of the third kind of knowledge and impossible to achieve total activity, this Deleuze explains in his seminar, subsequently titled, 'The Three Kinds of Knowledge' (2003, p. 15). In the pursuit of a life the test is to express the greatest proportion of one's essence, or intensive parts, which is always tethered to the fact of existence and the infinity of extensive parts that secure us to a here and now.

A constellation of Spinoza's three kinds of knowledge is elaborated and accompanied by the procedures of the any-space-whatever,

which also tend towards the virtual and an image of thought. In much the same way as Deleuze's essay 'The Exhausted', describes the exhaustion of all possible extensive attributes of any given space, in *The Movement-Image*, the any-space-whatever is also evacuated of all coordinates and becomes 'pure potential, it shows only pure Powers and Qualities, independently of states of things or milieux which activate them' (Deleuze, 1992a, p. 120). We can construct an any-space-whatever, we do this by extracting it from 'a given state of things, from a determinate space'. It is possible to extract the any-space-whatever from the first kind of knowledge, from mixtures of bodies and inadequate ideas, from passions both sad and joyful.

I should pause here a moment: for something is slightly awry in the above superimposition, it is not uncomplicated. Where the any-space-whatever progresses from shadows, to the so-called adventures of light and white, and thence onto colour, the three ethics, progress from *shadow* to *colour* to *light*. Beatitude as the third kind of knowledge that characterizes Spinoza's fifth book of the *Ethics* is what Deleuze calls an 'aerial book of light, which proceeds by flashes' (1998, p. 151). Though we should not forget that we are speaking of light, in which case white light is composed from the combination of all the colours. In *Difference and Repetition*, Deleuze explains 'the Idea of colour, for example is like white light which perplicates in itself the genetic elements and relations of all the colours, but is actualised in the diverse colours with their respective spaces' (Deleuze, 1994, p. 206). And when we do place the three procedures towards the construction of any-space-whatevers alongside Deleuze's delineation of Spinoza's three Ethics, we see that one system explains, fills out and elaborates the other. The importance of the relation and distinction between white light and all the colours is exactly the moment of actualization that occurs when one colour or another comes to clothe an existential territory, and that this colour is drawn from the potential that the white light of all possible colours combined allows. In much the same way, it is no use focusing purely on the achievement of a glimpse of the white light of beatitude if we give up on a coloured and shaded existence. What use is beatitude unless we have traversed the

shadows of the first kind of knowledge, and the choices between grey, white and black of the second kind of knowledge, that is, unless we have conducted a test by way of our very existence in a here and now (ever in flux).

The project here of becoming Spinozist without at first knowing why concerns the question of *a* life, how a life pertains to complete potential and complete beatitude, and the crucial thing, Deleuze reminds us, is to understand that life, is a 'composition of speeds and slownesses on a plane of immanence' (1988b, p. 123). But how do we construct this plane as we go? It will, of *necessity*, depend on *contingent* circumstances and unexpected encounters, which pertain in the first instance to the first kind of knowledge. Deleuze's reading of Spinoza's *Ethics* is made up of passages, thresholds and detours. The passage of affect, thresholds of extensity and intensity as well as the thresholds between one kind of knowledge and another, through which this passage leads us, and also the detours we must necessarily make in the direction of sad passions and inadequate ideas before we can progress again towards joys. The detours are a necessary part of our apprenticeship while we still find ourselves in the midst of things, in one encounter after another. A 'beautiful functionalism' attends the chance encounters in which we necessarily find ourselves (Lectures, 12/12/1980: 21), but it is up to us to make these encounters work. We must always return along some detour or another to Spinoza's first kind of knowledge, in order to proceed again towards beatitude, or the intensive peak of the third kind of knowledge. To exist, as Deleuze insists with respect to Spinoza, is a continuous variation of the power of acting, a diminution, followed by an augmentation, *ad infinitum*. Or as Spinoza explains: 'It must be remarked here that we live subject to continual variation, and according as we change into a better or worse state we call it happy or unhappy' (cf. Part 5, Prop. XXXIX, 1967, note). The continuous variation of *affectus* is enveloped by *affectio*, and the passage of affect simultaneously encompasses eternity, instantaneity and duration (Lectures, 12/12/1980). There pertains a complicated relationship between extensity and intensity, which is also aligned

with the relationship between affection (*affectio*) and affect (*affectus*). Although we are supposed to have departed from mixtures between bodies once we depart from Spinoza's first kind of knowledge, this departure is also made up of detours and returns. Outside and inside are defined by a fragile and frequently breached architectural line of shelter. A body preserves a certain set of relations through slownesses and speeds, movements and rest, and this body, I argue, incorporates the architectural body, with which we are ever in the process of creating another class of individual.

We commence from the midst of the shadows by drawing a line around ourselves, but we must continue by opening up this line and including the unknown, a coming people and a community that we have yet to imagine. This pertains to the architecture of refuge, but there is no way of determining its brief in advance, except perhaps to say that its walls must allow for a great degree of permeability. To call upon the architectural configuration of refuge is to call forth an ethico-aesthetics, such as that suggested by Guattari, who writes 'to speak of creation is to speak of the responsibility of the creative instance with regard to the thing created', furthermore, this ethical comportment is ever 'caught up in the movement of processual creation' (1995, p. 107). The construction of refuge is never a completed project but an ongoing apprenticeship. What's more, an ethico-aesthetics, as Guattari explains, occurs at the threshold or interface of the finite and the infinite, relative and absolute speeds, chaos and complexity, at the thresholds, for instance, that regulate the passage between Spinoza's three ethics, that of the first, second and third kinds of knowledge. In proposition X of book V, what Deleuze describes as the aerial book of the *Ethics*, Spinoza argues for the usefulness of outlining 'rules of life', or the 'right way of life': 'the best thing then we can bring to pass, as long as we have no perfect knowledge of our emotions [*affectus*, *affectio*], is to conceive some way of living aright, or certain rules of life' (1967, p. 207). These rules should not be mistaken as universal, rather they respond to the power of each mode in so far as a life is lived, collecting adequate ideas and aspiring to the creativity of joyful affections.

Strictly speaking beatitude cannot be considered in a spatially extensive manner, it owns no coordinates to be mapped and demarcated. This does not mean that we have to depart from thoughts concerning the architecture of the refuge. Serial relations are composed wherein architecture forms a support that offers the function of shelter. The framing support of architecture contributes to the passage of affect, it contributes to the compositions we construct according to the encounters we concatenate. Architecture, whether in the foreground or the background forms a necessary part of every encounter. What's more, in continuously forming relations with our architectural surrounds, our powers of existence increase and decrease. A special correspondence, a parallelism occurs between extension and intention, particles of bodies, and flights of thought. Even though the height of joys, beatitude, would seem to remove us from the concerns of extensive relations, if we still move along a passage of lived experience, we cannot do without these extensive parts, 'there is always a particle that strikes another particle' (Lectures, 1980). If we 'resonate' with our architectural surrounds, we form what would be a superior individual that takes up and combines our body and the architectural body in a joyful relation, of which these bodies form so many parts. What Deleuze would call a 'formidable new individual'.

This is how I can begin to venture what at first might seem an ill-conceived association between beatitude and an extensive and corporeally mixed space that I will call refuge. This space, at the same time, cannot be thought merely in extension but also arcs in a (perhaps uncoordinated) leap towards the third kind of knowledge to a 'mental image' of sorts that places each one of us, in the particular, within a direct identification or relation with absolute immanence. As with the any-space-whatever, it is necessary to extract and exhaust all those aspects of a life that reduce our pure power of being. At the same time it is always necessary to ask, what use is beatitude unless it return again through the detour of the first kind of knowledge, mixtures of bodies, our capacity to affect and be affected? One finds oneself Spinozist by taking the passage through the three kinds of knowledge, which constitutes a search that is an apprenticeship

in order to discover that one *already* participates in beatitude. The transition, as Deleuze points out in his chapter, 'Beatitude', 'is only an appearance; in reality we are simply finding ourselves as we are immediately and eternally in God' (1992b, p. 308) or in nature, or upon the plane of absolute immanence. Deleuze stresses in *Spinoza: Practical Philosophy*, that it is a matter of working out how to construct the plane of immanence, to lay it out in preparation for concepts. Furthermore, to construct at the same time as to inhabit or install oneself on this plane implies a way of living, a way of life. Crucially, this does not stop the necessity of striving, that is, of expressing and exploring an ethico-aesthetic existence.

Notes

[1] I wish to thank Simon O'Sullivan for drawing my attention to this article.

[2] Melissa McMahon helpfully argues that the image of thought provides a 'point of reflection, identification, orientation for the subject in relation to its community and to the world' (2002, p. 4).

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Index

actual, the
  and the body 225–6
  and the event 225–6
  and the virtual 161, 171
actualization
  and beatitude 258–9
aesthetics
  and community 143
  and imagery 155
  and politics 144
  relational 189–90
  and war 149
affect 125, 127, 139
  and beatitude 259–60
  Deleuzian 171
  and the encounter 139
  and history 154
  and hypersensivity 170
  and imagery 149, 156
  indices of 165–6
  screen
    and community 146
  and sensation 164
  and subjectivity 146
  and vectors 146
  and whispers 129
affects
  and becoming 86–100
  and landscape 16
  and literature 21
  and perception 87
  and sensation 86
affirmation
  and the eternal return 242
  and freedom 243
Agamben, G. 161, 165
Ahmed, S. 147
Alberro, A. 193 n. 22
Alliez, E. 184, 192 nn. 1,2, 194 n. 16
any-space-whatever
  and beatitude 248–9
  and Beckett 29, 36–7
  and cinema 257
  and knowledge 253, 257–8
  and the plane of immanence 248
apprenticeship
  and beatitude 261
Arakawa 161–4, 166–8, 170, 172 n. 8
architecture 111, 114
  and landscape 19
  and painting 110–12, 114, 117, 119
  and refuge 261
  and sculpture 114
art 187
  aboriginal 90–4
    and becoming 92–3, 95–6
    and earth 94, 96
    and people to come 94, 96
  and becoming 184
  Conceptual 182
    and the body 183
    and capitalism 183
    and Minimalism 181
  contemporary
    and sensation 189–92
  in Deleuze 4
  and difference 105
  and earth 84, 87
  and empiricism 104
  and future 97
  and house 119
  and language 167
  and life 121, 185, 187
  and line of flight 190

art *continued*
origins of 81
and phenomenology 179
and philosophy 198, 201
and plane of composition 84
and politics 185–8
practice
and concept 160
and psychoanalysis 81–2
and resistance 180, 192
and sensation 84, 87–8, 97, 176, 178
and transversality 191
Artaud, A.
as artist-philosopher 203–4, 211–12
and Body without Organs 209–12, 216n. 23
and the encounter 206
and imagery 152–3
and Jacques Rivière 206–7, 214n. 12
and Lewis Carroll 207–8
and schizophrenia 209
and sense 208–9
artist-philosopher 201–4, 211–12, 216n. 27
assemblage 120, 126
assent
and ethics 229
and freedom 229–30
avant-garde 186
and the eternal return 241–2
Russian
and Minimalism 180–1

Bacon, F. 22
and sensation 85, 88–9
Badiou, A.
as artist-philosopher 202–3
Baroque, the
and image of thought 237–8
and the incompossible 240–1
and plane of immanence 238
Barthes, R.
and *punctum* 126–7, 137, 139
Bataille, G. 67
beatitude
and actualization 258–9
and affect 259–60
and apprenticeship 261
and experience 256–7
and knowledge 255
and life 247, 256, 259, 262
and light 258–9
and the plane of immanence 256, 262
and power 259
and refuge 249, 261
structure of 248
Beckett, S. 2
and any-space-whatever 29, 36–7
and images 22–3
and music 35
Not I 33–5
Quad I & II 35–7
and refrain 35–7
and rhizome 32, 39
and space 36, 39
What Where 29–32
becoming 110
and aboriginal art 92–3, 95–6
and affects 86–100
and art 184
and the body 128, 172
and the encounter 130–1, 138
and faciality 135
and the impersonal 135
and madness 131
and refuge 260
and sensation 84–5
Bergen, V. 227
Bergson, H. 25n. 3, 38–9, 56n. 3, 224
and cinema 45
and freedom 238–40
and images 44–5, 57n. 11, 139
and immanence 132
and philosophy of time 43–5
and time 239
body
and the actual 225–6
architectural 162, 166, 168, 255, 261
and the outside 260
and becoming 128, 172
and cognition 163
and Conceptual art 183
and creation 127

destratification of 171
and hyperconnectivity 162
and imagination 171
and intensity 171
and language 162–3, 170
and madness 128
and reading 161–2
and screen data 145
and sensation 84–5
and speed 252
and the Stoics 225–30
and the virtual 170
Body without Organs 128
and Artaud 204, 209–12, 216 n. 23
and deterritorialization 210
and representation 209–10
Bogue, R. 72
Boundas, C. V. 161
Bourrioud, N. 189–90, 194 n. 26, 195 n. 27
Buchanan, I. 136, 156 n. 1, 213 n. 6
Buchloh, B. 193 nn. 10,11
Buren, M., 194 n. 24
Bürger, P. 241–2
Butler, J. 67

capitalism
and Conceptual art 183
Carroll, L. 207–9
as artist-philosopher 204
and sense 208–9
Carroll, N. 201, 213 n. 3
cartography
and rhizome 1
causality
and the event 231
and freedom 227
and the Stoics 227–9
and substance 232
Cézanne, P. 15
and plane of composition 187
and sensation 85
chaos
and force 89
and function 177
and painting 89–90
chaosmos 120–1
childhood
and becoming 138
cinema
and affective metaphysics 153
and any-space-whatever 257
and Bergson 45
and experience 134–5
and madness 130
and movement 42–3
and power 153–4
cognition
and body 163
Colebrook, C. 100 n. 13, 222
community
and aesthetics 143
and CNN 151–2
and delirium 152
and imagery 151–2
and militarism 151, 155–6
networked
and militarism 145–6
and order 151
and screen affect 146
and thought 151
and vectors 150
composition
plane of 184, 187
and art 84
and sensation 184
compossibility 237
and the event 235
conatus
and Spinoza 233
concept, the
and art practice 160
and logic 177–8
conceptual personae 73
connectibility
and language 165, 168
contingency
and sufficient reason 234
conviviality
and art 190
counter-actualization
and the eternal return 242
and freedom 222, 243–4
and vice-diction 241
couple, the
and the encounter 137–8

creation
and body 127
and life 121
creativity
and contemporary art 192
critique
institutional
and politics 191–2
cry, the 129

Darwin, C. 96 n. 1, 97–8 n. 5, 98 n. 7
and selection 82
and territory 83
death
and the crack 139
and the impersonal 136
and love 137
debt
and judgment 72
and life 77
decoration 110
delirium
and community 152
and militarism 145
Deleuze, Gilles
and affect 164, 171
and art 4
and Artaud 204, 214 n. 16
and the avant-garde 186
and Beckett 27–39
and Bergson 57 n. 9
Bergsonism 51, 57 n. 12, 124
and Body without Organs 204
and cinema
art-house 125
Cinema 1 14–15, 24, 38, 43–4, 57 n. 6, 154, 253–4, 258
Cinema 2 21, 24, 37, 42, 49–51, 56 n. 3, 57 n. 6, 129–30, 132, 135, 137, 152–6, 194 n. 18
and the couple 136–7
and crystal 51
and difference 51
Difference and Repetition 105–6, 108–9, 122 n. 7, 152, 200, 204–7, 240, 258
Empiricism and Subjectivity 229–30
and the encounter 130, 205
"L'Épuisé" 27–39
Essays Critical and Clinical 2, 20–3, 25, 163
Expressionism in Philosophy: Spinoza 262
and extension 108
and the figural 90
The Fold 230–1, 234–8
and force 128
Foucault 23–4, 172 n. 4, 250–1
Francis Bacon: Logic of Sensation 85, 87–9, 99 n. 9, 100–1 nn. 16–19, 123 n. 23
and freedom 221
and hypersensitivity 170
Immanence: A Life . . . 256
Kant's Critical Philosophy 200
and language
in Beckett 27–8, 34–5, 37, 39
and literature 24
Logic of Sense 100 n. 12, 136, 138, 177–8, 204, 207–9, 226, 229–30
and May '68 242–3
and multiplicity 122 n. 7
and necessity 231
Negotiations 137–8
and the outside 172 n. 4
and painting 25
and philosophy 200
and the possible 232
and rationalism 230
Spinoza: Practical Philosophy 252
and the Stoics 224–30
and temporality 37–9
and thought 1–2, 205
"Three Kinds of Knowledge" 248, 252–7
and time 50–1
and the time-image 135
Deleuze, G., and F. Guattari
and affect 127
Anti-Oedipus 130, 140 nn. 5,6, 209–10
and Body without Organs 209
and a people 216 n. 25
and artist-philosopher 211–12, 213 n. 2

and assemblage 126
and Body without Organs 128, 209–12
and capitalism 215 n. 21, 216 n. 22
and conceptual art 182
and faciality 134
and formalism 184–5
and haecceity 126–7
and judgment 72
Kafka. For A Minor Literature 27, 167–8
and literature 20
and Minimalism 180–1
and Modernism 185–6
and painting 183
and politics 215 n. 20
and sensation 183–8
and the sublime 186
A Thousand Plateaus 21, 98–9 n. 8, 131–4, 136–8, 146, 149, 186, 211–12
and the Body without Organs 140 n. 11
and faciality 9–13
and the refrain 253–5
and vitalism 113
What Is Philosophy? 15–21, 24–5, 99 n. 11, 100 nn. 14,15, 122 n. 21, 177–8, 180–8, 191, 198–200, 252, 255
desire 125
and representation 215 n. 18
destratification
and the body 171
deterritorialization
and Body without Organs 210
and landscape 16, 24–5
and representation 210
see also territorialization
Dewey, J. 112–16
and architecture 114
and intensity 112–13
and Matisse 114–15
and vitalism 113
difference 51
and art 105
and intensity 106
and representation 109
discourse
in Foucault 66
and justice 67
passional regime 73
regimes of 71–2
Duchamp, M. 181–2

earth
and aboriginal art 94, 96
and art 83, 87
embodiment
and house 17–18
and landscape 17–18
empiricism 114
and art 104
and representation 104–5
encounter, the 130
and affect 139
and Artaud 206
and becoming 130–1, 138
and childhood 138
and the couple 137–8
and love 139
and thought 205
energy
and sensation 86
essence
modal 149–50
and power 150
and thought 150
eternal return, the
and affirmation 242
and the avant-garde 241–2
and counter-actualization 242
and freedom 222–3, 230
and memory 239–40
ethics
and assent 229
event, the 156 n. 3
and causality 231
characteristics of 225–6
and compossibility 235
and freedom 223, 236
and language 167, 169
in Leibniz 235
as sense 226
and singularity 237
and video 148

experience
and beatitude 256–7
and cinema 134–5
lived
and Minimalism 179
and rhythm 115
experimentation
and life 248
expression 109–10
extension 108

fabulation
in Bergson 25 n. 3
and landscape 21–2
faciality
and becoming 135
and fetishization 10
and landscape 10, 18
and madness 136
and semiotics 10–11
and statements 11
and subjectivity 133
and visibility 11–12
Fauvism 106–7
fold, the
and life 250
and the outside 250–2
and the plane of immanence 248, 250–2
force 128
and chaos 89
and imagery 154
vibratory
and sensation 88
Foucault, M. 63–4
and discourse 66
and inversion 64–7, 69
and pleasure 72
and sexuality 64, 66, 69–71
and statements 23–4
and truth 71
and visibility 23–4
freedom
and affirmation 243
and assent 229–30
and causality 227
and counter-actualization 222, 243–4
and the eternal return 222–3, 230
and the event 223, 236
and line of flight 223
and memory 239
and paradox 223
as problem 223
and self-determination 232
and the Stoics 228–9, 232
and the virtual 222–3
Freud, Sigmund 96 nn. 2,3
Fried, M. 180, 193 n. 6
friendship
and madness 134
function, the
and chaos 177
and logic 188

Gibson, J. 172 n. 6
Gins, M. 161–4, 166–8, 170, 173 n. 8
Greenburg, C. 179, 185–6, 188, 192 n. 4
Guattari, Félix
and art 187
Chaosmosis 168–70, 187, 190–1, 260
and contemporary art 190–1
and Radio Alice 191
The Three Ecologies 188
and transversality 191

haecceity 126–7
and madness 134
and memory 133
Hallward, P. 221
history
and affect 154
Hjelmslev, L. 244 n. 4
house
and art 119
and territorialization 24
Hume, D.
and causality 229–30
hyperconnectivity
and body 162
and language 166–7, 172
and touch 165, 167, 171
and words 162
hypersensivity
and affect 170

image
  and narration 22
imagery
  and aesthetics 155
  and affect 149, 156
  affective 143
    and Gulf War I 144
    and Gulf War II 144–7
    and subjectivity 144
  and community 151–2
  and force 154
  and movement 149
  and power 150
  screen
    and video 147
    and YouTube 147
  and shock 153
  and sound 148, 154
  and thought 152

imagination
  and the body 171
impersonal, the
  and becoming 135
  and death 136
inclusion
  in Spinoza 234–6
incompossible, the
  and the Baroque 240–1
incorporeals
  and Stoics 225–30
individuation
  and thinking 105
intensity 106–8, 112–13
  and body 171
  and difference 106
  and representation 109
  and sexuality 83
  and territory 83
  and truth 6
intolerable, the
  and thought 150, 154–6
inversion
  in Foucault 64–7, 69

Jackson, P. 114
James, W. 114–15
  and empiricism 114
Johnson, V., 102 n. 25
Judd, D. 193 n. 9
judgment
  and debt 72
  in Deleuze and Guattari 72
justice 64–5
  and saving 71
  and truth 66–7, 76

Kafka, F. 37
Kant, I. 203–4, 213 n. 7
  and causality 227
  and phenomenology 193 n. 7
knowledge
  and any-space-whatever 253, 257–8
  and beatitude 255
  kinds of 252–7
  and refuge 254–5
Kosuth, J. 181–2, 193 nn. 12,13

Lampert, J. 226–7, 240
landscape 25 n. 1, 53
  and affects 16
  and architecture 19
  and cinema 13–15
  and deterritorialization 16, 24–5
  and embodiment 17–18
  and fabulation 21–2
  and faciality 10, 18
  and literature 20–2
  and music 12
  and percepts 16–17
  and refrain 12
  and respiration-space 14
  and stratification 24
  and vital breath 14
language
  and art 167
  and the body 162–3, 170
  and connectibility 165, 168
  and event 167, 169
  and hyperconnectivity 166–7, 172
  and the outside 169
  and perception 166
  and touch 167
  and truth 66–7
  and the virtual 171
Latour, B. 173 n. 11

Lawrence, T. E.
and landscape 21–2
Leibniz, G. W. von 224, 230–8
and compossibility 237
and monads 233–4
and plane of immanence 237
and the possible 236
and Spinoza 233
life
and art 121, 185, 187
and beatitude 247, 256, 259, 262
and creation 121
and debt 77
and experimentation 248
and the fold 250
and logic 77
and Minimalism 183
and the plane of immanence 252, 259
rules of 260
and sensation 188
and war 156
light
and beatitude 258–259
Lind, M. 190
line of flight
and art 190
and freedom 223
Lingis, A. 97 n. 4
literature
and affects 21
and landscape 20–2, 25
percepts 21
logic
and the concept 177–8
and the function 177
and life 77
and phenomenology 178
and philosophy 199
and sense 177–8
Lorenz, K. 98 n. 6
and territory 82–3
love
and death 137
and the encounter 139

machinic, the
and creation 111
and desire 75
and the mechanosphere 104
madness
and becoming 131
and body 128
and cinema 130
and faciality 136
and friendship 134
and haecceity 134
Maldiney, H. 14–16
Marker, C.
La Jetée 124–34, 137–9
Sans Soleil 126, 140 n. 3
Massumi, B. 137, 160, 169, 172 nn. 1,5
Matisse, H.
and architecture 111
and art 104
and the artist 115
and assemblage 120
and becoming 110
and chaosmos 120–1
The Dance 112, 116–19
and decoration 110
and Dewey 114–15
and expression 109–10
and Fauvism 106–7
and intensity 106, 108
and life 121 n. 4
and painting 121 n. 1
and *papiers découpés* 119–20
and sculpture 119
and vitalism 107, 110–11
Maturana, H. 170
May, T. 121
McEwan, I. 76
McMahon, M. 126
meaning
and sound 154
memory
and the eternal return 239–40
and freedom 239
and haecceity 133
Merleau-Ponty, M. 178, 192 n. 3
Messiaen, O. 19–20
and territoriality 12–13
metaphysics
affective
and cinema 153
and thought 153

micropolitics 7
militarism
  and community 145–6, 155–6
  and delirium 145
  and imagery 143
  and thought 151, 155
Minimalism
  and capitalism 183
  and life 183
  and lived experience 179
  and phenomenology 180
  and Russian avant-garde 180–1
  and sensation 180–1, 183
  and subjectivity 180
Modernism 185–6
monad, the
  and singularity 235–6
Morris, R. 179–81, 193 n. 8
movement
  and cinema 42–3, 49
  and imagery 149
  and Stein, G. 41–2, 47–9
music
  in Beckett 35
  and landscape 12

necessity
  and truth 231
new, the
  and Surrealism 241–2
Nietzsche, F. 38, 224
  as artist-philosopher 202–3
  and the eternal return 239–40
Norden, N. L. 139–40 n. 2

Olkowski, D. 126
order
  and community 151
outside, the 172 n. 4
  and the architectural body 260
  and the fold 250–2
  and language 169

painting
  and architecture 110–12, 114, 117, 119
  and chaos 89–90
  and sensation 88–90
paradox
  and freedom 223
  Stoic 226
  and the virtual 172
Peirce, C.S. 38
people to come 216 n. 25
  and aboriginal art 94, 96
  and resistance 199
perception
  and affects 87
  and language 166
percepts
  and landscape 16–17
  and literature 21
  and perception 87
  and sensation 86
Petyarre, K. 91–3, 102 n. 23
phenomenology
  and Kant 193 n. 7
  and logic 178
  and minimalism 180
  and politics 178
philosophy
  and art 198, 201
  and logic 199
  as usual 200
Picasso, P. 47–9
plane of immanence, the
  and any-space-whatever 248
  and the Baroque 238
  and beatitude 256, 262
  and the fold 248, 250–2
  and the image of thought 248–9, 252
  in Leibniz 237
  and life 252, 259
Plato
  and art 203
pleasure
  in Foucault 72
  and repression 70
  and sexuality 70
politics
  and aesthetics 144
  and art 179, 185–8
  and institutional critique 191–2
  and phenomenology 178
  and sensation 186–7, 189–92
  and the sublime 186

Possum (Tjapaltjarri), C. 93–4, 102 nn. 24,26
power
  and beatitude 259
  and cinema 153–4
  and imagery 150
  and modal essence 150
  and thought 150, 153–4
Presley, E.
  Mystery Train 148–9
psychoanalysis
  and art 81–2
  and sexuality 81–2

Rajchman, J. 100 n. 13, 164
rationalism 230
reading
  and body 161–2
real, the
  and the virtual 228
reason
  sufficient
    and contingency 234
refrain, the 18–20
  and Beckett 35–7
  and landscape 12
  and territorialization 19
refuge
  and architecture 261
  and beatitude 249–50, 261
  and becoming 260
  defined 249
  and knowledge 254–5
  and subjectivation 250
relations 73–6
religion
  and science 213
representation
  and art 104–5
  and Body without Organs 209–10
  and desire 215 n. 18
  and deterritorialization 210
  and difference 109
  and intensity 109
repression
  and pleasure 70
resistance
  and art 180, 192
  and a people 199
Resnais, A. 127, 154–5
rhizome
  and Beckett 32, 39
  and experience 115
rhythm 115
  and sensation 89
Rivière, J. 206–7, 214 n. 12
Robinson, M., 63, 67–69, 73–77
Ropars-Wuiilleumier, M.-C. 38–9

saving
  and justice 71
  and truth 67–8, 71
schizophrenia
  and thought 95
science
  and religion 213
sculpture 120
  and architecture 114
self-determination
  and freedom 232
semiotics
  and faciality 10–11
sensation
  and affect 164
  and affects 86
  and art 84, 87–8, 97, 176, 178
  and becoming 84–5
  and body 84–5
  and composition 184
  and contemporary art 189–92
  as conviviality 190
  and energy 86
  and incarnation 17
  and life 188
  and Minimalism 180–1, 183
  and painting 88–90
  and percepts 86
  and politics 186–7, 189–92
  and rhythm 89
  and the sublime 186–8
  and vibratory force 88
sense
  and logic 177–8
  and nonsense 208
  and surface 208
sexuality
  and displacement 82
  in Foucault 64, 66, 69–71

and intensity 83
and pleasure 70
and psychoanalysis 81–2
Shaviro, S. 126
shock
and imagery 153
singularity
and the event 237
and the monad 235–6
Smith, D. 130, 215 n. 18
sound
and imagery 148, 154
and meaning 154
space
and Beckett 29, 36, 39
and respiration 14
speed
and the body 252
Spinoza, B. 151, 224, 230–8, 247–62
and affect 139
and beatitude 256
and causality 231–2
and *conatus* 233
The Ethics 150, 256–60
and freedom 232
and kinds of knowledge 252–7
and Leibniz 233
and modal essence 149–150
statements 65
and faciality 11
Stein, G. 41–2, 45–60
and Bergson 42, 56 n. 3
and cinema 42, 46–7, 50, 52, 59 n. 27
and continuous present 45–6, 58 n. 15
and landscape 53
and movement 47–9
and Picasso 47–9
and time 53–5
Steinberg, L., 193 n. 17
Stoics, the 224–30
and causality 227–9
and freedom 228–9
stratification
and landscape 24–5
Straus, E. 15–16
subjectivation
and faciality 10–11
and refuge 250
and singularity 123
subjectivity
and affect 146
and affective imagery 144
and faciality 133
sublime, the
and politics 186
and sensation 186–8
substance
and causality 232
Surrealism
and the new 241–2

Tanovic, D. 158 n. 14
temporality 37–9
territoriality
and Messiaen 12–13
territorialization
and house 24
and refrain 19
see also deterritorialization
territory
and intensity 83
thinking
and individuation 105
thought
and affective metaphysics 153
and community 151
in Deleuze 1
and the encounter 205
image of
and the Baroque 237–8
and the plane of immanence 248–9, 252
and the virtual 240
and imagery 152
and the intolerable 150, 154–6
and militarism 151, 155
and modal essence 150
and power 150, 153–4
and vectors 145
time 50–1, 53–5
in Bergson 239
and the crack 138

touch
  and hyperconnectivity 165, 167, 171
  and language 167
transversality
  and art 191
truth 64
  in Foucault 71
  and justice 66–7, 76
  and language 66–7
  and necessity 231
  and saving 67–8, 71

van Gogh, V.
  and sensation 85
Varela, F. 170
vectors 157 n. 3
  and affect 146
  and community 150
  and thought 145
Verbrugge, R. 161, 165–7, 173 n. 7
vice-diction 244 n. 8
  and counter-actualization 241
video
  Aegis Trophy 147–9
  and the event 148
  Honour Killing 147
  and screen imagery 147
Virilio, P. 146, 148
virtual, the
  and the actual 161, 171
  and the body 170
  and the event 225–6
  and freedom 222–3
  and image of thought 240
  and language 171
  in Leibniz 234
  as paradox 172
virtue 64–5
visibility 65
  and faciality 11–12
vitalism 107, 110–11, 113
von Uexküll, J. 12

war
  and aesthetics 149
  and life 156
Williams, J. 222
words
  and hyperconnectivity 162

YouTube
  and screen imagery 147